

The Beloved

A Psychotherapist Falls in Love with a Client

Banks Hudson

Cover design by Larry Vaughan

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ISBN 979-8-8723-8754-1
Banks Hudson
Nicholasville, KY 40356

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To the Women I Have Loved

Tess Angelina, a combat helicopter pilot returned from Afghanistan suffering from Post Traumatic Stress. She suffered trauma in an explosion that killed several of her friends and left her with head injuries and the loss of an ear. After months of struggling with alcohol addiction, severe depression, and panic attacks, she sought the help of psychotherapist Howard Kingston.

During the course of Howard's therapy with Tess as described in my book, "A Journey to Now", he fell in love with her. This is his story.

PREFACE

One of my mentors once told me, “If you can define love, you don’t know it or have it.”

I agree, but one of my favorite attempts to define it comes from C. S. Lewis in his book, The Four Loves. (Some paraphrase, some quotes; disregard gender).

Falling in love is that very extraordinary experience that most often comes first in a delightful preoccupation with the “Beloved.” There is a general unspecified preoccupation with her totally. “A man in this state really hasn’t leisure to think of sex. He is too busy thinking of a person. The fact that she is a woman is far less important than the fact that she is herself. He is full of desire, but the desire may not be sexually toned. If you asked him what he wanted, the true reply would often be, ‘To go on thinking of her.’ He is love’s contemplative.”

There is little thought of sex with this love in the beginning stages. Men after sex want a woman. This man wants a particular woman. Love desires the Beloved herself, not the pleasure she can give. Love sees pleasure as a byproduct, not an end in itself. Sexual desire comes later for that shifts the attention inward, a focus on one’s own needs, a sensory pleasure occurring in one’s own body. Love finally obliterates the distinction between giving and receiving.

“Love is all there is!” Unknown

This is a story about falling in love that attempts to define it by asking you to take the journey and perhaps with your own association to know it more fully now or again in this moment, not through these words, but by your own memory/experience of what it is/was like for you.

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Prologue

Howard

In 1905, my great grandfather purchased four hundred acres of wilderness land on the narrow northern part of an island off the coast of South Carolina. He built a beach house on the ocean in a remote area on that parcel of land. A few years after that, the state agreed to designate that parcel as a “Wilderness Preserve.”

The coastline from the house stretched north to the tip of the island for about two miles and for about one mile south. From that southern point, there was about two miles of beach to the southern tip of the island. The first half mile was deserted, and rumor had it that a resort would be built on that land at some point in the future. There were a fair number of houses on that last one and a half mile of beach stretching to the southern tip of the island.

All our family lived in a small town on the mainland about seven miles from the beach house. It was heavily used over the years by most of our relatives. When Mom and Dad brought me for scattered weekends, Mom would pack a lunch for me, and I would stay gone all day exploring and pretending I was a great adventurer in a strange land. By the time I was in high school, I had covered what seemed like every inch of that land and knew it well. I felt like it was my own wilderness.

Over the years, most of our families stopped using the house and it was slowly deteriorating. There was talk among my father and his siblings of tearing the house down. At the time, I was in the Army and stationed overseas and when I got word of those plans, I asked them if I could purchase the house. There was some resistance, but they later agreed to let me purchase the house and the two acres surrounding the house with the understanding that the house and land would never be sold.

After being discharged from the Army, I went back to college with the help of the GI bill and finished a few undergraduate courses and graduated with a major in psychology. I went to graduate school and got my master’s degree and after several years of clinical training and supervision, I was granted a state license to practice psychotherapy.

A mentor of mine in graduate school introduced me to the work of Eckhart Tolle and his two books, The Power of Now and A New Earth. I was and am today fascinated with his approach to what I call ‘enlightened living.’ Every time I reread

the books or listen to the two books on tape, I learn something new. Some of his ideas are for me quite challenging and sometimes difficult to understand and apply to everyday living. I use his ideas to help my clients who are mostly suffering with panic and anxiety, and I use those same ideas to help me in my moment to moment living.

I love learning more about how to maximize the power of the brain/mind in all areas of life. My interest in meditation and hypnosis has led me down some interesting and exciting paths. I learned from Tolle how important it is to live in the moment where we can become free of aspects of our mind that lead us down the roads of pain and suffering. I learned how practicing and training to embrace a deeper silence can be the beginning of an inner peace that defies description. I learned something of the discipline it takes to live those ideas that have become for me the truth to freedom and inner peace which I call, “being Centered.”

I married Florence, a woman I met while in graduate school. We had two children, a girl, Simone, named after my grandmother. We called her Si. And two years later, a boy, Lance. We lived in town where I worked four days a week for a local mental health company doing outpatient psychotherapy. Florence worked in her father’s investment company.

When Florence had to work on the weekends, the kids and I would take off on Saturday morning and go to the beach house. They loved going there and roaming the beach. Most of the time, each of them took a friend and they would at times help me with my continuous work/projects on the house.

After about ten years, I had the beach house in good shape. I didn’t do much to change the original floor plan. There were two bedrooms. The main or master bedroom was medium large with a picture window facing the ocean. There was a guest bedroom on the same side of the house and the bathroom in between the two bedrooms. The main room was in the middle of the house and was large with a fireplace. There was a picture window on the ocean side and a door that opened onto a deck. The kitchen was large with an island and a table big enough to seat about eight people. On the ocean side of the kitchen, there was a wonderful nook with windows. There was a side door that opened outdoors to the parking area.

The kids in their high school years wouldn’t come with me as often as they did in the earlier years. Lance was busy with his friends. He and I were fairly close, but he loved his grandfather, Florence’s Dad, and would spend more and more time with him.

Si and I were close. She would come at least a couple of weekends a month and sometimes would bring her boyfriend Roger. When it was just Si and me, we would take long walks and talk about what was going on in our lives.

Before I knew it, Si was off to college. USC had recently built an extension of the university about forty miles away. She was majoring in psychology and wanted to be a psychotherapist like her dad. During those undergraduate years, I still saw her at least a couple of times a month. On our walks, we would talk about her courses. She had such a zest for life and was so eager to learn and understand how to help people with their problems.

On my days off when the kids weren't there, I loved taking day trips walking along the water. I would start off with a little beach chair attached to a shoulder strap that made it easy to carry, a light lunch and a book. I would stop at different places on the beach and read for a while and meditate. On my many explorations of the preserve, I had found an old steel rocking chair about ten feet from the beach and hidden by some brush and trees. That was my special space. I called it "my sanctuary." The only people who knew about it were Si and my best friend Henry.

While I was in the Army, I had gotten in the habit of exercising and since that time I had always jogged four or five times a week. It was so special to be able to run on the beach and my favorite time of day was early morning. I knew that exercise was very important for both my physical and mental health.

One evening while Si was still in graduate school, during one of our walks on the beach, she asked, "Daddy, do you love Mama?"

Pause. "Yes, I love your mother. Why do you ask?"

"I don't know. You all don't spend much time together. She is always working and you're here at the beach every free moment you have. It just doesn't seem like you all have much in common. Roger and I want to be together all the time and I can't imagine living like you and Mama."

"I remember when your mother and I felt the same way. For months it seemed like we were inseparable. In graduate school, we liked a lot of the same things. We shared political views; both went to the Episcopal Church, loved going on picnics and reading poetry to each other. But sometimes I think we didn't take enough time to really get to know each other."

I continued, "As soon as we were married, your mother started working for your grandfather and he demanded so much of her time. She complained about it in the beginning, but soon she seemed to accept it. Over a period of time, I think she was determined to prove to her grandfather that she was up for the challenge. As you know, she is very successful and I'm very proud of her."

"But are you happy Daddy?"

With some hesitancy and concern about how she would respond, I said, "Honestly Sweetie, I guess I have to go back to your first question about loving your mother. I do love her but not in a romantic way. Your mother and I care for

each other and respect each other, but I guess you could say we went in different directions and that very special love between a man and a woman just isn't there."

"Several years ago, we tried marriage counseling and went for about six months, and it helped us communicate more clearly but we agreed the love still wasn't there anymore."

She was quiet for a minute, and I was starting to regret saying anything. She reached over and took my hand, stopped me, and put her arms around me and held me tight and I looked down at her and lifted her chin and tears were rolling down her cheeks. Then tears welled up in my eyes and we stood there for a while holding each other. I got out my handkerchief and wiped the tears from her cheeks and then the tears from my own eyes.

As we walked on, she said, "Daddy, I just want you and Mama to be happy."

"Now I can answer your question, Si. I am happy and love the life I live. I get a little lonely sometimes, but I'm content. And you'll have to ask your mother the same question, but I think you'll get the same answer."

"I hate for you to be lonely Daddy. I know Henry's your best friend and you see him a lot. Right?"

"As you know, Henry works in construction, and he stays very busy. When I was working on the house, he would come out and help me when he could. As you know, I see him for lunch every week and occasionally we eat supper together. Si don't get me wrong. I love my solitude, but I would like someday to have that special love with someone."

She said, "I hope someday you'll find that person."

"Thank you, Honey."

We turned around and headed back to the house holding hands. Si had a nice surprise as we walked up the sand to the house. Roger was sitting on the deck waiting for us. She ran toward him, and they met and fell into each other's arms. Their wedding was planned for the summer after she finished graduate school.

She came up and gave me a hug and said, "Daddy, do you mind if Roger and I go for a walk?"

"Go ahead Honey. I'll have supper ready when you all get back." And they were off and I was relieved that Roger had come. I didn't know what else to say to Si and I was glad she had Roger to talk to.

I shared everything with Henry at lunch the following week. He kept on with his usual reminder that neither Florence nor I were ever going to find someone to love if we didn't get a divorce and move on.

Several weeks later, Florence and I met for a late supper in town. I told her about my conversation with Si and Henry. That night, we decided to get a divorce.

She confessed she had been seeing someone else at the office for about a year. I wasn't surprised.

Florence asked, "You're the counselor, what happened to us?"

I thought for a little while. "People asked me frequently, 'How do you keep the spark alive?' I always tell them you both must be conscious or awake and committed to making it happen. Learn how to communicate and I gave them a handout on 'The Art of Communication'. Set your goals and then have weekly check-ins to evaluate how you're doing. Most of the time people, including us, don't follow that advice."

She said, "We both thought it was a good idea at the time and initially worked on our communication skills and had our weekly check-ins, but after time, we just didn't do it anymore."

"I think our marriage counseling gave us some insights into why that didn't happen. Finally, we discovered we had more important things to do. Me, the beach house. You, your work."

She sighed with a faraway look, "What a shame. I'm sad, but I'm also ready to move on."

The week after, we both agreed it was best for me to move to the beach house. That was a sad day, but my love for the ocean and beach at all times of the year was unceasing. It was there I found a deeper peace and contentment. I seldom wore a watch to help me focus on the moment and it was as if time stood still and didn't exist in the normal way.

Soon after I moved in, Si and Roger brought me a housewarming gift. They made me go into the kitchen while they went out to Roger's truck to get the gift. When I was summoned, there were two little kittens looking at me from the sofa.

Si said, "We didn't want you to be lonely Daddy. I know you love cats and Mama didn't like cats, so this seemed to be a good time. This little orange and white is PJ and this is his sister GJ. I hope you don't mind that Roger and I named them."

Smiling, "Thank you all! No, not at all. This is the perfect gift."

I sat on the sofa and PJ immediately came and sat on my lap. GJ was not that interested. She had already jumped down and was checking out the house.

"We got everything you need Daddy so you're all set."

I thanked them again and asked them to stay for supper. They did and we had another great evening together. After they left, I cleaned up and went to bed. PJ was already on my bed and GJ was nowhere to be found. When I woke up the next morning, they were both asleep on the bed. I was glad to have cats in my life again.

Finally, I was settled where I had longed to be and I intended to spend the rest of my life here. I had been obsessed with this place. I had to face that as part of my responsibility for what got in the way of my relationship with Florence.

I had continued working at the mental health center but had been thinking about opening a private practice. I talked about it with my mom, dad, Si, Henry and some of my colleagues. The first few years would be a challenge building the practice and finding ways to get referrals from the local medical community. A psychiatrist in town had an office vacant and since we both specialized in treating anxiety disorders, it was a great fit.

At least one night a week, I would go over to a little out of the way restaurant on the inland side of the island. Sometimes, Henry would join me. Larry's was the best kept secret on the island, and he was a wonderful chef. Most of the time I would have a glass of wine and eat my meal at the bar and chat with Pete, the bartender. When the crowd thinned out, Larry would often join me at the bar and we would chat for a while. The place had a wonderful energy.

Several years after I moved into the beach house, I decided to build a small office near the house. I designed the structure to be built about one hundred feet south from the beach house in a clump of a few trees and a little closer to the ocean. Henry was now part owner of the construction company, and his workers built the structure, put in the plumbing and the electricity. On the weekends, Henry and I put in the trim and finishing touches.

It was built on stilts. My office was on the side facing the ocean and the waiting room and bathroom were on the side facing the mainland with a hallway running down the center of the building. I had a large picture window in my office that provided a wonderful view of the ocean.

I was concerned about the 30-minute drive from my old office, but I didn't lose too many clients in the transition. Also, I was the only psychotherapist on the island and the population was growing so I was very hopeful of being able to work three full days a week.

I loved my life. It was in this setting that I felt Centered and connected to life, to all of God's creation. I had my family and my friends and for the most part, I felt content and at peace.

At some point, I did want someone to love, but I found such comfort and peace here that I often wondered if at some deeper level I didn't want to take on the challenge of a relationship. Maybe that's what happened with Florence. Maybe after all, what I really wanted was to be a solitaire. No, not really. During my walking meditations on the beach and my sitting meditations, I would ponder the answer to those thoughts.

1

Tess

Even though I loved living and working at the beach, there had been some adjustments living away from town. I missed being closer to all my family and Henry. I still visited often and had Friday lunches with Henry but missed being able to drop by more often.

Si and Roger were married, and Si was working at the same mental health clinic where I had worked. It helped that they usually came out one or two Saturdays a month for long walks and then supper with me. Occasionally, they would spend the night. Si and I would talk on the phone at least two or three times a week.

Florence had opened an office for her father in Denver and Lance worked in that office. I would see him during the holidays when he came back for a visit. PJ and GJ were great company. GJ had finally warmed up to me, but she didn't like strangers. Yes, it was an adjustment, but overall, I was happy with my decision to move.

Si and Roger had their first child, Chase, who was born about two years after I moved into the new office. He looked just like his dad. I was a very proud grandfather.

After about four years in the new office, she called and asked if I treated Post Traumatic Stress (PTS). She was a helicopter pilot who had recently returned from Afghanistan and was suffering from PTS. We settled on a time and I gave her directions to the office. Her name was Tess Angelina.

When we sat down, I couldn't help noticing a scar on the left part of her face that ran down from about one inch behind her eye down her face and under her jaw. It was partly hidden by her hair. I wondered what had happened. Even with the scar, she was an attractive woman. She was appropriately dressed. Before she left that first session, she told me the story behind the scar and that her ear had been severed.

She was on Prozac and Xanax, as needed, and eager for me to help her get off the meds. She wanted to know my approach to therapy. I explained it was about helping her create a philosophy that would help her heal and that turning the philosophy into an experience would require work and training. She had some different ideas about therapy, and I didn't see her again for a couple of months.

When she came back, she said she had tried another therapist, and it didn't work out. She said I was the lesser of two evils.

I smiled, "I've been labeled and called worse."

After about seven or eight sessions, I realized I was looking forward to sessions with her more than normal. After a few more sessions, I faced the fact that I was teaching her to be more conscious/awake in her life and that I was conveniently unwilling to wake up and face the fact that I was growing fonder of her than was appropriate in a client/therapist relationship.

I told Henry and he immediately told me I needed to refer her to someone else. I told him I knew he was right, but there was something about this woman that stirred some deeper emotions, and I couldn't let her go yet.

Frowning, he said, "Are you out of your mind? I'm sure you could lose your license over this."

"She'll never know how I feel and she's making great progress and I wanna be able to continue to help her."

"If you wanna help her, let her go. And how do you know she can't tell by the way you look at her? Some women have great intuition."

I insisted, "She won't be able to tell."

"Howard, I'm sorry, but you're a lousy actor. She'll read you like a book."

"Henry, I can pull this off and if I thought I couldn't hide my feelings, I would refer her."

He said, "I think you're kidding yourself. You need to do some serious meditation about this. You've spent a lot of time teaching me what it means to be Centered and how to get Centered. I'm telling you now that you are not Centered. This is a terrible idea."

"I know you don't agree, but I need your help and I have no one else to talk to."

"Well, I certainly know you can't talk to Si about it. She would kick your ass and tell you to do the right thing and to stop worrying about yourself and consider what damage you might be doing to your client."

I hung my head. I knew he was right.

We sat in silence for a while. I don't know how much time lapsed before he put his hand on my arm. I looked in his eyes and could see his compassion. "I obviously don't know this woman, but I'm concerned for her and of course I'm also concerned for you. You've got to play the tape forward. I see this leading down a road where you're going to be in a lot of pain. This is a difficult situation and I hate to see you get hurt and most likely hurt someone else."

"I know. Thanks for listening."

"You can thank me by referring her! I've gotta run. I have an appointment back at the office in fifteen minutes. I can't be late. How about me coming out to

your place after work and we can walk over to Larry's and have a drink and get something to eat?"

"Yeah. That would be great." We stood, embraced and he was off. I sat there wondering what would be great about seeing Henry that evening. He was going to keep bugging me about referring Tess.

Hearing myself for the first time talk about Tess with anyone made me face more clearly the reality that I cared for her more than I had admitted to myself. Who was I kidding? I was falling in love with her and at some level I knew this was akin to professional suicide with untold personal grief and more importantly, even though I didn't want to admit it, I was putting her in danger. Henry was of course right. It had to stop.

I ran a few errands and couldn't get Tess off my mind. It was Friday and I wouldn't see her again until Tuesday. I put stuff up and then went for a run even though I had run earlier this morning. I needed to focus on my body and work my muscles and get into a rhythm that would help me let go of the tightness and tension.

I ran past the path to my sanctuary. Soon I turned around and headed there. I sat in the chair, closed my eyes and started rocking and taking slow deep breaths. When I opened my eyes, I could see parts of the ocean through the brush and trees. I needed to get Centered and find in this special space the strength to do what I knew was the right path with Tess.

I taught her about everything I know. My plan was to see her for about ten more sessions to work with her on the training aspect of the therapy. I knew she was ready to be on her own. She didn't need me or anyone else to guide or help her. She had the tools and the skills to continue her healing.

I closed my eyes and began my Centering meditation. I took some deep breaths and then scanned my body to let go of the tension. I opened every part of me to feel the soothing and peaceful energy of this space around me; the trees, the breeze, the sound of the waves, the gentle warmth of a few sunbeams and the sound of a seagull in the distance.

I have no idea how long before I was ready to create those thoughts that would set me free from that part of me that was not thinking about anything other than myself.

From Center, I began the litany of thoughts: 'I care for Tess and all that matters is her healing. I will let her go. I will pray for her and in meditation send her healing energy. I wish for her the experience of peace, love and healing.' I repeated those thoughts over and over.

Finally, I imagined in my mind that last session when I would perhaps never see her again. And even though I felt the pain, I accepted it as part of my healing

and letting it be. And then I was thankful to the Universe for the gift of Tess. A few tears ran down my cheeks. I took a few deep breaths and then I opened my eyes. I felt a huge burden lifted and at the same time felt a deep sadness. I committed to repeating this meditation several times every day until she returned on Tuesday.

When Henry arrived a little later and on our walk over to Larry's, I told him about my afternoon. He put his arm on my shoulder and said he was proud of me and would be there for me during the pain and sadness that would follow. We had a nice meal at Larry's, walked home and he left.

During the session with Tess this past Tuesday, we had been discussing that it was time for her to focus our time together on the training. I had told her I had taught her everything I knew and that the training was all that was left.

When she came for her next session on Tuesday, I reminded her that she had signed a release for me to talk about our sessions with a colleague friend of mine. I had explained at the time that we both shared cases of people we were working with who had signed the same release. I told her we exchanged ideas and offered suggestions about our approach or therapeutic interventions.

I lied and said to her, "We met last week to discuss cases and when I talked about you, he suggested I consider it might be helpful for you to do the training on your own with the stipulation that if that didn't work, you could call and come back for an additional session or sessions. What do you think about that idea?"

Pause. "Well, I don't know. As you know, I've been designing my own training for the past couple of sessions so I guess I could continue to do that and come back as needed. What did you think about his suggestion?"

"He thinks I have a tendency at times to keep people coming back for more sessions than are necessary. Sometimes I agree with him and sometimes I don't."

She asked, "What about this time?"

"I've spent considerable time thinking about it since he made the suggestion. I've been mediating on it and have come to this conclusion. I have told you several times that I seldom have a client who is as dedicated and who works as hard as you do. That makes my job much easier, and it is more satisfying to see someone who is committed to doing the work. That also makes it more enjoyable."

Smiling, as best I can, I continued, "So I think he is right. I have enjoyed working with you and have for the reasons I just gave have looked forward to you coming for the sessions. So, I'm reluctant to give up that enjoyment, but I do think he's right and it's time for you to see how you do on your own. And I think you will do fine and of course you can always call."

Pause. She asked, "How about if we have our session today and then I come back in two weeks and then try it on my own. What about that?"

“That sounds good.”

We finished our session and she left.

After my last client, I called Henry. “I pulled the trigger. She will come back for one more session and then she’ll work on her own. She knows she can call me if she needs help.”

“Good for you. I’m eager to hear all about it. I have to go now, but how about me coming out after work?”

“I was hoping you would.”

Henry would not arrive for a couple of hours. I have never felt such despair. I put on my running shoes and took off. It was finally becoming clear how much I loved this woman. I think I had repressed the depths of that feeling for several reasons. The first being of course that it was inappropriate and unethical to allow this to happen. The other reasons had something to do with a wall I had built around me to protect myself from being that vulnerable.

Sometime during the run, I ended up in my sanctuary. I must have been in some kind of trance. I didn’t remember anything up to that point. I closed my eyes and did some deep breathing. I needed a break from the noise in my head going on and on about how it would be okay to keep seeing her without her knowing how I feel. I did my Centering meditation from yesterday and felt some better.

I wondered if I ever loved Florence. We had such a wonderful court ship while in graduate school. Was I the one who early on shifted the focus of my life from her to the beach house? Did she start working late because I was gone? Or was it the other way around? The details were clouded. Why didn’t I approach her early and talk about us drifting apart? The marriage counseling had come years later and was too late.

And with Tess, I felt for the first time that without her nothing else in my life, apart from my family and Henry, would matter. Right now, even the beach house and my work would seem empty and meaningless. I had to keep working on getting Centered.

One of my male colleagues and I had discussed on several occasions the inherent danger of a male therapist falling in love with a female client. I remember talking about how we get to know some people at the very core of their being. Some lay every aspect of who they are at our feet and want our help. And there had been a few men and women who I remember thinking, ‘This is a wonderful person. Anyone who ends up with this person will be getting a gem.’ But until Tess, I had kept a wrap on letting any feelings stir that would be inappropriate, unethical, and put a female client in danger.

What was it about this woman who early on had called me ‘the lesser of two evils’? She was one of those gems. I envied her husband. As I walked back to the house, I realized that I was asking the wrong question. Tess was remarkable for sure, but there was a much more important question: How did I let this happen?

I would ask Henry to help me answer that question. In any other situation, I would have asked Si for help. But I couldn’t talk to her about this. She would be so disappointed in me. I couldn’t deal with that right now.

On my way back to the house, I just wanted to grieve the loss, to feel the sadness and to embrace the pain of not having Tess in my life. I couldn’t stop the tears that ran down my cheeks. As in all issues of life, it always for me comes down to ‘acceptance.’ That was one of my goals; there was no other choice if I was going to get over this.

When I got home, I showered, fed PJ and GJ and straightened up the house. I had some left-over lasagna, so I made a tossed salad and some garlic bread. Henry and I could eat out on the deck.

Shortly after that, I heard his truck. He came through the side door. “How you holdin’ up my friend?” He came over and gave me a hug.

“Pretty good. It’s been tough since she left this afternoon. You want a beer?”

“Sure. How many have you had?”

A slight smile, “Several.”

We went out on the deck. “Tell me how it went with her.”

I told him what I said to her.”

“Do you think she was suspicious or suspected anything? Like whether you were telling the truth or maybe an inkling of the sadness and pain you were feeling.”

“I don’t think so. I know I was looking for her reaction.”

“What could you tell?”

“She seemed a little disappointed, but nothing beyond that.”

He said, “What was that like?”

Pause. “Painful and I was in the depths of despair after she left. I don’t know how I got through my last two clients. They both seemed like we had a good session, but I know I wasn’t at my best. They deserve better.”

Pause. I continued, “If I had been Centered, it would have never happened. But now that it’s happened, I have to be awake and strong enough to stay in charge of my life and keep my unhealthy thoughts from contaminating my experience. This afternoon, after she left, I ran and spent some time in my sanctuary and did my meditation and felt like I made some progress.”

“How did you get Centered?”

“Our talks have helped. Since I told you last week, I have been more aware, more conscious of what was happening. It was like I had been in some kind of trance. I know better. I have no excuse for what I’ve been thinking and feeling.

I continued, “My first step is to accept it without judgment. The moment is what it is and judgment has no place in the process.”

“So, what do you do beyond acceptance?”

“Acceptance is a huge step, because it frees up energy from the self-condemnation to make good choices as I go forward. As you know, with every client, I help them set up a training program which is designed to help them heal. That’s what I now must do for myself. I’m fortunate as I have a lot of tools in my toolbox.”

Smiling, “Why didn’t you use those tools to keep from falling in love with Tess?”

“Would you like to take a shot at the answer?”

“Yes, because you weren’t conscious, awake, alert, present, aware or paying attention.”

“Bingo.”

“Why weren’t you awake?”

Pause. One of the things I like about Henry is that he never lets me off the hook on anything. Another thing is he is comfortable with silence. So, we sat a little longer while I pondered his question and then I said, “I’m not sure yet why I wasn’t awake, but I think it has something to do with a deeper longing inside me for love, intimacy, and a partner to share my life. Maybe at some unconscious level that need propelled what happened.”

More silence. I continued, “All I know is that somewhere around ten sessions with her, I woke up and realized I felt this incredible connection with her.”

Smiling, he said, “Like you wanted to get naked and connect?”

Smiling back, “No, not really, but she is very sensual.”

Laughing, he interrupted, “Even hotter than Ms. Evans in 8th grade? I would get hard just watching her move around the classroom.”

Smiling, “Maybe.”

Pause. I continued, “I think it’s a good sign that I haven’t thought much about her in a sexual way.”

He interjected, “Who? Ms. Evans or her?”

Smiling, “Shut up!”

“Sorry.”

“You’re fine.” Pause. “Before you got here, I couldn’t hold back the tears. There’s something so much deeper than anything sexual. It’s like my life won’t

seem complete without her and since I can't be with her, all I want to do is think about her."

"That's so different. You've always said all you needed was the beach house, the ocean, and the preserve to be happy and content."

"I know and now I'm convinced that I was running from the kind of intimacy that I mentioned earlier that would leave me vulnerable."

"Vulnerable to what?"

"To the unknown, the ambiguity, the impermanence of a relationship."

Pause. I continued, "Here at the beach everything has seemed permanent and comfortable. And when I'm Centered, I know that in life nothing is permanent. So, one of my goals is to be more Centered where ambiguity, impermanence and the unknown are part of the journey and there is an acceptance and peace about it."

He asked, "How do you get there?"

"By keeping my attention on those goals and doing the training to help me reach those goals the best I can."

Pause. I continued, "You know I've been teaching this for years and have just taken her through this rigorous training program to help her get more Centered in her life."

"How's she doing?"

"Right now, I think she's doing a lot better than I am."

"How so?"

"She has been willing to face all her demons and is making good progress in learning how to live without them. And at the same time creating her philosophy and then training very hard to live that philosophy."

"So, what are your demons?"

"I feel like in most aspects of my life I do a pretty good job of being Centered."

"For what it's worth, I think you're one of the most loving and compassionate people I've ever known."

"Thanks Henry. My demons I believe are all related to fear."

"What kind of fear?"

"I think it's relatively easy for me to be a kind and compassionate person. But back in the shadows, there is the fear of not measuring up, the fear of rejection, a lack of courage when it comes to taking a risk and so on. And now I'm beginning to consider that all those fears have gotten in the way of a chance for an intimate and loving relationship with a woman."

"Do you think that's what happened with Florence?"

"Yes. I think perhaps we were both in different ways terrified. I escaped to the beach, and she escaped to her work."

He asked, “With all those fears, what was going on when you fell in love with her?”

“Again, unconscious to the process and then this incredible attraction. She is like a dream come true.”

“And yet the dream is becoming a nightmare. So, what’s next?”

“A wise person once said, ‘We teach those things we most need to learn ourselves.’ I’ve been teaching people that the peace and love we long for can only be found at our Center within us. I’ve been training for years to be more Centered in my life and in most ways, I think I’ve made good progress. Now it’s time to focus on and do the training that will help me know and experience at Center that fear doesn’t exist. One of my favorite metaphors is that feelings like fear exist/live in darkness and they cannot exist/live in the Light of our Center. They can’t breathe.”

“Go on.”

“First, when I see her for our last session, I must let her go. Then I must work on a training plan to get Centered with the pain of losing her and then a training plan to find at my Center that peace that knows no fear.”

Pause. I continued, “I feel better. It’s helped me to talk to you about it.”

Smiling, “I’m glad. You’ve also given me some things to think about. You’ve been talking about getting Centered for some years now and as you know, we’ve done some meditations, but I’ve never really taken it that seriously. Now may be a good time to start.”

“I’ll be glad to help in any way I can.”

He asked, “Isn’t it possible that whatever kept you sleeping on the job with her will raise its’ head again?”

“Yes, in most situations, this is true. But not in this situation. I let this happen because I wasn’t paying attention. Here’s my point. I have been moving around some rocks outside to make a rock garden. The other day I was trying to position one of those rocks and mashed my finger. Why? Because I wasn’t paying attention. How long do you think it will be before I do that again?”

“A couple of days for you.”

Laughing, “Okay, I get it, but I can tell you because of the blood blister and pain, it won’t be anytime soon.”

“So, your point is you slept through this situation with her and because of the pain it’s caused you and maybe her, you’re not about to go back to sleep with another female client. Is that it?”

“Can we ever say never? Maybe not, but I will anyway because I can guarantee you this will never happen again with a female client. The traumatic imprint will keep me awake for as long as I’m doing psychotherapy.”

“But again, at some point won’t you need to figure out why you let this happen with her?”

“Yes, down the road after the dust has settled, I will need to figure that out. Not because it will keep me from repeating that with other female clients, but because as you suggested a few minutes ago, that same dynamic might raise its head in other situations in my life.”

He said, “Some months ago, you talked to me about Buddy who you described as the part of your mind that doesn’t work. You said Buddy was like your ego. What role did Buddy play in this situation?”

I responded, “During that conversation, I mentioned again that Eckhart Tolle is my favorite author. I suggested his book, The Power of Now, which does a great job explaining what he calls the observer and the observed. You have read The Power of Now, right?”

“Well, I’ve read some of it.”

“How much?”

Smiling, “Most of the introduction.”

“Got it. I have read his book several times and listened to it on tape and I still find it challenging to understand.” Smiling, “When you read it, he explains why his theory is difficult to understand.”

“Tolle would say something like when you fell in love with Tess, your ego was in charge of your life and you were not conscious. I described that as asleep at the wheel and not paying attention and so on. I have found it helpful to name that part of my mind, my ego, Buddy.”

“Why didn’t you talk about Buddy when we were talking about this a few minutes ago?”

“To be honest, I didn’t wanna go into it, because I don’t want to focus there right now. You keep bugging me about figuring out why/how I let this happen and I know I have to figure that out at some point, but this is not the time.”

“Okay, I’ll give it a rest, but I’m curious about Buddy. So, you can observe him when he’s in charge of a particular moment or series of moments?”

“Yes, if I’m awake.”

“What do you do when you wake up and realize he’s been runnin’ the show?”

“I do the best I can to get back into Center. And that’s what I’m doing with her.” I feel pretty Centered right now and I know what I need to do. Can we move on?”

“I just have a few more questions about Buddy. I’m trying to figure out how this works. I want to think about using this approach for myself to better understand what you call ‘getting Centered.’”

“We’ve been talking about it for some time now and I’m glad you’re more interested particularly in light of my recent struggle with getting Centered myself.”

“How do you feel about Buddy? Do you ever get angry at him?”

“No, I see Buddy as a child who wants what he wants, and he doesn’t care how he gets it. He is totally focused on himself. Again, my ego. If I’m conscious, I don’t judge him. If he gets loose, I accept his thinking/behavior and hopefully wake up and shift into Center.” Anger is always Buddy’s gig. So, when Buddy surfaces and I am awake or as Tolle would say, ‘conscious’, I say, ‘Shut up Buddy’.”

“You talk to him?”

“Yes, when I’m conscious and he attempts to take control.”

“Isn’t that what people do who have serious mental problems?”

“Yes, but the difference is they don’t know they’re talking to themselves, and I do.”

“How do you make that shift from Buddy being in charge to you being in charge at Center?”

“There’s a cousin of your question again.”

“Yes. This theory is not going to help me if I don’t get the question answered.”

“Got it. By doing the training. It takes time and work to reach the place where when Buddy slips a Focker thought into my life, I automatically think ‘tilt, red flag, hold up, wait a minute’ and so on. I intervene at that point by making the shift to Center telling Buddy to ‘shut up!’”

“So, you didn’t think, ‘tilt, red flag, hold up, wait a minute’ while Buddy was falling in love with her?”

“No, I didn’t.”

“Why not?”

“Okay, yes, at some point I have to figure that out. For right now, I know there is no excuse for not being conscious and every possible reason/excuse for not being conscious sounds like ‘special pleading’ which turns into BS.”

“The best I’ve got for you at this point is, maybe I was too focused on the therapy or maybe at some deeper level I longed for someone to love and was not awake enough to put the brakes on.”

Smiling, “So Buddy fell in love with her and when you finally woke up, you Howard realized you were in love with her.”

“Something like that.” Smiling, “Now I’m getting confused.”

Smiling he said, “Maybe I need to read Tolle’s book.”

“And I need to read it again.”

“Yes, you do! What now?”

“Now that I am Centered, I will not allow Buddy to do anything else to hurt her and will after the next session wish her well and tell her to let me know if she needs further help.”

“What if in a few weeks or months, she calls you and wants more help? What will you do?”

“I haven’t gotten that far yet, but it’s a very important question I have to address.”

“Would it be helpful if you make a commitment to me that if she does call, you will let me know immediately so I can ask you again, ‘what is your plan’?”

“Yes, that would be a great help!”

“Right now, you, Howard at Center are in a lot of pain. So how will you deal with it?”

“One step and one moment at a time.”

Smiling, “That’s a little vague.”

“I’m going to practice what I preach. Use the tools I teach everyone else.”

“Let me know how else I can help.”

“You’ve already been a huge help! Thanks for listening and for your questions and advice.”

“You’re welcome.”

“Are you hungry?”

“Yes.”

He helped me get supper together and we ate out on the deck. He had brought one of our favorite wines. I wasn’t very hungry, but I enjoyed the best I could some small talk while we ate.

Henry loved his work even though it was demanding and sometimes stressful. He was divorced with two children and had a good relationship with his kids. He shared custody with his ‘ex’ and fortunately they got along pretty good. His girlfriend was an alcoholic and that was an ongoing challenge, but he was ‘nuts’ about her. Her name is Jill.

He offered to help with the dishes, but I told him they could wait until tomorrow.

He asked, “Are you okay?”

“Yeah, again, I feel better thanks to you.”

“Good. I better get going. You still seeing clients tomorrow and Thursday?”

“Yeah, I’ve got a full schedule both days.”

He said, “As difficult as it may be, remember what you said about acceptance. Sounds like that can help.”

“Thanks, I need those reminders!”

“Remember, I’m going with Jill this weekend to visit her parents but call if you need me. I’ll check in with you sometime before our lunch Friday.”

“Thanks!” We embraced and he left.

I watched the taillights of his truck disappear through the trees. I teared up again. It was such a new experience here at the beach house for me to feel anything other than peace and happiness. I looked up at the stars and felt a tinge of hope that I would find my way through the pain.

The Last Session

Henry and I met for lunch on Friday. I told him I was doing a little better.

“What has helped?”

“Our talk on Tuesday after work was a big help. I have continued to meditate and have been working on a training plan to help me move on.”

Pause. I didn’t have much of an appetite, but I was forcing myself to eat as healthily as possible. Susie’s was known for her healthy food.

He said, “You’re just picking at your food.”

“I know.”

“Well, it might help if you ordered something other than a seaweed and tofu salad. Here, take a big bite of my grass fed hamburger.”

Smiling, “Thanks, I’ll pass this time. I’ll work on this grilled piece of chicken. You have some catsup running down your chin.”

He wiped it. “Sure, you don’t want a bite.”

He continued eating his hamburger and sweet potato fries. Nothing looked or tasted good to me.

I said, “I did some thinking last night and I want your opinion.”

“Go ahead,” as he stuffed some fries in his mouth.

“The ethics handbook for psychotherapists states that we can have no social contact with a client until two years after the last therapy session.”

“Well, it’s a no brainer where this is going. So, in two years, you’ll call her up and ask her for a date or just walk up behind her in The Market and pinch her on the fanny and say, ‘Hey it’s me!’”

Smiling, “Hey I’m in pain. You’re supposed to be empathetic and serious.”

Smiling, “Or you could call her and say, ‘Hey it’s Howie. I have a room over at the Hampton Inn. Would you like to come over to my room, have a drink and get naked?’”

More catsup down his chin.

“You have more catsup....”

“I know.”

I continued, “Seriously, I’m thinking after the two-year period, I might figure out some way to make some kind of contact.” Smiling, “In the meantime, you could keep tabs on her and let me know what’s happening in her world.”

“So, you’re going to put your romantic life on hold for two years?”

“My romantic life has been on hold for at least twenty years. Two more won’t make a difference and it’ll be worth the risk.”

“So, in the meantime, I’m supposed to be your ‘private dick’ for these two years.”

“Yeah, isn’t that’s what friends are for.”

Pause. “Well, I might be willing to do that since I’ve already checked her out.”

“You what? You don’t even know her name.”

“It’s a small town and I have my ways. Don’t ask any questions. I’ve checked her out. Her first name is Tess. Her husband heads up a big accounting firm in Charleston and has a small office here in town. He commutes between offices. They have two kids. She is a helicopter pilot who lost an ear in Afghanistan. They go to Southside Episcopal Church.”

“How did you do that? I didn’t tell you anything about her.”

“No, you didn’t. Again, I have my sources.” Pause. More serious, “So this idea makes you feel better. Gives you some hope?”

“Yes, and it goes against my whole philosophy about living in the moment and not being caught up in the past or the future.”

“You’ve got some work to do. I gotta run. Your last session with her is a week from Tuesday, right?”

“No, it’s next Tuesday. She called and rescheduled due to two weeks at summer camp starting the week we were scheduled.”

“Do you want to meet over at Larry’s after I get off work?”

“I would rather you come to the house.”

“It’ll do you good to get away from the house.”

Reluctantly, “You’re probably right.”

“See you then.” As he was leaving, “Call me if you need to talk before then. Remember, Jill and I are going to her parents this weekend.”

“Got it.”

On my way home, I went over to see Mom and Dad. They seemed to be doing fine other than a few aches and pains. Then, I ran a few errands and went home. I had some work to do outside. It was hot. After, I took a short nap and showered.

Henry was right. I did need to get out of the house. I decided it was too hot to walk. On the way to the truck, I looked at the office thinking next Tuesday would be the last time I would see her for a long time. I stood there for a minute and wished there was some way I could have something of hers. If it were wintertime and cold, she might leave a scarf or something. I needed something to smell and touch. No chance this time of year.

Henry and I had a few beers and visited some with Pete at the bar. It was crowded so we ate a sandwich and soon after told Pete to tell Larry we would see him next week.

As we left, he said, "I wanna come out to the house next Tuesday after your last session."

"Thanks."

He turned around as he was heading for his truck and said, "Remember to follow your own advice and stay Centered as best you can."

As I drove back, I was glad he didn't bring up Tess at Larry's. I needed that break too. I was still puzzled how he knew about her. I know I didn't tell him her name, but did I let her first name slip? I'm almost positive I didn't. If I did, the violations were piling up. I was too young to retire, but if I didn't get my stuff together, I could be forced to retire."

When I got home, I watched more mindless TV as a distraction and fell asleep on the sofa. When I woke up, PJ was sleeping at my feet and GJ was sprawled out on the floor. I went to bed and had a restless night.

I was glad that Si, Roger, and Chase were coming out to spend the day tomorrow. They were going to have lunch with me and were heading back later in the afternoon to spend the evening with friends. I was determined to be myself and not let Si know there was something wrong.

After lunch, Roger suggested Si and I go for a walk. He wanted to spend some father/son time with Chase and then would put him down for his nap.

We hadn't gotten very far when Si said, "Daddy, you don't seem like yourself. Is anything wrong?"

I hated lying to her. We prided ourselves in being open with each other about challenging situations in both our personal and professional lives. I couldn't handle telling her now. I was so embarrassed. She would be so disappointed in me. She had told me before that it was wonderful having me as a father and a mentor.

"Honey, I'm fine. I haven't been sleeping well and feel tired."

"Any ideas why you're not sleeping well?"

"Not really."

"When was your last physical exam?"

"My annual is due in a couple of months."

"Daddy, you've always been so healthy. Promise me you'll see your PCP before the two-month visit if this keeps up."

"I will Honey."

We had a nice walk and she talked about her work with different clients, and she asked my advice on several interventions she was considering.

When we got back to the house, Chase was still up and was resisting a nap. They decided to head home. Hugs and kisses and they were off.

I got up Sunday morning and after some breakfast, I decided it was time to finalize my two-part training plan. This first part will include two meditations a day. The setting could be anywhere, but I knew for the most part it would be in the rocking chair at my sanctuary or walking on the beach or at the house.

The meditations would be about twenty minutes each. The goal would be to separate them by at least four hours. I decided to write out the meditation in the second person and then record it on my phone. That worked well with a lot of my clients. It's like you become your own mentor as you guide yourself through the experience.

Meditation

“Begin this meditation by knowing you can open or close your eyes at any time. Now have the intention of making this a very powerful experience to help with healing and Centered living. Begin by using deep breathing to slow mind chatter and to help with focusing on the meditation..... Do a body scan to help release any physical tension and tightness..... Recall momentarily feelings associated with your past inappropriate behavior..... Recall what that felt like in your body..... Now do more deep breathing and more body scans taking a few more moments to experience relief in both your mind and your body.....

Now, go to your Center, your sanctuary. You may already be there in person or if not imagine you are there and open every part of you to feel the soothing and peaceful energy of this space around you; the trees, the breeze, the sound of the waves, the gentle warmth of a few sunbeams or the sound of a seagull in the distance or whatever your senses engage. Let it all bathe your mind and body in its radiance. Feel the freedom, the tranquility, the acceptance, the joy, and anything else that unfolds. Take a few more moments.....

Now go over in your mind your Centered thoughts. ‘I love Tess and all that matters is her healing. I will let her go. I will pray for her and send her healing energy. I wish for her the experience of peace and love in her life. I will learn to live without her and focus my life the best I can in the moment. And every day I will renew my passion for acceptance of each moment without judgment.’ Take a few more moments to let all of that sink in.....

As you continue sitting or walking, remember those Centered thoughts you were just thinking and in whatever order they come to you begin saying them to yourself and then out loud and then louder and then scream them over and over again. Do all of that in your mind if it seems more comfortable. Repeat these

thoughts a number of times until you feel the energy of them in your body as they come alive inside you. More time to repeat them.....

Spend some time thinking and repeating the following statements or something similar, 'I'm integrating these thoughts. They are growing stronger and stronger. They will become more and more powerful. I am determined to stay Centered. More time for integration.....

Imagine in your mind after that last session when you will perhaps never see her again. And even though you can feel the pain, you accept it as part of your healing and let it be what it is. Imagine in your mind each day and feel yourself healing and making peace with your life as it is. See yourself growing and becoming more Centered and living in the Light of peace and freedom. Imagine yourself reawakening your love for all that is here in this space that reminds you to celebrate and be thankful for each moment. And finally grateful for those few months to have known and loved this wonderful and amazing woman. Take as much time as you need and when you're ready, let this meditation be over for now."

Short Integration Training (Do this Sporadically during the Day)

The second part of my training plan includes a three step (Three Stepper) experience that will also help with getting more Centered in my life. The first step is to take three or four deep breaths to slow the mind chatter. The second step is to do a 15-30 second body scan to release tension in my body. The third is to repeat out loud or to myself Centered phrases that speak to my situation in that moment. Examples include: "I can do this." "I will be fine." "I will be more Centered." "I will accept this moment as is." "I can and will embrace the moment." And so on.

I printed the meditation, straightened the house, put on my running clothes, put the meditation script and phone in my pocket and headed north for my run. It was a beautiful morning with a few clouds on the horizon and a gentle breeze. I ran to the tip of the island and then turned back toward my sanctuary. I walked and practiced the Three Stepper and when I reached the sanctuary, I sat for a while, did some deep breathing, and just soaked in the moment and the beauty and all that went with it. Then I recorded the meditation on my phone. I then listened to it and sat for a while longer and headed home.

I spent the rest of Sunday writing and watching some mindless TV. Had a couple of beers and a sandwich for supper, called Mom and then went for a walk. I teared up several times but was able overall to appreciate the beauty of the twilight. And I was thankful for the countless number of blessings.

Henry called me that night to check on me and tell me about his weekend. He said he would be over Tuesday after work.

Monday, I spent most of the day writing and doing chores around the house. I did my meditation at the sanctuary after my morning run and then did it again later in the afternoon. During my time at the beach, I practiced the Three Stepper. Most of the day at short intervals, I also worked on visualizing the last session with Tess.

She was coming at ten tomorrow. I had not scheduled anyone for nine or eleven. I wasn't sure what kind of shape I would be in either before or after.

I had a restless night and couldn't sleep anymore after five. There was a little chill in the air, so I put on a sweatshirt and walked up to the sanctuary. About halfway, the sun peeped up over the water. There were a few clouds on the horizon, and it was a beautiful sunrise. I walked along the edge of the water, and it felt good on my feet. I did a bunch of Three Steppers on the way. My short phrases along the way were something like, "I can do this. I can live without her and be okay for now."

When I got to the sanctuary, I spent some time remembering all our sessions and how much I had enjoyed them and looked forward to every time she was on the schedule. I could not at this point imagine living my life without her. In the back of my mind, there was always a hope that after two years there might be a chance we could be together. I did my meditation and had some difficulty concentrating, but overall, I felt a little better after it was over.

When I got back to the house, I had a cup of coffee, forced down a piece of toast, took a shower and then headed over to the office. It was about 9:30. I got out my charts on the clients I would be seeing today, did a quick review of each one and had ten minutes before Tess would arrive. I spent that time taking some deep breaths and doing the best I could to get Centered. The bell rang right at 10.

After a little small talk, she said, "I feel like I'm making good progress with the panic and the flashbacks. I'm focusing a lot of my training now on what we worked on the last two sessions. I am patient, but eager to reach the place where I don't have any more of those experiences. And since the last session, I haven't had either one."

We spent most of the session talking about her training plan and sharing ideas about changes she might make to improve it.

We had discussed early in our sessions that she had been grounded from flying since the accident in Afghanistan and how important it was that she be cleared to fly again. Her Commanding Officer said he would need a letter from me and her physician stating that she was cleared to fly. I told her I would write that letter after she had six months with no panic attacks and no flashbacks. I told her to send me an email after three months and then another after six months to give me an update on her progress.

It was about 10 minutes before 11. I said “I don’t know how often you come over from the mainland to the island, but there is a chance we might run into each other. My mom, dad, daughter, and her husband live in town, so we could also run into each other over there.”

She asked, “What do we do?”

“If I see you in a setting where there are other people and you also see me, I will smile, but will pretend I don’t know you. If you were talking to someone and stopped me and introduced me as a friend or my hair stylist or my whatever or my therapist and so on, that would be fine. I would play whatever role you attached to me.”

She asked, “What if we see each other and we are in a setting where there is no one else around or anyone around we know?”

“I will smile, but not stop unless you wanted me to stop at which point you could say, ‘Hey you!’”

“And if I want another appointment, I can just call and schedule. Right?”

“Sure.”

“Could we have lunch together at some point?”

“In our field, we cannot have any contact of a social nature with a client until after two years following the last appointment.”

“Got it. That sucks. Oh well, maybe we’ll run into each other after two years has passed.”

“Maybe we will.”

I continued, “Sometimes, people have to come back for more therapy after a year or so. Any ideas why they have to come back?”

Smiling, “They missed the view from your office?”

Smiling back. “Maybe. Any other reason?”

She blurted out, “They stopped doing the training!!!”

“Yes!!” I blurted out.

Pause. She was looking out the window. The silence felt a little awkward. She said, “The view is beautiful from here. I wish I had a dollar for every time I looked out that window with tears in my eyes.” Pause. “Another thing I’ve discovered is that crying now feels so easy and freeing and, in some ways, very soothing.”

Smiling, “What’s the difference?”

She smiled back, “Acceptance!”

“As I’ve told you, I have never had a client who has worked so hard to stop the pain and suffering and to find and discover the Light within. I am so pleased that you’ve found your truth to freedom.”

“I’ve never had a better teacher. You have even topped Hotdog Harris (her combat helicopter instructor) and that is a great compliment. Both of you with

different styles and personalities have saved my life. Hotdog, my actual life and you, my Spiritual, mental, and physical life and being.”

“Thank you for the compliment. I have one final question?”

She laughed, “I knew you would pull something like that. Anything to make sure I stay conscious. Go ahead Howard.”

“I had lunch with a colleague the other day and we were sharing some about our approach to therapy. He made the statement, ‘we cannot know love unless we have known it’s opposite.’ What would your response be to that statement?”

“I would share with him something like this. ‘Over the past months, I have been in training with someone who taught me how to slow down my thinking mind and explore the depths of a silence where there is no thinking. It was in that inner silence, in that space that I experienced and discovered a love beyond words or description. A love that knows no opposite, a warm and soothing energy that permeates all with its peace that passes all understanding.’”

We smiled and held each other’s gaze for a moment and then abruptly she said, “I have to go!” And she was gone.

I heard her go down the stairs and the outside door close and I went to the waiting room to look out the small window that overlooks the parking area making sure she wouldn’t be able to see me if she looked up. She was wiping her eyes with a Kleenex. When she opened her car door, the Kleenex fell to the ground. She started her car and left. I wiped the tears from my eyes and waited a minute and then went down to pick up the Kleenex.

I smelled it and then put it in a plastic bag and sealed it and put it by my bed. I went back to the office and drank the water from her glass and ran my tongue around the rim of the glass. I sat down in the chair she had been sitting in and sat there for a while hoping to feel her energy. I was desperate for any little touch of intimacy which would have to last me for two years and maybe for as long as I lived.

As far as I know, she never knew how I felt about her. I am aware of no indication at all. In my behavior, I was very appropriate. It was only in my head and my heart that I crossed that very clear line between a therapist and client. And I really believed that she could not have known how I felt. I would have to do the training to reach an acceptance of the situation. However, I could not imagine ever reaching the space where I would not grieve this loss of her for the rest of my life.

The rest of the day in the office was miserable. Luckily, my last two clients called, cancelled and rescheduled. After my last client left, I thought maybe it would have been better if those two clients had not cancelled. Now, I had two extra hours to think before Henry would get here.

I decided to spend those two hours walking on the beach. It was a beautiful day with the temperature around 80 and the usual gentle breeze. I decided to skip my afternoon meditation and just do a lot of Three Steppers as I walked. There were many facets of my goals to move on with my life, but one of the main goals was of course acceptance of the situation. There was nothing I could do and the only response that made any sense was to accept what was and what is and what would be for the next two years and maybe for the rest of my life.

3

Confessing to Si

Henry called and said he was running late and would be at my house around seven. Said he had eaten a big lunch and didn't want much to eat. I made a salad and some garlic bread. When he arrived, we got a beer and went to the deck.

He asked, "How did it go?"

"Before we start with me, I'm glad you had a good weekend with Jill and her parents."

"It was nice and as I told you, Jill stayed sober. She doesn't drink around her parents unless she's in a bad place. Tell me about today."

I told him about my morning before Tess arrived.

"I felt pretty Centered, and the session went as well as I could have expected. I made sure I was free the hour before and the hour after."

"Wise decision!"

"Yes, it was. My greatest fear was that she would be able to tell how hard it was to say goodbye."

"Do you think she had a clue?"

"No, I don't. She asked me about meeting for coffee at some point. I told her about the two-year rule. She said that sucks which I was glad to hear. She did say that who knows maybe we'll run into each other after two years."

Smiling, he said, "Well, maybe there's hope."

"Maybe. We'll see. Two years right now seems like an eternity."

"I got that."

"I went through with her my usual briefing about us running into each other. Then I told her I had never had a client work as hard as she did. She told me that I was one of the two best teachers she had ever had."

"Did that compliment help any?"

Smiling, "Not really. She gave me a lot of pushback in the earlier sessions, but in the end, I knew she thought I was good teacher."

"How did you end it?"

"I told her I had one final question for her, and she smiled and said I knew you would have another test question."

"What was the question?"

"I asked her to tell me how she would respond to someone who made this statement in her presence. 'We cannot know love unless we have known its' opposite.'"

"What did she say?"

“After she left, I wrote it down the best I could. Wait, I’ll get it. I put it on my bedside table..... She said something like, ‘I have been training with someone who taught me how to slow down my thinking mind and experience a silence where there is no thinking. In that inner silence, in that space I discovered a love beyond words or description. A love that knows no opposite, a love that permeates all with its peace that passes all understanding.’”

“Is she talking about romantic love?”

“No, she is talking about spiritual love.”

“Why did you put it on your bedside table?”

Pause. “It’s little part of her.” I started to tear up.

“Now don’t start crying. You’ll spoil my appetite.”

“I thought you said you weren’t hungry.”

“You’re right. Go ahead and cry if you want to.

“I’m okay.”

“Go ahead and finish up. I need another beer.”

“After she gave her response to the question, we held each other’s gaze for a moment and then she got up rather abruptly and said, “I have to leave.”

I continued, “After I heard the door downstairs close, I went to the waiting room and looked out the window careful to position myself so she couldn’t see me if she looked up. She didn’t look up, but I saw her wiping tears from her eyes. As she was getting in the car, she dropped the Kleenex. Several minutes after she pulled away, I went and picked up the Kleenex. I took it in the house and put it in a sandwich bag and put my nose in it and took in a deep breath to see if I could get a glimpse of her scent. I knew not five minutes ago the Kleenex had been next to her face, to her lips. It was an intimate moment. I put it on my bedside table with the quote.”

“Wow, you are ‘smitten’!”

“That’s not all. I went back to the office and drank the rest of her water and then closed my eyes and ran my tongue around the edge of the cup. It was like I was kissing her lips. Then I sat down in the chair she had been sitting in and closed my eyes and did deep breathing to take in any particles of energy that might have been left.”

“That’s some crazy shit Howie.”

“That gives you a glimpse of how smitten I am. She has shared with me the most intimate details of her life. Things she has not shared with another person. And I glimpsed into her soul during some of the meditations. She is a dream come true and I don’t know if I’ll ever even have the chance to have another conversation with her.” I started to tear up again.

He asked, “How did you do during the session?”

“Again. I don’t think she has a clue how I feel about her. I was able to keep it very professional.”

“What about her leaving abruptly and crying on the way to her car?”

“As I said a few minutes ago, she has shared things with me she has never told anyone else. It is a wonderful experience I think for any of us humans to be able to share on that level and not be judged. There’s a natural connection and a kind of intimacy that goes with it. I think that’s why she asked about us meeting for a cup of coffee. It’s more like she wanted to be friends because I think I have become an important person to her. Somebody she can trust. So, the tears suggest she will miss our sessions together.”

“So, you don’t think her behavior suggests there are some deeper feelings beyond losing a great friend?”

“I don’t know. I’m just saying it’s very possible and perhaps more likely that there are no romantic feelings.”

“What about you mentioning the ‘love’ word?”

“She would understand it, I think, in the same way I meant it. It was a philosophical statement common to a particular way of understanding the general nature of the human experience of love. I know she saw it as a test question related to her grasp of the philosophy, I had been suggesting all through our training sessions.”

He said, “I need another beer.”

“Me too. You wanna eat now?”

“Sure.”

We both picked at our food and drank our beer in silence.

He finally said, “I didn’t realize how much you love this woman. I kept thinking you’re just missing having a relationship and this is more like a passing infatuation particularly since it’s a client and eventually you will come to your senses.”

Pause. He continued, “I know you’ve been telling me different, but I don’t think I wanted to believe it.”

“Why?”

“Because as I mentioned before, in a situation like this, you’re headed for a lot of pain. I didn’t want to see you suffer.”

“Thanks Henry.”

More silence. Finally, he said, “I guess I better get going. I have to be on site in the morning at five. I’ll see you for lunch on Friday. If you need me before then, don’t hesitate to call. You know I’m ‘in’ for this part of your journey. Whatever you need and whenever you need it, I’ll be there the best I can.”

“I know it. That means a lot!”

We hugged and he was gone. I sat there under the stars for a while and wondered what Tess was doing. Was she missing me just a little? I was glad I had two full days of clients ahead of me. I needed to get Centered and focus on doing my job and being there for my family.

The next two weeks or so were uneventful. I missed her terribly and realized for now, it's important to focus on having structure and things to do. I didn't need a lot of idle time to let my mind do the 'poor me' and 'ain't it awful' attitude. Each day I set aside a special time to walk on the beach and allowed myself to miss her, to grieve, to dream, to remember special times in sessions and so on. Then, I did the best I could to move on with my life taking one moment, one day at a time.

I was full fledge into my training plan and all three workdays each week had been full. I was focusing more on my writing and spending more time visiting Mom and Dad. Si, Roger, and Chase had been out last Saturday to spend the day. Si was about six months pregnant. A little girl was on the way. They were going to name her Dorothy after Roger's grandmother and call her Dottie.

When Henry and I were together, we spent some time talking about Tess, but during our last supper at Larry's two evenings ago, her name did not come up. I had made the effort not to bring her up. It was part of my commitment to do the best I could to move on with my life. However, I did have a dream about her last night and Henry and I were meeting for lunch today and I wanted to talk about the dream.

I was waiting at our usual table at Susie's when Henry walked in looking like he was having a bad day.

"What's wrong?"

"Is it that obvious?"

"Yes, to me it is."

"When I got home last night, Jill was in bed, and I thought she was taking a nap. I gently touched her and she didn't move. Then, I said, 'Jill, wake up Hon.' She didn't stir. I looked at her more closely and could tell she was passed out drunk.

I decided to let her sleep it off. Later' she came out of the bedroom crying saying, 'I'm so sorry Babe. I just got so depressed this afternoon.' She came over and sat on my lap and just kept crying. She finally calmed down and fell back asleep and I carried her and put her back to bed."

"Henry, I'm so sorry."

"I know. Thanks. We talked this morning, and she has agreed to go to that inpatient treatment center in Charleston you've been talking about. I think it's a six-week program, right?"

"Yes, that's right."

He said, "I'm trying to get Centered myself. As I've told you before, I'm not sure how much longer I can take this. Henry Jr. and Pearl want me to let her go. They don't think she will ever recover. We have all heard a lot of promises. However, this will be her first treatment center. Maybe this will work. I'm going to hang in there. You know I'm crazy about her; I don't wanna lose her."

"The Center where she is going has a great reputation. They do good work. As you know, however, it will be up to her."

"I know. How you doin'?"

"I'm doing pretty good. Did you wanna talk more about Jill?"

"Not much else to say. Tell me about you."

"I'm staying on plan and it's helping. I dreamed about her last night which didn't help. I was doing something in Charleston, and I looked across the street and there she was with another man."

"Was it her husband?"

"I don't know. I've never seen him. I followed them from the other side of the street, and they were arm and arm laughing and having a great time. They ate outside at a little café. They looked so happy together. After eating they walked down the street and went into a hotel and disappeared."

"Whatta you make of it?"

"I haven't attempted any dream interpretation to speak of. I've always seen dreams as very complicated. So, I won't attempt any interpretation. It just reminded me how painful it is to think about her being in someone else's arms. Maybe the dream forces me to face more clearly the reality she is married and if she gets a divorce, what's to keep her from finding someone else? It makes me realize that I have to keep working on myself and I have no control over the future."

We spent the rest of lunch talking about how Henry is going to help Jill make arrangements for going to the treatment center. He spent the rest of the time talking about work stress. He said he will have his hands full over the next week, so we planned not to see each other until next Friday.

He said, "Oh, I forgot to tell you Tess has not been to church at Southside for a number of weeks, but her husband and two kids are there every Sunday."

"Thanks. Sometimes I feel like we're spying on her which we are, but it helps me so much to know a little about her life."

"Well, it's not serious spying. No one is following her, but I have a few people who know of her, and they let me know without knowing why I want to know. They are good enough friends that and they don't ask. It's more like gossip. See you next Friday."

Three weeks passed.

Si was coming out tomorrow by herself. Roger had to work, and Chase was spending the weekend with Roger's mom and dad. Si had said several times in the last month or so that she thought I still seemed distracted and kind of withdrawn. I had said I was just tired, and she asked me again when I would see my PCP. I told her it was next month.

It was so hard to keep things from her. She knew me so well and could tell if I wasn't myself. I had decided to tell her about Tess tomorrow.

She arrived around nine. We sat in the kitchen nook, had a cup of coffee, talked about her pregnancy, how she was feeling and exchanged news about family, work and so on.

She asked, "How about a nice long walk?"

"Sounds good."

On our walks over the years, we walk up to the northern tip and then back to the house. Gives us a four-mile walk.

I asked, "Are you up for the usual walk?"

"Most definitely. I'm still walking every day."

It was a beautiful fall day. A little warm but the usual nice gentle breeze.

We walked in silence for a while, which was normal for us. We liked being together and not talking. Sometimes during that time one or the other of us would stop and hold out our arms indicating 'I need a hug'.

As we turned around at the northern tip, she asked, "Daddy, it's time for us to talk. I made arrangements for Chase to stay with his Pawpaw and Memaw so we could have this time together. Please tell me what's going on."

We walked on for a few more minutes and then I said, "You are so important to me not only because you're my daughter, but also because I feel like we can share anything with the other without being judged. That's a precious gift I think we both treasure."

"Yes, I feel that way too."

"Do you agree that neither of us feels an obligation to tell the other 'everything' that's going on in our lives?"

"Yes, very much so. There are things very private and special I only share with Roger."

"What I am about to tell you seemed for a while to be in that category. I want to quickly say that my health is fine so don't go there as you imagine what I am about to tell you."

"Thanks, that's exactly where I was afraid you were going."

"For a while, I kept telling myself that I didn't want you to worry, but I've known all along that I was too embarrassed and didn't want you to be disappointed in me."

She interrupted, "So, are you having an affair with a married woman?" Smiling, "Or have you discovered you're bisexual and are having an affair with a married man?"

Smiling back, "No, neither one of those." Then more serious. "It's somewhat worse than both of those."

More serious, "So are you having an affair with a client?"

"Not exactly."

"Okay, I'll shut up."

As we walked, I told her the whole story from the beginning to now. I told her that I would of course leave out things that would reveal her identity. I gave her name as Lucy. I also left out the part about picking up the handkerchief, drinking her water, running my tongue around the rim of her glass, and sitting in the chair she had sat in. Those did in my view fit into the same category as her private thoughts/experiences she only shared with Roger.

She never interrupted me, and several times got a Kleenex out of her pocket and wiped her tears. Without even being consciously aware, we had completed the last of our walk and were sitting on the deck when I finished the story.

She continued to wipe an occasional tear. After some silence, she softly asked, "You know why I'm crying, right?"

"I'm not sure Honey, but I have a few guesses."

"Well, I don't want you to guess. I know you have been perhaps unconsciously searching and longing for a kind of 'soul mate' for a long time. You said this beach house and this space was all you needed to be content and happy, but I knew different. I never doubted the importance of this space to you, but I knew it would never fulfill your longing for that special kind of love."

More tears, "And now you've found Lucy and the chances of a life with her are not good. I can hardly stand to think of the pain you must be feeling."

She started weeping. We both stood at the same time and fell into each other's arms, and I couldn't hold back my own tears.

I don't know how long we stood there, but she said, "I have to go to the bathroom."

I had to go too and when I was finished, she was sitting in the kitchen nook. She said, "I need a cup of coffee."

Sure, "I need a beer."

We sat for a while and looked out at the water.

She said, "I'm glad you had Henry to talk to."

"He has been a big help, but also said from the beginning I was making a big mistake on several fronts. And of course, he was right."

She asked, "Tell me again why you didn't refer her when you knew you were crossing that line."

“I know there are no excuses for this behavior. When I realized I had crossed that emotional line, I started rationalizing that I was helping her and convinced that I could remain professional and do my job until it was time for her to end the sessions. That was a risk I should never have taken.”

“How do you know that she couldn’t tell how you felt?”

“There was never any indication on her part.”

“What about when she cried after the last session?”

“I can’t be sure, but I assume you have had men and women over the years tear up at the end of the last session. So, I don’t think her tears were any different, but I don’t know for sure. But I feel confident that she had no clue about how I felt.”

“But you can’t know for sure. You have always been my hero in so many different areas. I am disappointed you took this risk with her. It’s out of character for you, but I know you’re human. It’s going to take me some time to digest all of this or as we say in the business, to process it. I’m going to head on home and will check in with you tomorrow.”

“I understand Honey, I’m so sorry to disappoint you.”

She gave me a hug and left. As I watched her car disappear down the road, I knew that I had betrayed the most important person in my life. Whatever happened in the future, I knew nothing would ever take away the regret and shame. Nothing would ever be worth the hurt I saw in her eyes.

She called me the next morning, “Hey Daddy, how you doin’?”

“Still feeling terrible about this whole situation. You didn’t need this kind of behavior from me and especially being pregnant. I will always regret it. It was very selfish of me on many fronts.”

“Last night, I told Roger the whole story. He thought I was being a little too hard on you. He pointed out there was no unethical behavior on your part. Then he asked me, ‘can feelings be unethical’? I explained to him the unethical behavior was you didn’t refer her after you started having the feelings.”

“Yes, you’re absolutely right.”

“Then he said that it wasn’t fair to you that I had put you on a pedestal. He said that you were only human and that we all make mistakes. I told you that yesterday, but I integrated it more after my talk with Roger. So, Daddy, we want you to come over for supper tonight.”

“Thank you both. It’s embarrassing, but I would love to come for supper.”

We sat outside on their deck and talked over all the feelings each of us was experiencing while Chase took turns crawling in and out of our laps. Si said she needed to check on the meatloaf. Roger nodded to me to follow her. I did and when we got into the kitchen, she turned around and gave me a big hug.

“Sit down Daddy while I finish getting things ready.”

“I really appreciate you all having me.”

“I’m so glad we did. I’ve been thinking about everything. Yes, I am disappointed in you, and I know you feel terrible, but I want you to know that nothing could ever get in the way of our relationship. Outside of Roger, Chase and little Dottie (she patted her stomach), you are the most important person in my life and I will always treasure our relationship.”

She came over and kissed me on the forehead.

“Thank you, Honey.”

“You have a rough road ahead. Your behavior will punish you many times over in the coming two years. There’s a good chance that you and Lucy will never be together.” Smiling, “But I don’t see how any woman could keep from falling in love with you Daddy, so there may be a chance.”

She continued, “And I know you will follow the ethical standards set by our profession of no social contact until after two years. Right?”

“Yes, I will Honey.”

“In the meantime, if it’s not too painful. I would love to know all there is to know from you about Lucy and why you fell in love with her and all about her as a person. Of course, I know you will not tell me anything about her therapy. Again, I just want to know who this person is you fell in love with?”

On my drive home, I knew it would be a while before I could talk to Si about Tess. She needed time to adjust to the fact that I had let her down and move into the state of mind that we both believed was one of the major keys to relief from suffering and pain: acceptance.

Over the next weeks, I did the best I could to be in a state of acceptance. I had learned from this terrible error in judgment. And that lesson was what I constantly teach my clients, ‘You must be awake, conscious, aware, attentive and present if you want to live from your Center.’ If I had been Centered, I would have noticed the first inkling of those emotions and acted accordingly. Either shut them down or refer her to another therapist. I hope I would have shut them down simply because she was responding to the path I was suggesting and making good progress.

Some people might ask, how do you shut down those kinds of feelings? You start with a commitment to do just that and then you do the work, the training to create something different in place of those feelings. Tess made incredible progress in shutting down the thoughts and feelings that caused her pain and suffering. Part of my lesson is to live what I teach.

The pain of not having her in my life would be a great motivator to continue my training plan. I had always been more comfortable with structure in my life and I would use that to help me live in the moment each day as best I could. I would

continue my meditations two times a day, do my Three-Stepper training and do my breathing exercises when walking on the beach.

I would continue my daily exercise program, spend a while each day while walking to think about her, wonder how and what she was doing and allow myself to miss her. The chances of any relationship with her were slim at best. And finally enjoy the times with family and friends and then the normal chores of everyday life.

The End of the First Year

Near the end of two more months, I caught a glimpse of her in Winn Dixie on the island. She didn't see me, and I made sure she wouldn't be able to see me as she was doing her shopping. She looked so radiant and beautiful. I watched her take her groceries to the car and then pull away. I longed to just be able to touch her arm or breathe in her energy just for a moment.

After loading my groceries, I called Henry." Hey, I wanted to check on Jill to see to see how she's doing. I know you said last Friday she was sober, but as I told you, those first two or three weeks back from treatment are important."

"We had a great weekend; so far so good. I am cautiously optimistic."

"If she has any relapses, be sure to let me know right away."

"Will do. How you holdin' up?"

"I saw Tess today in Winn Dixie. I'll tell you about it on Friday."

"Did she see you?"

"No. So glad about that!"

"Got it. Are you sure you wanna wait till Friday?"

"Yeah, that's fine. Si is sometimes off on Monday afternoon. I'll give her a call. If she's busy, I'll catch her later. I'm so glad Jill is doing well. See you Friday."

I called Si and she was home. I told her about seeing Lucy for the first time since our last session.

"Daddy, this is the first time you've brought Lucy up since a couple of months ago."

"I've told myself I needed to give you time to heal, but I decided a week or so ago that I was really giving me time to accept the best I can how my irresponsible behavior hurt and disappointed you."

She said, "I have a couple of hours before I pick up Chase. Why don't you come over?"

"That would be great. I'll leave now."

We sat on her back deck and talked a little about Chase and Roger. She let me feel little Dottie kicking her. Then she said, "Tell be about seeing Lucy."

I told her the details."

"Even though I can imagine, tell me what that was like."

"The first glimpse, my heart started racing. I was so glad I didn't bump into her rounding the corner of an aisle. I'm not sure I would have had enough air in my

lungs to say Hi. When I knew I was safe to just watch her from a distance, I felt this incredible longing to get closer to her.”

Then I had this urge to go up to her and say, ‘Lucy, it’s good to see you. I just wanted you to know I’m madly in love with you and can’t live without you and wondered if you would consider running away with me?’”

She smiled, “I’m sorry, I don’t mean to smile. It’s just that I’ve never heard you talk like that. Outside our family, the only time I’ve heard you use the ‘love’ word was when you talked about the beach. I never heard you and Mama say, ‘I love you’ with anywhere near the passion.”

Slight smile, “That’s sad for both of us.”

“Are you okay talking about what made you fall in love with Lucy? It’s of course fine if you need more time.”

“No, it’s okay. It was just so easy to love her. I thought when I first saw her that she was attractive, but I’ve had a thousand attractive women in therapy. But nothing like this has ever happened to me.”

“I’m not surprised that her looks weren’t the attraction. So how did it happen?”

“I heard from a wise person, ‘If you can define love, you don’t know or have it.’ So, I know I can’t define it. It’s like putting words to it diminishes the experience. So, what it was about Lucy is illusive and sometimes seems numinous.”

“What do you mean by numinous?”

“Like having a spiritual quality. It’s like an energy that is nonmaterial. Again, it’s like you can feel it but you can’t describe it.” Pause. Smiling, “But I’ll give it a try since words are all we have.”

“As you always say, ‘Do the best you can’.”

“From the beginning, she was feisty and resistant to what I had to say. At one point she said I needed therapy more than she did and later called me a ‘fucked up therapist’.”

“Wow, I haven’t had that happen to me yet thank god.”

“After a little more experience. I predict you won’t care.”

“That would be nice. Right now, I want all my clients to think I’m brilliant.”

“Well, don’t get me wrong. I still have some of that.”

“So even though feisty and resistant, she had a curiosity that enabled her to be open to exploring ideas that at first glance seemed unrealistic and seemed to offer no help with her pain and suffering. At one point while we were walking along the edge of the water, I suggested one of my outlandish ideas and she laughed, reached down and threw water at me and called me ‘crazy’ or some word to that effect.

“It sounds like at that point she still thought you were ‘fucked up’. I didn’t know you took clients walking.”

“Yes, I’ve been doing that ever since I moved to the office. I give them all a choice to take walks from time to time. I think some clients find that very helpful.”

“Tell me more about Lucy.”

“So, she was open to the exploration of things that at first to her didn’t make sense. Life is such an incredible adventure. I’m attracted to that in any person, male and female.”

Smiling, “But you don’t fall in love with all those people.”

“No, I don’t. Remember I’m trying to put words on an experience that’s difficult to describe. But here are the words that come to mind. She is compassionate, sensitive to others, a lover of the beach environment, exercises regularly, loves to banter, has a great sense of humor, has nerves of steel, but also a soft and gentle side.”

“I want to ask you all kinds of questions about her, but mostly they are about things that would give me some hint of her identity and I know we can’t go there. If after two years, there is some chance that you all might at least be able to be friends, I hope to meet her. She sounds like the kind of person I would enjoy being around, but I’m still not sure why you fell in love with her.”

“We’re back where we started trying to define love. I’m not going to be able to explain it, but if you meet her and are able to spend some time with her, you’ll get your answer.”

I continued, “You also asked about the timing. That is also illusive. I think it was somewhere around the 7th or 8th session, I found myself thinking more about her between sessions and then also looking forward to our sessions more than appropriate. That’s about the time I started rationalizing that I was doing good work with her and that she was making good progress and that I could keep it professional. Of course, a huge mistake!”

Pause. “So how can I help?”

“Just letting me talk about it helps a lot. You really can’t say anything to make me feel better. I know you love me and that you’re working on not being as disappointed in me. That’s all I can ask Honey.”

“I’ve had plenty of time to move on from the disappointment. Daddy, I want to be involved with you every step of the way. I want you to feel like you can talk about it at any time.”

“Thanks Honey.”

She said, “I’m also interested in the training plan you’ve designed for yourself. In my therapy sessions with clients, I’m using a lot of the techniques you’ve taught me over the years, and I want to see how you’re specifically using them for this situation.”

“I can give you a thumb nail sketch now if you have time. You’ll be able to fill in the blanks.”

“I don’t have to pick up Chase until 3:30. Go ahead.”

I went through the plan with her. She has been with some clients using meditation and variations of the Three Stepper. She had several questions. I thanked her again. We hugged and I left.

About four months after our last session, I received an email from Tess. “Hi Howard. Hope you are doing well. I wanted to let you know that I have had no panic attacks or flashbacks since the two weeks before our last session. I wanted to thank you for all the help you have given me during our sessions. I know you will say I did the work and that’s true, but you were the one who showed me what to do.”

She continued, “Without that, I don’t know where I would be at this point. I will let you know when I have reached the six-month mark of my goal. At that point, I will send you the address of my commanding officer and the post physician so you can write them and recommend that I be cleared to fly again. I miss our sessions. Tess.”

The email of course awakened those feelings of more intense longing to see her, to be with her, to hold her, to walk with her....

I continued my training and talking to Si and Henry. I worked hard to continue getting on with my life and for the most part was doing pretty good. I continued each day to take some time to think about her and miss her and long for her. I had no idea there was any future for us, but until I knew for sure, I was not giving up my hope that one day we would be together.

Two months later, Dottie was born. All went well.

Soon after Dottie was born, I received the email from Tess that she had continued to be free of any panic attacks and flashbacks for the six-month period. She sent me the addresses and I mailed a letter to both people stating that from a psychological perspective, I recommended she be cleared to fly again. I sent her a copy of the letter. She thanked me in an email a few days later.

Two weeks after sending the letter, I had a shock by running into her at The Market. I looked up from the fresh fish display window and there she was with a friend coming right toward me. She was deep into conversation and didn’t see me and almost bumped into me. She looked up and was visibly embarrassed. She smiled and said, “Oh, I am so sorry.” I smiled back and said, “You’re fine.” I gave her a moment to say something else and when she didn’t, I looked away and they walked on. I purchased my fish and hurriedly left the store.

The next six months were good. I continued my training plan with some adjustments to my meditation. The weekly visits with Henry at Susie's and a couple evenings a month we went over to Larry's to hang out. My work was going well. Most weeks, I didn't have any openings.

I spent a lot of time with Si, Roger, and the kids. At least one day every weekend they were either at my house or I was at their house. We had great fun and I loved playing with Chase and Dottie. On some weekends, Chase would come out and spend the night. He loved playing on the beach and in the water. I looked forward to when he would be old enough to take walks and explore the preserve with me.

I was pleased that I was getting back to my Center focusing in the moment and celebrating and being grateful for all my blessings. Si told me it was good to have her Daddy back.

Henry told me several times there was nothing new to report on Tess. She was busy with the children and her usual activities. Nothing much had changed.

I had one year to go before being able to contact her. I had prepared myself to face the possibility that Tess would never be a part of my life. One thing I had learned this past year was that I could have a good quality of life without her. With that in mind however, there was still that longing for her. It was for me a healthy longing and quite exciting that it might happen. But it was not keeping me from celebrating each moment right now.

5

Taylor and the Next 10 Months

Henry greeted me at our next lunch with. “Well, it’s been about a year. One down and one to go.”

“Yeah, and as long as I take one day at a time, it’s works well.”

“Whatta ya mean?”

“You know what I mean.”

Smiling, “Yes, I do. One moment, one breath, one day at a time with an attitude of gratitude. You’ve been preaching that to me for years.”

“And you’ve also heard me say countless times that we teach those things we most need to learn ourselves.”

“Right. That’s why I asked you. To make sure you’re living what you teach. Alright already, can we order? I’m hungry.”

After ordering, He said, “Jill and I are having our monthly party tomorrow night. She wanted me to make sure you will be there.”

“Of course, I never miss. Why did she want you to make sure I was gonna be there?”

“She has a friend from Charleston she wants you to meet.”

“How come?”

“She thinks it would be nice if you had a female friend to spend some time with during the last year before you check things out with Tess.”

“You didn’t tell her Tess’s name, did you?”

“Of course not. She knows Tess as ‘the mystery woman’.”

“Thinking about dating creates anxiety.”

“I got it. How long has it been since you’ve had a date?”

“Since before Florence and I got married.”

“Wow! Well, she just wants you to meet her. Not date her.”

“That’s good because I don’t want to start dating anyone. And it’s not because of Tess. You know I don’t know if there will ever be a chance with her. The thought of dating not only stirs anxiety, but also seems like a lot of work. I like my life the way it is now. Simple and peaceful.”

“I got it. But what’s the harm of at least meeting her? No one is going to force you to ask her out.”

“Okay, tell Jill I’ll be there, but be sure to let her know how I feel about dating.”

“Will do.”

I had some errands to run and then decided to stop by Si's to see if she and the kids were home yet. She was just pulling in the driveway,"

She had groceries. "Hey Hon, good timing on my part. You go ahead and get Dottie. Chase and I'll get the groceries."

"Thanks Daddy."

I sat at the kitchen table while she put things away. I told her about the party tomorrow night and about my anxiety."

"Are you going?"

"I told Henry I would."

Smiling, "You'll have to work that anticipatory anxiety into your daily meditations. I think it's a great idea."

"I know it's crazy thinking, but it's almost like I feel like I would be cheating on Lucy if I had a date."

More smiling, "You need to work that into your meditations too."

"I know you're right."

"Daddy. You came at a good time. Would you watch the kids? I need to run over to The Market and pick up some salmon. Roger and I are having Joan and Cecil over for dinner tomorrow night."

I ended up staying for dinner. Roger let me pinch hit for him, and I read Chase a bedtime story. Soon after that, I left and headed home.

Saturday was filled with chores around the house and my daily routine of exercise and meditation. I surprisingly found myself taking some extra care about what I was wearing to the party and how I looked. Sometimes I didn't shave or care what I wore. These were all old friends, and it was always very casual. Some part of me wanted to look nice for this person.

I was a little early, so I helped them get ready and also made sure Jill had no expectations about me dating her friend.

Henry and I were having a beer on the deck when Jill came out and said smiling, "Why Howard you look so nice tonight. Of course, Henry told me you don't want to date anyone. That's fine. I've known her for years and she recently moved back to Charleston. I asked her to come and meet some of my friends. She will be coming late because she had to work."

A little embarrassed, I said, "Thanks Jill. What's her name?"

"Taylor Stone."

Shortly after that, the gang started arriving. I had a couple more beers and was enjoying the usual chit chat of our group when I saw Jill going to the door. I knew it must be Taylor since everyone else was here. They were smiling and laughing, and Jill took her by the arm, and they disappeared into the kitchen. I didn't get a good look at her from where I was standing. About 15 minutes or so later, she began introducing her to our friends.

She looked about 5' 6" and was slender with blonde hair. She was dressed attractively with black pants that came down slightly below her knees and a white sleeveless blouse. Her hair rested on her shoulders. Her face was rather long with a small nose, wide thin lips and eyes that appeared to be blue. They were making their way over to Henry and me as he whispered, "Take a few slow easy deep breaths. You're gonna be fine."

With a big smile, Jill said, "Taylor, this is my husband Henry and his best friend Howard."

We stood there and talked for a while and then they moved on to meet other friends. I had a few more beers and was feeling very relaxed. Around midnight, everyone had left but Taylor and me. We all sat on the deck and talked for a bit and then Jill asked Henry to come in and help her clean up. Taylor and I both offered to help but they insisted they could handle it.

I was feeling relaxed and had a beer or two over my self-imposed limit. I had a cup of coffee and Taylor had a glass of wine. "So, Taylor, how did you and Jill become friends?"

She went through a short version that they had met in college at USC and became best friends and after college stayed in touch. She talked about her job as a marketing rep for Consolidated Department Stores headquartered in New York City saying she traveled a lot and had recently been promoted to marketing manager for the Southeast region.

"Jill and I are so excited even though I'll still be traveling, I'm going to be working some out of the Charleston office and we'll be able to see a lot more of each other. How about you Howard? Have you lived here all your life?"

I told her the short version of my story and my lifelong friendship with Henry and about my children and grandchildren.

"Jill said you were a physical therapist."

I was pretty sure Jill had had no alcohol and decided that Taylor just mistook what she said. "Actually, I'm a psychotherapist."

"Oh, I'm sorry. I misunderstood her."

"Perfectly fine."

Smiling, "Actually I have been acquainted with several psychotherapists over the years and they were not friends if you know what I mean."

Smiling back, "Yes, I know exactly what you mean. I have also been acquainted with several psychotherapists and they were not friends."

She burst out laughing, "You're kidding, right?"

"No, how many do you know?"

Thinking back, she said, "Two I think."

Smiling, "I've got you by one I've known three."

“How could that be? I thought you all were supposed to have ‘it’ all together.”

“Who told you that?”

“No one, I just assumed.”

“I’ve actually been told by a number of my clients that I needed more therapy than they did.”

More laughter,

Henry looked out the door and said, “What are you two laughing at?”

I gave him a quick rundown.

He said, “Howard, I think you forgot the shrink over in Columbia.”

More laughter, “That was a psychiatrist.”

Taylor asked, “You saw a psychiatrist?”

Trying to be serious, “Yes, but it was only for ten years.”

Smiling, Henry said, “I didn’t know it was for that long!”

More serious, Henry continued, “Taylor, I think we owe you an apology for introducing you to Howard. Even I didn’t know he was that mentally challenged. Howard, I think you ought to head on home and check your meds.”

Serious, raising my voice, “Henry, I don’t appreciate you for all practical purposes calling me a ‘retard’.”

Henry responded, “Howard, I’ve told you I’m not covering for you anymore. Now calm down!” He yelled, “Jill! Bring me a couple of Xanax for Howard. He’s having one of his fits.”

Taylor got up and said, “I better be going.”

Jill appeared and said, “What’s going on out here? Taylor, are these two messing with you?”

Taylor looked at us and then at Jill and we all burst out laughing.

Taylor sat back down and said, “I will find a way to get back at you two!”

Jill sat down and the four of us spent the rest of the evening talking and laughing and having a very nice time.

Taylor was spending the night with Jill and Henry. Henry followed me out to the truck and said, “Whatta you think?”

“I like her. She is very nice.”

“Jill has talked about her for years and as you know, this is the first time I’ve seen her.”

“Will she be coming for more visits?”

“I don’t know. I’ll let you know.”

On the drive home, I decided I would like to see her again.

Si had made me promise to call her and let her know how it went. I called in the morning, and she was happy it went well.

She asked. “Does that mean you would like to spend some time with her?”

“Yes, I hope so. We’ll have to see how she feels.”

At our lunch on Friday, Henry said, “Taylor is planning another visit three weeks from tomorrow and will be at the monthly party. By the way, she told Jill she liked you and thought you were funny and a nice person.”

Smiling, “Glad to hear it.”

“Any particular reason?”

“I think it would be nice to spend some time with her if she’s interested.”

I continued to do well over the next weeks staying with my routine. I thought some about Tess and spending time with Taylor. I worked through any hesitation about Taylor. I would just let it unfold.

On the night of the party, Taylor and I spent most of the evening sitting out on the deck. It was a beautiful setting. Jill and Henry’s house backed up to a canal with lots of palm trees. Boats were drifting in and out over the evening. I learned more about her family and her work, and I shared the same with her.

When everyone but the four of us had left, we enjoyed more time on the deck talking.

Jill said, “At my AA meeting earlier today, I got my token for being sober for 1 year.”

We all hugged and congratulated her. It was a major accomplishment, and all understood the importance of her success.

We helped clean up and I asked, “Would you all like to come out to the house in the morning and have brunch?”

Jill looked at Taylor, “What time do you have to go back tomorrow?”

“Not until around three.”

I said, “Good, how ‘bout it then?”

All agreed and we decided to gather around ten.

We said good night and I left.

Early next morning, I made a sausage, egg and cheese casserole. Was able to get in my run, came back and showered. A little after ten, an SUV I didn’t recognize pulled up to the house.

Taylor got out, smiled, and said, “They made up some lame excuse they couldn’t make it.”

“It sounds like they want us to get to know each other.”

Smiling, “Sounds like it.”

“Come on in. I’ll show you around.”

PJ and GJ were nowhere to be found.

“I love your house. What’s the story on how you came to live here?”

I gave her the short version.

She looked out the window and said, "And that's your office over there?"

"Yes."

"Jill told me about it. That's a nice setup."

"Yes, it's perfect for me. Would you like to go for a short walk?"

She hesitated, "I have a confession. I'm not really a beach person.

Obviously, you love the beach, but I associate it with being hot and sand being all in my clothes etc."

"Of course, that's perfectly fine. Would you like a cup of coffee?"

"Yes, I'd love one."

"Would you like to sit out on the deck?"

"Could we sit in your kitchen nook? It looks so cozy."

"Sure. Would you like something to eat?"

"No thanks, I had a croissant with Jill before I left."

We sat in silence for a few minutes. Our eyes met a few times and we smiled but were both mainly looking outside.

"It's a beautiful view from here."

"Yes, this is one of my favorite places in the house."

After a little more silence, she said, "Howard, I'd like to tell you a little about my situation." Pause. "I'm about two months out from the final of a very painful divorce. And this is the second divorce in the last twenty years. The first one I wanted and the second one he wanted. I don't blame either one of them or myself, but the pain has left a huge impact on my life. I've tucked away somewhere deep inside me any desire or interest in a romantic relationship. Not that you would even be interested, but I had to put that out there."

"Thank you for letting me know. I also went through a divorce about ten years ago, but I don't think my level of pain even touched what you've been through. I'm not sure what else to say except I wish you had been spared those experiences."

"Thank you, but I was equally responsible for every bit of it."

We sat in silence for a few minutes and were both looking out the window.

I looked at her and said, "I also have something to tell you. I am in love with a woman, and she doesn't know it. I have no idea if she has any feelings for me, but I want to spend the rest of my life with her. I have to wait about a year from now before I'll have the opportunity to let her know how I feel."

"That sparks a lot of questions, and I am curious, but on the other hand I don't want to know the details."

"Thank you."

A slight smile, she said, "I've been thinking about you since our first meeting last month and when you disclosed a few minutes ago that you were in love with someone, I made the decision to ask you about an idea."

“I’m curious.”

“As I said a few minutes ago, I’m not interested in an emotional intimate relationship, but I am interested in a physical relationship. I’ve heard such a thing described as, ‘friends with benefits.’ Have you heard that phrase?”

A little embarrassed and at the same time immediately aroused, I said. “Yes, I’ve heard the phrase.”

“You look embarrassed, and I am too. I hope you don’t think I’m too forward. I’ve never done this before, but I did have a few affairs during my first marriage. And I’m a very sexual person.”

Smiling, “I’m of course surprised, but I don’t think you’re forward. I’m also a sexual person but have not had sex since my divorce. I have to take care of ‘business’ on my own.”

“I have not had sex since my divorce.” Smiling, “But I never leave home without my vibrator.”

We both smiled.

She said, “I was nervous when I came, but now I feel better. I was afraid you would think badly of me.”

“Quite the contrary, I admire your honesty and courage to ask for what you want in our friendship. And I have thought since I first saw you last month that you are a nice person, attractive and very sensual.”

She replied, “I have thought the same thing about you.”

We both got out of our chairs and joined hands hanging at our sides just looking at each other for a moment and then we softly kissed exploring lips and tips of our tongue and then more passionately and soon exploring each other’s mouth with a hungry passion and as I carried her to the bedroom, I thought for a brief moment this was what Tess experienced when she had that brief encounter in Afghanistan. And then I was lost in the passion for and with this very sensual woman.

I have no idea how long it lasted. At the end, we both drifted off into a light sleep. When I woke, she was still sleeping. I tip toed out and put on some fresh coffee and heated up the casserole. Soon after, I heard the shower.

“Hey Howard, that was wonderful, and I’m starved. We sat in the nook and ate and drank coffee and talked and laughed and had a wonderful time and then she left.

As she pulled out of the driveway, I started feeling a little guilty that I enjoyed it more than I thought I would. I closed my eyes and took deep breaths and reminded myself it was all perfectly fine. It takes nothing away from the way I feel about Tess.

I called Si and told her the whole story. She was surprised, but happy for me that I had found someone to spend time with over these last months before I could see Lucy.

“Daddy, you know that sex and emotions are sometimes inseparable. Be sure to stay conscious and awake and closely attentive to the possible scenarios that could happen. Let it unfold, as you always say, but again watch closely for the possibility of going down a path that doesn’t work for you or for her.”

“I will Honey. Thanks for the reminder.”

Taylor and I got together once a month on Sunday. We rotated months. I went to her place, and she came to mine the next month. We had sex and then had a meal and then left. It usually lasted about two hours. It was working for both of us. We had no contact between our meetings. We talked mostly about current events, our families, and our jobs. There was no talk about personal issues or feelings.

The next ten months went faster than I could have hoped for. I continued my routine which worked really well for me. I stayed for the most part conscious and focused in the moment. There was much to celebrate with family and friends.

There were three sightings of Tess during that ten-month period. They were all at Winn Dixie on the island. The first one was when we both turned into the same aisle at opposite ends. We both smiled when we looked up and saw each other. Neither of us turned around but it was obvious she wasn’t going to stop. As she passed me, she said, “Hello Howard, I hope you’re well.” And I said as she looked over her shoulder, “I hope you’re well too Tess.”

I don’t think she saw me on the other two. One in the parking lot and one inside the store. I was always on the lookout for her and her car when in town and on the island.

One Friday at lunch with Henry, I got some surprising news.

“Hey Henry. How you doin’ my friend?”

“I’m doing good. Jill is continuing to do well. How are things with Taylor?”

“Great. Our plan has worked out and we’re both having a good time.”

“Still no romantic emotions?”

“I feel close to her and care about her and want her to be happy, but nothing beyond that. If she were to start having those kinds of emotions, I believe she would tell me, and we would stop seeing each other. That was our agreement. If she starts dating again, our arrangement will end. She knows when the year is up, we will go our separate ways.”

“I’m glad it’s working for both of you. Changing the subject, I just saw my main spy yesterday after she had gone dark on me for the last seven or eight months. There was a strange newspaper on my desk when I got to work yesterday

and inside there was a note that said, ‘Come to the old Wilson Hardware store down by the tracks tonight at midnight and come alone.’”

Laughing, I said, “Okay Henry, what did she say?”

He took another big bite of hamburger and kept chewing and chewing and chewing and smiling at the same time.”

“Come on Henry, what did you find out? You’re killin’ me.”

“I’ll tell you tonight. I have to get back to work.”

He started to get up. I reached over and pulled him back down. People were starting to stare.

Smiling, he asked, “Are you sure you want to know? It may be bad news.”

“Come on Henry! Out with it!”

He looked around the room and then leaned closer to me and whispered, “Tess and her husband have gotten a divorce. Shhhhhh, don’t give away in this place that you’ve gotten good news. There could be repercussions.”

Then he leaned back and laughed.

I was speechless. It was not morally right to be happy about them getting a divorce. What about the children? I was stunned. I didn’t know what to say.

Smiling, he said, “Say something.”

“I don’t know what to say, I don’t know whether to feel happy, sad, hopeful, sorry, elated?”

“While you’re trying to figure that out, I have one more piece of news.”

“What?”

“She has bought a small fixer/upper beach house on the island about a mile from the southern edge of the preserve.”

“How do you know where it is?”

“My friend described it to me, and I went out there this morning and found it. It was in obvious need of some work, so I put my card in the mailbox.” Smiling, “If my company gets the job, I will be able to let go of my spy and do my own spying.”

“I wonder how she could afford it. That land is so expensive.”

“My friend said she had inherited some money from her grandmother. That’s all I know. I think she plans to move in the next few weeks. The house looks pretty good but needs work. It’s one story. White siding with light ocean blue shutters and trim. You can’t miss it. Now, I really do have to go.”

“Thanks Henry! Will check in with you later.”

I was tempted to drive out to that area and look around, but I’m sure she had seen my old truck parked next to the house when she was coming for her sessions. She might be out there now. I wasn’t going to take the chance. I drove home, changed clothes and put on an old safari hat, sunglasses and started walking south. It was about two miles.

So much to think about. I was trying to get control by thinking things like she must be making moves so we can be together. I told my mind to shut up and made the decision to stay with the facts. She was divorced and moving to the beach. I knew nothing else. There were about two months until the two years were up. I would not take any chances of an encounter that could be construed as “social contact.”

I passed the marker designating the preserve with about one mile to her house. After about one hundred yards, the beach houses started. On the way, there were several public access paths to the beach. I finally spotted her house and could see there were no cars parked in her driveway. However, she might pull up at any moment, so I kept my distance.

Seeing the house made it seem more real. I turned around and went back to the house. I stuck to my daily routine and when I was finished, it was around 5:30 so I called Si and filled her in.

She asked, “What are you thinking?”

“I think it’s not healthy for me to read much of anything into it. There are way too many variables.”

She said, “I think that’s a wise choice. A couple of things I know you have probably thought of. She was having marital problems and loves the beach so her behavior could have nothing to do with you. On the other hand, maybe she knows the two years are almost up and she wants to have options about what might happen. By the way, I know you would have told me, but I assume you’ve not seen her walking on the preserve beach.”

“No, I don’t think so. Several times from the office, I’ve seen someone who kind of resembles her, but I couldn’t be sure.”

She said, “Maybe it was her and maybe she has walked the preserve beach often. I think even if she doesn’t love you, that area could still be very special to her. But on the other hand, if she does love you, she would be very careful not to be seen by you? Just like today when you walked to her new house and were careful not to be seen.”

“Honey, I’m gonna do the best I can to keep going with my life as it’s been over the last twenty-two months. I won’t deny that I’m getting very excited about the end of the two years, but I’m also working hard as we have talked about to let go of any expectations. I’m continuing to work during my meditations on acceptance of whatever happens. I would love of course to have her in my life, but if that doesn’t happen, I’m determined to continue the best I can to create a life of peace and joy.”

She asked, “How are things with Taylor?”

“About the same. We’re going to stop seeing each other after our next two meetings. She brought it up last time that the 1 year is getting close.”

“What do you think that last session will be like?”

“I think it will be sad for both of us. It’s like saying goodbye to a close friend. But she told me last time she’s interested in a guy at work who has asked her out a few times. She keeps telling him to give her a little more time. And she said it doesn’t have as much to do with me as it has to do with her being ready to possibly fall in love again.”

“I’m surprised this has worked so well for you all. These situations as you know often get entangled and complicated. Good for you both.”

“Thanks Honey.”

We hung up. I got a beer and went to sit on the deck and think. I couldn’t believe the divorce and move to the beach. I couldn’t contain my excitement. I felt bad about the divorce for all four of them, especially the children. In my experience over the years, even the divorces where both parties want it, there is always emotional and physical pain and suffering. I hoped their divorce would be amicable and that shared custody would work well for everyone concerned.

PJ had followed me out and curled up on my lap. The biggest challenge I faced was being present in the moment and not wanting time to pass quickly so I could get on with the plan I didn’t have yet. What was my plan? I’d thought about it and considered different scenarios over the past months but had not made any decisions.

I was determined not to start focusing on a plan until about two weeks before the two years were up. There was also the issue of not making a move exactly two years after our last session. That would show how eager I was to contact her. Not sure she would notice or if she did, what would she think?

I had of course considered that she had met someone else. Maybe someone in her Army Reserve unit she had known for years. I decided not to think any more about that now. I still couldn’t believe she was divorced and that she lived right on the beach so close to me. It was twilight and I decided to walk down to her house again. I put PJ in the house, put on an old hat and started walking. By the time I got to her house, it would be almost dark.

As I got nearer, I could see there were lights on in the house and there was a car in the driveway. I couldn’t tell if it was hers. I couldn’t stop myself from getting a closer look. Luckily the tide was in and there were a few other people like me walking along the edge of the water... There were two large picture windows in the front, and she was moving around and talking to a young girl. I assumed it was her daughter April who would be about fourteen.

What was I feeling? Still adjusting to my response earlier today about the divorce and move. It was exciting to see her, which was similar to sightings at Winn Dixie, but I was surprised that the feeling right now wasn’t elation. It was

like all of this is too good to be true. I think it was a form of self-protection. There were too many things that made this dream of a life with her a long shot.

I turned back and walked by her house. The car was pulling out of the driveway. I needed time to process all that had happened today. So much of my training over all these months had been focused on accepting the possibility that it would not work out with Tess. And on the fact that I would be okay. I had embedded the idea in my consciousness that I would find a way to be happy and content.

The good thing about this awareness and confidence was it gave me the freedom to take the risk, to give it every chance to work out and to hold nothing back. I would take it one step at a time.

It would be like a progression of events. At any juncture, I could get a clear signal from her or the situation that it was hopeless to go any further. And I was very aware that this signal, this reality could present itself early after I had contacted her.

When I got home, I felt a sense of contentment and a budding excitement about the possibilities. I was free to have those feelings because when Centered, there is no vulnerability, no fear, no expectations, only hope, only an energy to go forward without hesitation remembering that her happiness in the final analysis is more important than anything else. My dream was to be a part of that happiness.

Henry called me the next Tuesday telling me that Tess had called him and thanked him for the offer to help her with the house. She was using a company out of Savannah owned by a disabled veteran.

He said, "She sounded very nice and kind of flirted with me over the phone. You could tell she was single and in need of some male company. I told her thanks, but my best friend was madly in love with her, and he would kill me if I accepted. She said, 'Why who is that? I'll give him a call'."

"Are you finished?"

"Not yet. I learned from my spy yesterday that she would be moving in about 1 month. I gotta go. Are we good for lunch on Friday?"

"You got it. Thanks for letting me know about the call and the move. Keep your spy on the payroll for now. How's Jill doing?"

"She is still doing great and has a great sponsor and continues her AA meetings."

The Initial Contact

It had been two weeks since the end of the two years following our last session. I wanted to wait a few weeks after the two years so it wouldn't seem quite as obvious as it already seemed. The only significant thing that had happened in the last two months was Henry said his spy informed him that Tess had been out on a date several times with the same guy. He had no information on who he was.

I was prepared for this news. Tess had a lot of friends and when she was divorced, I knew there would be guys interested in her. I was just hoping that she wasn't too interested in any of them. My meditations had prepared me for acceptance of whatever happens. I was just excited to see her again if of course she was agreeable.

I had spent the last several weeks talking to Henry and Si and planning this initial contact. I was ready to go. I picked up the phone and dialed.

She said, "Hello."

"Hello Tess, this is Howard."

Pause. She said, "I'm sorry. Howard who?"

"You probably don't remember me. It's Howard Kingston, your former shrink."

"It's still kind of fuzzy, but are you the one on 2nd Street who had the therapy dog?"

And then she couldn't hold it any longer and burst out laughing and I joined her. "No, you were the one with the therapy dog, right? Or do I have the wrong client."

"No, I don't have a therapy dog. Good luck finding your client. Goodbye." And she hung up.

I called her back. She answered laughing. "Howard, how are you?"

"I'm fine, how are you?"

She said, "I'm doing well thanks."

"I've thought about you often and have wondered how you're doing." I jumped right in. "What would you think about getting together and catching up?"

She hesitated, which seemed to last for an eternity even though it was only a few seconds. "Okay, sure that would be nice. I usually run about 7:30 in the mornings. I go south on the beach and then turn around after a mile and then turn north and stop at the edge of the preserve and then walk home to cool down. I could meet you there say this coming Friday around 8 and we could walk north like the old days. Would that work for you?"

“Sure. I could get my run in at the same time and meet you at eight.”

“Oh, the doorbell just rang. Have to go. I’ll see you then.”

“Got it.”

She hung up. I was elated. She sounded so good, and the bantering started right away and I thought, ‘let the games begin.’ I just wish Friday was not five days away.

Not a good thought wishing five days of my life away when I’m working hard to live in the moment.

I called Si and Henry to let them know how it went. They were both happy for me. I let Henry know I might not make lunch on Friday. I didn’t know how long she could stay.

He said, “If I haven’t heard from you by 11:30, I’ll know you can’t make it.”

“Sounds good.” We talked for a while longer and hung up.

I stayed with my normal routine and was fortunate I had a full schedule of clients all three days. I didn’t sleep well Thursday night with a lot of tossing and turning and I remember every time I woke up, I smiled and thought only a few more hours.

It was a beautiful morning with some white clouds and blue skies and a very gentle warm breeze. I shaved, put on my running shorts, my favorite tee shirt and drank some water. After my run to the northern tip and back. I stopped at the house to pee and eat a granola bar with a couple sips of coffee.

I started walking south along the edge of the water to get to the southern edge of the preserve at eight. I was glad there were only a few people out gathering shells. And then I saw her walking toward me, and I wanted to run to her and take her in my arms and hold her tight and swing her around and around and then put her down and just look into her eyes forever and just love her. As we drew near, we both had a big smile on our faces.

She was wearing black running shorts, a yellow athletic tank top and what looked like an old pair of running shoes. Her hair was pulled back in a ponytail. No attempt to hide the missing ear. She had a little sheen of sweat on her face with just a little blush from the run. She looked beautiful.

As she drew near, “Hey Howard.”

“Hey Tess.”

And it seemed so natural that we hugged like in church with butts out in the breeze. But it was also a comfortable hug even though it only lasted a couple of seconds.

As we started north, she said, “I think I’ll take off my shoes. How about you? My feet need to cool down in the water.”

“Yes, I’d love that. We can drop them off in front of the house.”

“How have you been?” she asked with a big smile.

“What are you smiling about?”

“Oh, it just seems so different seeing you outside your office and not being in a session. It’s like I don’t know how to act. It’s just kind of strange and different, that’s all.” Continuing to smile, “I’ve seen you several times, but it seems like a long time since we talked.”

“Yeah, it seems like a long time to me too,” Knowing she had no clue what I meant by that statement.

“I guess I was a little surprised to hear from you.” she said.

“I can understand that. Remember near the end of our sessions when I said I always looked forward to seeing you. You worked so hard and were so easy to work with. I wanted to see you and catch up on what’s been happening in your life.”

She gave me this side long look and had a slight smirk on her face. “Do you do that with other clients?”

“Once in a while I’ll call someone when I run across their chart. I guess I would say it doesn’t happen very often. But two of my former clients are friends and we go to lunch occasionally.”

She was definitely having fun and asked, “Are any of them women?”

Pause and thinking, “Funny you asked, when I think about it all of them are women.”

With what seemed like a kind of forced smile she asked, “Really?”

Smiling, “Actually no. Sometimes I will call women and men to check on them, but I’ve never met a woman in person after the last session.”

Laughing, she reached over and pushed me off balance. “Don’t start that shit with me Howie.”

“So, you’re going to call me Howie now. I don’t like Howie.”

“Too bad HOWIE!”

“Why did you ask about women?” I wanted to see what she was up to.

“I was just wondering; so again, why did you call me?” she continued with that little tinkle in her eyes that I love.

“As I said, I liked working with you and to be honest, I wasn’t really sure you would be okay without our therapy sessions.”

“Well, why did you wait for two years to call!? I could have been in a psych ward and in a strait jacket by now.”

Smiling. I had to divert this conversation; I was starting to squirm a bit. “Got it. How are your children?”

“They’re fine. I’m a single parent now. Oh, did you know Arthur and I got a divorce?”

“Yes, my friend Henry told me. He has his finger on the pulse of the community and not much escapes him.”

“How did it come up?”

“As I remember, he linked us as veterans, and it was more like gossip.”

“Did you know I moved to a little house on the beach?”

Smiling, “Yes, he told me that too. What’s it like for you being divorced?”

She let me pull off the diversion again. “It was really hard at first, but I think we’ve all made the adjustment. We’re still good friends and he was always a good father. Keller and April were very upset with me at first since I was the one who wanted the divorce. Several days after we told them, he confessed to them that he had an affair. In that meeting, I also told them about my almost affair in Afghanistan. Then they were mad at both of us.”

“I assume you all have joint custody.”

“Yes, and it seems to be working out. Keller is sixteen and April is fourteen and we let them have a voice in the arrangement. April is a ‘mama’s girl’ and Keller, and his father are very close. They have bedrooms in both places, but April spends more time with me, and Keller spends more time with his dad. Every Sunday, we all coordinate schedules for the week. As I said, it’s working well.”

I asked, “How are you doing overall?”

Smiling, “Is that a therapy question?”

“I know it sounds like one, but I didn’t intend it to sound that way. I like you, Tess. I’m just interested.”

“That’s sweet. I’m doing well. I’m dating a really nice man. His name is Kent Hill. He is an attorney in Charleston. He and Arthur did business together. He lost his wife several years ago to cancer and has two children about the age of my two. I’m not sure what will happen, but we are enjoying each other’s company.”

I struggle with every ounce of energy I can muster to keep my cool and show no signs of any shift in thinking, mood or affect. “I’m glad for you,” I lied. I continued, “How do the children like him?”

“They both make it clear to me they are not happy with me dating anyone right now. They just need a little more time.”

That statement scared me; like need a little more time to adjust to the divorce or need a little more time to adjust to him. I decided not to pursue that one for now.

With my short pause, she jumped right in, “Howard, you’re asking me a lot of questions. It’s my turn. How are your children?”

I filled her in on all the major happenings including that I had become a recent grandfather. She was happy for me.

“Are you dating anyone?”

“Not anymore.”

I looked at her and she kept looking ahead as we continued walking. I couldn't tell how she took the news.

"Why did you stop?"

I lied, "It wasn't working for either one of us."

"What wasn't working?"

I continued to lie, "She lives in Charleston and travels a lot. We didn't get to see each other very much and she got involved with someone else."

I needed to divert her attention before there was the question about when the relationship ended. I had already lied, but I wanted to keep it to a minimum.

"Florence said I would never have room in my life for a woman. She said my whole life was wrapped up in my passion and love for the preserve, the beach life, and the beach house.

"Florence was your wife, right?"

"Yes."

"Do you think she was right?"

"I thought all I needed was my wonderful life at the beach, but my daughter told me that I just hadn't found the right woman for that special kind of love that transcends everything else in life. She liked Taylor, that was her name, but said she could tell she was not that woman."

She stopped and turned and looked at me and said, "Do you believe that special love is missing?"

"Can we keep walking?"

Smiling, "Sure, as long as you answer my question."

"Okay." We walked on for a few more minutes. "With the exception of this brief experience with Taylor, I've been alone for so long. Sometimes it seems natural or just the way it is. Remember acceptance?"

"How could I forget? You drilled that into me for all those weeks."

"Well, I just accepted it for a long time, but I've come to believe that my daughter, Si, is right. I do believe that having someone special is missing in my life. And Taylor was never the one, but I've been exploring in my own meditations what is holding me back. Like, what am I afraid of?"

"Have you made any progress?"

"Yes some, but it's slow going."

"Are you using all the skills and tools you taught to me?"

"Not really. That stuff doesn't work for me!"

She reached down and cupped some water and threw it at me and was reaching down for more....

"Okay, okay!" Smiling, "Yes, I'm using all the tools."

"What's taking you so long to figure it out and move on? You worked my ass off and I've moved on. Are you working your ass off or do I sense some

resistance to the process. You accused me once of being resistant. Remember that?"

Smiling, "Not really, but I'm sure I did."

"Well, it sounds like you need a good therapist, and I may take on the job myself."

"Are you licensed?"

"No but I've been a therapist to all my friends for the last two years. I bet I can teach that stuff better than you can."

Laughing, "Probably so."

"We can set up some sessions for you later. You are in bad need of help!"

"How much do you charge?"

"A hundred and twenty an hour."

"I may not be able to afford it."

"No worries, I have a sliding scale."

We walked for a while with an occasional remark about the beauty of the ocean and sand and how good the gentle breeze feels.

She said, "I still listen to my meditation tapes. My sanctuary brings so much serenity and clarity to my life."

"I'm glad for you."

"Do you remember that I always wanted to give you credit for my progress and you always told me that I had it within myself?"

"Yes, I remember."

"And you said that it was just a matter of accessing and reaching that special place where I have all the resources, I need to stay calm and focused."

"Yes, I remember that too."

"Well, you taught me well, I'm feeling really good about myself these days and about my skills and my ability to stay more Centered in my life. And even though I don't give you the credit, I'm still grateful to you for inspiring me to believe in myself."

"You were a model client."

We walked on in silence for a while, perhaps remembering that during the sessions, we would just sit or walk in silence.

"I love being able to fly again even though we don't get to fly much anymore for budget reasons. Oh, I was promoted to Major and am now the Executive Officer of our unit."

"Congratulations!"

"Thanks."

We walked for a while longer and then she said, "Walking on this part of the beach brings back so many memories of the work we did out here. I will never

forget the exercise, 'It's not important.' That was so much fun. And then all those times you had me stop and close my eyes and listen to the waves and feel and smell the air. Those were special memories as they were part of what opened the door to my Center."

"I was glad to have some part in helping you discover your Center."

She stopped and said, "I've got an idea. I want you to take me through one of those exercises when I close my eyes and open my senses. I always felt a little unsteady with the water coming in and then going out over my feet. Let me walk out in the water a little more and I want you to come up behind me and stand about a foot behind me and put your hands on my shoulders to steady me and take me through an exercise."

I of course loved the idea. "Sounds good."

She moved out into the water and said, "I'm ready."

I rested my hands on her shoulders and could immediately feel her energy. It ran through my whole body like a wave, like a warm current. I guided her through the meditation and extended it a little more than normal. I didn't want to take my hands off her shoulders.

When I asked her to open her eyes, I lifted my hands off her shoulders and she turned around and gave me another church hug and said, "Howard that was wonderful. Thank you."

She was smiling, "I feel so good and free and happy. Let's run in the water." She grabbed my hand and started pulling me and running along the edge of the water and we were splashing each other as our feet fell on the water sending sprays in all directions. I'm not sure which one of us got winded first, but we slowed down and I said, "Hey you're still in really good shape." She gave me a cute look and I said smiling, "I mean you're in good condition."

"Well, what is it Howard, do I have a good shape or am I in good condition?"

Acting very shy and embarrassed, I said, "both I guess."

"You guess??"

"No, I mean both."

"Why thank you. That's sweet."

I loved her joking around. I had never met anyone except Henry who liked to banter back and forth.

We walked for a while longer in silence. Several times we looked at each other and smiled and kept walking. I wanted these moments to go on and on and never end.

She finally asked, "What are you smiling about?"

"You told me in your email that you missed our sessions. Well, I missed them too. And it's just good to see you again."

“Isn’t this spot close to the entrance of your sanctuary?”

“Yes, we’re almost there.”

“Do you mind showing it to me again?”

“Be happy too.”

She said, “I love this spot. The energy is so good here. Before our work together, I had no idea about energy. Now, I can feel it everywhere I go when I’m awake to it. Some negative and some positive.”

“Is your sanctuary in the same place?”

“Yes, and I still go there all the time. I have not found one like yours that is an actual place, but I’ve stopped looking. I’m perfectly satisfied with mine as it is.”

“Do you still visit your Spirit guide, Angel when you go to your sanctuary?”

“Yes, almost every visit. She still lives further up the side of the mountain.”

When we got to my sanctuary, she asked if she could sit in my chair. I said, “Sure” and I sat on the ground. We didn’t speak for a while. Then she stood up and looked at me and smiled and we started our walk south.

I asked, “Would you have time to stop at the house and have a cup of coffee?”

“Sure, that would be nice.”

We walked about half the way back in silence.

Then she asked, “Are you still working Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday?”

“Yes. That still works well. Have you thought about working outside the home in addition to your job with the Reserves?”

“Not much. Arthur and I jointly own the Finance Company, so I’m entitled to a monthly distribution which is plenty for me to live on. I’m open to doing something. I’m just not sure yet. In the meantime, I’d like to volunteer somewhere. Oh, in case you’re wondering, I inherited some money from my grandmother and that’s how I bought the beach house.”

I didn’t tell her I already had that information. “I know how much you love the beach. What a wonderful gift.”

We were walking up toward the house, and she said, “I admit I’ve always been curious about your house. It looks so cozy from the outside.”

“I’ve spent a lot of years working on it and like changing things both on the inside and outside. I still like doing little projects here and there. It’s like an extension of my sanctuary.”

“Yes, I remember you saying anywhere can be your sanctuary.”

She looked over at the office and grinned. “I spent quite a few hours in that office. Seeing it again brings back different memories. I sure shed a lot of tears

there. I also remember when I started feeling better. It was such a satisfying feeling to be consciously aware of my own healing process.”

I gave her a tour of the house which of course didn’t take very long. I introduced her to PJ and GJ. PJ walked right up to her and rubbed against her leg and she reached down and petted him. GJ turned up her nose and went outside through the pet door. Maybe it was a woman thing.

I showed her pictures of my children and grandchildren.

“Si looks familiar to me. I don’t think we’ve met, but I think I’ve seen her around town. I don’t recognize your son. His name is Lance. Right?”

She continued, “So you have two grandchildren. What are their names?”

“Chase is four and Dottie is two.”

“They are so cute, and I love that picture of you holding them together.”

She seemed to love the house.

“It will only take a few minutes to get the coffee brewing.”

“Would it seem nosy if I wanted to look around more slowly?”

“Not at all, feel free to go anywhere in the house. Take as much time as you want. Feel free of course to use the bathroom.”

I wondered if she had any suspicion about how I felt about her. Could she see it in my expressions or in what I was saying? Or could she feel my energy? No way to know, but I still wanted to be very careful. I got out some croissants and set us a place in the nook.

The coffee was just about ready when she walked in and said, “The coffee smells wonderful and those look delicious. I think the walk has given me an appetite.”

“What do you like in your coffee?”

“I usually do black in the early mornings. Do you have Splenda by any chance?”

“No, but I have the pink sweet and low.”

“That will be fine with a little milk if you have it.”

“I do.”

“Let me get it Howard; I don’t want you to wait on me.”

“No, you sit down; I’ll bring it to you.”

“Thanks.”

“Would you like some butter or marmalade or jelly for your croissant?”

“No thanks, plain is just fine. What do you put in your coffee?”

Smiling, “I put a lot of creamer, usually hazelnut flavor.”

“How do you taste the coffee?”

“I’m not a big fan of coffee, but it tastes pretty good with the creamer.”

“Do you drink tea?”

“Sometimes. I like some of the Celestial Seasons. Do you like tea?”

“Not that much, but sometimes it tastes pretty good.”

“Howard, I love this view of the ocean. Did you do your own landscaping?”

“Yeah, I did most of it.”

“I’m impressed.”

“Thanks.”

We sipped our coffee and took bites of croissant and then she looked at me and said, “I guess you realize that I know very little about you. There were many times in therapy I wanted to ask you questions about your life, but I never felt it was appropriate to ask. But looking around and seeing more closely the pictures of your children and grandchildren has made me even more curious.”

“Well, I’m happy to answer any questions you have. What would you like to know?”

“How did you happen to find and purchase this property and how did it happen with you being in the middle of the Nature Preserve?” She hesitated, “Maybe that question is a little too personal.”

“Not at all.” I told her the story about my great grandfather purchasing four hundred acres at the north end of the island, his accomplishment to make it a Nature Preserve, the history of the house and my arrangement with my family to purchase the house and two acres with the understanding that it would never be sold.

“So, you have these four hundred acres pretty much to yourself along with all the wildlife. I’m like Si though, I wonder too about you getting lonely.”

“I have my work and I also enjoy my solitude.” I told her about frequent visits from Si and family and that sometimes I keep the grandkids when Si and Roger need a break. I see Lance when he is home for the holidays. I go see Mom and Dad once a week. I told her about my weekly lunch with Henry and our frequent visits to Larry’s and my occasional lunch with the two former client friends. I left out my monthly visits with Taylor. I would tell her later if it worked out for us.

“How are your mom and dad doing?”

“They both have blood pressure issues, but so far medication seems to be keeping everything stable.”

“You mentioned Larry’s. That’s a restaurant?”

“More like a bar and grill.” I didn’t say anything more about it because I hoped to take her there myself. “So, there’s not much time to get lonely.”

She responded, “But you said earlier that something is missing.”

“Yes, and you said that you were going to help me get over the fear.”

“Yes, you need some serious help!” She gives me a coy look and then smiling says, “Again, are you sure none of those friends are females?”

I smiled, "Let me think about that a minute...give me another minute...well no, not really, but I'm kind of working on maybe having a female friend."

"You are? Tell me about her."

"Well, she is a very nice person and I've known her for about two and a half years and she has two children and she loves the ocean!"

She is starting to slightly blush and looks out at the ocean and looks back at me with a shy smile. "Is that what we're doing, becoming friends?"

My turn to blush. "I hope you don't think me too forward."

"No, please Howard, you look embarrassed. I don't think that it's forward at all. I'm just trying to think about the whole idea of friends. You said you have a close friend. I don't know if I have a close friend, but I do have several girlfriends and we go to lunch occasionally. I can talk to them about some personal stuff, but not the real personal stuff. As I said, I am seeing this guy and I guess he would also be considered a friend."

Because I already have that information, I'm prepared and show no emotion or any surprise and as casually as I possibly can after a little silence between us, I go for more details and ask, "How is that going?"

With a kind of faraway look in her eyes, she says, "I'm sorry, I guess I was somewhere else. What did you say?"

"I just asked you how it's going with your male friend."

"Oh, it's going fine. Did I tell you his name is Kent? I remember you always suggested I take one day at a time and that's what I'm doing with him. One thing I am quite sure about and that is I don't ever see me getting married again."

Even though people sometimes say they're never going to get married, they often ending up doing it but I'm still relieved to hear her say that.

She said, "So you haven't dated anyone except Taylor since your divorce?"

"No, I haven't really looked for anyone else and in the past, I just didn't have the interest."

"What about Taylor? You were interested in her."

Oh shit, I set myself up for that. "She's a friend of Henry's girlfriend, Jill and she was trying to play 'matchmaker'. Taylor was nice, but again, she was not the one."

"You said one reason you all stopped seeing each other was she started dating someone else. What if that had not happened, would you still be dating her?"

Squirm time. "I was ready to stop, and I was glad she found someone else so I didn't have to be the one to break it off. Since Taylor, I haven't had the interest."

"Yes, I could see you not wanting to hurt someone's feelings. Is it the fear that keeps you from having the interest? You seem so vibrant and passionate about

life. It just doesn't seem...I don't know the right word...maybe natural for you to be without a woman."

Smiling. "So, you think I need a woman?"

"The word 'need' isn't what I really mean. I guess I still wonder how you could not be lonely out here by yourself. What I mean is I think I would be lonely."

I'm not sure what to say so I decided with some nervousness to lay something out there for her to think about. "Maybe I'm just waiting for the right woman to come into my life."

Reflectively she says, "I wonder if we are looking for the right one, should we just wait for that right person or should we be more proactive? I wasn't looking for Kent; he just kind of came into my life."

I already know what she implied earlier, but I need some reassurance. "Do you sometimes think Kent may be the right one for you?"

Pause. "I'm not really looking for the right one. I don't plan to get serious with him and I told him that up front."

"Do you think he believed you?"

"I don't know. I hope he did because I don't want to hurt anyone either."

Pause. She continued, "Since neither one of us is actively pursuing a relationship, maybe that means we don't want one that badly."

"Maybe both of us are at a place in our lives where waiting seems like the best choice for now."

She turned to look outside and stare at the ocean and I could see a tear run down her cheek.

"Tess, have I said something to upset you?"

"No, it's okay. You didn't say anything. Even though it's been over six months since the divorce was final, I think maybe I'm not yet quite through grieving about it. I have no regrets about wanting the divorce; it's just sad." A little smile, "I'm probably just hormonal."

I was sad for her after all she had been through with Arthur and in combat. Maybe best to change the subject. "Would you like more coffee?"

"Sure, just a half cup."

When I sat back down, she said, "Tell me about your best friend."

"Henry and I have been best friends since high school. He and his partner own a construction company. He helped me design and build my office. And as I said a few minutes ago, Jill is his girlfriend," I gave her a few more details.

"I think it's great you all have continued to be close for all these years. I can tell he is very special."

"Tell me about your children and how they're doing."

"Now that's not fair Howard, I'm supposed to be finding out about you, but you know how I enjoy talking about them so I guess I can bring you up to date."

She talked about their activities and some about their personalities. She did like to talk about them, and she gave me all the latest details. I asked her more specific questions about them, and we must have gone on for quite a while. I had an ulterior motive behind this part of our conversation. I loved to watch her talk and her different expressions and the way her mouth formed words and the sparkle in her eyes.

Suddenly she seemed to get a little uncomfortable. Was it the way I was looking at her? Did she see something in my expression that made her shy and a little nervous? And so, she said a little abruptly, "Howard, this has been nice, but I need to get back to the house and get started on a list of things I wanted to get done today."

I tried again with everything inside me not to show my disappointment.

"Okay, I can drive you back to your house."

"Thanks, are you sure that's not too much trouble?"

"No, I'm happy to do it." She seemed to be relaxed again as soon as I offered to drive her back. Before we left the house, she went over, and petted PJ and he purred and rolled over on his back and when she tried to pet GJ she jumped off the sofa. We both laughed at the difference in their reaction.

I took her on a back road down toward her house and we exchanged small talk about the scenery and vegetation along the way. Then we were there. When I walked her to the door, she asked me to come in but as much as I wanted to, she seemed a little uncomfortable again, so I declined saying that I better go on. Was it relief on her face? I couldn't tell. Maybe I was just being a little paranoid.

"Well Tess this has been really enjoyable and...." I hesitated and didn't know what else to say and felt like a fool kind of stuttering and....

She finally rescued me and said, "Why don't you give me a call sometime."

"OK..., sure..., I will. Take care of yourself."

"You taught me how to do that and I will; you take care of yourself too."

"I will. Goodbye."

"Goodbye."

Follow Up and Regret

As soon as I got to the truck, I quickly called Henry to make sure we were still on for lunch. I really needed to talk to him. I was a mess. I couldn't get a clear enough head to process the morning. Had it gone well? What did she think? Henry wasn't there when I arrived, so I went to our favorite table and waited for him. What was keeping him? Then he walked in and apologized for keeping me waiting. "A customer just chewed my ass because her tile wasn't installed the way she wanted it. I'll spare you the details. Anyway, I'm here. How did it go?"

"I think it went pretty well. We picked up right away on the bantering that was common in the later therapy sessions."

"What else?"

"There are several things that stick out in my head. One is that she pursued the question about why I called her, and I told her I had enjoyed working with her and I was just interested in how she was doing."

Henry asked, "How did she respond?"

She seemed to accept it. I told her I often called former clients to check on them and then she asked if I ever met with any of them. I told her a few. She asked if any of them were females. I started squirming some and hesitated and then said they were both male."

"How did she respond to that?"

"She just smiled. What do you think?"

"Nothing much. She may have been flattered. It's hard to read anything beyond that at this point. What else?"

"She asked me if I was dating anyone."

"What did you tell her?"

"I told her about Taylor. She wanted to know why we weren't still seeing each other. I told her that she had met someone else and that I was glad because I was ready to end the relationship. Luckily, she didn't ask me when it ended so I didn't have to lie."

"I see what you mean. The timing may have made her wonder why it closely coincided with the end of the two years. Do you think she's picked up on the timing issue?"

"Yes, she brought it up. We were bantering about why I called her. I said I called because I wasn't sure she would be okay without the therapy sessions, and she said something like why you waited two years as I might have been in a psych ward. Then she was kidding me about me needing a therapist and volunteering to

do the job saying she had had a lot of practice over the past two years being a therapist for her friends.”

“So, she is aware of the timing for sure, but there are no clear implications there. She remembers you said two years during the last session, and she likes you and wanted to have coffee with you and she knows you like her so maybe friendship is all she’s interested in.”

“You’re not helping me.”

“I’m trying to be realistic. I don’t want you to get your hopes up when there is nothing to suggest you should.”

Feeling disappointed, I said, “I know.”

“Howard, live your philosophy. It will help cut out expectations and help with acceptance.”

“I know. Thanks for reminding me.” Pause. “She told me she was dating. His name is Kent Hill, an attorney from Charleston. She said they were just friends and she had told him she was not interested in a serious relationship.”

Pause. He asked, “How do you feel overall?” Smiling, “Given the fact that you’re trying not to have expectations.”

Pause. “I think what gives me some hope is we had a good time and she seemed genuinely happy to see me.” I told him about the meditation with my hands on her shoulders, her pulling me along in the water, the joking about her shape and being in good condition, the church hugs, her throwing water at me, our coffee in the kitchen nook, my disclosure that Si had helped me realize I was missing that special person in my life and that my fear had been holding me back. “That was where she smiled and agreed to be my therapist to help me get over the fear.”

He put his hand on top of mine and said, “There are some positive things for sure, but it’s all conjecture. We’re back to your philosophy and taking one day at a time.” His phone rang. “I’ve got to go. Another emergency at work. Real quick. How did it end?”

I told him.

“Keep me updated. Call if you want to get together again before next Friday.” He left.

I drove back to the house, returned some calls, read, and wrote some emails and then went for another run to help clear my head. I stopped at the sanctuary and did a meditation working on those same issues mentioned by Henry at lunch. I walked home and worked on getting Centered with an ‘attitude of gratitude.’ That was always my go to mantra. I walked down to the edge of the preserve and then back home.

I decided it was time to start spending more time on my book. Over the past year, I had done pretty well with my writing, but this past month I had not done

much with my mind focused on seeing Tess again. I loved writing so this was a good time to focus on getting back in that grove. I wrote until supper, had a sandwich, read some of my novel and went to bed.

I had a restless night but followed my morning routine. Si was coming about nine to spend the morning with me. Roger had to work. Chase and Dottie were with my mom and dad. She had been eager to hear about my meeting with Tess after work yesterday, but said she decided she would rather wait until this morning due to a lot going on at their house last night. She asked if we could go for a run when she arrived as she would have no time to get her run in after going back home.

During the run I told her everything that had happened. I was eager to get her perspective on it. We ran another mile or so and then started our walk to cool down.

“Daddy, it sounds like the visit went well and it’s definitely hard to read anything into it other than she was really glad to see you. But that’s a good start to having a friendship for now. I’m not sure how it could have gone any better. Even if she is madly in love with you, she is not going to say anything at this point that would divulge how she feels. When will you call her?”

“I don’t want to appear too eager. Maybe she doesn’t have romantic feelings, but a friendship might lead to that. As hard as it will be, I think I’ll wait about a week before I call her. Whatta you think?”

“I like that idea.”

“I’m driving myself crazy with the ‘what if’s’.”

“Would it help to talk about ‘em?”

“Yes, I think it helps to say them out loud. What if she doesn’t want to see me anymore? What if she likes being friends, but has no interest in a relationship? What if she fell in love with me while seeing me and then after two years fell out of love with me? What if she is already falling in love with Kent? What if she just wanted to be friends with benefits? I have more with variations of that same theme.”

“Daddy, you know what to do.”

“Yes, I know. My meditations have saved my life over these past two years. The first year was of course more of a challenge, but the second year was manageable, and I want to get back to that state. I felt Centered most of the time and was able to rest in a state of acceptance and cautious optimism.”

I continued, “It was like my life almost returned to normal functioning where I was happy, content, and thankful for my blessings. I never allowed anything to get in the way of my relationship with you all or Mom and Dad and Henry, but I think my work suffered some that first year and it was difficult to

focus on my book. So again, right now, I want to return to that state of acceptance and gratitude. I don't want that obsessive way of thinking about her. I love her and I'm going to work hard to take one day at a time and stay Centered in my life. Yes, Si, my sweet daughter, I know what to do."

She was quiet and it looked like she was thinking about something. "What are you thinking Honey?"

"I just said a few minutes ago I thought you had a good plan, but now I'm wondering about a different plan. What do you think about the idea of telling her how you feel?"

It was my turn to be silent.

"That's a good question. I've thought about doing that and if I knew or had strong suspicions that she loved me, I would do that in a heartbeat. But since I don't have a clue, I keep thinking I have to be patient and move slowly exploring the friendship in hopes that if she doesn't have feelings, she will over time fall in love with me."

Pause. I continued, "If I tell her and she doesn't have any feelings for me, I could also scare her away and never have a chance with her. I'm fearful about taking the risk."

She responded, "I get that. From what we know so far, I like the first plan better. However, after the next meeting, I suggest you be open to revising your plan. Please keep me in the loop. I want to be able to give you a female perspective."

"Thanks Honey, I wouldn't think of going forward without your input. Was there anything you wanted to talk about?"

"Yes, I wanted to talk to you about my book. I'm struggling with the chapter on addiction."

"I'm not surprised. That for me is one of the most puzzling disorders to treat."

We spent the rest of the morning talking about it, had some lunch and then she left for home. I spent the rest of the day writing and took a long walk to think about my next contact with Tess. When I got back, I worked on an outside project for a while, took a shower, had some supper, and fell asleep watching a football game.

The next week was uneventful. I had decided to call Tess on Thursday after work. I was nervous and took some deep breaths to help me get Centered.

I dialed the number and a young girl I assumed was April answered the phone.

"Hello."

"Hello, this is Howard Kingston, could I speak to your mother?"

Pause. "Are you the shrink that saw my mom?"

In a friendly and kidding way, I said, "I'm sorry young lady. That's confidential."

Laughing, "Well if it's confidential it must be you. You need to start seeing her again. She has a lot of problems."

Still kidding, "What kind of problems?"

"She's too strict. Can you fix that?"

In the background in a loud voice, "April, who's on the phone?"

Taking the phone away from her head, she yells back, "It's your shrink. I'm setting up an appointment for you!"

Laughing, "April Angelina, give me that phone!"

"No!" There's some rustling noise in the background.

"Howard is that you?"

Disguising my voice, "Yes, this is Howard from the hardware shop; your lawnmower is ready to be picked up."

"You must have the wrong number; I don't have any grass in my yard."

"In that case, could I sell you some grass seed?"

We both laugh. She said, "Hold on."

"April go somewhere in the house or outside where you can't eavesdrop. Go on. If you want to go out tonight, move young lady!"

Back on the phone, "Sorry, yes, I could use some grass seed. Will it grow in the sand?"

"Yes mam. Our grass seed will even grow on concrete."

"You mean like weeds growing up through the cracks."

"Well, I guess you do have a point on that one. But I still have the used lawnmower in case...."

She interrupts, "Hey Howard, what a surprise. I didn't expect another call from you for another two years."

"Remember living in the moment where there is no time?"

"Yes, I remember it well. What's your point?"

"I don't think I have one."

She laughs, "Hey Howie, how are you, my friend."

"So, we can be friends?"

Acting coy, "I haven't decided yet. That was just a greeting phrase."

"In that case, would it be possible to get together and talk about it?"

"Sure, let me look at the calendar. Hold on." Pause. "Keller is coming over tomorrow to spend the weekend with April and me. How about Monday morning at eight where we met last week. We can both get in our runs before. Would that work for you?"

"Yes. It sure does."

“Sounds good. See you then. Goodbye.”

“Goodbye.”

That goodbye felt kind of abrupt, but I need to let it go. I had lunch with Henry the next day and I told him about the call to Tess.”

“Sounds like April likes to kid around like her mom.”

“Yes, I really liked her. I don’t want to talk anymore about Tess. It’s part of my practice at getting Centered. I’ll let you know how it goes. Tell me what’s going on in your life.”

He talked about his work and some of the frustrations he is dealing with at the moment. He told me that Jill is still clean and sober, and they are getting along really well.

“Oh, I meant to tell you that Jill is going to Charleston tomorrow to spend the day and night with Taylor. I thought we might go to Larry’s for supper and spend the evening together.”

“That’s great. What time do you wanna meet?”

“I’ve got a busy day tomorrow so how about seven?”

“It will be busy at Larry’s. I’ll call Pete and have him hold our seats at the end of the bar.”

“Super. Gotta run. See you tomorrow night.”

The weekend went well. I picked up Chase on Saturday morning and then took him home around four; met Henry at Larry’s and on Sunday, spent the day doing some outside projects.

I woke to a misty drizzle. Showered and shaved, had coffee and toast, and left for our second meeting. The sun had peeped through, and the run was refreshing. I stopped at the house to pee and then headed south to meet Tess at the boundary of the preserve. My tee shirt and shorts were soaked, but it felt nice. There was not much breeze, and the temperature was perfect.

When I got there, she was not there, but I saw someone about half a mile away and I continued walking. As I got closer, I could see she was still jogging.

“Hey Howard, sorry, I’m running late. Keller stayed until this morning and Arthur was late picking him up and I didn’t want to leave until he was gone.”

“Perfectly fine Tess.”

“Would you mind if we ran for another mile? I didn’t have time to get my usual distance.”

“Sure. You set the pace.”

She had been running for years and her pace was about the same as my normal pace. We ran in silence and in sync and I loved it. It had been one of my dreams to go running with her. She slowed to a walk about a half mile north of the house and said, “That felt really good. I didn’t get my run in yesterday.”

I asked, "Would you like to go back to the house for coffee?"

"Sure."

"As I remember, you're very diligent about your daily run. What happened?"

"The kids and I went to Charleston to spend the day."

I immediately wondered if Kent was the reason or if he met them. I asked, "What was going on in Charleston?"

"The annual art festival. Have you ever been?"

"Yes, but it's been quite a few years."

"They still have a lot of fun things for kids to do. I think Keller got a little bored, but overall, it was fun. We were supposed to have lunch with Kent, but I had to cancel."

"What happened?" I was eager to know.

"Keller doesn't like Kent. I don't think it has much to do with Kent. It's more he doesn't like the idea of me dating."

"How does April feel about Kent and you dating?"

"She is more open to it. She says Kent seems nice, but I think being around him still feels kind of awkward for her."

"Do the kids seem any more accepting of the divorce?"

"Yes, I think so. April for sure and Keller is a little better."

"Did you tell them about meeting me today?"

"No, I decided not to. I need to give them a little more time to get used to me being single. Although April really likes you and got a laugh when I told her about your hardware routine. She loves to kid around."

She turned and faced me and said, "Wait a minute, you're asking all the questions. What have you been up to since I saw you?"

I gave her a summary of all the things I had been doing.

She asked, "Have you told your kids and Henry about meeting me last week and now?"

"Yes, I told Si and Henry. Si was full of questions?"

"How come?"

"She was just curious."

Smiling, "So what did you tell her?"

"Well, I started out telling her you had been a client. She interrupted saying you can't have any social contact with a client for two years. When I told her it had been over two years since our last session, she was relieved."

I needed a quick diversion. "I haven't said anything to Lance because I haven't talked to him for a couple of weeks. I did tell Henry and he said something like a couple of veterans becoming friends. He thought it was great."

By that time, we were walking in the front door and both of us were wet from the moisture in the air and sweat from the run. The temperature in the house was cooler than outdoors.

“I feel a little chill and would like to put on some dry clothes. Si leaves clothes here for all kinds of occasions. The top two drawers of the dresser in the guest bedroom are full of different clothes she wears. I know you could find something you feel comfortable in if you would like to change.”

“Oh no, that’s okay. I feel comfortable in the clothes I have on. I wouldn’t want to wear any of her clothes without asking.”

“Trust me Tess. She is going to be disappointed when I tell her what you said. If or when you meet her, you’ll understand what I’m saying. Please feel free to do it.”

“Howard, I just don’t feel comfortable.”

“Got it. Come on in the kitchen. I’ve turned on the heat and started the coffee. Why don’t you sit at the table in the nook? There’s a vent underneath the window and you should feel some heat in a few minutes.”

“Okay.”

“I have plain bagels. Would you like it toasted? I have cream cheese or grape jelly or butter.”

“Are you going to have one?”

“Yes.”

“Okay, I will too. Toasted and cream cheese please. You said while we were walking that Si had some questions about us meeting. Do you mind telling me what those questions were?”

I realized earlier when I told her about Si that she was going to ask me that so I’m ready to lie to her since I had confessed to Si that I loved Tess a long time ago. “No, not at all. She wanted to know why I contacted you. I told her the same thing I told you the other day. You were one of my favorite clients, that you worked hard, that I really enjoyed our sessions and that I wanted to get in touch after the two years and see how you were doing.”

“What else did she ask?”

“She asked something like do you have any other intentions?”

Smiling, she asked, “Well, what did you tell her?”

Smiling back, “I told her I hoped we could become friends just like Jake and Will.”

“Those are your two friends that were former clients, right?”

“Yes, and I told her I wasn’t sure whether that was going to work for you. I reminded her I’ve never had a female friend and I was hoping it would work out. Do you think it could work for you?”

“I’m still thinking about it. If we start getting together for coffee or lunch or whatever, I will have to tell Kent. I don’t think he’s going to like it or feel comfortable with our friendship.”

“I think if I were in his shoes, I would feel the same way. In my work with people over the years, I’ve for the most part encouraged people who were pursuing an innocent friendship with a member of the opposite sex to be very careful.”

“And yet you’re talking about us becoming friends.”

“I would like more coffee, would you?”

Smiling, “But you’ve only had one sip. Why do you need more coffee?”

Smiling back, “So I can think about how I’m going to answer your comment.”

When I came back to the table, she was still smiling and asked, “What did you come up with Howie?”

“I think two people as skilled as we are in getting and staying Centered can create whatever we choose to create. If we stay awake, this friendship won’t go in any direction other than the one we want it to go in.”

“What if one person wants it to go deeper and more serious than a friendship and the other one does not want that?”

“Would you like to take a stab at your own question?”

“This feels like therapy again. Remember how many times you asked me to answer my own question?”

“Yeah, I know it was a lot.”

“If I answer, does that mean we have to wait two more years before we can see each other again? Just kidding. What was the question again?”

“What if one of us wants a more serious relationship?”

“Okay.” She continued, “If we decide we want to be friends, that’s a risk we’ll have to take, because all we know in this moment is that we’re exploring whether we would like to be friends. I would suggest we make a commitment that if one of us is moving in the direction of being more serious, we let it be known to the other before it gets too far along. I don’t think either one of us would want to hurt the other.”

“Remind me to always ask you to answer your own questions. You give better answers than I give.”

Smiling, “Who taught me?”

“Thanks. I just did a little nudging.”

“I would call it a lot more than nudging.” Pause. “Okay, as I said a few minutes ago, however we define our friendship, Kent is not going to be comfortable with it. I don’t even think he would be comfortable with us meeting once a month for lunch.”

“I understand that.” This is a scary conversation. If she has feelings for Kent, a friendship is not going to be possible between us.

“Howard, I have a lot to think about. I’m not interested in a serious relationship with anyone. With the divorce being so recent, I’m very aware of how complicated, entangled and challenging they can be. Since my divorce, I have felt so free and happy. Now, I’m facing the situation where two people want to be my friend and I have to make a choice. That doesn’t feel free and happy.”

“I hate that for you. I don’t want in any way to complicate your life. What do you think about the idea of taking some time to decide what’s going to make you feel free and happy. Kent was already in your life before I called you. Would it be helpful for me to get out of the picture for now? We could leave it that you will call me when you have decided what’s going to work best for you.”

“Yes, I was thinking I need some time to decide what to do. I think you know I’m very fond of you and it’s good to see you again in a different circumstance. You have helped me so much with my healing and the skills and tools I needed to create that freedom and happiness.”

“That makes it even more important to me that I never do anything that would disrupt or contaminate what you’ve created.”

A slight smile, “There have been so many changes in my life situation; the divorce, the move, the adjustment of being a single parent, the adjustment of my children to having two homes, Keller’s anger at me for wanting the divorce and me exploring what I want to do with my life.” Smiling, “And now you want to be my friend and ordinarily that would be fine, but with Kent in the picture, now that’s complicated.”

“Tess, I am so sorry. I had no intention of adding any complication to your life....”

She interrupted, “Howard, please! I don’t want you to feel bad. Remember all you taught me about acceptance of our life situations, events, people, trauma etc.?”

“Yes, but to think I have caused complications that make it difficult and challenging to accept.”

“I understand. Do the best you can to let it be. I will take some time and then let you know how I’m doing. I’m thinking I will need several months to get things sorted out and time to use my skills and tools to embrace acceptance of whatever I decide. You have been a very important part of my life, and I will always thank God that I found you to be my therapist and my mentor. I’ll leave now.”

“Can I give you a ride back?”

“No thank you. I’ll walk.”

She stood up, gave me a church hug. I walked her to the door, and she left. I watched her walk out to the water. She took off her shoes and walked south. I

walked out to the shoreline and watched her until I could barely see her. She did not turn around.

Pain and Suffering

I phoned Si and Henry knowing they would both be at work. I left them voice mails that the meeting had not gone well. I still didn't know how she felt, and she needed some time to think about us being friends. She told me that it would possibly complicate her relationship with Kent. I told them I would check in later in the day.

I walked inside and sat in the nook thinking about what had just taken place. It was a nightmare. What was I waiting for? What was my problem? Ten minutes ago, I should have had the guts to tell her how I feel about her. I could have been transparent since that's what I teach and encourage other people to do. At least she would have something to decide on other than this fuzzy talk about a friendship.

I put the burden on her. Too much of a coward to take the risk. It was my fear, I kept telling myself. Fuck the fear! Grow "a set" for god's sake. At Center, fear doesn't exist. WHY CAN'T YOU LIVE WHAT YOU TEACH!?

I was so angry. I left the house and started running and ran all the way to the tip of the island and back to the house and up to the tip and back and fell exhausted onto the sofa. When I woke, it was late afternoon and pouring rain. I was still so disgusted with myself.

I sent emails to Si and Henry and told them that I would get in touch with them tomorrow but needed some time now to contemplate the situation with Tess and my own inner space.

I walked in the rain to my sanctuary, closed my eyes, started deep breathing, and soon dozed off. When I woke, it was dark, and I was shivering as the wind had picked up and the temperature had substantially dropped. I walked slowly back to the house and fell in bed.

I woke as the sun was coming up over the water. I drank some water, ate some bread and walked back to my sanctuary. I was feeling some better. I had three hours before my first appointment. I had beaten myself up yesterday and that was for the most part wasted time. I suggest to all my clients in a situation like that to take some time (fifteen minutes or so) for remorse and regret and beating yourself up. Continuing to do that beyond that time frame becomes self-indulgent and self-absorbed behavior. Nothing good comes out of that and you (like me) end up wasting time.

I spent about twenty minutes doing some deep breathing and then opened my eyes and knew it was time to shift gears and do some reflection and contemplation.

When I talked to Si last week, it seemed like the idea of not telling Tess was a good idea for now. So, I followed the plan. I did not tell her because I had no awareness that she had strong feelings for me and so being friends gave me a chance to take it slow and hope that she would come to feel about me as I feel about her. Also, if I told her, it might scare her away.

What I failed to realize was that being friends could complicate her relationship with Kent and make things difficult for her. I think at some level, I unconsciously would not allow myself to consider that Kent might be that important to her.

I looked out through the trees at the water and the sun beams making their way through the bushes and back through the trees. I felt a comfortable breeze and listened to the surf and some sea gulls in the distance. I was feeling Centered with a soothing calmness and peace in body and mind. I sat in silence for a while and into my mind came the question, "What if you had been Centered with Tess yesterday? What would you have said?"

As I remember, we were walking back to the house after our run, and she asked if I had told Si and Henry about our last meeting. I told her yes and that Si had been curious. When she asked me what I told Si, I of course started lying to her again.

So, if I had been Centered after her question about what I told Si, I would have been honest and told her the truth, but it was too late now.

I had lacked the courage to disclose my feelings and respect her enough to know that she could deal with it and decide on her own how she wanted to respond.

Given all that, I needed now to give her the space she asked for and not intrude on her experience of figuring out what she wanted to do. I had put all the pressure on her. And in doing that, I also lost my chance to share with her what was in my heart.

I was left now with the best and only approach to the situation. Acceptance of what had happened and work on getting Centered in this moment. I took the time to sketch my plan for this experience. I needed the structure.

On the days I wasn't working for the next two weeks, I would continue my normal routine of having lunch with Henry on Fridays, Saturdays with Si and family and visiting Mom and Dad. That would be the only contact with anyone else other than my family. There would be no other contact with anyone else except my clients. No television, simple meals, no sweets, no coffee and no alcohol.

I would get up at six every day; go for my normal run, a cool down walk ending at my sanctuary where I would do a twenty-minute-deep breathing exercise. Each day would include one more visit to my sanctuary for a twenty-minute meditation, and a thirty-minute reflection walk and two hours of manual labor on the outside of my house.

For thirty minutes two times a day, I would write in my journal the story of my experience from the time Tess called up to the present moment. The story would explore all facets of my behavior, the experiences, the whys, the how, the impact of my behavior, all facets of the real and possible pain and suffering of Tess, my family, and friends. It would include the embracing of my guilt and shame, and through confession and contrition, finding the experience of the love and forgiveness of God.

I called Si and Henry and filled them in on the situation and told them about my plan for the next two weeks. They supported me and understood the importance of what I needed to do.

I was surprised how quickly the time passed. I was really pleased how well it went. I felt a burden had lifted and an energized commitment to be awake and attentive to being more Centered in all phases of my life.

It had been close to four months after our second visit that she called. I had forced myself not to expect the call or wait for the call with some success. I was doing well living in the moment with an attitude of gratitude. Because I didn't give myself the luxury of spending time thinking about how much I missed her and how much I loved her, I dreamed about her quite often. I would wake up with a smile but would not allow myself to ponder the dream.

A few days later, my phone beeped, and it was Tess. "Howard, this is Tess. I've made up my mind what I want to do and would like to talk. Can we set a time?"

"Sure. You pretty much know my schedule. When and where would work for you?"

"You're off tomorrow, right?"

"Yes."

"Would you come to my house around four?"

"Sure."

"Good. I'll see you then. Goodbye."

"Goodbye Tess."

For four months, I had trained and worked hard to stay Centered in this situation with Tess. Before I would have anguished about the abruptness of her tone during that brief exchange and worried about what it meant. Now I was just

glad to hear from her and would do the best I could to let go of any expectations. If I could do that for any length of time before tomorrow, I would be happy.

I worked on my book for a while, but it was hard to concentrate so I went outside and continued working on my project. I ate a late supper, cleaned up and went to bed. I got up at six, did my usual routine, and started walking toward her house around 3:30.

She met me on her deck with what looked like a nervous little smile and gave me a church hug. She had a tray with coffee and two cups. She had some hazelnut creamer for me.

Her deck faced the ocean, and she had two easy chairs facing a sofa and a small table in between the chairs and sofa. She motioned for me to sit on the sofa. She had on a pair of white pants that came down to a little above her knees, a sea blue sleeveless blouse, a pair of sandals and her hair was pulled into a ponytail. She looked lovely and radiant.

She took a sip of coffee and said, “I have a story to tell you, and would you be willing to let me finish before you say anything?”

“Yes, sure.” Even with all the training over the past few months, I was getting very nervous. However, whatever she said, I was confident I would not under any circumstances dump my stuff on her or say anything that would cause her grief or pain. I felt like I was finally me again. Not the therapist me, but the me who would never hurt anyone on purpose and would take the hit if it meant the other person would not have to suffer.

She began, “This is hard for me. I guess that’s why it’s taken almost four months to get back in touch with you.”

She looked me right in the eyes. This was the combat helicopter pilot who had flown her chopper in and out of landing zones with fire fights all around to pick up wounded soldiers and bring them to safety, saving many lives in the process. She was not afraid. In my view, it was about getting clarity that took time.

“When I first came to you for therapy, I thought you were nuts about your ideas about training and hard work etc. Then, about halfway through that first session, you took me through that two-minute exercise where you had me close my eyes and listen to the waves. At first, I thought that was crazy, but during the last moments of the exercise, I experienced something wonderful and mysterious which I couldn’t explain.”

“You responded by saying in those moments, you can glimpse something inside you which will be the key to helping you heal the flashbacks, panic attacks and nightmares. At that point, I still thought you were crazy. It was only later in our sessions that I realized the significance and importance of that experience.”

She took another sip of coffee. “After a few months following that first visit, I made another appointment to confirm my view that you were nuts or stick around

to see what you had to offer.” A slight smile, “Then, when you told me I didn’t have any problems, I almost got up and left, but my curiosity kept me there. You said no problems, only situations.”

“I think the turning point for me came during session four when you asked if I would like to walk on the beach explaining you offered this to lots of your clients. While we were on the walk, you said something far out and crazy, and I reached down and cupped some water and threw it at you.”

“Shortly after that we went through that crazy experience where you responded to every comment I made, ‘It’s not important!’ I kept making statements and you kept saying, ‘It’s not important!’ and I remember we were both smiling. Somewhere in that experience, I let down my barrier to thinking I needed help. I think part of the reason for that is that I sensed you genuinely cared about me and were going to do everything you could to help me.”

Pause. She said, “I need to go to the bathroom.”

I said, “Me too.”

When we go into the house, “You take a left and I’ll go right. You’ll see it.”

I sat down outside and soon after, she brought out two bottles of water.

“Thanks.”

“I think it was around session five that I became aware that I was starting to look forward to our sessions. Your ideas were still kind of far out and crazy, but you were so patient with me and kind and made me feel in that moment that I was the most important person in your life.”

“And you made me laugh. It was like you were teaching me that therapy could be like an exciting exploration, a fascinating journey with some humor thrown in and of course along with lots of hard work and training.”

Pause. She looked out at the water and continued, “At a session or two after that, I started imagining spending time with you apart from therapy. How much fun we would have joking and bantering and spending time together. Then soon after that, I started fantasizing about having sex with you and realized I was falling in love.”

She looked out toward the water and a few tears ran down her cheeks and I wanted to take her in my arms and hold her and tell her what was in my heart, but I had promised to let her finish. What I couldn’t do was hold back a few tears of my own. I don’t think she noticed.

She looked back at me, “Those remaining sessions were the highlight of those next few months. You were constantly on my mind, and I couldn’t wait until the next time I could see you. At some level, I knew it was all crazy. It was like a dream that would never come true, but I couldn’t pull myself away from this passion, yes, this obsession to be with you and wanting to spend the rest of my life with you.”

More tears. “And before I even realized it, we were talking about spacing out our sessions and eventually leaving it on a ‘will call’ basis. I dreaded that last session more than you will ever know. I prayed you would take me in your arms and tell me that you loved me.”

Pause. She was wiping her tears. “It seemed in those last couple of sessions that you became more business-like and more professional. And then when the day came, I made that last attempt to be able to see you again by saying something like maybe we could have coffee together sometime. Of course, that’s when you told me about the two years before any social contact. My heart sank and it took every ounce of my energy to keep from standing up and leaving.”

I asked, “Can I say something?”

“If you don’t mind, I would like to finish.”

“I’m sorry.”

“As it was, a little later, I remember leaving rather abruptly. I had to get out of there before I started sobbing.”

“You had asked me early on to consider using a journal to help with my healing. It turned out to be very helpful. I also kept a personal journal with all the details of how and when I fell in love with you. After that last session, I spent the next week or so going through the personal journal looking for anything I had written down that might mean that you also loved me or were falling in love with me. I found things that gave me hope, but nothing for sure. They were just hopeless dreams.”

She drank some water and continued, “In my wildest dreams, I hoped you were in love with me and if you were, I couldn’t believe you wouldn’t break that stupid rule and contact me in some way to let me know how you felt.”

“Of course, I heard nothing except the exchange of emails over the letter about releasing me to fly. After a couple of months of longing, hoping and waiting for you to call, I gave up and started to accept the reality that you didn’t love me. I knew you liked me and enjoyed working with me, but I wanted or needed so much more than that.”

I am dying sitting here listening wishing I had been Centered during that second meeting four months ago.

She continued, “So, I had to get on with my life without you. I set up a training plan just like you taught me entitled, ‘falling out of love with Howard.’ The very skills you taught me I used to let you go and get on with my life. It took about a year in all. Finally, I felt free and happy. And when I saw you that second year at several places in town and on the island, I felt nothing. The training had worked. Then eventually, I divorced Arthur, and you know the rest.”

Pause. “So, when you called asking me to meet with you, I thought the two years must be up and you wanted to check on how I was doing. After all you said I

was one of your favorite clients. After I agreed, I got out all my notes and reviewed my training plan to get over you and did some meditations that had helped me the year before.”

She continued, “I wanted to make sure there were no residual feelings left. In addition, I had met Kent, and he was handsome, fun to be with and I was moving toward a ‘friends with benefits’ relationship. I was determined, however, not to get too emotionally involved with him as I was not interested in a serious relationship. Never again, I promised myself.”

“So, before we met, I was ready to meet with you and confident that I could pull it off without getting emotional and caught up in my previous feelings. And our first meeting was so nice, and I had such a good time and picking up right where we left off with the bantering. We talked about you needing a woman in your life and your comment that maybe you hadn’t found the right one yet.”

“Then somewhere in there, you talked about us becoming friends just like you were with Jake and Will. In some ways that was a relief knowing that I was not in the running for being the right one and that you felt nothing more for me than being a friend.”

“Near the end of that first meeting, I think I was talking about the children and the way you were looking at me was a little unsettling. It was like I could see into your heart and all I could feel was love. And then I told myself to stop being presumptuous. If you loved me, you would surely tell me. And when we were talking during our second meeting about the complications with a friendship, you offered quickly to stand aside and let me work things out with Kent. That sealed the thought that you just wanted to be friends.”

“I’m telling you this because I wanted you to know the reason, I can’t be friends with you. It’s just too dangerous. I can’t afford to love you again and then lose you again. It doesn’t feel like I could survive two broken hearts in one lifetime.” She looks away and starts crying.

When she looked back and saw the tears flowing out of my eyes, she said with irritation, “Howard, I don’t want your pity! I felt I owed you an explanation about why I couldn’t be your friend. I can’t stand you feeling sorry for me.”

Softly, I said, “My tears are about a regret that’s ripping me apart. To know now how much pain, I have caused the one person in the world that I have searched for all my life and who I love more than anyone or anything else in the world.”

She looked at me as if she could put no meaning to those words, no comprehension and then she burst into sobs. “You love me, and you waited till NOW to tell me? I suffered all that time because you couldn’t break some stupid rule. And it’s been over five months since those two years were up. You’ve had all kinds of opportunities to tell me. What’s wrong with you? And don’t give me any

sob story about you being too scared to tell me. Until now, I thought you were the most Centered person I had ever met and now it feels like you're a coward. Please leave and don't call me. I will never forgive you for what you've done. You're not the person I fell in love with. I don't know you. Please go!"

I got up with tears still flowing and touched her shoulder gently as I passed her, and she jerked it away. I walked down toward the water and looked back, and she was gone. About halfway home, it started to rain. I couldn't tell the difference between the rainwater and my tears. All the old pain of that first year came back with a vengeance. The devastation, the emptiness, the hopelessness, the physical weakness, and the despair.

I will never forget the pain and suffering I caused her. She displayed such courage by telling me her story. She laid herself out there pushing through any hesitation or fear of the vulnerability she must have felt. The imprint of this experience would be with me forever.

When I got home, I called Si and then Henry and told them it had not gone well. I gave them the snapshot that Tess did fall in love with me, but assumed I didn't love her since I didn't let her know even after the two years were up. When I told her I did fall in love with her, she was angry that I kept it from her because of some stupid rule and even then, didn't tell her during the five months after the two years had passed. She said I broke her heart and told me to leave and not to call her. She told me she would never forgive me for what I had done and that I was not the person she had fallen in love with. She said I don't know you. Please go!

Determination

That night I had no appetite and tossed and turned all through the night. I went through my usual morning of exercise and meditation. I was experiencing two divergent feelings. Despair about the pain I had caused her and elation that she had loved me and that there might be a chance for us. I tried to eat something, took a shower, and then called Si and Henry and left them both messages thanking them for their support and encouragement during our phone conversations yesterday. I told them I was doing pretty good this morning and would check in on Thursday after work.

I don't know how I got through the next three days. I felt an urge to cancel all my appointments for this week, but I was not about to do that to my clients. I don't know how I did it, but I made it through the three days. I had trouble focusing at times, but I did reasonably well in spite of what had happened. I was relieved work was over for the week.

I needed to keep meditating on what to do now. There was no question in my mind that I would do everything in my power to win back her love. Nothing would stop me unless she told me there was no chance for us. Even then, I would not give up until I had done everything possible to win her back.

With that settled, I was now left with the question of what to do; where to start; what action should I take? To figure that out was my goal and that was what I needed to contemplate over the next few days.

I went back to the house and called Si and brought her up to date and asked her if she could come to the house on Saturday morning. She said she could come early for coffee but would have to leave by ten as Roger had planned a family day outing. I called Henry and gave him the latest and asked if we could still meet for lunch tomorrow. That worked for him, and he was eager for a person to person update.

My goal now had to be self-acceptance; it was the only logical and healthy choice. It was only as I started letting go of the past that I could create the energy and clarity to do everything I could to let Tess know that I loved her and beg for a chance to let me prove it.

The next morning, I called her and there was no answer. Before I left to meet Henry for lunch, I called again and got no answer.

Henry was late as usual and was smiling as he gave me a big bear hug.

“Well, I’m happy she loved you and am hoping you can reignite that love. I have to say I’m optimistic you can pull it off.”

“Me too. Henry I’m not giving up. I don’t have a solid plan yet but I’m working on making it a Centered plan.”

“Good for you!”

“How are things in your life right now?”

“Jill is still clean and sober; the kids are great, and work is an ongoing challenge. I spend a lot of time working on getting Centered with my customers. I’m doing good with that skill you taught me about not giving anyone the power to control my feelings and experiences. A few slips here and there, but pretty good overall.”

He continued, “Jill said to remind you that our monthly gathering at the house is a week from this Saturday.”

“My dream would be to bring Tess.”

“I guess it would. I hope it happens.”

We spent the rest of the time catching up on other things.

I went by to see Mom and Dad and spent the rest of the afternoon with them.

That evening I called Tess again and April answered. “Hello April, this is Howard Kingston, is your mom home?”

“No, she’s in Charleston and won’t be back until Monday. Are you the guy from the hardware store?”

“Well, yes and no....”

She interrupted, “My Mom told you she didn’t want any grass seed. Don’t call again you jerk!” She hung up.

“I called back.”

“Are you hard of hearing? I told you not to call back.”

“Will you at least tell her I called?”

“I’ll think about it, but probably won’t.” She hung up.

Why did April have her cell phone if she was in Charleston? Maybe they switched phones for the weekend. Was she with Kent enjoying ‘friends with benefits?’ I wouldn’t blame her.

Si arrived around eight. We hugged and she wanted to know if we could go for a run.

“Roger has the day planned and my run was not on the schedule. I would love to get it behind me before I go home.”

I put my shoes on and we were off. It was a beautiful morning, and the temperature was perfect. I was beginning to feel some relief from all the trauma of this past week.

She asked, "Daddy, how you doin'?"

"Pretty good Honey. I feel like I've put most of the trauma from this past week behind me. I will not give up until I'm certain there's no chance for us."

"What are you going to do?"

"Well, yesterday I called her twice before I had lunch with Henry. There was no answer. Then around six, I called her again and her daughter, April answered the phone and told me she was in Charleston." I told her what April said.

"She sounds like a character. How old is she?"

"I think she's around fourteen."

"So, what's your next move?"

"April told me she wouldn't be back until Monday. I'm going to call tomorrow just to make sure she didn't come back early."

"Are you calling her cell phone?"

"Yes. I thought about that. I'm thinking she traded cell phones with April so I couldn't reach her."

"I hate to bring this up, but didn't you tell me she was dating someone in Charleston?"

"Yes, I did. And I'm worried she might be with him, but that's just part of the consequences of my behavior. And that's not part of beating myself up. That's just the reality of the situation. I can tell you there's nothing or no one that's going to get in my way of doing everything I can to win her back."

"Good for you Daddy. If I can do anything along the way to help you, let me know. You understand there are no certainties and I'm so glad you're willing to take the risk. She is obviously worth it!"

"Thank you, Honey!"

I asked her about what's going on in her life and she filled me in and then it was time for her to leave.

"Keep me in the loop!"

"Will do Hon. You all have a good time today."

I spent the rest of the day working on my project to build a stone path from the parking area to the kitchen door. It was great therapy for me as I had to carry the stone from the woods and then dig the space to lay the stone so it would be fairly level. I was too tired to fix supper, but I forced down a ham sandwich.

Around 7, I called Tess's number just in case she had come back early.

April answered, "It's you again. What do you want!?"

"Did your mom by any chance come back early?"

"No."

Pause. "What time do you think she'll be back?"

"I have no idea."

“Would you guess?”

“No, what good would that do. I don’t know.”

“Have you decided if you’re going to tell her I called?”

“Yes.”

“What did you decide?”

“I’m not going to tell her.”

“Could I ask why you won’t tell her?”

“You already just ask it.”

“True. What’s your answer?”

“It’s none of your business!”

“Look, I’ve got grass seed piled up to the ceiling. I have to get some sold or I’m gonna get fired.”

She couldn’t hold back her laughter. “Howie, you’re a funny guy. Why have you been so mean to my mama?”

“Because I’m screwed up.”

“It’s okay you can say fucked up.”

“Okay because I’m fucked up.”

“You’re a fucking shrink, you’re supposed to have your shit together. What’s your problem?”

Pause. She said, “You’re speechless and I’m watching a good TV show. I don’t have the time to hear it. You need a good therapist.”

“Will you please tell your Mom I called?”

“No. Keep calling. You’ll eventually get her if she ever decides she wants to talk to you. She’ll be back tomorrow around five. Now don’t call me again.” She hung up.

I had to smile. Yes, she is a hoot.

I couldn’t get it out of my mind that she was with Kent. I tried to watch some TV, but I couldn’t get interested in anything. Soon after, I passed out on the bed and didn’t wake until the sun was shining in the window.

I drank some water, ate a piece of toast, and did my morning routine of running and meditating. When I got back, I took a beach chair and Bible out near the water and read some of my favorite Scriptures. I did another meditation and then just sat there for a while and contemplated my next moves with Tess.

After lunch and lots of water, I continued working on my project for the rest of the afternoon. I quit around five and again was exhausted,

I called Tess at 5:05.

April, “She’s not home yet.” She hung up.

I called at six, seven and eight and there was no answer.

I called at nine and April answered, “She’s asleep.” She hung up.

I went to bed early and slept fairly. I wish I was working today. I had another day ahead of me just like yesterday. At least I would be able to finish the project today. Before I started work, I decided to give her a call.

Tess answered, "What do you want?"

"I would like to talk to you."

"About what?"

"About how much I love and miss you and how badly I messed things up and how much I regret ever causing you pain."

"I'll make a note of that." She hung up.

I called back. No answer.

It was a rough day. I was beginning to wonder if she was going to give me a chance. Then I remembered that was not the point. My goal was to have no expectations and give it everything I had. I loved the sound of that, but in the back of my mind, I wondered if I would get that second chance.

I called her again before supper and then again before I went to bed. No answer both times.

The next three days were going to be challenging. I needed to get my shit together and focus on being present with my clients and that's what I intended to do. And that's what I did the next three days.

I finished at five after the third day and called Tess.

April answered, "She says she's not here." She hung up.

I went for another run and spent time at my sanctuary. I worked on acceptance and the determination to keep trying with Tess. I wasn't even considering that I would ever give up. I went back to the house, took a shower, ate a light supper, picked some wildflowers, and headed on foot via the back road for her house.

I rang the doorbell several times. Even though I had never seen April, I knew it was her who answered. She glared at me through the screen door, "I told you we don't want any grass seed." And she shut the door. I knew Tess was there because her vehicle was in the driveway. I rang the doorbell several more times with no answer. I laid the flowers on the front porch and left thinking to myself; I'll be back tomorrow and the next day and the next day....

On my way back to the house, I noticed the clouds coming out of the west. A major rainstorm had been predicted to hit the coast around nine. I still wasn't hungry but managed to get down some soup and crackers. I hadn't been sleeping well that week and was exhausted. It had also taken a lot out of me to do my job these past few days. I put on some classical music and stretched out on the sofa with PJ and GJ snuggled against me.

Tess and Howard

I drifted off to sleep and was having this unsettling dream with a loud pounding noise in the background. A large crack of lightning woke me up and right away, I realized that someone was pounding on my front door. It was dark, perhaps they were lost. PJ and GJ took off to their favorite hiding places.

I opened the door and Tess soaked to the skin, hair dripping wet, tears filling her eyes and mascara running down her face threw herself into my arms wrapping her arms around my neck pressing her body against mine holding onto me for dear life and between the sobs saying, "Howie, I love you. Never let me go."

Then, I broke into my own sobs, my body shaking, "Tess, I've longed for you and dreamed of this moment, and I'll never let you go."

She pulled her head away from my neck and looked in my eyes with tears still running down her cheeks and gave me the most gentle and sensuous kiss. Her lips only slightly parted and the tip of her tongue just for a moment slid in and out of my mouth. My body tingled. I took her face in my hands and lightly kissed both of her eyes, her cheeks, and then just a gentle short kiss on the lips. I used incredible restraint. I wanted so badly to drink in every ounce of her, to kiss every part of her body, to make love to her for hours. I pulled her closer. We stood there clutching each other, afraid to let go, afraid this was just a dream.

She whispered in my ear, "Are you going to close the door?"

Grinning, "Is it still open?"

Closing the door, I continued. "You're soaked. Did you walk here?"

With a big grin, "No, I'm wet because some idiot wouldn't open the door."

Laughing, "I knew it was you and I wasn't sure it was safe based on how angry you were the other day."

Smiling she said, "It was a good thing you didn't open right away. I had a baseball bat. Finally, I dropped the bat because I needed two hands to bang on the door. In the interim, I decided to kiss you instead of hitting you with the bat."

"I deserved the bat, but so glad you changed your mind."

"For now!"

I pulled her back into my arms and said, "Tess, I love you! Tess, I love you! Tess, I've loved you for almost as long as I've known you!"

We've got to get you out of those wet clothes. Please borrow some of Si's clothes."

"As long as you're sure she won't mind."

“I’m sure and you know where the bathroom is and towels are in the little cabinet under the sink. I’m going to change too and light a fire and put on some coffee. Have you eaten?”

“I’m fine. The fire and coffee sound great.”

I was bringing the coffee in when she came out of the guest room. She had on a loose-fitting pair of hunter green lightweight shorts which came down to about the middle of her thighs. Si was about 5’ 4” and I guessed Tess was about 5’ 6” or 7”. She had on an old grey sweatshirt with the sleeves cut off above the elbows.

Smiling, I asked, “Do you have any underwear on?”

A sexy smile, “That’s a rather personal question so soon.”

“I’ve been making love to you in my dreams for almost two and a half years.”

“And you think I’ve been doing the same and therefore you can take the liberty to get that intimate this soon? By the way, what was your question again?”

I answered, “Do you have any underwear on?”

“I can’t remember. Would you help me out?”

She turned away and lifted one of her pants legs and pulled it up just enough to get a glimpse of bottom part of her bare ass. “Do I, she asked?”

“I still can’t tell.”

“Well, that’s all the hints you get.”

“How about a bra?”

“You’ll just have to guess big boy. And by the way, do you have any underwear on?”

“I don’t ever wear underwear here at the house.”

“Show me.”

I set the tray down and facing her, started to pull up the front of my pants leg.

Laughing, she said, “No, no, turn around. I don’t want to see that thing quite yet.”

“Got it.” I turned around and showed her a portion of my butt cheek.

“Well now that’s settled,” she walked into my arms and our bodies pressed together like they had been separated and lost for a long time and had finally found each other. She was shivering a little.

“How about that coffee and let me pull the sofa a little closer to the fire.”

She fixed her coffee and sat on the sofa. I backed over to the door leading to the kitchen.

She asked, “Where are you going?”

“Do you mind if I walk around the room and just look at you? I have longed for you in so many ways. When you asked for water in a session, after you left, I

would put my lips and tongue around the edge of the cup and drink the rest of the water. I would sit in the chair you sat in and close my eyes and try to feel your energy. I would pretend you were sitting on my lap. Now, here we are in the same room, and I don't have to keep my distance. I don't have to have that ache inside, that emptiness, that intense longing, that lingering and painful loneliness that only you can make disappear."

"And there's some part of me that is scared to touch you for fear that in the touching the dream will go 'poof' and you will be gone, and I will be alone again." I continued walking around the room looking at her.

"And it's so exciting that in a few minutes, I can come over to you and touch you and hold you and kiss you. And what I want to do right now is just come over and sit beside you and drink our coffee and enjoy in our minds the freedom to love each other and know the love is returned."

And that's what we did. We sat on the sofa in front of the fire, each holding our mug of coffee. We were both a little nervous and yet content for now to say nothing as we watched the fire flicker and burn. Our legs and arms were touching, and, in the silence, there was this incredible intimate energy.

I said a little above a whisper, "I remember all the times I would have been thrilled just to hold your hand for fifteen seconds.

She said, "There is something very special about sitting here doing something we were not allowed to do. It's like when you were walking around a few minutes ago I was saying to myself this man loves me and, in a few minutes, he will be sitting beside me snuggled together drinking our coffee."

I said, "I have a thousand questions and a thousand things I want to tell you and I want to do it all in the next twenty minutes."

I could see her smile out of the corner of my eyes.

"Me too. I told you before that you know so much more about me than I know about you. I want you to tell me about yourself as a little boy, what you liked to do, special memories, what it was like growing up, your happy times and sad times, your fears, what you dreamed about. I want to know everything."

I said, "I thought if I knew you loved me, everything would be wonderful. But I'm aware of some new fears. As you just said, you don't know that much about me."

She said, "There's a lot you don't know about me either. What kind of fears are you talking about?"

"What if you get to know me and find out as you said on Monday that I'm not the person you fell in love with?"

She responded, "I'm scared I will love you even more than I do now, and something will keep us apart and block us from being together." And a faint smile, "Or you won't love me as much as I love you."

“I can match your fears and go one up on you. What if you decide I’m too old for you or someone else convinces you I ‘m too old for you?”

“Or someone convinces you I’m too young for you or what if Si and Lance don’t like me?”

“What if your dog doesn’t like me?”

“I don’t have a dog.”

“You’re missing the point, what if you had a dog and it didn’t like me?”

Smiling, “Well, I know GJ doesn’t like me. She runs every time I see her.”

I said, “That could be a deal breaker.”

In a more serious tone, she paused and then said, “I’m scared my missing ear will repulse you. You taught me I am not my body and I worked hard on integrating that. It has allowed me to avoid keeping it covered up all the time. But now that I’m with you, I’m more conscious of it.”

“I love your body. I love every part of it. One of the reasons I fell in love with you was your determination to refuse to let the missing ear define you or hold you back from living your life.”

“But it has been such a challenge at times. Like right now, I’m allowing it to cause me to worry that at some point it might turn you off.”

“Tess, what if your injury had been more serious like the loss of a limb or limbs or something worse, I would have still fallen in love with you. I love your body because it is a part of you, but my love for you goes much deeper than that. I fell in love with your spirit, the essence of who you are.”

“I know what you mean. I know that if you had had some disability that it would have made no difference to me. I just want to be with you, to hold you, to do things together, to live our lives. That’s all that counts.”

“I’ve been reluctant to look at that side of your face because I wasn’t sure what you would think or if it would make you self-conscious. Now I can look at all of you without hesitation and I’m so glad we’re talking about it now. Are you comfortable with me kissing you there?”

“Just go slow. It’ll be fine. Some parts of it are still a little sensitive. Now I feel like we can go on with loving each other and I don’t have to think about it.”

She turned and looked at me, “Can you tell by looking into my eyes how much I love you?”

“Yes, and I also feel the love pouring out of me. Can you tell?”

“Yes.” She looked in my eyes smiling, “Howie, how could two people who love each other so deeply and completely have so much difficulty finding the path to each other? Every week we sat in your office loving each other and longing to be in each other’s arms and we might as well have been miles away.”

She continued, “After our sessions, I would walk down those stairs and feel like I was leaving my life behind. The only way I survived those times was to get

lost in the lives of my children and in my military life. So often when all was quiet in the house or I was alone somewhere, I would think of you and my eyes would tear up and I would smile and wonder what you were doing.”

I responded, “That first year I looked for you everywhere. I would drive by your house hoping not to see you for fear that you would recognize my vehicle or see me. But when I did it, I somehow felt closer to you for those few seconds.”

“Remember on our first meeting after the two years when I asked you to take me through a meditation on the edge of the water and put your hands on my shoulders to help me keep my balance?”

“Yes, I will never forget it.”

“When you touched my shoulders, I felt this surge of warm energy run through my whole body and it was very sexual. I think I knew at that moment I was in trouble. I kept telling myself that I was over you and it was just an emotion of the moment.”

I said, “And it felt so wonderful to me too. I had such a hard time lifting my hands off your shoulders. It was the first time I had touched you. And there was this incredible longing.”

Pause. She smiled, “Aren’t you supposed to be carrying me off to the bedroom and aren’t we supposed to be ripping off our clothes and fucking our brains out?”

Smiling, “Is that what you want me to do?”

“Isn’t that what they do in all the movies and romance novels?”

“Yes, I guess it is.”

She said, “I’ve wanted you naked in my arms for a long time, but right now, I’m thrilled just to be able to hold your hand and have our arms and legs touching. And to be able to talk to you with no barriers, no walls, no rules, no people to keep us apart. Oh! I forgot to tell you; I must leave in about fifteen minutes to pick up April.”

Trying not to look too disappointed, I said, “Can you come back?”

“Not tonight.” Then laughing and pushing me over on my back and almost knocking the coffee off the table, “Just kidding Howie.” And snuggling her head into my neck, she said, “My love, nothing could tear me away from you tonight unless I get hungry,” More laughing.

Then we shifted around on the sofa getting comfortable with Tess laying on top of me. Smiling, she said, “Just because I want us to wait to make love right now, it doesn’t mean I don’t want to feel our ‘privates’ snuggling. Let’s spread our legs some.”

We moved around some and I said, “You’re going to give me ‘lover’s nuts.’”

Smiling, she said, “Yes, I remember that from my teenage years. I have 1 brother and I learned a lot growing up with him. Keller is overall closer to his father, but Arthur doesn’t feel comfortable talking to Keller about sex. He finds it more comfortable talking to me. I think it has to do with the fact that I’m not a traditional woman.”

She continued, “Several months ago, Keller told me his balls were really hurting and it scared him. I asked him if he and, I’ll leave out her name, were kissing and hugging etc. and if he got sexually aroused. He said yes and I explained the ‘lover’s nuts’ and told him that was natural, and that masturbating would give him some relief.”

She said, “Backing up a little, years ago, my brother told me he felt guilty masturbating when he was a kid. I didn’t want Keller to feel that way, so I had that conversation with him last year. He told me he didn’t feel that way because in their sex education class at school, the textbook they were using said masturbating was natural and perfectly fine.”

I said, “I wish they were teaching that when I was going to school. I’ve always thought that masturbating was a sin against God and that my ‘dick’ at some point was going to shrivel up and fall off as part of God’s punishment.” Smiling, “Thanks for giving me a ‘heads up’ on that. It’s a huge relief.”

She reached over and grabbed a pillow off the floor and hit me over the head with it. I held my arm up to prevent further blows. “Okay, okay, I’m sorry I lied. Actually, my mom told me last year I didn’t have to feel guilty.” Another blow!

She threw the pillow back on the floor and snuggled her body back down on mine. She said, “I’m having so much fun. Raise up a little so I can get my arms around you.” And then she nestled her head in the crook of my neck and started gently squeezing me and making subtle hunching moves.

Smiling and softly into my ear, “Feels like you have a little something going on down there.”

“I do and this is where I wanna carry you to the bedroom and fuck our brains out.”

She lifted her head and loosened her arms and put her lips close to mine and whispered, “We haven’t even properly kissed yet.”

She started moving the tip of her tongue slowly circling my lips and when she was finished, I did the same to her and then with our lips softly touching, the tips of our tongues met and circled in an erotic dance and then with lips remaining soft, our tongues began to explore more deeply with a soft penetrating touch that became more and more sensuous and intimate and wet and juicy each drinking in every drop tasting and longing for more.

Whispering, “Oh Tess, I can’t get enough of you.” A wild hunger taking over us like we would never be able to taste each other again and we had to get

enough to last us for a lifetime. And then out of breath, we buried our heads into each other panting.

She whispered, "I have dreamed of those kisses for so long. And I can't get enough of you either. Oh Howie, is this really happening to us? Is this really the end of all the dreaming, of all the hoping, of all the loneliness and all the fear that you didn't love me?"

"Yes, my precious Tess. It's the end of all that." I reached for an old comforter on the back of the sofa and threw it on the floor. She took off the jersey and I quickly ripped off my tee shirt.

Her nipples were hard, and I started teasing them with my tongue and she moaned, "That feels so good." Then she pulled me down to her and with her legs stretched out on the floor, she spread just enough so I could get one leg and my dick between her legs.

Being careful not to put too much weight on her, we continued the deep and sensuous kisses and the rhythmic motion of our bodies. We held onto each other again as if someone or something might have the power to separate us. The light weight and slick material of our shorts with no underwear made the movement between our legs even more sensual.

Finally exhausted again, we simultaneously shifted, and I rolled over on my back. She cuddled up next to me resting her head on my chest and draping a leg over my body. We were both still breathing heavily and content just to be in the other's arms.

Her breathing slowed and she seemed to drift into sleep. I closed my eyes and smelled her hair and when she exhaled, I took long slow easy deep breaths to bring her scent into my body. Soon after I drifted off myself.

I don't know how long we lay there, but the fire was almost out.

She said, "Hey, my love, are you awake?"

"No, I'm totally in a dream state,"

Smiling, "I have to pee."

"Me too."

PJ had parked himself on the arm of the sofa and was looking at us.

She said, "PJ doesn't seem to be bothered by me."

"GJ doesn't like anyone but Si."

I got up and pulled her up into my arms. "Just one quick kiss before you go."

As she headed to the bathroom, I asked, "Would you like something hot?"

Smiling, "You mean besides you?"

"Well thank you sweetheart."

"Yes, any of the Celestial Seasons teas would be great."

I put some water in the microwave and put out some different flavors of the tea. When she came back in, "Help yourself, I'll be right back."

When I came back, she asked, "Did you know it was two o'clock?"

"Yes, I glanced while you were in the bathroom." I had stoked the fire, and we went back in with our tea."

We cozied up together. I asked, "Can you stay?"

"April told me I had to be home by midnight."

"Well, you could be in some big trouble."

Smiling, "She will never know. She is staying at her dad's."

"I guess she told you about our conversations. She put me in my place a number of times."

"Yes, I know."

"What did she tell you?"

Smiling, "She didn't have to tell me anything. I overheard every conversation."

Surprised, "She said you were in Charleston for the weekend."

"We lied. I was right there for every conversation."

"Well, that's a nice relief. All weekend I imagined you making love with Kent. I thought it was a fitting punishment for my sorry ass behavior and I hoped he was treating you a lot better than I treated you."

Pause. "What happened with you and Kent?"

"A few days after our last talk four months ago in your kitchen, I met him in Charleston and told him I couldn't continue to see him anymore, because I had some unresolved issues with a previous relationship, and I needed time to figure out and decide what to do. He asked me to call him if it didn't work out. I told him I would let him know. So, after our talk on Monday, I called him the next day and told him that it had worked out with the other person and that I wished him well."

Surprised, "You told him it had worked out after Monday?"

"Yes, even though I could have hit you with a baseball bat and right after you left, I continued to cry and call you every bad name I could think of. April knew I had been upset for the four months after our second meeting. She had been bugging me to tell her what was wrong, and I kept putting her off. When I came in the house sobbing Monday, she screamed at me, 'Mama, tell me what's wrong.' I couldn't stop crying and she put her arms around me and held me until I settled down."

"She took my hand and led me over to the sofa and said, 'Mama lay down and put your head in my lap.' She stroked my forehead and the top of my head and continued, 'I want to know what's going on. When I came in from shopping and I heard you on the deck yelling and crying. And I look out and a man was leaving.

And now, I have never seen you so upset. I know these past months have been so hard for you. Please tell me!”

“I told her the whole story from the beginning to that moment. She listened and teared up some and called you some names I didn’t know were in her vocabulary.”

She continued, “I think I was so caught up in my pain and anger, that it wasn’t until near the end of the story that I began to take in the meaning of your words.”

“April said, ‘so when you finished confessing to him that you had loved him, again, what did he say?’ I told her you said something like your heart was ripping open with regret that you had caused so much sorrow and pain to the one person you had searched for all your life and the one you loved more than life itself or something like that. Then I told her that’s when I went off on you for not telling me sooner. I told her I didn’t know she had come home and that she could hear me.”

“April said ‘Yes, but I couldn’t tell what you were saying.’”

“She tried to get me to eat something, but I wasn’t hungry. I went to bed and passed out and didn’t wake up until the next morning around nine. April had made coffee and it smelled wonderful. She fixed us scrambled eggs, fried some bacon, and warmed up some bagels. We took it out on the deck. It was a beautiful morning.”

“April asked, ‘How are you doin’ Mama?’ I told her I was feeling much better. The rest of our conversation was centered around the fact that what I learned yesterday was more important than anything else; my dream had come true.”

“She asked, ‘Whatta you think he’ll do now?’ I smiled at her, I don’t know exactly when it will happen, but now that he knows my story, I can tell you for sure he won’t give up until he has done everything, he can make it work.”

“By then, April had also softened, and it was in that conversation that we decided to make you work for it. I knew you would call or come by the house. That’s when we planned our response to whatever you might do. We had a strategy for every move you might make. It was her idea to make up the story about me being in Charleston knowing that you would think I was with Kent. And she made up her own responses to your calls. And we had so much fun planning it.”

“I really like her. She has spunk and I love the way she loves her Mama!”

“April is like an old soul in a fourteen-year-old body. She’s stood by me through so much over the last few years. I don’t know what I would have done without her.”

“What a wonderful relationship you all have.”

“Yes, I feel very lucky. Don’t get me wrong. We still have our moments of mother daughter drama.”

“Got it.” Pause. “So, April is not mad at me?”

“No. now that she knows you adore her Mama.”

“I’m relieved. I’m kind of looking forward to meeting her.”

“Why ‘kind of’?”

“If someone treated my mom like I treated you, I would be really mad.”

“Don’t worry, she was mad at you on Monday after you left, but as I said, we both softened by the next morning. Also, she thinks you’re funny. I think you all will have a great relationship.”

“Backing up a bit, after all the pain and suffering I had caused you, I knew I didn’t deserve a chance, but I hoped and prayed there was some spark of love still there for me. There was of course no way I was going to give up. And you knew that all along. Right?”

“Yes and no. Mostly yes.” Smiling, “But you had been such a ‘chicken shit’ up to that point, I didn’t know how long it would take you to pull the trigger.”

She continued, “I remembered again the way you looked at me while we were talking in the kitchen nook the first time we got together. I had been right. I could see the love in your heart by the way you stared at me. There was a kind of longing in your expression. Of course, at the time, I just dismissed it as me wanting it to be true.”

She reached up and gently stroked my face, “I love you Howie.”

“I don’t deserve you, Tess. I will never forgive myself for everything I put you through.”

Smiling, “Oh, I’ve got a long list of stuff you can do to make up for it.”

“I’ll do whatever you say.”

“I think you really mean that.”

“I do.”

Smiling, “We’ll see.”

She continued, “There is one last thing I want to tell you about Kent and then I would like us to forget he ever existed.”

“Got it.”

“We had sex once before the first time you and I met, but there was nothing there for me emotionally. Now, is there anything you want to ask me about Kent before we let all of that be and let it go?”

“Not really, but since you asked, Was he a great lover? Was he better looking than me? Was he younger than me? Did you have an orgasm? Was it a powerful orgasm? Did...”

Laughing, she interrupted me, “Stop! Stop! Okay I shouldn’t have asked, but since you did, the answer is a ‘yes’ to all of those questions.”

Continuing to laugh, she picked up a pillow and started beating me over the head and shouted, “Yes, yes to all those questions, but I still think you may, might, could be a better catch. Don’t ask me to explain why.”

Smiling, “Believe me I won’t ask you. I’m glad I didn’t know about you calling it off. It was part of my consequences for not telling you during our second meeting that you were the woman of my dreams.”

“You haven’t said much about the reasons for not telling me in our second meeting that you loved me other than you have been beating yourself up for not letting me know.”

“Remember all that talk about me being afraid of having another intimate relationship?”

“Yes.”

“It was all bull shit. I hadn’t had another relationship after Florence, except for that brief time with Taylor, because I didn’t want one. I wasn’t looking or searching and wasn’t interested until you came along. Then, as I said, somewhere in the middle of our therapy sessions, I knew you were the person I had been looking for all my life. Even though consciously, I was not aware that I had been looking for anyone.”

“Go on.”

“That’s where the fear came in. I had no idea you had any feelings for me other than you thought I was a nice person. I was afraid if I told you how I felt and you didn’t feel the same, it would have been so embarrassing for you and made you feel bad that you had to hurt my feelings by telling me you didn’t have those kinds of feelings for me.”

“What about how you would have felt?”

“Well, yes embarrassed, but also heart broken. I thought the only chance I had was for us to be friends and I hoped once you got to know me better you might fall in love with me.”

Pause. I continued, “Even if I hadn’t known you loved me, I now think I should have told you. I should have taken the risk. I felt like a coward. I was filled with self-anger and self-loathing.”

She said, “But all that angst came after you knew I loved you.”

“It did but knowing that you loved me made me see that all my reasons for not telling you were selfish, and ego driven. It was all about protecting myself.”

“I disagree. You said I would have been embarrassed and it’s true. I would also have felt so sorry for you and felt bad for you. And that would have been very painful for me. Even if I hadn’t fallen in love with you, I would have felt an

emotional intimacy and connection with you and would have never ever wanted to do anything that would cause you pain.”

“But you could have handled it and worked through it. I should have given you the credit and told you the truth. I owed that to you and needed to take the risk. You could have at least gotten on with your life.”

She continued, “Remember the phrase you taught me, ‘It’s not important!’ I think that applies to this subject. What do you think?”

“I agree now that it’s not important. All that matters is here we are.”

She said, “I do however I have a couple more questions for you.”

“Okay.”

“Why did you tell me you would step aside so I could figure out how I felt about Kent?”

“I thought that was the honorable thing to do. You were upset and saying your life had been free and peaceful or something like that and now it was getting complicated. And I was the one who had caused you the complications. It was a risk I felt like I had to take. I felt a little better about myself telling you I would step aside and give you whatever time you needed.”

“One more. Why did you tell me you wanted me to be a friend just like Jake and Will? That was painful to hear.”

“But Sweetheart, I didn’t know you would want anything more than that. I had to take it slow. If I had implied that I wanted more than that, you might have gotten suspicious and that might have scared you off. I was wondering if you were already getting suspicious. We were having such a good time.”

“Go on.”

“And I couldn’t help the way I looked at you. I didn’t realize it was so obvious. Maybe at some deeper level I wanted you to see and feel the love. That desire had to be unconscious because I felt my only chance was to pursue a friendship in hopes that I could win you over so to speak.”

Pause. Reflectively, she said, “I’m not even sure I understand why I didn’t tell you sooner how much I loved you.”

“You owe me no explanation! Last week, you were the one who had the courage and guts to tell me how you felt. You were the one who took the risk, who opened up to share something so personal and intimate. I say to myself, ‘How dare you ever ask her that question.’”

“Thank you. It took all the courage I could muster.”

“Yes, I can and at the same time can’t imagine.”

Pause. Smiling, “With that out of the way, I told you about sex with Kent and I’ve been dying to ask you about Taylor. Tell me what went on between the two of you?”

I told her the whole story with the most important part being no emotional connection and most of the time while having sex, we didn't even kiss. It was all physical and she was a nice person, but there was nothing there.

"So, you all got together once a month for how long?"

"It was for about seven or eight times."

"Where did you meet?"

"We rotated here and at her apartment in Charleston."

"When you were here, did you ever go for walks on the beach?"

"No, she didn't like the beach and sun and getting sand on her feet and so on."

"When was the last time you saw her or had any contact with her?"

"It's been five or six months."

"I'm jealous. I wanted you all for myself."

"I'm jealous too. It drives me crazy to think about you and Kent being naked together and kissing and making love."

"I would not call it making love. I would call it having sex. Remember in therapy when I told you about my brief encounter with Rick Foster in Afghanistan where I almost had sex with him?"

"Yes. I remember it too well."

"All physical and no emotions. You remember that, right?"

"Yes."

"Same with Kent."

I asked, "What do you think about using our skill of letting things be?"

"Yes, let's do the best we can to do that!" Smiling, "One more thing, how did you all end it?"

"Remember I told you when you and I met the second time that she had started seeing someone else and that I was relieved that I didn't have to break it off?"

"Yes, now I remember."

"I didn't tell you everything about the breakup. The reason for my part was that the two years were coming to an end in a few months and all my attention was going to be on finding a way to let you know I loved you. Of course, I couldn't tell you that before. The good news is that we were both ready to end it and neither felt the other deserved nor wanted an explanation."

"Were you ever jealous that she started dating someone else?"

"Quite the opposite. I was relieved."

"Did you tell her anything about me?"

"No, we never talked about personal stuff, and I would never have told her about you."

"How come?"

“It would have contaminated the sanctity of what I felt for you.”

“I’m glad. I like the way you described that. I never told Kent about you either even though I had convinced myself that I had been over you for at least a year. And now of course I know I never got over you. I just stuffed those feelings somewhere deep inside me.”

We finished our tea and she sat on my lap with her arms around my neck. A few more light and sensuous kisses and then she said, “I’m having so much fun, but I’m also exhausted. Can I spend the night with you?”

“Sure, the only problem is the guest room bed doesn’t have any sheets on it.”

“That’s fine, I’ll just head on out and see you in a few days.”

“No! No! You can sleep in my bed, and I’ll sleep in the bed without sheets.”

A big smile, “I love you Howie.”

“And I love you my precious Tess.”

We hugged and held onto each other for a few minutes.

“I have an overnight bag in the car. Would you get it for me? It’s on the front seat. I’ll clean up these dishes.”

When I came back in, I helped her finish up.

I said, “Let me go pee and I’ll get my toothbrush and brush in the kitchen and the bathroom will be all yours.”

“Okay. Is it alright if I look in the fridge and open a few cabinets while you’re in the bathroom?”

“Please don’t ever ask those kinds of questions. This is your home away from home. I never want you to feel like a guest.”

Smiling, “Okay. And I want you to feel the same way at my house.”

“Got it.”

I always sleep in the nude, but I’ll put on a pair of boxers. She came in with a two-piece nightie. She crawled under the sheet. More sensuous kisses and snuggling.

I whispered, “I just can’t get enough. I want to kiss every part of your body.”

She was on top of me and whispered back in my ear, “I wanna make love to you in every way and position possible, but there is something so special for me about waiting. I love the idea about a courtship and taking our time. Remember you know me much better than I know you. Again, I want to ask you so many questions about your life and the more intimate and personal parts of you. I shared with you so much about me in therapy. Now it’s my turn to know all about you.”

She kissed me with such gentleness and passion at the same time and then rolled off my body, laid cuddled with her head in the crook of my neck and one leg drooped over my body and whispered in a sexy and sleepy way. “I love you Howard Kingston.”

“I love you too Contessa Angelina,”

She made a little groan and drifted into sleep. It took me a while to fall asleep. She had known several days ago that we would be together. I had only found out hours ago. I wanted to replay everything that happened and somewhere in that replay and PJ getting on the bed, I too drifted into sleep.

The First Day

I woke up with the sun's light shining brightly in the window over the bed. Where was she? And then I smelled the coffee. I got up, peed, and went to the kitchen. She wasn't there. Then I could see out the nook windows she was on the deck with a cup of coffee. I went to the door, "Good morning sunshine!"

A big smile, "Good morning my darling!"

I got on my knees in front of her and as I moved toward her, she spread her legs and I gave her a long and gentle kiss.

I whispered in her ear, "Could we go back to bed and get naked?"

"Why don't you get a cup of coffee, and we'll talk about it."

"Be right back. Do you want a refill?"

"No thanks."

PJ was on his cushion in the corner and GJ was probably in the guest bedroom pouting because a strange woman slept in her house. I got my coffee and looked around for something to fix for breakfast later and went outside.

I asked, "How'd you sleep?"

Smiling, "Wonderfully well. How about you?"

"The same. I woke up once and watched you sleeping. You looked so beautiful and peaceful. I synchronized our breathing for a while and then drifted back to sleep."

She said, "Come over here and sit by me."

"Before I do, let me call Si and Henry and let them know the news before we get cozy, and I won't be able to think about anything else."

Grinning, "April already knows of course but let me check in with her while you talk to Si and Henry. I'll call from the kitchen and while you're talking, I'll fix us something for breakfast."

"I just looked around for breakfast. Not sure there's much in there."

"I'll find something. Come on in when you're finished."

"Wait!"

"What?"

"I want another kiss."

"Sorry you've used up your ration before breakfast."

"Just one little kiss!"

"Ordinarily, that would be okay, but you need to brush your teeth!"

"But I've already brushed them just to make sure I didn't have bad breath."

“You need to go back and put more toothpaste on the brush!” She went inside.

I went to the bathroom and brushed again with more toothpaste and went in the kitchen and said, “Okay, I’m ready for my kiss.”

Laughing, “Come here big boy.”

After a delicious kiss, I asked, “Did you just pass gas? I heard something and now I smell something.”

“I’m sorry. This is so embarrassing. While we were kissing, I felt it coming on and I squeezed my butt cheeks together but it just kind of exploded.”

Laughing and yet puzzled, I said, “I was just kidding. I didn’t hear anything and don’t smell anything.”

She went back to the counter and continued cutting up some tomatoes. “I’m not surprised. I noticed during therapy that I had to repeat myself quite often, so I knew you had a hearing disability, and my family and friends tell me mine don’t stink.”

“You’re what don’t stink?”

“I’m not going to say it; it’s too intimate!”

Before I could respond, she was hugging me and laughing.

I said, “We’re going to have so much fun! And my breath wasn’t bad?”

“No, your breath was fine! Now go make your calls. I’ll check on April and come back in when you’re finished. I should have some breakfast ready.”

When I came back in, she said, “I scrambled some eggs, fried some tomatoes and toasted a bagel.”

“Sounds delicious.” We sat down in the nook.

She asked, “Do you say a blessing before you eat?”

“Yes, how about you?”

“Yes, mostly with the children. ‘God is great, God is good, Let us thank Him for our food....’”

“I eat alone a lot, but I like to say, ‘An attitude of gratitude’ and then in Italian, ‘La vita a bella’ meaning, ‘Life is beautiful!’”

She said, “I love that. I would like to say that before our meals and hold hands. Whatta you think?”

“I like that and what about looking into each other’s eyes as we say it?”

“Love it.”

We did it and there were tears again and she said, “Right now those words in some wonderful ways have added meaning.”

Looking into her eyes with all the love in me, “Yes they do my darlin’!”

We picked at our food experiencing a little silence as we were both looking out the window and then she reached out and put her hand in mine.

She said softly, "It's like the silence between us will always be a friend. In those moments the energy between us will always be enough."

"Yes, words will never be enough to explain to you how I feel about you. A wise mentor of mine once said, 'If you can define love, you don't know love.'"

Smiling, she said "Yes but let's keep doing the best we can with the words." We turned to each other, and I said, "Absolutely my love!"

We went outside and cuddled on the deck and took in the beauty all around us. We sat for a few minutes and then I asked, "What did April have to say?"

"She was so happy for me and for you too. She wants to meet you soon. What did Si and Henry say?"

"They were both thrilled for us and were not totally surprised. They thought we would eventually get together but didn't have a clue about the timing. They both thought it might take you more time to get over me, not telling you earlier how I felt. They both felt terrible about what you have been through."

"Didn't they feel bad for you?"

"Kind of, but Henry had warned me in the beginning I was setting myself up for a lot of pain. Si of course didn't know until our sessions were over. They have been supportive, encouraging and emphatic over the months and the years, but they knew my pain was self-induced. They didn't know the extent of your pain and suffering until I told them on Monday."

"I hope they don't blame you. When I started falling in love with you, I could have stopped coming to see you. I don't want you to feel any more responsibility than I feel. I had no idea you were falling in love with me. You taught me blaming is a waste of time and I don't want us to waste our time. The moments we have right now are too precious."

She scooted over and sat on my lap, and we put our arms around each other. Tears were running again, each aware of how close we had come to missing this chance of a lifetime.

She whimpered, "What if only one of us had romantic feelings for the other. I just can't imagine living without you. I don't even know how I've managed to do it for this long."

Through my tears finding it difficult to talk, I said, "When I fell in love with you and for the first time ever, this place often seemed empty. You stirred in me an awareness that without knowing it, I had always been searching for the love of my life, someone who without any effort on her part could fill my body, mind, and soul with everything my heart longed for. Love took on a whole new meaning. There was this intense longing and desperation to hold you and never let you go, to make love to you for hours, to merge our bodies into one body."

She looked into my eyes, her face still wet with tears, “I am the happiest I have ever been. You have my heart, and it is yours for as long as I live. I have longed for you day and night, dreaming that one day you would be in my arms loving me with the same energy and passion and with the same fullness of all that I am and ever will be. And here you are my love, my dream finally come true.”

Some silence and then I said, “We had a unique courtship. Have you thought about that?”

“No, but thinking about it, it sure was different. As unethical as it sounds, my therapy was a large part of our courtship. We fell in love and never knew it. We waited two years with almost no contact and then with my confession, it all exploded into the dream.”

“And before your confession, we were with each other in our fantasies and our imaginations all those months holding each other, kissing, and making love. It’s like when you burst through the door last night, there was already present this emotional intimate energy. There was no hesitation, just this incredible explosion, as you said, of the dream coming true.”

She asked, “With that in mind, can we go lay on the bed? I just want you to hold me for a while.”

She stood up and I carried her into the bedroom. With our clothes still on, she motioned me to lay on my back. She sat on top of me and moved in different directions as I lightly pinched her hard nipples through the tee shirt.

After a minute or so, I said, “Please stop Tess. You’re driving me crazy. The first time I cum, I wanna be inside you and I’m dangerously close right now.”

She took a little breath and said, “Me too. Are you still okay with us waiting?”

“Yes. I want so badly to make love to you, but the anticipation is so incredibly sensuous. And the moment-by-moment experience of just having you close is something I have dreamed of for so long, I want time just to savor it all. So what excites me now is the next moment loving you and being with you.”

Then she laid on top of me and we kissed until we both needed a break. She laid her head on my shoulder and whispered, “I’m living my dream my precious Howie.”

“Me too my sweetheart,” We lay there and soon, she slid off me and lay in the same position as last night. In no time, she was asleep, and I followed soon after.

When I woke up it was 11:13 and she was in the shower. I went into the kitchen and fried some bacon. Soon she came through the door with a towel wrapped around her upper body and another one wrapped around her head. “That

bacon smells wonderful! Where did you find it?” She put her arms around me and held me for a few moments.

“Found it in the freezer. How about a BLT?”

“Yes, that sounds wonderful! Would you like to jump in the shower while I throw on some running clothes and work on the sandwiches?”

“Sounds great.” We kissed again.

When I came back the sandwiches were ready, and she was sitting in the nook. “Where’s your Miracle Whip?”

“I don’t have any. That stuff is nasty!”

“Well big boy, you’re definitely not getting in my pants until there is a jar of Miracle Whip in your fridge.”

I protested, “But the stores are over a mile away.”

“I used your regular old mayo today, but I better see some in your fridge soon. And who says you’re going to get in my pants right away anyway?”

Sounding disappointed, “Got it.”

We sat in the nook, said our blessing, and ate our sandwiches with ‘shit eaten grins’ on our faces.

She asked, “What are you smiling at?”

“What are you smiling at?”

“I asked you first.”

“I’m so happy, I can hardly stand it.”

We took a few bites, and I reached over and took her hands and asked, “Can I say it again?”

“Say what?”

Do you have any idea how much I love you?”

She kept smiling. “Yes, I do now, finally.”

After a few more bites, “I’m a little nervous about asking you this question, but how long can you stay?”

Pause while she took another bite and chewed and chewed.

I said, “Without knowing it, you’re taking a page from Henry’s playbook. He does that same thing to me when I ask him a question I want answered right away.”

Innocently, “What do you mean?”

I told her and she said, “Why I wasn’t chewing and chewing to make you wait. I just took a big bite, and it required a lot of chewing.”

“Well, what’s your answer?”

Pause. “What was the question again?”

“Could I borrow \$15?”

Laughing, “Okay. Today is Saturday. Right?”

“I think so, but I’m not positive.”

“I have to pick April up at her Dad’s house on Monday around 8AM. But I still have to leave here in about an hour to run some errands.”

“What kind of errands?”

“I don’t have my list, but Saturday I do my errands.”

“Do you really have to go. I was hoping you could help me paint the guest bedroom.”

She asked smiling, “Do you ever think we’ll stop this bantering? No, don’t answer that. My therapist would tell me to say we don’t know the future so stop trying to figure it out.”

“He must have been brilliant!”

“Well, I wouldn’t say that.”

“Why not?”

“I saw him for a bunch of sessions and that’s the only thing he ever taught me worth remembering.”

“Alright enough bull shit, I have to go get started on the painting.”

We looked at each other and smiled. I said, “I’m thrilled we have until Monday morning.”

“Me too!” We continued eating our sandwiches and not taking our eyes off each other.

“Oh, I forgot to tell you that Henry and Jill have a monthly get together with friends. Henry reminded me yesterday at lunch that it was tonight. When I told him about what happened last night, I said we would take a rain check and be there next month. He said to ask you rather than making the decision on my own. I told him I would. What do you think?”

“My knee jerk response is I would rather wait till later to meet Jill and Henry, but what about this idea? We could go for drinks when it starts and stay for maybe an hour or so and then leave. It also gives us more time to live through the anticipation of making love for hours.”

“I’m in.”

She interrupted, “No you’re not. You’re out. Remember, we decided to wait.”

“Shit, another one for you. Okay, let me call Henry back.”

“I’ll be on the deck.”

“Henry said that was perfect. He said come around 7:30 and stay as long as we want and feel free to stay and eat.”

We cuddled and sat in silence for a while.

Then I asked, “Did Arthur mind it that you were dating Kent?”

“No, he had moved on. He and the woman he had an affair with while I was in Afghanistan have gotten together. They seem very happy and I’m very glad it worked out. We are cordial and are a good team in raising our children.”

“I’m always so impressed when a couple can work that out. So often, there are a lot of bad feelings, and the children suffer in the long run.”

“How did you and Florence do with the parenting after your divorce?”

“I think we have done fine. Lance and Si were a few years older than Keller and April so that helped some.”

“It will take Keller some time to warm up to you. He didn’t like it I was dating Kent.”

“I understand. What does he like to do? “

“He loves football and basketball.”

“Those are two of my favorite sports too. Does he play?”

“This fall, he will be a sophomore. The football coach told him last year if he was serious about playing and worked out over the summer that he would get some playing time this year.”

“What position does he play?”

“Defensive back.”

“He must be fast.”

“He is.”

“How about basketball?”

“He played on the freshman team as a guard and he is really good on defense, but his shooting needs some serious work.”

“Well, when he’s ready, this will give us something to talk about.”

“Did you play?”

“I was quarterback my senior year in high school. We didn’t have a good season. Our record was won one, lost seven and tied one.”

“How about basketball?”

Smiling, “I thought I was good enough, but the coach didn’t agree. I was never invited to try out. I remember you played soccer in college, and you were really good.”

“I was a hard worker and got to play on varsity my freshman year. We were ACC champions my senior year. I loved the competition and mixing it up on the field. Some people thought I was too aggressive and some even said I was a ‘dirty player’.”

“Were you?”

Smiling, “I did get called for a record number of fouls my senior year and coach several times pulled me out of the game and chewed my ass. He loved my aggressiveness but kept telling me to ‘play smart’.”

“Did you?”

Smiling, “Sometimes.” Pause. We haven’t talked about Lance since our first meeting. Is he still in Denver working for his mom?”

“Yes, to still in Denver, but now Florence is working part time and Lance has moved up the ladder. I think I told you his grandfather founded the company. He died recently and his wishes were that Lance take over the company. He selected one of the senior partners to be his mentor until this person decides that Lance is ready to be the CEO.

“What about Florence?”

“From what Lance said, she has found someone and wants to spend more time with him and less time working.”

“How do you feel about that?”

“Just as you are happy for Arthur, I am happy for Florence.”

“How are things with you and Lance?”

““Better. I’m not sure what happened. Other than a few holidays and some sporadic calls, we didn’t have much contact. I think he blamed me for the divorce. A few days ago, he called and said something like, ‘Pops, (he calls me that because that’s what I call my dad) I want us to be closer. You know how close I was to grandpa and since he died, I realized I wanted that same kind of relationship with you. Can we talk at least once a week on the phone, and I’m going to try and get back home more often to see you Si, Roger and the kids and Meemaw and Pawpaw.”

“Oh Howard, I’m so happy for you. I know how much you’ve missed him and how proud you are of him.”

“Yes, on both counts. Si and Lance are very close. They talk a lot. Si told me the middle of last week that she told Lance a very short version of the story that I had fallen in love and although there had been some challenges, it looked like we were going to work it out.”

“Did Lance mention what Si had told him?”

“Yes, he said something like, ‘Pops, Si told me what you’ve been going through and I’m sorry for the challenges, but so glad it looks like you all are going to work it out. You tell Tess that I’m looking forward to meeting her the next time I’m in town and I wish you all the best.”

She reached over and touched my face, “Howie, honey, why are you tearing up.”

“He then said, ‘Pops, I love you.’ And I could barely get out the words, ‘I love you too son.”

She held me and kissed away my tears and then motioned for me to lay my head in her lap. She asked, “Do you want to talk about it?”

“Yes, in a minute. Is that okay?”

“Sure.” With her fingers, she lightly stroked my face with little circles of touch.

“I’ve talked to Si about it over the years. It was an ache in my heart/chest. I

reached out to him in so many ways but the pain of the divorce had hardened his heart. When he was in town, he was pleasant, but he never allowed me to get close.”

“I know Si has spent countless hours trying to get through to him that the divorce was mutual and that their mom had never blamed me. Maybe all that did help. Lance as I mentioned said it was the death of his grandfather. At this point, of course I don’t care what it was.”

“I am so happy for you. Hearing all of that is what I was saying earlier. You know so much about me and I know very little about you. Knowing that part of your story makes me feel even closer to you if that’s possible.”

Smiling, “I’m glad. It was like I was making emotional love to you as I was telling the story. You were listening and understanding and loving me all at the same time.”

“I long to hear more about your life.” She bent down and kissed me and smiled, “How about a run?”

“Sure. How far do you wanna go?”

“How about to the northern tip and walk back to the house?”

“Sounds good.”

We cleaned up the kitchen, both made a ‘pit stop’ and we were off. About halfway, I asked her if I could drop back a few yards.

“What for?”

No answer.

Smiling, “Oh you just wanna look at my ass.”

No, no, you just have a smooth rhythm and I wanted to study your body movements.”

“Right!”

I pulled up beside her. “I’ve got it. There’s a special way you swing your arms. And I might add you have an exquisite ass.”

At the end of the island, we turned around and started our walk back arm in arm along the edge of the water. After a short pause, she asked, “So when did you tell Henry about me?”

“As soon as I realized I was starting to have feelings for you. He immediately told me I was asking for trouble and that I should refer you right away.”

“I agreed with him but told him something like what I told you.”

“Which part?”

“That I felt like you were making good progress and that I could keep my feelings under control.”

“He said something like I wasn’t a good actor and good luck with that.”

“Again, I knew it was wrong and unethical, but I just couldn’t bring myself to refer you. Somewhere in there he asked me what you were like. I told him that was confidential and all I could say was that you were a veteran.”

“Wasn’t that also confidential information?”

“Yes.”

“So, why did you tell him?”

“I don’t have an excuse, but I desperately needed someone to talk to and Henry was the only choice.”

Smiling, “Have you had any ethics training lately?”

“Last year I had a three-hour ethics course.”

“What was it about?”

“I don’t remember.”

Smiling, “Sounds like you may have slept through the course.”

“I was probably daydreaming about you. I knew I shouldn’t have told him. No way to get around it being a breach of confidentiality. It’s embarrassing. More selfishness and irresponsibility on my part. You could turn me into the board of licensure, and they would suspend my license.”

“I’ll think about it. So, it sounds like he figured out who I was since he told you about my divorce and my move to the beach. How did he get that information?”

“Do you mind if I jog on back to the house?”

Smiling, “Only if I can ride piggyback.”

“Okay, Henry told me he had a woman who worked in the office of his construction company, and she mentioned she knew of a woman who was a veteran who had served in Afghanistan. He was curious since in our small town, there were not a lot of women in the Army. So, he guessed it was you. Occasionally they would have casual conversations about you. Apparently, this woman knew one of your friends.”

“So, you had a spy keeping an eye on me.”

“I don’t think I ever directly asked Henry to spy on you, but I didn’t discourage it either. I was always eager to hear any information he found out.”

“So, you lied when you told me that Henry in a casual conversation gave you the info about my divorce and moving because he knew we were both veterans.”

“Yeah, I lied,”

She said, “Well, it’s time for me to tell something.” Pause.

“Don’t keep me waiting too long. My heart is picking up speed thinking you may tell me something I don’t wanna hear.”

“Remember that Tammy, my therapist friend was the one who referred me to you?”

“Yes.”

“As soon as I knew I was in love with you, I told Tammy. She told me to change therapists. I told her I couldn’t do it. She said you’re setting yourself up for a lot of pain and if Howard knew, he would want you to stop seeing him. He is very ethical.”

Smiling, “At the time of course, I believed her. We, like you and Henry, had lunch every week and she finally gave up getting me to change to someone else. Every time we met, I asked her if she had seen you or talked to you. She had told me that most of the therapists in the area meet once a month to do something she called a ‘case conference’.”

“So, you like me had someone we were bugging for any information we could find out about the other.”

“Yes. Unfortunately, I didn’t get much. She said you all had never been more than colleagues. Reluctantly, she agreed to let me know any little bits of information that she might overhear other than confidential information. She said her impression of you was that in conversations with others, you were more of a listener than a talker. She did tell me that over the last year or so that you had been even quieter than usual at the meetings and often seemed distracted. That’s about it.”

I asked, “Anything else you wanna tell me?”

“Well yes, I admit that I would jog up toward your house at least once a week on days you were working making sure I didn’t run into you. I never got very close. I would have been so embarrassed. After that first year, as I said earlier, I had convinced myself I didn’t care anymore so I stayed away. I think staying away was a protective mechanism of sorts. ‘Out of sight; out of mind’.”

“Once you moved to the beach, I would walk down toward your house, but like you, I didn’t want to get too close. Several times, it was dark so I would take a closer look.”

“I feel better telling you about Tammy and my trips up toward your house. Are there other times you lied to me?”

“Yeah. I lied about my conversations with Si.”

Smiling, “Okay, let’s have it.”

“I told Si I was in love with you a few weeks after our last session. Up until then, Henry was the only one who knew what was going on during our sessions.”

“Why didn’t you tell Si during those last sessions?”

“I was too embarrassed, and she would have never agreed that I could keep seeing you. Did I tell you that Si is also a psychotherapist?”

“I don’t think so.”

“If I kept seeing you, Si would have been obligated to report me to the board of licensure. I could never put her in that situation. And, of course, I had convinced

myself that I could continue to help you and you would never know how I felt and therefore no harm to you.”

“Why did you tell her after our sessions were over?”

When I was still seeing you, I was overall doing pretty well. I had my routine, and I had our next session to look forward to. It was only when I knew I had to let you go that I started struggling.”

“In what way?”

Smiling, “I think you know the answer to that one. Would you like to take a stab at the answer?”

She grabbed me around the waist as we kept walking, “Sure! Life was going to be unbearable and miserable for you when you didn’t have our sessions to look forward to.”

“Bingo. And it was so hard for me to suggest during a later session that since you were doing so well, perhaps we needed to spread out the sessions to every other week.”

“I remember that moment and how hard it was for me. I thought it was proof that my hope you had any feelings for me were just my fantasy.”

Pause. We continued arm in arm. She asked, “Why did you feel you had to let me go?”

“I had already been so irresponsible and selfish. I think I felt like I had to hold on to some small measure of self-respect just to live with myself.”

She said, “I wonder what would have happened if I had told you somewhere around that tenth session that I had fallen in love with you. What would you have done?”

“I hope I would have been strong enough to tell you I was very flattered that someone so young and beautiful had fallen in love with me and that in another world and setting, I could easily see myself falling in love with you. I hope I would have continued by telling you that if I were to fall in love with you, it would complicate your life and mine in ways that are unimaginable.”

“But what if I said I didn’t care and that all I wanted was to be with you?”

“My love, if you had said that it would have been over. I know I would have teared up and said, ‘A moment ago, I lied. I also love you more than I believed I could love another person.’ I would have taken you in my arms and held you and hopefully whispered in your ear something like, ‘Can we talk about this before I kiss you?’ I hope you would have said ‘yes’.”

“I’m not sure I would have but go on.”

“I would have explained about the no social contact with a client until two years after the last session. Failure to follow that rule would mean losing my license. It would also mean I was contributing to the break-up of a marriage where two children were involved.”

She said, "You can stop there. I see how complicated it would have been. Depending on how messy it got, it could have also affected my military career."

We walked on for a while. She said, "As painful as it has been, I'm so glad it all happened the way it has."

We stopped and put our arms around each other. I whispered in her ear, "I have never been in so much pain in my life, but every second of it was worth it as we're now free to love each other with no complications."

When we let go and started walking again, we were about twenty feet away from my grandmother. She walked the beach sometimes when feeling up to it and we had been so involved in ourselves that we didn't see her coming. She was moving very slowly. "That's my grandmother."

Smiling, "Okay."

When we got a little closer, "Hey Bea."

She waved a little and when we stopped, I gave her a hug and she smiled and said, "Howard Kingston, your granddaddy would have been furious with you for such PDA on the preserve beach. Now who is this young lady?"

"Bessie Parker, this is the love of my life, Contessa Angelina. She allows me to call her Tess and claims she is not a countess."

Bea gave a small bow, big smile and said, "Your Grace, it's an honor to meet you."

Embarrassed and smiling, "Mrs. Parker it's an honor to meet you too."

She said, "Honey, call me Bea." She looked at us, "I don't believe I've ever met two people who look more in love than you two, except of course, for me and my Roland who passed some years ago, God rest his soul."

I responded, "I don't doubt it for a second Bea. You and Pop were the best."

She teared up a little and said, "Well, I'll let you two young people head on. I'm gonna try to make it a little further. Howie, I left my car at the house. When I get back, I'll head on."

I said, "Bea, we would love to have you stop by for a drink before you leave."

"Thanks, that's kind of you, but Doug told me no more drinking and driving. I had a little mishap not long ago. And I'm pretty tired, but thanks for the invitation." She smiled and looked at Tess and said, "Your Grace, you take good care of Howie." She winked, "He's a good man."

"Thank you Bea, he sure is. I'll do my best."

"Bye bye you two love birds." And she continued her walk.

"What a charming lady. And she calls you Howie too."

"Yeah. Her father is the one who bought this land, got it designated as a Nature Preserve and built the beach house."

"Who is Doug?"

“He’s my uncle, Bea’s youngest. She lives with Doug and his wife Katherine.”

“She meant ‘public display of affection’ when she said, PDA, right?”

“Yes.”

“I heard that somewhere in the Army.”

“Me too.” We were at the house. “So, what do you want to do now?”

“I want to hear about you telling Si. First, I have to pee.”

“Me too. You go first. Do you want to sit out here on the deck or sit in the house?”

“It’s getting warmer, but there is still a nice breeze. And the lattice and vines really help to block the sun. Let’s sit out here in the shade.”

“Would you like something to drink?”

“Yes, I’ll take a bottle of water. Thanks.”

I sat on the end of the lounge, and she laid on her back with her head in my lap.

“Okay, so tell me about you telling Si after our sessions were over.”

“Si and I have spent so much time together that she picks up on any changes in my feeling level and behavior. So, after our sessions were over, again, I was really struggling.”

Smiling, “Si kept bugging me about what was wrong. Again, she can read me like a book and for those few weeks, she kept asking me why I couldn’t talk to her about what was bothering me. Finally, I knew it was time and I had to face her with the truth.”

I told her the whole story of my conversation with Si.

“I think it is so neat that the first thing she did was take you in her arms and start crying.”

“Yes, and that’s exactly what April did with you after pouring your heart out to me. We are lucky parents. So, Si’s first thought was that I was going to get my heart broken and that the chances of you being in love with me were slim to none. And then the two years I would have to wait. She thought there was no hope of it working out.”

Pause. She said, “This must be hard to talk about.”

“Yes, it is. I can still see the look on her face following her feeling sorry for me. She couldn’t believe I had broken one of the cardinal rules of our profession. She had always had me on a pedestal which made her disappointment more intense.”

“So, what happened next?”

“After a day to think about it, she said something like ‘Daddy I should have never put you on a pedestal and I know you’re human so give me some time and I’ll be fine.’”

“Soon after that, she wanted to know all about you and how I fell in love with you. And she said she hoped and prayed that she would someday be able to meet you. And then she said, ‘All I want for you Daddy is for you to be happy and I hope somehow it will work out for you’. Si added, ‘And you will follow the rule of no contact for two years. Right?’”

“I told her yes that I would follow that rule.”

“She still calls you ‘Daddy’. I think that’s nice.”

“I love it. So anyway, she knows you were a client, but I told her nothing about you that would give her a clue about your identity like I did with Henry. But I told her everything about your personality and what a wonderful person you are and how I was madly in love with you.”

Tess reached up and stroked my cheek, “All that time, both of us were in so much pain. It makes me wanna hold on to you forever with an occasional slap on your face for not telling me how you felt.”

“Hold me forever and the slap would actually make me feel better.”

Giggling, “I wouldn’t slap you too hard.”

“Oh, there’s Bea. I’ll help her in her car. Be right back.”

“Do you want me to come?”

“No that’s fine. I’ll be right back.”

She waved at Bea, and she waved back.

When I sat back down, I said, “Bea really likes you.”

“I’m glad. She seems so gentle and sweet.”

“I think so too.”

She sat on my lap and buried her face in the crook of my neck and put her arms around me. I held on to her with one hand and stroked her hair with the other and sat there knowing that nothing could ever separate us again and take away that which we had longed for and dreamed of for all those many months. Then a few gentle kisses and she laid her head back down in my lap.

She asked, “Can I shift the subject back to the rule about referral?”

“Sure.”

After a few minutes, she said, “I’m thinking about how I would have responded if you had followed Henry’s advice and told me you were going to refer me. What would you have given as the reason for referring me?”

Smiling, “The only thing I can think of is that every time you come into my office, my dick gets hard and that’s against the rules for a therapist.”

“Be serious Dick, I mean Howie.”

“The referring issue just piles on the inappropriateness and selfishness of my behavior. I was doing good work with you, and I was the only therapist in the area using hypnosis, biofeedback and meditation. And you had already tried another

therapist and it didn't work. So, you were getting better, but the ethical guidelines stated that you should be immediately referred regardless of the reason."

"If I had it to do it over again, I would do the same thing again and not refer you until I thought you were ready. I was committed to not doing anything to give away my feelings. There would be no harm because of that commitment."

I continued, "I took a risk that I could pull it off and you said I was able to do it, but I don't feel good about it because I should have never allowed it in the first place."

"You asked about the reasons I would have given you if I decided to refer you. I mentioned earlier that I could have said it had to do with my health, but that would have been unrealistic since I would have had to terminate all my clients. I can't think of any other reasons I could have given you and maybe unconsciously, that stems from not even wanting to consider there could be other reasons. And I'm sure there are other plausible reasons."

She said, "I'm ready to leave this subject if you are."

"You can I'm sure imagine how ready I am to leave it forever."

She reached up and gently ran her fingers over my lips and softly said, "Yes I can."

After some comfortable silence, she said, "I was thinking while you were getting a shower that you told me you didn't know how I felt about you after our sessions were over. When you saw me wiping away tears as I was walking to my car after our last session, didn't that give you a clue that I cared deeply about you?"

"I wanted so badly to believe that, but I was pretty sure it wasn't true."

"Why not?"

"I've had a number of women and men tear up when we're finishing our last session."

"Really?"

"Many people in therapy have no one to share their inner most thoughts who will listen without judgment and accept them for who they are. Unfortunately, that is rare in most relationships and sometimes even in therapy. As therapists, if we leave our egos at the office door, we get to offer that gift of unconditional acceptance. It's one of the most satisfying and important benefits of our experience. So, when people finish their time with us, it can be emotional."

"Do you tear up too?"

"No, I've never done that until you came along. And of course, you didn't know because I waited until you left. I've also never gone to the waiting room window and watched someone leave."

She sat up and looked at me. Thoughtfully, "Maybe I didn't fall in love with you after all. Maybe I just loved the unconditional acceptance. I need to go home

and think about that for a few days. I could be making a huge mistake here.”
Standing up, she said, “I’ll be back in touch. Have a nice day.”

“Wait! I have some fresh bagels. Would you like one before you leave?”

“Do you have any cream cheese with chives?”

“No, but the plain taste really good without the cream cheese and chives.”

“That’s fine, I’ll just run along. As I said I’ll be back in touch in a few days.”

“Wait! What about these last twenty-four hours?”

“What about them?”

“Well, you seemed so sure you loved me.”

“I know. I thought I did. I’m so sorry Kent.”

“Wait a minute! I’m not Kent!”

“Got it, so what’s your name again?”

“Does ‘Dick’ ring a bell?”

“No but you’re kind of cute. What’s your name again?”

“I told you, it’s ‘Dick’.”

“You mean like in ‘private dick’?”

“Well, my dick is private, but that’s another matter.”

“So, you are Dick and you have a dick that’s private.”

“Bingo.”

She grabbed my hand and pulled me up and said, “let’s go play in the water! I bet I can beat you to the edge!”

We both took off and she was definitely faster than me and beat me easily as she started high stepping toward the waves and dove into one. I followed close behind. We were splashing each other, and I dove under and came up right in front of her. She put her arms around my neck and a wave sent us tumbling. When I came up for air, she was already up and running toward the shore. I followed her as she headed for the house. She was about ten meters ahead of me and when I got inside, she had disappeared. I thought she probably went for the bathroom. The door was closed and locked.

“Tess, let me in! I have to poop really bad.”

“Get your entrenching tool and go dig a hole out back.”

“I don’t know where my entrenching tool is and I’ve got really bad gas. Please let me in!”

“I’m naked and you will stink up the bathroom.”

“I promise you, just like your farts don’t stink, my shit doesn’t stink!”

She opened the door, “Only naked people allowed.”

I ripped off my tee shirt and shorts and she pulled me in and closed the door.

We got in the shower and using our hands, we slowly soaped up each other’s body. I went first and when I moved my hand down below her navel, she slightly

bent her legs inviting me to move my hand between her legs saying softly, “Not too much soap down there.”

She washed me as I said, “Go easy on himself. He’s very sensitive and ready to explode.” We put our heads under the water while we kissed and pressed our bodies together.

She said, “I’m not sure how much longer I can last. I want you inside me so much I can hardly stand it.”

“Waiting with the incredible expectation and anticipation seemed like a great idea at the time, but I’m not sure how much longer I can wait either.”

We got out of the shower and dried each other.

She pulled me close and put her arms around my neck and said, “As much as I want you right now, what about waiting a little longer and having a romantic evening together before we make love?”

“Sorry I can’t wait any longer.”

“Come on Howie. You can do it.”

“Did I hear the word “cum” and the phrase “do it”?”

Laughing, “I guess you did.”

“Hey, my angel, can I call Henry and tell him we’ll take that rain check after all?”

“I was hoping you would. I can’t stand the thought of sharing you with anyone else right now. Let’s get our clothes on and plan our evening.”

“Do we have too?”

“I thought you nodded agreement to plan our evening.”

“I did but not to getting our clothes on.”

She slapped me on the ass and said, “Put your clothes on and go call Henry!”

I saluted her and said, “Yes Ma’am!” I snapped to attention and asked her if there were any more orders.

“No Captain, I’ll let you know. Now move out!”

“Yes Major, may I kiss your breasts before I go?”

“No! But you can have a couple of licks.”

“Where?”

“Idiot, if you don’t know where, get your clothes on and make that call!”

I saluted, hurriedly put on my clothes and left. Henry was expecting the call. He never believed for a moment we would be there tonight.

I asked, “What were we thinking?”

“Good question. Whatta you say we start the evening with a glass of wine out on the deck?”

“I love it.”

“What kind of wine do you have?”

“ I only have a Cabernet Savignon.”

“That’s fine, but I love Pionot Grizo. Soon, I better see some of that wine with some Miracle Whip in your fridge.”

“Got it sexy!”

“Now run along while I finish getting dressed.”

“You got it!”

“What have I got?”

As I walked away, I yelled out, “Everything I’ll ever need!”

Unfolding Intimacy

I put on some music, got some brie from the fridge, warmed it up in the microwave, put out some crackers, poured the wine and took it out to the deck. There was a gentle breeze, and the sun was slowly making its' decent toward the trees in the back of the house.

She came out in a yellow pair of lounging shorts and a white blouse looking radiant with a wonderful glow about her.

She said, "Howie you look so handsome and so lovable."

"Radiant and glowing were my thoughts about you."

We kissed with a sensual softness. There was no urgency, no hurry. Only a tenderness and a longing to merge every part of ourselves into the other. And woven into the experience for me was that continuing subtle need to hold her as if someone or something might have the power to separate us and take her away.

I said, "As soon as I fell in love with you, I would close my eyes and imagine this very experience; the two of us sitting out here drinking wine. Opening my eyes would leave me with that loneliness and despair knowing that the chances of it ever happening were slim to none. Tears were a common experience."

She took a sip of wine and said, "Falling in love with you was like a fantasy I never dreamed would come true. And then to finally believe that being together would probably never happen. Speaking of tears, many nights I cried myself to sleep."

She scooted closer to me, and I put my arm around her and we sat in silence for a while looking out at the ocean and the waves rolling in, sipping our wine, basking in the energy of approaching twilight and listening to an album of classical music.

"Are we dreaming?"

Right after that question, the outside speakers began softly serenading us with Puccini's 'O Mio Babbino'....

She looked up with tears in her eyes only to greet my own tears and she said, "What incredible heartache as she had to say goodbye to her baby. I hope and pray we will never have to do that to our children before we 'pass'."

"Me too my love!

We sat in silence for a time and then I asked, "When you went to your sanctuary and talked to Angel, did you ask her about me?"

“Many times, over those two years, I sat at her feet. Sometimes, I would just take in the beauty all around me and other times I would talk to her about my pain and my longing for you. As you might expect, she said very little; mostly just listened.” Pause. “And in the quietness with Her, I found some semblance of peace and acceptance. I wanted to ask Her questions but realized in the experience of that peace and acceptance, I already had Her answer.”

I said, “I lied to myself thinking it was okay if you didn’t love me. I just wanted you to know how much I loved you. When we met on the beach for the first time, I wanted to tell you everything and take the risk you didn’t feel that way about me. Of course, it didn’t happen.”

She asked, “Did you find help in your sanctuary over those two years?”

“As we talked about in therapy, God had always for me been that Light within at Center to guide my footsteps and help me find my way. It was in my sanctuary during meditation that I worked on my skills to practice ‘mindfulness’ the best I could to live without you in my life.”

I continued, “When you left after our last session, there was an emptiness that I had never felt before. It was like I had not only lost my connection to this place and my sanctuary but had also lost my connection to God. It was an existential aloneness. If not for my family, Henry and a few friends, the despair would have seemed unbearable.”

Pause. Smiling, I continued, “Interesting that even though I had been training for years to be Centered in my life and you had just learned about this approach, I think you did better than I did with finding that peace and acceptance at your Center.”

She responded, “I wouldn’t go that far, but it was a great help!” Smiling, “So I know you didn’t stay in an ‘existential aloneness’ for the two years.”

“No, I didn’t. Eventually with lots of training and practice at my sanctuary and here at the beach and time with family and friends, I found what I needed to create a measure of contentment and happiness. However, always in the background was an anticipation for the time when I would have the chance to see you again.”

Smiling, “After all those hours you spent teaching me to be present in the moment?”

“Yes, it’s embarrassing. Part of me was always waiting for those two years to be over. And remember how I took you through endless training to integrate the philosophy that ultimate peace, contentment, and joy can only be found inside your heart at Center? That no one or nothing else can give you what you ultimately long for?”

“Yes, I remember it well! Do you still believe that?”

“Yes, I do, but I have really struggled with it as I wondered at times if I could live without you. Deep inside, I knew I could, but I never gave up hope there might be a chance that you loved me or could come to love me over time. That’s what kept me going.”

We both took another sip of wine and snuggled a little closer as we looked out at the water and listened to the music. The snow caps on the water were glistening in the sun.

I asked, “What are you thinking?”

“Many things.” Pause. She continued, “While I was in counseling with you, I always thought you were so Centered and that you must have the perfect life. You always said something like, ‘I teach those things I most need to learn and remember myself.’ But you always seemed to have it together. In the last few days, I have discovered that I was right. You were and are a ‘fucked up therapist!’” She laughed!

I laughed too. “I read recently where a therapist said that we become psychotherapists because we are ‘fucked up’ and hope we can save ourselves. Yes, you were right on target.”

“Wow! A wise person!”

“In spite of that, I was so glad you gave me a chance. Even though you were stubborn, resistant, and cocky, I was pretty sure I could help you with your PTS.”

She picked up a cushion and hit me over the head with it and made me spill my wine.

“You little shit!” I reached over and pulled her to me with one hand and with the other reached the wine bottle and poured some down her blouse. While it was tipped over, she grabbed the top of the bottle and pushed it over, so the wine ran down my tee shirt. Then she gave me a big shove and took off running toward the water. I took after her at my fastest speed and she outran me again.

She let me catch up and the water was already up to her waist. We exchanged a lot of splashing, and I finally closed my eyes and lurched for her. As my head came down in front of her, she pushed my head under the water. I exploded back up and lurched again. As soon as I came out of the water, she threw her arms around my neck and we both went under and while under she reached down and squeezed my balls. That brought me right back out of the water with Tess still hanging on with one arm and she started laughing hysterically.

“That hurt!” I screamed. More hysterical laughter. I let her go and went back under and grabbed the waist band of her shorts and jerked them down. She was kicking me, but I managed to get them off and then I came up for air. My turn to laugh and now we were both laughing and simultaneously put our arms around each other.

She whispered in my ear, "That feels pretty good. Why don't you take your shorts off?"

"Excellent idea."

We rubbed up against each other and I thought I was going to cum right there in the ocean.

After a few minutes, she asked, "Aren't you afraid some kind of fish or shark will come along and bite off your dick?"

"It's not that big."

"How disappointing."

"Sorry, you should have asked me when you first started to have feelings for me."

"So somewhere around the sixth or seventh session, between meditations, I should have asked, 'Could you tell me the size of your penis?'"

"I would have said, 'I get asked that all the time and I'm frankly getting pissed off about why women ask me that. And be honest, please! Do I look like I have a small dick?'"

Laughing, "Well kind of. What size shoe do you wear?"

"Eleven."

"That may be it. I've heard the larger the feet, the smaller the dick. At least you don't wear a twelve or thirteen."

I said, "I love rubbing up against you."

"Me too, Are you ready to get out?"

"No, I'm ready to get in."

Smirking, "Maybe later. I'll take my shorts,"

"Oh shit. I forgot to hold on too 'em'."

"Where are your shorts?"

"They're wrapped around my left foot."

"That's fine, I'll just take yours. Mine will probably wash up on shore tomorrow. If not, you can just buy me a new pair."

"Gladly. It was worth whatever it cost. Okay. Hold on."

I reached down, retrieved my shorts, and handed them to her.

She smiled, "What about you?"

"What about me?"

"How are you going to get to the house?"

"Unless you plan to carry me, I'm walking with you."

"What about that 'thing' hanging down."

Laughing, "Well for starters, right now it's not hanging down, it's pointing up."

"Do you mind if I go on and you can come after I get in the house."

“What if I walk a few feet behind you? You can pretend you’re not with me.”

Laughing, “I would love to have a video of that. You are following a few feet behind me with your pecker at attention and I’m pretending I don’t know you’re there.”

More laughter. Finally, after calming down, she said, “Okay hotshot, I’m getting hungry. Let’s go. The place looks deserted. You’ll be fine with no pants. Is you dick at parade rest yet?”

“Not quite. If sticking straight out is ninety degrees and pointing to the ground is one hundred eighty degrees, I’m about at one hundred thirty-five degrees.”

“That’ll work, Let’s go.”

As we walked up, she looked at ‘it’ several times. “Not bad.” she said.

I smiled, “Thanks!”

I continued, “Would you like to shower first and I’ll look around for something to eat. I think I have some left-over lasagna from last month in the pantry.”

Smiling, “No need to warm it up. Room temperature is fine.”

I did some chores and checked the kitchen and went out to light the grill. When I came in, there she was and looked stunning in a long white almost see through dress.

“Wow!”

“Go get your shower! I’m starving.”

“Got it. I found a piece of salmon I got at The Market a couple of days ago and the grill is heating up. I usually rub on some olive oil, salt and pepper.”

“Have you got any lemon and dill?”

“No lemon, but I have dill. There may be some lemon juice in the fridge. Will you cut up a salad? There’s some organic Romain lettuce and other fixin’s in the fridge and the oven is preheating for some garlic bread. I won’t be long.”

“Sounds good love.”

After my shower, I put on the nicest leisure shorts I had with a colorful tee shirt.”

“You look great Howie.”

We put our arms around each other with some soft and gentle kisses. She whispered in my ear, “Food.”

“Got it.”

She said, “Put the salmon on the grill and I’ll put the bread in.”

When I came inside, “How do you like your salmon?”

“Slowly cooked to medium.”

“Wow. Me too. We were meant to be together!”

“Not so fast big boy. I’ll have to see how the salmon turns out. Tell me about your bread. It smells delicious.”

“All I do is spread butter and grated Parmigiano Reggiano cheese on slices of a Tuscan loaf of Italian bread and bake for about ten minutes at 385 degrees. Come outside. You can help me with the salmon. I’ll set the timer on my phone to check on the bread.”

“Howie, it is so beautiful out here. I knew that at some level, but during our therapy, I was so focused on you and on my own pain, I couldn’t experience the extent of the beauty.”

“I even take it for granted at times. Would you like more wine?”

Resigned, “Even though I would prefer Pinot Grigio, I’ll take what you have.”

“It’s on my list for tomorrow along with the Miracle Whip.”

“Would you like me to baste the salmon?”

“Yes.” The watch timer went off. “I’ll get the bread, salad and wine. All I have is Hidden Valley Light Ranch Dressing, Is that okay?”

“Yes, I like it.”

“I’ll light the candles in the jars.”

I had a little table on one side of the deck and we sat across from each other.

“This deck really is charming and cozy.”

“Last year, Henry helped me put the lattice over the deck and these vines intertwined seemed a good way to diffuse a little more of the sunlight.”

“All these plants and the music with your outside speakers give it such a nice ambiance. What’s the album playing?”

“It’s Tom Barabas, Classical Healing.”

“I love it! What a wonderful theme for us.” She reached across the table and touched my cheek and with a dreamy look on her face, “That’s what we’re doing; healing from all the pain over these last two years.”

I covered her fingers with my own. “Yes, my Tess, that’s what we’re doing.”

“Okay,” she said, “Let’s eat.” She raised her glass to mine, “Cheers!”

While we were talking, we took turns feeding each other.

“You have said how much you like the house and the deck. I would love any ideas you have; everything now seems so unfinished; like the house and deck have been waiting on you all this time to come and put your personality into it and onto it.”

“I can’t think of a thing to change or add.”

“Well, if you ever do, you know you don’t have to ask.”

At one point near the end of our meal, Tess forked a huge amount of lettuce and said, "Open wide." I opened as wide as I could but as she was putting it in my mouth, some dressing dripped around my mouth and onto my chin. She reached over with her finger and wiped it off and put it into her mouth and sucked on her finger giving me this sexy look, "Mmmmmm good." When she reached over again and got more dressing off my chin, I took her hand and put that finger in my mouth, massaged it with my tongue. "Mmmmmm very good." We smiled.

I said, "It's still incredible to me how easy it is for us to be together, to tease, to banter, to kiss, to be both emotionally and physically intimate."

She responded, "I know. We haven't even been together for twenty-four hours and it feels like we have been together for years."

"Yes, and in one way for me, we have been together for two and a half years as 'you were always on my mind' as Willie Nelson sings. And you reminded me, I had the advantage of getting to know a lot more about you and so I think it was easier for me to fantasize about you and your life and what you were doing. I knew more details."

She said, "And I think all the dreaming was almost like a real courtship. In my fantasy, I knew you loved me, and I could imagine our dialogue, our having fun together, eating together and making love. And it did make it harder for me because I knew almost nothing about your personal life."

She went on. "But I had something much more important. I experienced with you an energy that was mysterious and irresistible. You were compassionate, empathetic, a wonderful listener, non-judgmental, an encourager, great sense of humor, easy on the eyes etc., but those were not the reasons I fell in love with you. I don't think I will ever be able to describe what that energy was like."

"Didn't we talk about the idea that if you can describe love, you don't have it?"

"Yes, we did."

I said, "I often wonder if we were created to have what I feel with you. A connection that goes beyond filling a void or an emptiness. But on the other hand, it's like it completes me; it brings me a sense of wholeness that's also hard to describe. But I can tell you I have never felt such joy!"

We both stood up and put our arms around each other in a very gentle and intimate way. For both of us there were no words; only the swaying of our bodies with some soft music playing in the background. She whispered in my ear, "I love you my darling Howie."

"And I love you my precious Tess."

We swayed with the music for a while longer and then I whispered, "I love the twilight. Would you like to walk?"

“Yes, I love the twilight too. There’s kind of a mysterious hue or ambiance that sometimes gives me a peaceful feeling and at other times I feel this deep kind of sadness that brings tears to my eyes. And it’s all fine. It’s like sadness and joy are intertwined. Again, hard to explain.”

I continued, “This was the time-of-day walking on the beach when I missed you the most. I think it’s related in some way to what you just said. But I didn’t tear up. Most of the time, I was crying and sometimes sobbing because I missed you so much.”

We walked in silence for a while; content to feel the experience, the dream come true, the ecstasy of each moment.

If someone could see us, what a picture we would make. A beautiful woman in a white flowing dress arm in arm with her lover walking on the edge of the water slowly disappearing in the fading twilight.

When we got back to the house it was almost dark, Tess started on the dishes, and I got a fire going in the fireplace. There was a storm blowing in from the northwest. The temperature had already dropped.

We finished up together in the kitchen and Tess went to “freshen up” while I brushed and fed PJ and GJ. GJ was still hanging out in the guest bedroom as she had not been in the mood for a stranger in the house. I had to put a litter box, food and water dish in the guest bedroom for her. PJ was hanging out wherever he wanted. He had let Tess pet him several times. GJ just needed a little more time.

I fixed us a cup of tea, put on some soft music and she joined me in front of the fire. I sat on the floor with my back to the sofa and my legs spread. Tess scooted back between my legs. She had on soft yellow shorts and a shirt which looked like pajamas. I was in light shorts and a tee shirt. I kissed her hair and the side of her neck and whispered in her ear, “Can we make love tonight? My body is literally aching to be ‘in’ instead of ‘out’.”

Smiling, “I long for you to be inside me; it’s like an ache. But there is also something else going on and it’s difficult to describe.”

Pause. She went on in a kind of dreamy voice, “I’ve made love to you so many times in my dreams.” And with a soft giggle, “And I might add, often, with the help of my vibrator.”

I whispered in her ear, “You’re killin’ me.”

More smiling, “I know darlin’. I can feel ‘it’.” More serious, “What I’m trying to say is that this prelude is like the courtship we never had, and I want to savor it as long as I can stand it. If we had met and fallen in love, I hope we would have taken time to get to know each other before making love.”

I kissed her on the neck and pulled her closer to me and whispered, “I can wait to make love to you until you’re ready. In the meantime, I’m savoring each precious moment we’re together.”

Pausing and then, “There are so many questions I want to ask you and so many things I’m curious about.”

“What would you like to ask me?”

She said, “I know you have had very attractive and appealing women in therapy. How do you explain not falling in love with any of them?”

“Actually, I have fallen in love with a lot of them, but they weren’t interested.”

She scooted up and grabbed a pillow from the sofa and started beating me over the head.

“Stop, stop. I was just kidding.”

Laughing, I continued, “After you leave on Monday, I’m getting rid of all my lounge pillows.”

“You wouldn’t have to do that if you stop being a ‘smart ass’.”

Smiling, “Getting back to your question. No, I didn’t fall in love with any of them.”

“Explain!”

“There was a line I was not willing to cross with any of those gorgeous women.”

She reached for the pillow.

“No wait, just kidding.”

“About which part?”

“About crossing the line; no wait, I mean about the gorgeous women.”

Reaching for the pillow again, “Make up your mind!”

“Okay, let me start over again. Yes, I worked with some attractive women, but I never crossed the line in my mind. I maintained a professional approach in every case.”

“What do you mean ‘in your mind?’”

“Would you say I maintained a professional approach with you during the therapy?”

“Yes. I had no idea how you felt.”

“With you I crossed that line when I began having those thoughts and feelings which very soon got out of control. I explained a little while ago what it was about you that led me to fall in love with you. I never had those thoughts and feelings with another client.”

“When you started having those thoughts and feelings, why didn’t you stop having them?”

“Are you fishing for more reasons I couldn’t resist your charm and incredible charisma?”

Smiling, “Probably. I love that song playing. Can we dance?”

“I would love too.” I moved the sofa back and took her in my arms.

“We pressed against each other and swayed with the music. Our bodies took advantage of the music and moved in a sensuous rhythm.

After a few minutes, she pulled back a little and looked up into my eyes and said, “Do you have any snacks? I’m hungry.”

Smiling, “I’m hungry too for your body.”

A sensuous smile, “Me too for yours, but for some reason I’m also hungry for food.”

“I have some delicious aphrodisiac chocolate chip cookies.”

Laughing, “You’re fucking kidding me!”

“Did you say you’re fucking me?”

“Hopefully soon!” Pushing me toward the kitchen, “Right now I’m hungry!”

“Why don’t you look around and see what you can find. I’ll just sit here in the nook and watch you.”

She opened the fridge and looked around. “How about this peach yogurt? Before you answer, let me check the expiration date.... It’s good.”

“Why did you look so surprised?”

Laughing “Are you kidding me? You left that left over lasagna in the pantry. Remember?”

“Yeah. It was delicious. I ate it while you were in the shower.”

She got a spoon, came over and dipped a big bite to put in her mouth and then flipped it in my face and squealed and took off running.

I caught her before she reached the door even though some of it had gotten in my eyes. I grabbed the cup with one hand and rapped my other arm around her waist and dumped the yogurt on the top of her head. More squealing as she reached to the top of her head and cupped her hand and spread the yogurt on the top of my head and forehead and with my hand I spread more on her forehead and face.

Almost simultaneously we started licking the yogurt off each other’s face. Our tongues thrashing around until they found each other with a hunger, longing, and passion symbolic of the months we longed for each other in so many ways.

I lifted her off the floor as we continued wildly thirsting for each other. There were our moans of “I love you, need you, can’t live without you, never let me go, make love to me forever....”

We fell into the bed and were ripping our clothes off holding onto each other continuing moans of “kiss me, hold me, make love to me”. She rolled me over and straddled me and took my dick and moved it in circles until taking in every bit of

me. I thrust upward as she rode me like a bucking bronco. In a matter of seconds, we were both cumming and screaming “omg!! omg!! omg!!”

And then she fell on top of me stretching out her legs burying her head into my neck.

Almost breathless, “Oh Tess, what can I say? Ecstasy! Euphoria! Magic! There are no words. Nothing can ever describe it!”

She breathlessly whispered in my ear. “It was the third best orgasm I have ever had.” And then howled with laughter.

I slapped her on her ass.

“Ouch!”

She whispered in my ear, “Sweetheart, that was the most incredible experience of my life. Even though we have both agreed we can’t define love, I now know what it is to love and be loved.

“Yes, for the last 24 hours, it’s been a whole new experience.”

We laid there in the silence for a while and then I asked, “Are you as exhausted as I am?”

“Yes, I am!”

“I’m gonna grab a couple of hot wash clothes and a towel. Let’s clean each other and then let’s cuddle.”

“A heavenly idea.”

We took turns and then cuddled and drifted into sleep.

The sun was just peeking through the windows when I woke up. I had to pee really bad. ‘It’ was as hard as a rock, and I was feeling a little self-conscious. I didn’t want her to see me walking across the room with ‘it’ sticking straight out. I slipped out as easily as I could, and she stirred.

“Howie?”

“Yeh, I’m here sweetie, I just have to pee. Be right back.”

“OK, I have to go too.”

When I got back, she had put her tee shirt back on and was sitting on the side of the bed having trouble waking up.

“Hey sleepy head, you look groggy. Want me to help you to the bathroom?”

That seemed to rouse her a little more.

Smiling, she said, “No thanks, I’ll make it by myself.”

“OK, just askin’.”

PJ stretched and left for the kitchen to eat his breakfast. I got the coffee brewing and looked around for something. She walked in still looking a little sleepy.

I asked, “How did you sleep my darlin’?”

“I passed out.”

“Are you hungry?”

“Not really. How ‘bout taking our coffee outside?”

“Let’s do it.”

“How did you sleep Howie?”

“Same as you. Passed out.”

We sat close together on the lounge looking out at the water and sipped our coffee. The silence between us was magical. All we could hear was the sound of the waves and some sea gulls in the distance. The water was calm, and a little breeze felt refreshing.

After we finished our coffee, she said, “I would love to go for a walk. How ‘bout you?”

“Count me in.”

Smiling, “Yes, you are finally ‘in’.”

With a shit eatin’ grin on my face, “Yes and I’m speechless!”

She smiled, “Me too!”

I slipped my hand into hers and we walked up to the edge of the water with our feet submerged and she guided me heading north along the shore. We must have walked at least a mile in silence when I said, “You seem in a reflective mood this morning.”

She stopped, faced me, and took my other hand, “You taught me the importance of silence and meditation. This is like a meditative silence for me. You sometimes called it, ‘contemplation.’ As you know, this skill or experience saved my life. I wanted to spend some time contemplating these last 36 hours. I wanted to stop talking and feel the experience, the joy, the bliss, the thankfulness, the ecstasy.”

She let go of my hands and put her arms around my neck. We just held each other for a while, not too tight, just a comfortable and intimate embrace.

She softly whispered in my ear, “Can you feel my love Howie?”

I paused for a few moments and whispered back, “Yes.”

Continuing to hold me, she said, “What does it feel like?”

“It feels warm and like I can’t tell where your body ends and mine begins. Can you feel my love, Tess?”

“Yes, like you described and like a subtle vibration and smooth energy.”

She brought her arms down and took my hand and steered us south. We were silent until we reached the deck. She smiled and said, “I’m starved, but first, I want a kiss.”

“Me too.”

She pulled me to her, and we kissed gently and softly.

I said, “Let’s go see what we can find.”

She said, “I have a proposition.”

“Really?”

“Yes, but don’t get ahead of yourself. I need a shower. What if I get my shower while you fix us something to eat, and I’ll do the dishes while you take your shower.”

“You sure you don’t want me to wash your back?”

She looked over her shoulder and said, “Quite sure Howie Kingston.”

I sautéed more of those over ripe tomatoes in butter, fried the two pieces of bacon I had left, scrambled a few eggs in a little bacon grease and toasted two pieces of bread.

She came in with a towel around her head looking radiant.

We were both hungry and ate our breakfast in silence.

We both had a second cup of coffee.

After a few more sips, I asked, “Did I ever tell you that you have the most smooth and beautiful skin? Would you describe it as a kind of light olive?”

“Thank you! Yes, that’s what I’ve been told. Your skin looks rather weather beaten and has a kind of leather quality to it.”

“Yes, that’s what I’ve been told.”

Bursting out laughing, “Come here old man! I’m just kidding you about the leather part. Living on the water for all these years gives you kind of rough sexy appeal.”

She put her arm around my neck and kissed me and then said, “Breakfast smells wonderful! I’m hungry!”

We decided to make a trip to The Market after breakfast. She asked, “Do you make a list?”

“Always, even if there are only a few items. How ‘bout you?”

“Since I’m younger than you, I don’t make a list unless there are more than five or six items. But I sure understand your situation.”

“Why aren’t you smiling?”

“The reality of your age and your loss of brain cells is no laughing matter. In the last day or two I’ve even begun planning for which nursing home would be most suitable for you and conveniently located for me.”

“Tess, that’s so sweet of you. My only request is that they allow unlimited conjugal visits.”

“Howie you know I’m just kidding. We have at least a couple of years before we need to address that issue.”

“Did you just break wind or just pass gas? I smell something resembling the smell of a fart.”

“No, I did not and I don’t smell anything. If you smell something, it must have been one of the cats.”

“They’re not in the kitchen so it couldn’t have been one of them.”

“Well, it wasn’t me, but now I do smell something resembling a fart. I’m sure glad I’ve finished eating.” Laughing, “Oh I get it. You farted and are trying to blame it on me.”

“It seemed like a good idea at the time.”

She kept laughing.

I said, “You don’t have any reason to be laughing.”

She stopped and said, “What do you mean by that?”

“I mean that last night you farted in your sleep and the smell was so bad it brought me out of a deep sleep.

“Your’re making that up, admit it!!” She was looking for something to hit me with.

“No, it’s the truth but it’s a lie that it smelled bad. I loved smelling your fart. In fact, I pulled the sheet up over my face and got some good whiffs.”

“You what?” she said.

“You heard me.”

“I learned that from an old teacher (HDJ). He taught seminars on Transactional Analysis. TA was popular before you got out of diapers. Anyway, he was teaching about how we label stuff based on conditioning and programming. He said when he was a kid, he didn’t think farts smelled bad. He said when he farted in bed, he would pull his covers up to get the full effect of the smell. His overall point was that everything we experience in life is a perception and that perceptions are different and not a matter of right or wrong. He added that we all have the potential to change our perceptions.”

“Do you think he meant that we could decide to shift from farts smell bad to farts smell good?”

“Yeah.”

“You’ve gotta be kidding!” she laughed. “I think that would be a tough one for me. Do you now think farts smell good?”

“No, just your farts.”

“You liar.”

“No, I’m serious but maybe I should say since I’ve only smelled one of your farts that I’ll have to wait until I smell the next one before I can give you a more definitive answer.”

“Can we change the subject?”

“Sure. Let’s get back to talking about our day.”

“That suits me just fine. I’ve had enough talk about farts to last me about ten years or maybe I should say a lifetime.”

“Yeah, OK, we can talk more about it tomorrow.”

She pulled the towel off her head and quickly folded it and hit me on the head several times as I put my hands up to deflect the blows.

“Didn’t you hear me; I don’t want to ever talk about farts again.”

“Never, ever?”

“Yes, you big shit, never, ever.”

“You may regret that decision later.”

“I can’t imagine under what circumstances I might regret that decision.”

“Well, what about...”

She interrupted, “Howie!!!!!! What did I just say? No more talk about farts!!”

More hits to the head with the towel.

“OK, OK, OK!! Can I just make one last point?”

“NO!!!!!!”

By this time, we were laughing hysterically. As the laughing subsided, she asked, “Did I really fart last night in my sleep?”

Smiling, “No.”

“Well, no question it’s only a matter of time.”

“True. Actually, I farted last night, and it woke me up but you didn’t even stir.”

“Got it. Whatta you wanna do today sweetheart?”

“You mean besides making love?”

Smiling, she gave me a sexy look, “How about that’s all we do?”

“Sounds good. Let’s get naked.”

Laughing, “Are you kidding me? I was just teasing. I vote we go to The Market. You’re getting low on groceries. It’ll do us good to get out.”

Looking disappointed, “I’m doing good right here.”

“Butt hole, you know what I mean. Why don’t you go get your shower and I’ll clean up the kitchen and then finish getting ready.”

“Got it.”

On our way to The Market, she said, “Being Sunday, it’s probably going to be busy. Now that I’m living on the island, I go there often. They have the best sea food and so many delicious specialty items.”

“They sure do. I’ve been going there for years.”

“What do we say if we run into people you know or maybe somebody I know?”

“Well, let’s see. I could introduce you as, ‘my soul mate’ which would be my first choice, but not sure about that.”

“I agree. That’s what I think too, but maybe that’s too something. I’m not coming up with words on that one.”

“This is ‘my lover’ sounds a little too intimate.”

“Yes. I’ve got one. This is my ‘private dick’. We’re almost there. Come up with something!”

“I don’t know why this is so hard.”

“You don’t mean your ‘dick’ do you?”

“Yes and no.”

“Hurry, we can’t just sit here in the parking lot.”

“Okay, ‘girlfriend’ or ‘boyfriend’. That’s the best I can do.

Getting out of the car, she asked, “Do you have the list?”

“What list?”

She hit me hard on the shoulder.

“Ouch!”

A voice behind us said, “Is everything alright?”

Surprised, we both turned around. Tess said, “Oh, yes thanks. He just forgot the grocery list.”

The elderly lady looked a little startled and then moved through us toward the door and glanced my way and said, “Good luck young man.”

As soon as the door closed, we burst into quiet laughter.

Then I said, “Let’s make this easier. Why don’t we get back in the truck and make our list and divide it into two lists. You take one and I’ll take the other and we can act like we don’t know each other. We can meet at the seafood counter when we’re finished. If Frank is working today, I would like to introduce you to him. He has been a friend for years. Whatta you think?”

“I like it.”

I finished before she did and waited in the aisle closest to the seafood counter. In a few minutes she joined me. We waited until he was free and then approached the counter.”

“Hey Doc, good to see ya’. Who is this good-looking woman next to you?”

Tess interjected, “I picked him up in the parking lot so he could carry my groceries to the car.”

“A good choice young lady, however, I want to warn you, that’s about all he’d be good for.”

“Alright you two! That’s enough! Frank, I’d like to introduce you to Tess Angelina, the love of my life!”

Big Smile, “Bout time Doc. Tess, where you been? He’s been looking for you for years. I kept asking him, ‘When you gonna get a girlfriend?’ And for the last few years, he’s been sayin’, ‘I’ve got my eye on my dream woman.’ And I kept saying, ‘What you waddin’ on?’ And he would say, ‘The right time.’”

Tess said, “He was a little slow making the move.”

“Well now, I don’t know what he was waitin’ on, but I can see you were well worth the wait.”

“Thanks Frank, that’s sweet of you to say.”

I interjected, “I knew you two would hit it off. What would you suggest today?”

“I’ve got some real nice jumbo shrimp, and some black mackerel just came in. The cod also looks good.”

I looked at Tess. Whatta you think about a pound of shrimp, and a half pound of the mackerel and the cod?”

“Sounds good.”

He got it ready and said, “Mighty happy for you two love birds.”

“Nice to meet you Frank.”

“You too Tess.”

I said, “Tell Larry ‘Hi’ for me next time you see him. And I’d like to surprise him too.”

“I won’t say a thing.”

On our way home, she asked, “Who’s Larry?”

“Didn’t I tell you about Larry’s?”

“Yes, I think you might have mentioned it.”

“Larry owns the bar and grill at the south end of the preserve on the inlet waterway. The road leading to it from down where you live ends at the preserve boundary. It’s the best kept secret on the island. We’ll go soon if you’d like.”

“I would. This reminds me again that I don’t know much about you. That’s goanna change soon.”

“Got it.”

Before The Call

After we had carried in the groceries, she said “I wasn’t going to say anything about the Miracle Whip and Pinot Grigio and see if you remembered.” Smiling, “And best I can tell, you didn’t remember and that is bad news for you since you seem to really enjoy getting in my pants.”

“Oh Tess. I am so sorry. Let me run back down to The Market.”

She interrupted laughing,” Just teasing. I saw you sneak out the door while I was taking care of my list and then sneak back in. I knew what you were doing. I was one step ahead of you Howie. You may find that a pattern in our relationship.”

Smiling. “I’m sure I will! I have an idea?”

“Howie, I told you I’m not getting naked right now. So, what other ideas have you got?”

“How about a picnic?”

“I love that idea even more than getting naked.”

“I thought you said getting naked was ‘off the table’.”

“It is, but that doesn’t mean I wouldn’t love getting naked; just not right now.”

“Got it. How would you like to have pimento cheese sandwiches, some tomato basil wheat thins and an apple for our picnic lunch?”

“That sounds great, but I don’t remember pimento cheese being on our grocery list,”

“It wasn’t, but the ingredients were. Would you help me make it?”

“Sure. Tell me what to do.”

I got out the ingredients: A one pound block of extra sharp cheddar cheese, half a dozen stalks of scallions, a mild jalapeno pepper, Worcestershire sauce, six-ounce jar of chopped pimentos, mayo and light ranch dressing.

“I’ll shred the cheese, you finely cut up the scallions including the green of the stalk and the jalapeno minus the seeds.”

Smiling, “It seems like you’re giving me the hardest job,”

Smiling back, “Okay. You shred the cheese.”

Several strokes of the cheese on the grater and she said, “You can take over.”

When everything was ready, I said, “Now we mix the cheese with cut up scallions, jalapenos, and pimentos. I prefer an equal amount of mayo and ranch dressing, but this is where a matter of individual taste comes in. This is also true about the amount added. I like my pimento cheese creamier than most people.

Once everything is stirred, I take the Worcestershire bottle and squirt what appears to be about one teaspoon and one final stir and it's ready."

When we finished, I said, "Take one of these wheats thins and dip in."

She did, "I really like it, but it's a little creamier than I like."

"I'll make a note of that my love."

She put her arms around my neck and said, "Have I told you lately how much I love you!"

"Yes and no. I'll never get tired of hearing it. I was just thinking how special it was going to The Market with you. It was a glimpse of what our life will be together, doing normal things like shopping, eating out, visiting family and friends, taking trips and so on. One more time, 'a dream come true' my sweet, adorable Tess."

We kissed and then just held each other for a while. She whispered in my ear, "Before I change my mind and decide for getting naked over the picnic, let's get ready to go."

Acting disappointed, I said, "Sounds like a plan."

"Do you mind if I give April a quick call?"

"Not at all. I'll load up the backpack."

She went over to sit in the nook and dialed.

"Hey honey, how you doin'?"

....."Sure, I'll wait."

She looked at me, "She wants to go outside to talk."

..... "I'm here honey."

..... "I know sweetie. I understand. Please try to get along with her. I think she feels under a lot of pressure and is probably trying too hard."

..... "Honey, she knows it's important to your daddy that you don't mind spending time at their house."

..... "Do it for him and hopefully over a period of time it will get better. How is Keller doing and did he pass his driving test?"

..... "Good. Has his dad let him take the car out yet."

..... "I'm surprised. Keller must have done a good job convincing him he's a good driver."

..... "Oh! Let me speak to him."

..... "Hey Keller, congratulations on getting your driver's license."

..... "That's great honey. Be sure to be really careful. When do you start practicing football?"

..... "Okay honey. Let me speak to April again."

"Honey, do the best you can to get along with Holly. I'll pick you up in the morning around 8."

..... "I will. Love you too!"

“April said to say ‘Hi’.”

“That’s nice. What’s going on between April and Holly?”

“I think I already told you this, but she blames Holly for the affair with Arthur while I was in Afghanistan. She also knows about the close call I had with Rick Foster. So, I don’t think it’s blaming either one of us or even Holly in the long run. I think it’s mostly that Holly just gets on her nerves.”

“What do you think about Holly?”

“I wouldn’t choose her as a friend, but overall, I think she’s a good person and she and Keller get along well which makes me very happy. Since Keller and Arthur are very close, it makes Arthur happy.”

“So, April spends most of her time with you and Keller spends most of the time with his dad.”

“I’m curious why Keller is closer with his dad.”

“Keller was very upset about my combat tour. I think he saw it as an abandonment and was scared that I wouldn’t make it back. He saw Arthur as the one he could count on for stability. When I did return, as you of course know better than anyone, I was a wreck. That first year was miserable for all of us.”

Beginning to tear up, she asked, “Can we change the subject?”

I took her in my arms and held her close and after a few moments, I whispered in her ear, “How ‘bout a picnic?”

“We start over on the back side of the house. The trail is a little rough in places but it’s not bad. You lead and I’ll follow.”

“But I don’t know where to go.”

“See that big tree over there, just head in that direction.”

“Okay.”

She looked back at me shortly after we started and caught me looking directly at her ass. “You pervert, you just wanted me to lead so you could stare at my heinie.”

“I’ve never heard of such a ridiculous idea. I wasn’t staring at your heinie, I was staring at your legs.”

“You lie! Now get your ass up here and lead the way.” As I passed her, she gave me a big slap on my heinie.

“Ouch!”

“Serves you right you butt hole.”

“I love it when we talk dirty.”

“Is this a picnic or are you just leading me out here so you can get laid in the woods?”

“Okay, I was hoping for the latter, but we can move on to the former. I promise to behave if I can have one little kiss.”

“No way, you’re just trying to make me horny.”

“Got it.”

We continued our trek through the woods. We stopped several times so I could point out different types of plants and wildflowers.

I said, “My dad and I built the tree house when I was around 15. The tree must have been 100 years old even back then. I’ve made several adjustments and improvements since those early days and spent a few days each summer keeping it in good shape. The children loved to play in it and spent many hours of their time here when they weren’t playing on the beach or swimming in the ocean. It’s about 30 feet up in the air.”

When I stopped, Tess didn’t see it at first but when I looked up, she looked up and said, “Oh my god, a tree house.”

“How do you get up there?”

“There’s a special way up that only a few people know about.” I climbed up using two different rope ladders that were hidden by branches and foliage. When I got to the top, I threw down the ladder. Tess made the ascent easily and I pulled up the ladder.

“Wow, it is beautiful up here, you can see the ocean through the trees and yet you feel like you’re in the forest.”

“Yes, it’s one of my favorite places. You may have noticed that the platform is anchored to the tree with leather straps so that when the wind blows it can shift. These foot high sides are of course for safety.”

“There’s so much room. What size is it?”

“It’s about 8 x 10.”

“I can see why you love it up here.”

“When I was a kid, my cousin and I used to spend the night up here. It was of course our club house.”

“Can you lean up against that part of the tree?”

“Sure.”

“I’d like to sit between your legs so we can look out together at the water and the forest.”

“A great idea.”

“Can we do a meditation?”

“Would you like to lead it?”

“Me?”

“Yes, you!”

“Okay, I should be able to do it after listening to your meditations hundreds of times and as you always encouraged me, I created my own meditations.”

She leaned her head back, so the remnant of her ear touched my cheek.

“Let’s start with some deep breathing allowing our bodies to drift into a nice soft feeling of relaxation....and when we’re ready let’s see with soft eyes remembering we can let go of any thinking or thoughts about what we see and allow the experience to unfold moment by moment....like we become what our eyes see void of any opinion or judgment and simply being present to celebrate no time, just the now....and when you’re ready, just turn your head and kiss me on my ear.....

And soon after that I kissed her ear and whispered, “That was wonderful my love. Thank you!”

We sat in silence for a few more moments and then she turned and whispered in my ear, “I’m hungry. How ‘bout you?”

“Me too.”

“Let me help you unpack.”

“That’s okay princess, I’ll take care of that. You just relax and enjoy the view.”

She smiled and said, “It sure is nice to sit back and let someone else do the work.”

“It’s not work my lady, it’s my pleasure.”

“Charmed, I’m sure,” she said with her sweet smile.

We enjoyed our food again, taking turns feeding each other and looking into each other’s eyes and smiling. After we had finished and packed everything up but our drinks, we sat side by side looking out at the trees and ocean.

After some silent time, she said, “You have told me about Si and her family and some about Lance and of course I met Bea and know you have an Uncle Doug, but I don’t know much else about your family.”

“Bea had four children, Aunt Dorothy and Uncle Wesley who are both deceased. Aunt Dorothy suffered from seizures and while taking a bath had a seizure and drowned. She was only about 25.”

“Oh Howard! I’m so sorry.”

“I don’t remember much. I was about five years old, but I will never forget that night. It was Halloween”.

“Uncle Wesley worked for the CIA and was killed in a foreign country. We were never given an explanation about what happened. They only told us that he was killed in the line of duty. We never knew any of the details.”

“The other two were Uncle Doug and my dad, Roland. Uncle Doug retired from his job in insurance and of course Bea lives with him and his wife Anna.”

“My dad married Mary Beth Johnson. Mom’s family lived in Charleston, and they met at USC. Mom was an only child, and her parents are deceased. Dad and mom had a little grocery store and they sold it last year and retired.”

“I have one brother DJ. He is ten years older than me and lives in Lexington, Kentucky. He is not married to a woman. He is married to his little horse farm. He has become a well-known expert in breeding horses. He has a long-time girlfriend, Jansyl who lives with him. She designs clothes and travels a lot. Fortunately for her, he has no interest in marrying her. He has no children.”

“Why ‘fortunate for her’?”

“DJ loves his horse farm and breeding horses. By his own admission, he would make a ‘lousy husband’. I guess that’s about it. Any questions?”

“Would you say you’re close to your family?”

“I see Si, Roger and the kids a couple times a week and visit Mom and Dad at least once a week. Bea, Uncle Doug and Anna live next door to Mom and Dad, so I see them often. And of course, I don’t see Lance except when he comes home during holidays.”

I continued, “But, I am excited that Lance wants to come home more so we can spend time together. I miss him and think he’s a fine young man. I hope he doesn’t get too lost in the corporate culture. Any other questions?”

“Not right now. I’m looking forward to meeting your family although, I’m a little nervous.”

I will be the same meeting your children. Tell me more about your family.”

“Mine is not nearly the size of yours. I have a younger brother, Clarence who lives in Germany. While in the Army, he married a Faulein. Her name is Greta, and they have two children, Hans and Freda. Mom and Dad have visited them a number of times but not much recently. They were here for a few visits and it was nice, but we are not close.”

“Mom and Dad were only children. So it’s just us.”

“Where do they live?”

“They live in Centerville.”

“I drive through there on my way to Charleston.”

“Mom and Dad have retired from their regular jobs and run a small B & B. I have two grandmoms who are in assisted living close to where Mom and Dad live. Both my grandpaws have passed.”

“Are you close to your mom and dad?”

“Yes, I see them about twice a month. Now that I have my own place, I hope they will come and visit us more often.”

We sat in silence for a little bit and then she said, “Let me move and put my back against the tree. You lie down now and put your head in my lap.”

She began to lightly stroke my face, head, and neck with her fingernails. I closed my eyes and her touch was so sensuous and felt so relaxing at the same time. There was a nice breeze that made the temperature just right.

She said, "Love, I'm starting to get sleepy. Could we head back to the house. I would love a nap right now."

"Sure, let's pack up and head on back."

We didn't talk much on the way back. Holding hands and basking in the silence of just being together. When we reached the house, she said, "I'm still pretty sleepy, how do you feel about laying down?"

"Sounds good."

She went to the bathroom and then sat on the side of the bed and said, "I'm going to leave my clothes on so I don't have to change when I get up."

"Sit here for a minute and I'll be right back." I turned on some classical music and then went into the bathroom and got a hot wet washcloth and kneeled down by the bed.

She lazily asked, "What are you doing?"

"Scoot back and lay back so your feet are just over the edge of the bed. Just relax now and close your eyes."

She did and I gently washed her feet being careful to get between her toes. She kind of moaned and giggled some and told me that it tickled. After I finished, I gently took each one of her toes in my mouth and twirled my tongue around with a slight sucking. At first, she jumped a little and then relaxed with some soft moans and "that feels so good."

I reached under the bed where I had put some lotion and gently massaged her feet. "Howie, that feels heavenly."

I kept my eyes on her voluptuous body. I could see the outline of her breasts. Her legs were slightly spread, and I could see the soft material of the shorts enfolding between her legs outlining that part of her body with a little slit right where it should be.

Softly, "Scoot towards me." I put my hands under her thighs and positioned her so her calves drooped over the side of the bed and I was on my knees between her legs.

I gently with my fingertips and nails moved over and around her thighs right up to the edge of her shorts and then reached up and did the same to her arms up the edge of her tee shirt sleeves. Taking her hand in mine, I gently stroked her palm and then the back of her hand and then surrounded each finger with my fingers moving back and forth. I kissed each finger and took her middle finger and put it in my mouth and gently sucked on it. More soft moans from her. Then I repeated the same with her other hand.

I moved my hands under her tee shirt and moved my fingers around her sides and up under her arms and then all around her tummy being careful to avoid her breasts. Softly and so quiet, I could hardly hear her say, "That tickles and feels

so good at the same time.” Then I moved to circling the edge of her breasts and then taking my time to move closer and closer to her nipples.

Then as I lifted her tee shirt, she arched her back just a little. I leaned over and cupped her breasts and alternating, I moved my tongue massaging her nipples and then gently sucked on them. More soft groans. Then with her help I raised her tee shirt over her head and moved back down on my knees between her legs.

I began again with the tips of my fingers to move over her thighs and after a few minutes, I moved my fingers around and on top of her soft loose-fitting shorts and when my fingers found the inner part of her thighs, she spread them inviting me to move my fingers around the area where her thighs connected to her pelvis. I touched her ever so gently being careful not to touch that slit in her panties. Then, I moved my finger as lightly as possible from the top of the slit to the bottom. More moans.

In a low voice, “Howie, please fuck me right now. I want you now!”

Softly “Shhhhhhhhhhhhh...”

I started again with my fingers moving very slowly this time under her shorts working my way from the outside and top of her thighs and then to her inner thighs. More groans. Then over the top of her bikini panties very gently stroking the slit. “That feels soooooo good.”

I began pulling down her shorts being careful to leave her panties on. She raised her hips to help me. I started licking her calves and then up to the top of her thighs and then to her tummy and then to her inner thighs and the edge of her panties and then with my nose moving up and down the slit. More moans and she reached to pull her panties down and I grabbed them and pulled them off.

She spread her legs as wide as possible and I went for her thighs licking as I moved closer and closer to her clit moving my tongue everywhere but, on her clit, going in circles and then passing my tongue lightly over her clit and then all around it and then over again lingering for a few seconds. She started hunching every time I touched it with my tongue.

Then I reached up with my hands massaging her breasts and she arched her back with legs in the air spread as far as she could get them. I focused on her clit and everything around it forcing my tongue as deep into her as I could and then more on just her clit. By then she was hunching and screaming, “oh my god, it feels so good.”

When I came up for air or focused for a moment on her inner thighs she thrust her body toward my tongue yelling, “Suck my pussy, suck my pussy, suck my pussy...” I focused all my attention right there. She guided me the rest of the way, “Yes right there, suck on it, not too hard, suck on it gently, now more tongue up and down, up and down, Yes! Yes!, just like that, just like that, Yes! Yes!”

Screaming, "I'm starting to cum!! I'm starting to cum!! Oh my god, oh my god, oh my god, oh my god, I'm cummin' so good. I'm cummin' so good!!

And then she went limp panting and out of breath struggling to say, "Get your naked body up here!"

As I crawled into the bed, she said, "Lay on your back." I want to lay on top of you."

She laid on top of me and whispered in my ear, "That was so incredible! Thank you my love, my precious Howie" She buried her head into my neck. "Give me a few minutes to literally catch my breath."

"Take your time my love."

"I don't wanna take my time. I'm still horny."

"You still being horny makes me even more horny and before this I would have said being more horny than I was would be impossible."

"I like that." She kissed me very lightly with her mouth open a little and her tongue moving in a circular motion. She kept doing it; just light kisses and our mouths kept getting more moist and wet and it was so intimate. It was like our mouths were connected and drinking the same juices. It was this intense longing of my body to melt into hers.

She reached down between her legs and took my dick and rubbed it on her pussy around and around and then sat up as my dick slide in her. I hunched upward in one movement and kept my ass arched up in the air to get in her as deeply as possible. She pushed down onto me, "Fuck me Howie, fuck me Howie!"

She began moving in slow circles continuing to push down on me while I massaged her tits. Then she lowered herself and continued with moist and wet kisses thrusting her ass back and forth with more wet kisses and then she began hunching wildly with her hips and me finally coming up for air yelling, "Fuck me Tess!! Fuck me Tess!!"

And then mutual orgasms and screams of ecstasy and delight with no words adequate to define that deep space where two become one.

We held onto each other and simultaneously began crying, each of our bodies shaking and celebrating moments that not so long ago were only a fantasy, a dream that might never have been a reality. There were no words between us, only something that remained precious and unknowable and unexplainable.

As our sobs became quiet tears, Tess slid off me and with one leg drooped over me and with an arm resting on my chest, we drifted into....

And when we woke a little later, Tess whispered, "I had this incredible dream that I had two orgasms."

"I wish I had been there."

Smiling, "I think you were."

More silence.

Then, she said, "In the silence, you will find everything you need to experience inner peace and contentment. I'm trying to remember where I heard that."

Smiling, she continued, "I think it's also true that in the silence, you find the deepest and true meaning of love."

We laid there for a while and then she asked, "What do you think about another run today? That felt so good yesterday and I feel kind of groggy right now."

"That sounds good to me too. How about jogging to the northern edge and then walking back like we did yesterday"?

Smiling, she said, "I don't think I'm up for much further than that. We had quite a workout a little while ago. I'm not used to that."

Smiling back, "I'm sure glad to hear you say that. That's new to me too!"

Whispering in my ear, "Glad to also hear you say that."

We put on some jogging clothes, 'hit the head' and were off. There was a nice breeze with a few scattered clouds. We were content with a moderate pace, each breathing a little harder than usual for this pace.

I said, "In wartime, the male warriors always said, 'Don't spill your seed before hand-to-hand combat.' I never was in that situation, but after our lovemaking earlier, I can sure see what they meant. I'm really feeling it right now."

She responded, "I was never in hand-to-hand combat, but I never masturbated right before a mission so I'm not sure how much difference that would have made."

I looked at her as she kept a straight face and kept jogging.

"How often did you masturbate?"

"It all depended on the day. If I was horny, probably three or four times a day. Sometimes more and sometimes less. But I never did masturbate while flying a mission."

I started laughing and she kept a straight face and kept jogging.

She asked, "What's so funny?"

"Good question. I guess it was the image of you masturbating in a helicopter after telling your co-pilot to take over."

"What's so funny about that? I was horny and I needed to cum. I take that seriously."

"I apologize for laughing. It has got me wondering how many times a day do you need to cum?"

"Minimum six and maximum nine or so."

"I'll be dead by next week."

“Don’t worry, you’re not going to be responsible for all six to nine times until we get your life insurance beneficiary changed.”

With that she dropped behind me and jumped on my back and screamed, “Giddy up cowboy!!”

With my seed spilled, I wasn’t up to a piggyback ride, so I headed toward the water and Tess yelled, “No not in the water, not in the water!”

I waded out until the water came up to my chest with Tess yelling all the way.

I slid her around with her legs still wrapped around me and in a loud voice asked, “Do you wanna cum now? I have several options.”

“Let me down pervert!” With her arms tightly around my neck, she said, “Disregard that last command. Take my pants off and hold on to ’em and then take your pants off. I wanna feel our ‘privates’ rubbing together. Again, it feels so good in the water.”

I put my arm through a leg hole in each of our shorts and turned my full attention to the experience.

“Don’t try to put that thing inside me. I’m a little tender. Just rub it around.”

“Got it.”

We played some in the water and then I said, “Do you wanna stay in the water and walk back towards the house?”

“Sure that sounds nice. Just don’t let go of my shorts.”

It didn’t take us long as we had only jogged less than a mile. Let’s put our pants on and walk the rest of the way to the house, Whatta you think?”

“Let’s do it.”

We got in the shower and washed each other between kisses.

“Do you by any chance have a hair dryer?”

“Yes I do. Si has spent so much time out here over the years that she brought one out here probably about ten years ago and decided to leave it. Hasn’t gotten much use since the kids were born, but I assume it still works. It’s in the closet in the guest bedroom.”

“Super, I wanted to try and do something with my hair.”

“Okay, I love it any way just so you know.”

“Thanks love!”

“While you’re doing that, I’ll fix some cocktail sauce for the shrimp, and we can have that with our wine on the deck. How does that sound?”

“Great.”

“I checked the weather, and a storm is coming around seven. Let me check the time. It’s a little before five. I think we’ll be fine for happy hour. We may have to eat inside.”

“Sounds like a plan Captain.”

“Thank you Major, we aim to please!”

She came out in a pair of those soft shorts. They were light orange with a light green blouse.

“How did you fit all your clothes in that small bag?”

“Everything is light and didn’t take up that much room. I’ve only got a few things left. Thanks for the wine, Howie. That shrimp looks delicious. Did you make the cocktail sauce?”

“Yes, I’m eager for you to try it.”

I smothered one in sauce. She opened and took a bite. She chewed and said, “That’s delicious. Not too hot and for me just right. Do you have a special recipe?”

“No. I learned this recipe from my dad and I think it’s pretty common.”

“What’s in it?”

“Two parts Heinz cocktail sauce to one part Heinz catsup. Add a squeeze of lemon, Worcestershire to taste and prepared horseradish to taste. Make sure the horseradish is the real stuff.”

“Got it.”

“Right. ‘Cheers my love’.”

“Cheers. You mentioned a storm coming. I can feel it in the air.”

“Me too.”

We sat in silence for a while enjoying our wine and the shrimp.

I said, “I wonder if you’re thinking what I’m thinking?”

“Yes, I think I am.”

“I would like to talk about it.”

“Okay. Do you wanna start?”

“I can unless you would rather start.”

She said, “Okay, I’ll start.” Pause. “I’m really torn about whether to have the mackerel or cod for dinner.”

“I have a preference, but I was more concerned about whether we have bread with just butter or butter with Parmigiana Reggiano.”

We both smiled. She came over and sat in my lap and put her arms around me resting her head in the crook of my neck. “Oh Howie, what are we gonna do? I just can’t stand the thought of leaving you in the morning. But Arthur is counting on me to pick up April at eight before he goes to work. And she has a dentist appointment at nine.”

“I feel the same way. I can imagine what it’s going to be like for me when you get in your car and head outta here in the morning. I don’t wanna even think about it.” Pause. “While I was making the cocktail sauce, I tried shifting to thinking about how our lives are going to change now that we’ve found each other.

Gone are the days when I can't call you, can't see you, don't know how you feel about me, wonder if you have found someone else and so on."

"Yes, that's where I need to focus too. Our lives will never be the same in a wonderful way."

"What do you think about planning our day tomorrow?"

"Let's do it. I'll leave here tomorrow around 7:30 to pick up April. I'll drop her off at the dentist office and see if I can convince Keller to go with me to McDonalds to get something to eat and spend some time together and then we can pick up April. I'll drop him off at Arthur's and April and I can run some errands. I thought about asking her if she would like to come out here with me and eat lunch with you."

"That would be great. I'm really looking forward to meeting her formally since seeing her briefly through the screen door when she closed the door in my face."

Tess laughing. "Yes, that was a tough time for you! After lunch, April and I will go back to the house and take care of some chores. Her friend Leslie has been bugging her to spend the night so we'll see about making that happen so I can spend the night with you."

"Sounds great! Looks like I've got a full schedule of clients all three days this week. Lately I've changed my hours to starting at nine and ending at four with lunch from twelve to one. I'd love for you to come to lunch with me on Friday so you can meet Henry in person."

"That would be great. I'm in the middle of several projects at the house so I will have plenty to do on the days when you're working. This planning makes me feel better. You were so on target a few minutes ago. It helps so much to know you and I can be together every day. I can call you, come to eat lunch with you when you're working, visit family together and go shopping. Remembering all that really helps."

We cuddled for a while and then she asked, "Would you like a short walk along the edge of the water before we have supper?"

"Yes. The storm is about an hour away and the sun along with the 'calm before the storm' adds such a nice ambiance. We do share a special liking for this time of day."

"We do."

We walked in silence arm in arm for a while along the edge of the water and turned back reaching the beach house just as the clouds covered the sun. The temperature was dropping.

I asked, "How about a fire and another glass of wine?"

"Sounds delightful."

After sitting down, she said, “We’ve both been rather quiet. I don’t know about you, but I feel sad, maybe even a little depressed. It’s like I’ve waited so long for these moments, never until very recently, believing that they would even exist. Now that they’ve become reality, in some ways, I’m afraid to leave.”

“I’m glad you will have some specific things to focus on when you leave in the morning. Your children, errands, projects at your house and of course talking to me and visiting as much as you can. Everything here, including the beach will remind me of these last two days together. Everywhere I turn there will be an emptiness, a void, some form of incompleteness.”

“How do we get through this? And Howie Kingston, don’t ask me if I would like to answer my own question.”

“Got it. The only thing I can think of is numerous trips to my sanctuary to help me get Centered and focused on the miracle of you in my life. And to be grateful that we are now together even though some physical separation is our reality in these weeks ahead. We both have the skills to do this. I have been practicing them for years and you have used these same skills over the last two and a half years for healing the major scars of the war.”

“And to do that, we must be conscious, awake.”

“Yes.”

The wind was starting to pick up and we could hear the rain. Before long, the wind was howling, and the rain was beating against the windowpanes. We cuddled closer together commenting how cozy it was and how nice it was to have wine and a fire.

Neither one of us was very hungry. I toasted some garlic bread, and we finished the shrimp.

She asked, “What are you going to do tomorrow?”

“After you leave, I’m going to call Si and give her a quick update and then try to reach Henry and do the same with him. I think I’ll go see Mom and Dad and then come back here to do some chores. What do you think April will say about coming out here for lunch?”

“I think she would love that. She is eager to meet you in person after you all having quite a history over the phone.”

“Yes, I’ll never forget that. She was a ‘hoot’.”

“Can we stretch out and cuddle? I feel so good and a little drowsy.”

I think she drifted off first, but I wasn’t very far behind.

It was dark when she whispered in my ear, “My love, can we just go on to bed. I feel exhausted.”

“Sure.”

“I need to use the bathroom first?”

“I’ll take this stuff to the kitchen. Let me know when you’re finished.”

She said from the bedroom, "Howie I'm finished."

"Let me tuck you in and I'll be back in a few minutes."

"Thanks. I feel so tired."

I finished in the bathroom and knelt by her at the end of the bed and whispered, "scoot your feet out over here."

Softly, "You're not going to start licking my feet again, are you?"

"No." I reached under the sheet and with both hands started lightly rubbing the tops and bottoms of her feet.

"Oh, that feels really good."

Then I started massaging her left arch and then the other."

"My whole body feels like it's relaxing."

And then, gently rubbing my hands back and forth on the tops and bottoms of her toes.

"Thank you, Howie. That was wonderful! Now, can I get a goodnight kiss?"

We faced each other and she gave me a slow passionate kiss and then buried her head in my neck with one leg draped over me and with a soft sleepy voice whispered, "I love you my precious."

A few minutes later, I could tell by her breathing she was drifting into sleep. When she exhaled, once again I slowly inhaled all the air I could. If I couldn't be inside her, I was going to bring her inside me. So as a gentle breeze and the sound of the waves moved through the room, I drifted off into the deeper spaces of my mind.

The Call

The alarm went off at six. I reached over and turned it off and scooted up next to her whispering in her ear, “Good morning sunshine.”

She stretched and sleepily asked, “Do you always get up this early?”

“How do you know it’s early?”

“I’m not blind ‘dickhead’. The suns not up yet.”

I burst out singing, “You are my sunshine, my only sunshine, you make me happy when...”

“Shut up, I’m nobody’s sunshine especially this early in the morning! PJ just jumped off the bed. He don’t wanna hear you singin’ neither. Come here my darlin’ and put your arms around me. Ahhh, that feels good. Wait a minute is your dick getting hard?”

“It’s always hard when I wake up and have to pee.”

“Well go pee and don’t bring that hard dick back to bed.”

When I came back, she was up straightening the bed.

“Let me help with that.”

“Okay, now I gotta pee.”

When she came out, she put her arms around me and said, “Can we go for a short walk?”

“Sure.”

The sun was peeking up from the horizon as we walked hand in hand toward the water turning north getting our feet wet in the surf.

After a few minutes, she said, “I guess I should leave around 7:30 in case there’s traffic.”

“Okay.”

We walked on a little further and I asked, “Are you alright?”

“I guess.” She turned to face me, and tears were running down her cheeks.

The moment I saw her tears, my eyes filled with tears, and we put our arms around each other, and I said, “This is so hard.”

She grinned and kind of crying at the same time blurted out, “You mean your dick or me leaving?”

I pulled her in to me and said, “Both.”

We just stood there for a bit, and I said, “Let’s do it Tess!”

“Do what? Make love or get me ready to leave?”

“You nail me every time! Get you ready to leave you little shit.”

As we walked back to the house, “I’ll fix us some breakfast while you get ready and get your things together. Anything special for breakfast?”

“I’m not hungry, but I’ll take one of those peach yogurts and half a toasted bagel with cream cheese. Thanks love!”

I could hear the shower running and she was singing, “You are my sunshine”. I smiled and did some light cleaning.

While we were eating breakfast, I asked, “How much did you tell Keller about us?”

“He came over last Thursday and April and I told him the whole story in shortened form.”

“How did he respond?”

“He had some questions, but seemed receptive and showed no visible signs that he was upset. I think I told you he didn’t like Kent, but I think he came to accept the fact that I would be seeing other people.”

“Do you think either one of them have told their dad?”

“Yes. I told both they could tell their dad and anyone else they wanted to.”

“I’m glad. You and I talked about it back in the day. Secrets always get us in trouble in one form or another.”

She looked at the clock. “I better get going.”

She picked up her bag and we walked to her vehicle. She put it in the back seat and then turned and put her arms around my neck and whispered in my ear, “I’m already missing you Howie. I love you so much.”

“It’s gonna be hard watching you drive away. I love you! Call me when you get a break. I hope April will agree to lunch.”

“I’m pretty sure you will. She really wants to meet you.”

She pulled out, honked, and waved. I watched her vehicle until she reached the turn about a mile down the road as the vehicle disappeared.

I had many chores and projects waiting on me this morning. My goal was to keep busy and think only about how grateful I was to finally have Tess in my life.

I checked in with Si and she asked me if she could come out to the house for a glass of wine around five with the hope of meeting Tess. Roger was going to watch the kids, I told her I wasn’t sure about Tess’s plans yet, but I wanted to see her even if Tess couldn’t make it.

I called Henry and filled him in on the details and told him I wanted to bring Tess to our lunch meeting on Friday. I called Mom and Dad and gave Mom the latest news. Mom said Bea had told her about meeting Tess and that she really liked her. I said I hoped to bring Tess over to meet them at some point this coming weekend.

The phone rang around ten and it was an unfamiliar number.

“Hello, this is Howard Kingston.”

The caller said, “I’m looking for some grass seed that will grow on concrete. Do you have any in stock?”

“Hold on let me check....I have one bag left. Would you like for me to hold it for you?”

“No, I want you to deliver it!”

“I’m sorry, we don’t deliver.”

“Let me speak to your boss.”

“Well, uh, I am the boss.”

“I was afraid of that.” She hung up.

The phone rang and before I could speak, she said. “Hey Howie, my moms on the phone talking to Kent, but I wanted you to know that I’m looking forward to meeting you.” And she hung up.

She is a real character.

Tess called around eleven to say she and April were on the way to pick up some groceries and would then be heading home to get some things done around the house. She asked if they could come for lunch around one.

“Sounds fine. Tell April I’ll have that grass seed ready for her when she gets here.”

“Will do.”

They pulled in a little after one.

As they came to a stop and I approached, April rolled down her window and said, “Go get the grass seed and load it in the back.”

“Sorry April, I double checked the storeroom and the only bags I had were for sand, not concrete.”

“Figures.”

Tess came around and hugged me and whispered, “I missed you.”

She looked at April, “Are you gonna get out of the car?”

“I’m not sure. Are you and Howie finished huggin’ on each other?”

Smiling, “For the moment.”

She opened the door and got out and looked at me, “I’m not sure whether I should hug you or hit you in the stomach.”

“Well, if hitting me in the stomach would make you feel better, give me your best shot.”

“You don’t look in that great of shape to take a good punch.”

“You’re probably right. I would much prefer a hug.”

“Okay, but don’t hold on to me too long. This is kind of embarrassing.”

“Got it.”

We hugged and I wouldn’t let her go.

She yelled, "Let me go you pervert."
I let her go and she wouldn't let me go.
I yelled, "Tess help me out!"
Tess said, "Okay you two. I'm hungry. I've been thinking about your pimento cheese all morning."
April said, "I don't like pimento cheese."
"She's messin' with you Howie. She loves pimento cheese."
As we walked in the house, April asked, "Where are PJ and GJ?"
"PJ should be coming out of my bedroom. There he is."
She went over and picked him up and sat down in the chair and started petting him. I could hear him purring.
I asked, "Are you all ready to eat?"
April said, "Mom, would you fix my sandwich? I want to stay here with PJ."
"Sure."
I asked, "What do you all want with you sandwich?"
April asked, "Do you have any chips?"
"Yes."
"Where's GJ?"
"She's in the guest room sleeping on the bed or hiding in the closet."
She picked up PJ and went toward the guest bedroom.
Tess asked, "What can I do?"
As soon as we were in the kitchen, we reached out for each other and held on tight with intermittent kisses and "I love you....I missed you...."
When we came up for air, I asked, "Should we get lunch ready?"
"I guess so."
We got it ready, and Tess yelled, "April, lunch is on the table."
She yelled back, "You all go ahead and eat. I'm not hungry and I'm working on making friends with GJ."
"She loves cats, but I think she just wants to give us some time together. She saw me tearing up several times this morning. She wanted to know what was wrong and I told her the truth. That I missed you and still couldn't get over that we were finally together."
She continued, "She asked me if I was so happy, why was I crying? I told her I couldn't explain it but sometimes tears can mean many different things."
I said, "She seems very thoughtful."
"She is most of the time, but she has her moments like all of us do. At times I worry about her. In some ways she is spirited, mischievous, funny, and confident but she can be abrasive. There is another side that is soft, vulnerable, and fearful."
"Sounds pretty human."

“I guess so, but I still worry some. She is also very dependent on me because of not being very close with Arthur.”

“It must have been very tough on her while you were deployed.”

“It was. But she is also a survivor and she made it without too much trauma. Since I’ve been back, we have gotten even closer. I have depended a lot on her too. Getting through these last two and a half years has been as you know challenging to say the least.”

“Yes, I know. I’m not sure how I would have done it without Si and Henry.”

Her phone rang. “This may be Leslie’s mother about April spending the night with them.”

She picked it up, “Hello.... Yes, this is Major Angelina....Hotdog Harris! You’ve gotta be kidding me. It’s been a long time. What’s going on?....No I’m with someone right now....Sure, hold on a minute.”

“He wants to talk to me in private. I’ll just go outside.” She kissed me on the cheek and left.

I waited a few minutes and looked out the window. She was about halfway to the water.

I went in the guest bedroom to check on April and bring the sandwich. She was in the rocking chair and to my surprise, GJ was sitting in her lap. PJ was stretched out on the bed. I had never seen GJ that relaxed with anyone other than me and sometimes Si.

I told April about GJ, and she said, “It took a little coaxing. I just sat on the floor outside the closet and talked to her and eventually she came out and rubbed against me and then sat on my lap. Thanks for the sandwich. Where’s Mom?”

“She got a phone call and said she needed to talk to the caller in private.”

“It’s probably Kent. He calls her a lot.”

“Probably so. We have an agreement. She will rotate days with Kent and me. I have Tuesdays, Kent Wednesdays, me Thursdays....

She interrupted, “Stop Howie. I think we’ve beat that one to death. Do you know who Mom is talking to?”

“It’s somebody she knew in the Army.”

“Since she was promoted, she sometimes gets calls from the Reserve Center.”

“Got it. I hope you like your sandwich. Are those chips, okay?”

“Yes, thanks.”

“Do you want something to drink?”

“No thank you.”

I went back to the kitchen and Tess was coming in the door. She did not look well.

“Hon, what’s the matter?”

“Hotdog told me he had been selected to join a “special operations” mission and had been told that this mission would require four helicopters with the four best pilots, co-pilots, and crew chiefs the Army had to offer. He told me he had selected me and Wilson, another pilot we served with, to be two of his pilots and Jason, another soldier we served with to be one of the co-pilots. He was calling around the country to friends he had known to select the rest of his crews.”

I was stunned to hear this news and my heart started beating wildly. In my experience in the Army, “special ops” were the most dangerous missions. I had been on a few as an Army Ranger, but most of them were “Reconnaissance Missions” and we never encountered any resistance even though they were very dangerous.

We just held each other and were silent for a few moments. I didn’t know what to say and it seemed Tess didn’t either.

Finally, I said, “I have a thousand questions, but I know from experience that special ops are mostly top secret and I assume this one is too.”

She nodded. I moved back and looked into her eyes, and it was like she wasn’t there. What can you tell me?”

“We will go to a designated training area and be there for a week and the mission will take place the following week on a designated day and we will return to the training base and be debriefed and put on a plane for our original departure location. If everything went smoothly, we would be home within two weeks. I’m to be at the Reserve Center at 1800 to receive more instructions over a secure line. That’s all I know.”

“There will be no more questions from me. Of course, if you get any information, you’re allowed to share with me, I know you’ll tell me and I’m trusting you to know me well enough to know I can handle it. Now, let’s figure out a plan to get you to the airport at the designated time.”

“I don’t need you to do that with me.”

“I know that but I’m asking you to let me help because I need to do that as long as I can be helpful and not in your way.”

She looked in my eyes. “You know this is what I’m trained to do and you also know that this person I respect has selected me as one of the top four combat helicopter pilots in the Army. You know from this moment; my one focus is to take care of business until I leave and then shift to it’s all about the mission. And what I want you to remember is that you are the love of my life, my soul mate and you will be always on my mind when I allow myself to think of anything else other than the mission.”

Pause, she continued, “Thanks for offering to help me get ready. I’ve changed my mind. I can use your help.”

“Let me get a notepad and why don’t you make a list of things you have to do before you leave. I went in and checked on April while you were on the phone, and she had GJ on her lap.”

“She did? GJ wouldn’t give me the time of day.”

“She seems like a natural. Anyway, I took her the sandwich and some chips, so I think she’ll be fine for a while. You haven’t eaten yet. Why don’t we eat, and you can think about things you want on the list. I’m ready to write.”

She said, “Let me do some deep breathing for a few minutes and settle down and get Centered.”

“I’ll join you. I need to do the same.”

She opened her eyes and between bites, she started the list.

1. Tell April. She is not going to want to stay with Arthur for the two weeks so make arrangements with Leslie’s mother to spend some nights with them.

2. Call Arthur and Keller.

3. Call Mom and Dad.

4. Howard to look after the house and related tasks.

5. Pack personal clothes.

6. Spend time with April and Keller. Maybe take them to eat at McDonalds.

7. Be at the Reserve Center at 1730 to pick up gear and take call at 1800.

8. With whatever time left, spend with Howard.

“I think that does it for now. I also wanted to know if it would be okay if I listed you as, ‘next of kin’?”

“Yes, absolutely.”

“I’ll get you a list of phone numbers for all my family. Can you think of anything I have left out?”

“Not really. When going out on a long-range patrol, the most important thing was to take everything I might need. Ninety percent of that was military stuff. I’m assuming all those things are at the Reserve Center.”

“Were you an Army Ranger?”

I nodded.

“You never told me that.”

“I’m sure it would have come out when we were talking about our military experiences.”

“I’ve told you some of my mine during therapy, but there will be more to tell including this one coming up when the dust settles, and clearance is lifted.”

She continued, “It’s time for me to tell April.”

“Here’s the list. I’ll stay in the kitchen and let me know if I can be of help.”

A few minutes later, I heard April crying and yelling, “No Mama, you can’t do that to me again!! What if something happens to you!! What if you get killed!!” She was sobbing.

I heard Tess saying, “Honey, it’s just for two weeks, just like summer camp last year.”

“No, it’s not like that!! I was able to come and see you and you were just 30 miles away!! And now I can’t even call you on the phone!! I know you’re going to do something dangerous!! Please tell them to get somebody else who doesn’t have children!! I can’t do this again!!”

Then, it was quiet and all I could hear was April crying and the murmurs of Tess trying to comfort her. Then I could hear them going out the door and the vehicle starting.

Now it was my time to get busy and keep moving. I texted Tess and told her to let me know if there were any errands I could run or anything else I could do. I told her there was no need to respond unless she needed my help. I hoped there would be a little time to see her before she left. I also offered to drive her to Charleston.

Around 2:30, Tess called. “Hey Sweetheart, I got April calmed down. I called Harriet, Leslie’s mom and explained the situation. She said April could stay with them for as long as we needed up until next Monday when they will leave on vacation for a week. We packed a few things and I promised to pick her up at Leslie’s later and that she and Keller and I could spend some time together. I called Arthur and then went by the house to see Keller. He was upset, but nothing like April. I’m not as worried about him.”

“I know these situations are so difficult for some children. Any way I can help?”

“I’ve been thinking about that since I left your house. After she calmed down some, she told me she didn’t want to stay with her dad and Holly. She likes Leslie’s mom and dad and would like to stay there some, but she surprised me and asked, ‘Do you think I could spend some days with Howie?’”

“At the same time, I wasn’t that surprised. She really liked you even before you all formally met. And I think in an understandable way, being with you will make her feel even closer to me. I was thinking that she and Leslie could spend the night with you a few times when she gets back from vacation.”

“That feeling goes both ways. Being close to her will make me feel closer to you. How do you think Arthur will feel about it?”

“Arthur will give me some pushback, but Holly will encourage him to agree. As I’ve said, she and April don’t get along and it’s somewhat disruptive to their household when April’s there. A weekend or two at their house will be enough for them. If it’s okay with you, I’m going to write Arthur and let him know that April will be staying with Leslie some and has expressed a desire to stay with you some days and that you’re going to invite him to come to your house so he can meet you.

I'm also letting Harriet know that April will also be spending some nights at your house. And I will also mention to her that if Leslie wants to join April for a sleep over at your house that you and she could meet to discuss the idea."

"Perfectly fine."

"I have the list of all my family and Harriet with addresses and telephone numbers."

"Sounds good to everything you've said. Honey, how are you doing?"

"I'm so busy I haven't had time to think and that's a good thing for now. Just allowing my mind to wander into what it's going to be like to be away from you borders on heartbreak. I love you so much Howard. The only thing I could ever imagine that could pull me away from you is a 'call to duty'."

"I know my love. We will get through this. How are you doing with your list?"

"Getting it done. April will have a key to the house and there is a spare key under the third flowerpot from the back door. I told April to check with her father and with you every morning. She is not to spend the night at the house by herself or with Leslie and she is to keep her father and you informed of her activities. I'm going to finish packing, write that letter to Arthur and then go pick up April and Keller and spend some time with them. Then it's on to the Reserve Center to pack my gear and get the call at 1800. I'll call you on my way back and meet you at your house as soon as I can get there."

"I'll have dinner ready even if you don't have much time. Be sure to hydrate and be careful my precious!!"

"Will do. Talk to you soon. I love you!"

"I love you darlin'."

I called Si at work and luckily caught her between clients. "Hey Hon, how was your weekend?"

"Fine Daddy, I don't even need to ask about you and Tess."

"Right Honey, there are no words that even touch what it was like."

"I'm so happy for you and I'm so excited to meet her. Is around five today still good for you all?"

"Sorry Honey, but Tess was called while we were eating lunch and told to report for some special operation. She will be leaving this evening and will be gone for two weeks. She wasn't given any detailed reasons and will be leaving tonight. She is busy getting ready and making arrangements. I am helping with some of the details. I was wondering if you would be able to come out tomorrow around 5:30?"

"Let me double check with Roger to see if he can watch the kids and if you don't hear from me, I'll be there at 5:30 tomorrow."

"Great."

“How are you doing? You all finally got together and now you must be separated for two weeks. I feel bad for both of you.”

“Thanks Honey. You know the drill; one moment at a time. I’ll be doing extra Centering Meditations until she is safely back.”

“Do you know if she will be doing anything dangerous.”

“She doesn’t know. To be honest, it scares me some.”

“Okay Daddy, I’ll see you tomorrow. Call me if you need to talk.”

“Will do. Thanks Sweetheart! I love you!”

“I love you too Daddy!”

Tess called me around 6:15 and was on her way back from the Reserve Center. She was going by Arthurs and give him the letter and say goodbye to Keller. Then over to Leslie’s to say goodbye to April. Said she would call me when on the way to my house. She warned me that we might not have much time. That depended on how things went with April.

I told her I totally understood. She was pulling in the driveway at Arthurs. She said, “See you soon my love.”

I got her call about 7:30. She was on the way to my house. She pulled in and said, “This has been a long day! Before I forget, here is the list of names and addresses.”

“Have you had anything to eat?”

“Yes, Harriet had fixed dinner and April wanted me to eat with them. I’m sorry honey. I was too tired to call and let you know. I had no appetite and only picked at my food.”

“I thought that would happen, so I’ve fixed you a couple of sandwiches and some chips and a few bottles of water to take on the plane. It would help me if you would come in the bedroom and lay with me for a little bit. I’ll set the alarm for 30 minutes and will wake you up. Trust me. I will not be sleeping, but I have two alarms to make sure you leave here on time.”

I laid on my back and she put her head in the crook of my neck with an arm and one leg drooped over me. She was asleep almost immediately.

I had been thinking about this mission all day and was scared. I had no idea about what these choppers were going to be used for. There was a wide range of possibilities and most all of them were not something I wanted to think about. Why were the best combat helicopter pilots in the Army being assembled for this mission? If it were something routine, any number of pilots could have been called or were available close by. She began to stir.

“Hey Darlin’. You woke up on your own. There’s only about two minutes left on the alarm.”

She rolled over on top of me and kissed me softly and deeply and then we just held each other for a few minutes.

She said, "Let me fill you in on what I know. I am to leave my cell phone here and I was given a disposable one. Don't answer any calls that come into my phone. You can let my family know tomorrow that you have my phone. I have already told everyone that I can't be reached so they shouldn't be surprised."

She continued, "I am to drive my car and arrive at 2100 at a designated motel in Charleston, park in an area in the back, leave the keys on the seat and the car door unlocked. I am to go in the back door which will be unlocked, use the rest room, and go through the front door and get into the back seat of a tan SUV which will be parked out front. All my gear and luggage will have been transferred. That's all I know."

She continued, "There will be no phone calls until after the mission is over. I was given an emergency contact number in case you need to get hold of me. There will be an operator who will relay a message to someone on the mission commander's staff. I think that's everything. Can you think of anything I've forgotten?"

"Did you tell Arthur that you listed me as 'next of kin'?"

"Yes, but since I didn't find out until later about the emergency number, can you tell him when you all talk that you have it?"

"Sure, and I'll give him the number."

"Tell him I told you not to call that number unless it is a true emergency."

She continued, "I'm so sorry Howie. It helps me so much knowing that having been in the Army you understand what's going on. I can't expect anyone else to understand."

"I will do everything I can to help April get through this and will reach out to Keller to see if there is anything I can do for him. Since he is so close to his dad, I don't expect him to respond, but you never know. I'll check in with your mom and dad every couple of days to see if they need anything."

She said, "I forgot to tell you that I called them earlier today and told them about you and described you as a 'close friend'. I told them they wouldn't be able to reach me during the two-week period as I would be on a training assignment. I gave them your number to call in case they need anything."

"Great. Again, I'll check in with them every couple of days."

"Thanks, my love. I hate long goodbyes. Let me get on the road. You know how I feel about you and how much I'll miss you and long to be back in your arms."

"I do my love. I will keep you in my meditations and prayers and please don't worry about anything here. I will take care of things here. You focus all your attention on the training, the mission being safe!"

We wrapped our arms around each other and held each other tight. And one quick kiss and “I love you’s” and she left. As I watched her disappear in the distance, tears spilled over my chin reminding me that I had only had her for a few days and now she was gone again.

I walked down to the edge of the water and in the twilight looked out over the vast expanse and prayed to God, the Universe to bring her back safely to us.

Life Without Tess (Again)

I didn't get much sleep, woke up early and went for a run. I was hoping the run would energize me, but it didn't happen. Fortunately, my first client wasn't scheduled until 11, but my last client didn't leave until five.

I wasn't hungry but ate a bagel with a cup of coffee. I got dressed and went over to the office. The house was too full of memories, and I could still smell her. I had to get focused and make a list of things I needed to do today besides seeing my clients.

Called mom and dad and gave them the news. Then I called Henry.

"Hey Henry, it's me."

"Can't wait to hear all about your weekend,"

"That will have to come later." I gave him the news.

"How you doin'?"

"Okay, it's just I keep thinking, 'What if I lose her again?' I've just gotta get Centered and deal with this one moment/day at a time. I keep telling myself it's just for two weeks, but then the thought about 'special ops' keeps raising it's head and the fact that for this mission, they needed the best helicopter crews in the Army for this job. What does that mean? And I keep thinking it must be dangerous requiring the best soldiers they've got."

"Do you want me to come out right now?"

"No, but thanks Henry. I'll be okay. I have clients till five and then Si is coming out around 5:30. Would you be able to come out for an early breakfast in the morning like around 7:30?"

"Yes, that'll work. Give me a call before in the morning if you need me."

"Will do my friend. Thanks for offering. Also, keep me on your schedule for Friday lunch."

"You got it. Take care Howie. See you in the morning."

I made a note to go see Mom and Dad after lunch with Henry on Friday. I decided to call Arthur tonight after Si left and arrange a time for him to visit. After work on Wednesday, call Tess's mom and dad. So glad I was writing all this down.

I had about an hour until my first appointment. I needed to get Centered. As I walked up the beach, I felt this incredible heaviness in my chest. It's like my heart hurt. It seemed like a combination of fear and anxiety. There were all these unknowns, and the greatest was no clue what she was going to be doing on this mission. I couldn't erase the facts that this was a special ops mission and why did

they need the best combat helicopter pilots in the Army? I could think of no other reason than it was a highly dangerous mission.

I reached my sanctuary and started the deep breathing. Several minutes into it, an image exploded in my mind that she was killed. I yelled at the top of my lungs, “NO NO NO, THAT’S NOT GOING TO HAPPEN!!! PLEASE GOD, DON’T LET THAT HAPPEN!!!! I buried my face in my hands and sobbed!

I don’t know how long it was before I calmed down. I looked at my watch and had about 30 minutes before my first session. I had about ten minutes before I had to get back to the office.

I set my watch and closed my eyes and started some slow easy deep breaths and focused the rest of my attention on the sound of the waves. My favorite verse in the Bible is, “Be still and know that I am your God.” I had taught hundreds of clients that it is in the stillness that we find the “peace of God that passes all understanding.” It is in the stillness that we find that all our angst, stress, pain, fear...is transformed/transmuted into peace, joy, bliss, love, acceptance....

I knew that meditation was the only hope I had for staying Centered and being present for the people who needed me during these two weeks and for my own health and wellness. I opened my eyes and made that commitment to be conscious and focused on my goals.

I did pretty good with all my clients. I finished my client notes and got over to the house about 5:20. I had not heard from Si so I knew she would be arriving shortly. I took a quick sponge bath, changed into some shorts and a tee shirt and heard her come in the house.

“Daddy!?”

“Hey honey, I’ll be right out. Pour yourself a glass of wine.!”

“Will do! Do you want me to pour you one?”

“Yes, thanks!”

We exchanged a hug, and she held on for a few more seconds than usual.

I asked, “How are Roger and the kids?”

“There’re fine. Roger told me to stay as long as I wanted to and that he would give the kids their bath and put them to bed.”

“You sure picked a good one honey, and I might say he is lucky too.”

“Thanks. Daddy, I’ve been worried about you.”

“Thanks honey. After just finding Tess, it’s hard to let her go.”

“I can’t imagine.”

You wanna sit out on the deck?”

“Sure.”

“I had a good meditation this morning and feel better. When I remind myself and practice staying Centered, I’m able to focus on the moment and

remember Julian of Norwich, ‘All things shall be well, all manner of things shall be well’.”

She smiled, “I got it. I’m trying to remember that every day. You taught me well!”

“You and I have taught each other many things.”

“It sounds like from what you said that Tess’s ‘call up’ was unexpected and somewhat puzzling.”

“Yes, and she was not allowed to talk about it and she didn’t know much anyway.”

“I won’t ask any more questions.”

“I wouldn’t know the answers even if you did.”

Smiling, “As soon as you called me on Saturday to let me know what happened on Friday night, I’ve been full of curiosity wondering about the details and what happened and how the weekend went. Do you feel like talking about it?”

“Yeah, that’s fine. I can’t promise but you may see a few tears.”

“I can handle it if you can.”

“I can. Did I tell you how it started?”

“No, you just gave me a quick overview. I remember you told me that you had taken flowers on Friday and had to put them on the front stoop because April told you to ‘go away’.”

“I had tried to call her all week and April always answered and even though I was desperate to talk to Tess, I had to smile at her humorous strategy to keep me away from her mom. I told you about confessing my love for her earlier in the week and how angry and hurt she was that I had not told her earlier.”

“Yes, I remember.”

“I found out later that when she got up the next morning, she had gotten over her anger and calmed down and realized that I loved her as much as she loved me. It was at that point she and April decided to make me pay. I tried all week to reach her and April always intervened.”

“How old is April?”

“She’s fourteen and acts like she’s eighteen. She and her mom are very close. She is a hoot and loves to tease. When I was calling last week, she told me her mom was in Charleston visiting an old boyfriend. I said, ‘if she is in Charleston, how come you have her phone?’ and she said, ‘none of your business’ and hung up. All the time, they were having great fun. So, taking the flowers was my last attempt on Friday. I would have never given up. I knew by that time that she loved me too, so it was just a matter of time.”

I continued, “So around eight on Friday, I was exhausted and laid down to take a nap. During my nap, I was dreaming and heard this pounding, and it wouldn’t stop. I was dazed but suddenly realized that the pounding was on my

front door. I opened it and there was Tess standing in the pouring rain and without a word, she threw herself into my arms.”

“Oh Daddy, how romantic! Tell me more.”

For over an hour, I told her everything I could remember leaving out only the intimate details of our lovemaking. She had a lot of questions and I loved telling the story. I teared up a few times which was fine for both of us.

“I am so happy for you. I know you loved mama, but this is a different kind of love.”

“I’m not sure if I ever believed in ‘soul mates’ but now there is no question in my mind.”

“Me too Daddy. Roger and I are ‘soul mates.’”

“I know Honey. It’s easy to see. Well, we forgot to eat.”

She said, “It would have been a distraction.”

“Would you like something now?”

“Sure, just a sandwich or something light. I need to get going soon.”

We ate our sandwiches, and she brought me up to date on the kid’s activities and a trip they went on last weekend.

“Let me help you with these dishes.”

“No Honey, you go on.

We hugged and she whispered, “I’m so happy for you and let me know if there’s anything I can do. Please visit us more than usual and I’ll call and check on you every day.”

“Thanks Honey. I love you!”

“I love you too Daddy!”

I cleaned up the kitchen and then called Lance and let him know the situation. He was happy for me and said he would pray for Tess’s safe return. He hoped to get back for a visit sometime in September. I asked about his mom and granddad, and they were both doing well.

I wasn’t looking forward to calling Arthur. I can’t imagine that he thought I had anything to do with their divorce. He had the affair with Holly when Tess was in Afghanistan and married her after the divorce.

I called him, “Hello Arthur, this is Howard Kingston.”

“Tess said you would call.”

“Right, I wondered if we could meet in the next day or two?”

“Tess said that April wanted to spend some time at your house while she is gone. I’m not happy with the idea since I don’t know you.”

“If you don’t want her to visit me while Tess is gone, I understand.”

Silence. “Give me some time to think about it. I could come out to your place and we could talk. Did you have a day in mind?”

“Yes, I was hoping you could come on tomorrow evening at any time that works for you.”

“That sounds good. How about around 5:30?”

“That’s fine.” I gave him some general directions and my address.

I was glad to have that conversation over. I suspected based on what Tess said that he would not agree if Holly wanted April to stay with them. Apparently, she managed to tolerate April only on the weekends and apparently the feeling was mutual. He was in a tough spot. I felt for him.

It was time to check in with April.

“Hey April, how you doin’?”

“Who is this?”

“Wanted to let you know I got a new shipment of grass seed in.”

Starting to cry, “I’ll take ten bags...Howie, what am I gonna do?”

“We’re all going to get through this.”

“What does that mean?”

“That we’re going to take one moment at a time and carry on with our lives the best we can.”

Still crying, “How do we do that?”

“With the support of our family and friends.”

“Aren’t you going to tell me everything will be okay?”

“I think you know how much I love your mama. I keep telling myself she’ll be fine. She’ll come back to us safe and well. I hope and pray she will, but no one can know the future.”

Still crying, “But that’s not helping me.”

“I know. It might be helpful to remember that when she left you last time, it was for a year and this time, it’s only two weeks. And we don’t know what she’s doing, but there is no war right now our country is involved in and that brings me some comfort.”

Still crying, “How much comfort?”

“More than if she were going to Afghanistan.”

Sniffling, “I wanna come to your house. I know mama was with you the last three days and it will make me feel closer to her.”

“I talked to your dad tonight and he is going to come over to my house tomorrow so we can meet and talk about you spending time over here.”

Normal voice, “What time is he coming?”

“5:30.”

“If Dad agrees, can Leslie and I spend the night with you tomorrow and Thursday?”

“April, it’s fine with me, but Leslie’s mom would also have to agree.”

“I’m gonna call dad and talk to Leslie’s mom and see if they will agree to let us spend the night both nights. I know I will have to go home on Friday, but my plan is to have dad bring me to your house on Monday morning and can I stay with you until Friday?”

“April, I suggest you focus for now on tomorrow and Thursday. We can see how this works for everyone. Then we can talk about next week.”

“Okay, you do know Leslie is leaving on a family vacation on Monday?”

“Yes, your mama told me.”

“Can I call you in an hour or so?”

“Yes.”

She called back and said, “I talked to Dad, and I had to beg him, and he finally said he would call me on the way home after talking to you and would let me know. He said he would only consider Thursday night but not Wednesday. I talked to Leslie’s mom, and she agreed with dad on just Thursday night. She wanted to bring us out around noon on Thursday if that’s okay and dad will pick us up on Friday after work and take Leslie to her house. Leslie’s mom is a good friend with one of your former clients and the client vouched for you so she will meet you when she brings us out on Thursday. How does that sound?”

“Wait a minute....I checked my schedule and I have a session at noon, but have an hour free after that. Ask her if she could bring you all at one.”

“Hold on....she said that would work.”

“Are you feeling better?”

“Yes, a little.”

“Is there anything else you wanna talk about?”

“Not really. Can I call you if I need to talk?”

“Perfectly fine. Oh, when I call you tomorrow night, I need a grocery list of things you all want to eat. I’ll go to the store before my workday starts.”

“Will do. Thanks Howie.! I’m gonna put in a good word for you at the hardware store.”

“Thanks, that will help. I’ve asked the owner for a raise. Hope you sleep well. Remember to call me if you wanna talk.”

“Okay, I will.”

I went for a walk, but only got to the edge of the water. The moon was out and the light shining on the water was as beautiful as ever. Tears started welling up and I turned around and went back to the house. I vacuumed, put in some laundry, and changed the sheets on the guest room bed. I needed to stay busy. I wasn’t going to change my sheets for a while. PJ was following me around and I realized I had neglected both of them after lunch yesterday. After I had gotten a few more things done, I picked up both cats and sat on the sofa petting them and watching some mindless TV. I fell asleep and woke up around midnight. Both kitties

followed me in the bedroom and even GJ stayed. I needed them. They knew something was wrong.”

I woke up around 6:00 after another restless night. I went for a run up to the end of the island and back to my sanctuary. I did a Centering meditation with moderate success. I thought how easy it is to forget what I teach. ‘My suggestion is to avoid expectations about your meditations and for everything else, do the same.’ I took some deep breaths, said a prayer, and started back home.

Henry arrived about 7:30. I met him at his truck,
He got out, gave me a hug saying “Hey bro. How you holdin’ up?”
“Pretty good.”
“You look like shit.”
“I avoid looking in the mirror.”
“Stay with that plan. It’s not good. I brought donuts for me and bagels for you.”

I asked, “Are you hungry?”

“Sure.”

“The coffee’s ready.”

“Sounds good.”

We got our food and sat out on the deck.

“What I’m feeling right now is similar to so many of those conversations we had at Susie’s while I was seeing Tess in therapy and then during the two years wait. This is of course worse. Now, I’m afraid I’m going to lose her knowing what we have together.”

“So, you think this mission is going to be dangerous?”

“Why would they need the best helicopter pilots in the Army?”

“Good point. Bro, we’ve talked about what to do when you’re facing this kind of situation. Be your own therapist? Right?”

“Yeah, I know. I’ve already decided what I need to do and have already started practicing the skills that will help me get Centered. You and Si provide an important part of this by being good listeners.”

“You got it. Now tell me about this past weekend. I have bits and pieces of what happened, but I want the whole story.”

While I talked, we had another cup of coffee. As usual Henry was a good listener as we have always been able to lean on each other. Whether it was Henry’s issue with work or Jill’s alcoholism or my issues with the divorce and with Tess, we have always been there for each other. The friendship has always been solid.

When I finished, he said, “That’s quite a story. I know you’re nervous about this mission, but you may be blowing it out of proportion. There’s not much going

on today except looking for terrorists and that's overseas. They have people already in place for that. If she had been deployed for six months, that would be another story."

"I know and that helps some, but I'm just so afraid of losing her after all this time. What also helps is that I have a lot to do while she's gone."

I told him about April and how she responded when Tess told her about leaving."

"She's the kid that jerked you around after you told Tess how you felt about her, right?"

"Yes, and even though it was frustrating, I had fun bantering back and forth with her and found out later that Tess was in the background the whole time and they were having a blast jerking me around."

I went into some detail about what was said and how that went.

"Anyway, we met in person for the first time Monday when she came over here for lunch with Tess. It was during lunch that Tess got the call. So, she doesn't get along with her stepmother and she wants to spend some of the time with me. She also told me that her mama had spent three days with me before she left, and it would make her feel closer to her."

I told him the plan so far and how we were handling the logistics.

"Fortunately, I've got a full case load of clients today and tomorrow. I'll be looking after Tess's house, visiting her parents on Saturday who live in Centerville, spending time with April, projects here at the house, the usual chores, visiting Si, Roger and the kids and mom and dad and lunch with you on Fridays. Oh, by the way, I think April will be with me on Friday. Do you mind if I bring her to lunch?"

"No, that would be fine. Do you think she'll want to 'hang' with us?"

"Not particularly, but it will beat 'hanging' with her stepmother."

"I'm gonna need to get going soon but would like a walk on the beach first. I've got a long day ahead and wanna get my bare feet in the water."

"Sounds good. All we've talked about is my stuff. How is Jill doing?"

"She's doing great. AA has really helped her. I don't think I've ever seen her this happy. I have to admit though, sometimes I worry that she will relapse, but before you say anything, I'm doing the best I can to focus on the moment."

"Good for you! How are Hank and Pearl? They are both doing well. Hank is working for me. I've got him running errands and Jake is also teaching him some carpentry skills. Pearl is doing a lot of babysitting and making pretty good money. They still spend one week with their mom and one week with Jill and me and it's working well."

"You're so fortunate they get along so well with Jill."

“I am. I just thought about our lunch on Friday. Why don’t I bring Hank with me, and he can meet April? How old is April?”

“She’ll be fifteen in September.”

“As you know, he is sixteen, but he is kind of shy around girls.”

“From what Tess has told me, she wishes April were a little more shy around boys.”

“Whatta you think?”

“Let’s bring them if they’ll agree to come.”

“Hank won’t have a choice if he wants lunch.”

“April, I think will be fine with it.”

I was sad to see Henry leave. He left with his usual phrase, “Call me if you need to talk.”

My first client was at ten with an hour for lunch and I finished at five. It was a blessing to be busy.

Soon after my last client, I called Tess’s mom and dad. It was a little awkward at first, but soon the conversation was very comfortable. They were both very nice and appreciated me calling. I asked them if I could visit them on Saturday and they seemed pleased. I told them I would check in on Friday night to get directions and finalize plans.

I cleaned up the dishes and gave April a quick call. “How you doin’?”

“Fair, Leslie and I had fun yesterday, but I couldn’t stop thinking about mama wondering where she was and what she was doing. I teared up a couple of times, but I’m trying to accept what’s goin’ on the best I can.”

“Good for you. I’m working on doing the same thing. Have you and Leslie decided what you want for dinner tomorrow night and breakfast on Friday?”

“Yes.” She read me the list.

“Is Harriet still going to pick Leslie up around ten Friday morning?”

“Yes.”

“Got it. Is there anything else you want to talk about?”

“Not really.”

“You know you can call me anytime, right?”

“Yeah.”

“Okay, is Harriet close by?”

“Yeah.”

“Ask her if she is free to talk to me or I could call her later.”

“Hold on.”

“Hello Howard.”

“Hi Harriet, I don’t think we’ve met.”

“No, we haven’t but I do have a close friend who was one of your clients.”

“I hope that was helpful. I kind of needed that personal reference since April wants Leslie to spend the night at my house tomorrow night.

“He really liked you, so when I bring the girls over tomorrow, we can talk, and you can show me around.”

“I haven’t met Arthur yet either and he is coming over today around 5:30. Would it be convenient to bring the girls over tomorrow around 6:30? If everything goes well, I will fix supper for them and feed them breakfast on Friday morning.”

“I need to pick Leslie up around ten. We have some errands to run. Did Tess tell you we are going on vacation next week?”

“Yes, she did.”

“Well, let me run on. We’ll see you around 6:30 tomorrow. Do you want to speak to April?”

“Yes, please. Thanks, and see you tomorrow.”

“Hey.”

“Your mama wanted you to check in with your dad every day. Just checking to see if you had called him?”

“No, I’ll call him now.”

“Okay, see you tomorrow.”

Arthur was due to arrive at 5:30. I had a few minutes to get a couple of chores done. I heard a vehicle approaching. I went outside and walked over to his vehicle.

Reaching out to shake his hand, “Hello Arthur, nice to meet you.”

He smiled, “Nice to meet you too, I think.”

Smiling back, “Got it. Would you like me to show you around?”

“Sure.”

I told him about the history of the preserve and then pointed to my office.”

“Must be nice to have your workplace so close to where you live.”

“Yes, my office was in town for a long time and it’s great having it here.”

“My office is in Charleston and the drive helps me shift gears and I enjoy the drive. The scenery is beautiful.”

“Your job may be more stressful than mine.”

“I don’t know. Sitting and hearing people’s problems sounds very stressful to me.”

“Sometimes, depending on the client, that can be true, but if I remember I can’t fix people, most of the time there’s not much stress.”

“But isn’t that your job?”

“It’s semantics. My approach when I’m paying attention is to help people find within themselves the answers to their questions and then help them design a

plan or path to healing and feeling better. My last job is to teach them the skills they need to make it happen.”

His tone slightly shifted, “Is that what you did with Tess?”

“Yes, I hope so.”

“And in the process, you fell in love with her.”

Surprised to some extent, but not totally. “Would you like a beer or a glass of wine?”

“Not really, but you look like you could use one.”

“You’re right, I could use one.”

With a slight grin, “Actually, I could use one too. I’m not in the running for ‘husband of the decade’.”

“That’s a relief. Let me show you around the inside of house and then we can have our beers.”

“Sounds like a plan.”

I showed him around the house and introduced him to PJ and explained that GJ was hiding.

“When April and Tess were here for lunch on Monday, April and GJ bonded and the only human GJ likes besides me is my daughter Si.”

“I’m not surprised. April loves animals.”

We got our beers and sat on the deck.

“Are there any questions you would like to ask me?”

“Not really. Tess has told me some about you and she of course thinks you are this incredible person. I admit I was skeptical when it seemed like you had violated an ethical code, but when I got the whole story, it appears like the only question was related to falling in love with her while she was under your care. I talked to a friend of mine who is a therapist and she said you should have referred her when you realized what was happening.”

“I should have.”

“She also said by waiting over two years after the last session before any contact with her was within the ethical code’s stipulation. She said if you had contact with Tess before the two years and she knew about it, she would have reported you to the South Carolina Board of Licensure.”

“She would have been in trouble if she hadn’t done that.”

“I didn’t tell her your name, but it’s a small town. She may have figured it out.”

“Probably so.”

“You probably know that you had no part in our divorce. I fell in love with Holly while Tess was in Afghanistan and I’m certainly not proud of that.”

I didn’t know what to say.

He continued, "I've talked to a few people I know and the ones that know you say you're a nice guy. I am, however, reluctant to allow April to stay with you and wish I had an alternative. The timing for Harriet and family to take a vacation is unfortunate for me. I'm sure Tess told you that April and Holly don't get along. Both are head strong women."

I wanted to interject that April is still a child, but he knows that, and April is mature way beyond her age in some respects. I can imagine them clashing.

He went on, "Anyway, here is what I will agree to. April can spend the night here with Leslie if Harriet agrees. I ask you to bring April home Friday by five and I will drop her off here on the way to work on Monday. She can stay here until Friday but must continue to call me every day. I'm asking you also to call me every day. She is not to leave the premises under any circumstances without you checking with me first. She is not to go in her mother's house except to get clothes and again must be accompanied by you. I'm sure there are some things I have forgotten but I will call you if I can think of anything else. Before I arrived here, I talked to her about these conditions, and she agreed. Do you agree with all the above?"

"Yes, it's all fine with me and if she does break the agreement, I will let you know."

"I need to go. I assume that Harriet will let Leslie spend the night here. If I don't hear from you, I will assume Harriet agrees with the plan."

"Sounds good."

"Thanks for the beer and I thank you allowing April to stay with you."

We shook hands and he left.

I called April and let her know that everything went well with her dad. She seemed relieved. I asked, "How you doin'?"

"It's helped being with Leslie. We enjoy being together. I teared up a few times, but like you said, I'm trying to stay in the moment."

"As you know, tears are okay. Work has kept my eyes dry, but I can't promise anything after I hang up."

"Got it. Leslie is calling me. I'll see you tomorrow,"

Another restless night. Got in my run and meditation and then left to go see mom and dad. On the way back, I stopped at Winn Dixie and picked up food for April and Leslie and picked enough food and supplies for the next week. Then I went by to check on Tess's house. Watered the plants and then headed to the house.

My first client was at ten and I fit in a client who was struggling during my lunch hour and didn't finish until five. Harriet came at 6:30 and after a brief conversation, she agreed to let Leslie stay with April.

“Why don’t you show Leslie around?”

She said, “Okay. I told Leslie all about PJ and GJ.”

“Did you tell her that GJ doesn’t like strangers?”

“Yes, she might be okay since we made friends before Mama left.”

“Maybe so. I’ve got a few things to do at the office and will be back shortly.”

They were already heading to the house.

When I came back, GJ was cuddled up on April’s lap and PJ was on Leslie’s lap.

We talked about supper, and they wanted to go for a walk on the beach. I told them to be back in 30 minutes. We ate supper and they talked about different topics teenagers liked to talk about. I remembered the days with Lance and Si when they were growing up.

I asked them to help me with the dishes and soon after that, they went to the bedroom. I read and watched a little TV and then went to bed. The talking had died down by then and it was quiet. The cats were with the girls, and I was glad they had some other people to spend time with. I knew they were getting a lot of attention.

I laid there for a while and thought about Tess. Today would have been her third day of training. I wondered when the mission was scheduled. I couldn’t get out of my mind that it was going to be dangerous.

I woke up in the morning and it was quiet. I passed on my run and did my meditation on the deck. I missed being at my sanctuary but didn’t feel comfortable leaving the girls. April wandered out to the deck around 8:30 and said Leslie was still asleep.

I asked, “How did you sleep?”

“Not good. I had trouble getting to sleep and kept waking up and thinking about Mama. Leslie has helped to distract me, but she’s leaving at 10.” She starts to tear up. “And then I’m going back to dad’s house later today and I don’t feel comfortable around Holly.”

“What would your mama tell you to do?”

“She would say Holly is a nice person and you need to give her a chance.”

“Do you feel like you haven’t done that?”

Pause. “Probably not.”

“Are you willing to give it another try?”

“I guess I don’t have much choice.”

“I think that would help your dad feel better. He is really worried about you and it took a lot for him to give you permission to stay with me. He remembers how hard it was on you when your mama left for Afghanistan.”

“How did you know about that?”

“Your mama told me when she was in therapy.”

“If I wasn’t all worried about mama, I would say something like, ‘so you fell in love with mama and now you’re giving out what is supposed to be confidential information. Your ethics suck and you need to turn yourself in.’”

“What would I do?”

“You could try to get your old job back at the Hardware store, but as I remember it, you weren’t doing really well there either. You were always trying to sell mama grass seed when you knew her front yard was mostly concrete.”

Before I could answer, Leslie came out on the deck. “What are you two talking about? What’s this about grass seed?”

April said, “You don’t wanna know. It’s complicated.”

“Okay girls, how about some breakfast?”

Leslie had a good appetite, but April just picked at her food. When finished, they took the cats and went back to the bedroom. I did some inside chores and was working on an outside project when Harriet pulled up.

She got out and asked, “How did it go with the girls?”

“They were no trouble at all.”

The girls came out and Leslie put her backpack in the car.

Harriet turned to April, “Honey, I talked with your dad last night and told him you were welcome to come on our vacation with us.”

Leslie interrupted, “Oh April, please come with us. We would have so much fun.”

She paused. “Thanks so much for the offer, but I’m not sure when mama will be home and I wanna be here when she does. Also, Howie is her contact and I need to stay close, but thanks so much for asking.”

April and Leslie hugged, and they left.

As we watched them pull away, I could see from the side that tears were rolling down her cheeks. She turned and without looking up at me, she took a couple of steps and rested the side of her head on my chest and put her arms around my waist and said, “I’m scared.”

I put my arms gently around her shoulders and said, “I know. I’m scared too. I believe and teach any of my clients who will listen, ‘All things shall be well, all manner of things shall be well’.”

“What does that mean?”

“I think different things to different people, but it means to me that whatever happens I will figure out a way to accept it and move on with my life.”

“That’s not comforting.”

“A therapist friend would say, ‘Put that in your pocket for later’.”

“Say something that will help me.”

“Well, there are several possible ways to respond. ‘Your mama will be fine; try not to worry.’ ‘God will watch over your mama.’ ‘Whatever happens will be God’s will.’ ‘Whatever happens, God will help you through it.’ ‘Just pray for your mama’s safety’.”

“Those don’t work either.”

“The most difficult part of this situation is that we don’t know what’s going to happen. So, we are left with whatever comfort we can find in those phrases I just mentioned.”

“I know. I think I’ll go inside and lay down with PJ and GJ.”

“Good plan. Remember, we’re having lunch with Henry at noon. I’ll come and get you when it’s time to go.”

“Can’t we cancel?”

“We could, but I need this time with Henry in some ways just like you needed time with Leslie. I think you already know this, but your mama is the woman I’ve always dreamed of finding and now that I have found her, losing her terrifies me. We’re both terrified of losing the person we love most in the world.”

“What about, ‘All manner of things shall be well?’”

“Just like you, that phrase is not helping me much right now.”

“Put it in your pocket for later.” She continued, “Can I sit at another table while you’re talking to Henry? I can’t stand to see adult’s cry.”

Smiling, “Of course you can. I was going to ask you to do that anyway.”

She went inside.

When we arrived at Susie’s, Henry and Henry, Jr were waiting for us.

April pulled at my sleeve and whispered, “You didn’t tell me he was going to be here.”

I turned my head toward her and whispered, “Sorry, I didn’t remember.”

Sarcastically. “Right!!”

Hugging Henry, “Henry, glad to see you, my friend!” Reaching over to shake hands with Henry, Jr, “Hank, glad to see you, my man!”

“Good to see you too, Dr. K.”

“Henry, this is Tess’s daughter, April.”

April asked, “Aren’t you the guy that works at the hardware store with Howie and came and offered to help fix up our house.?”

“Well April, you have a great memory. Actually, Howie works for me at the hardware. I own it.”

“Well, he needs some training in customer service. He has been trying to sell my mama some grass seed on a surface that won’t grow grass.”

“It’s not all his fault. I’ve been pushing him pretty hard. He has a quota to sell 100 bags of grass seed in the next week. If he doesn’t pull that off, he’ll have to go back to his old job of being a therapist.”

She countered. “He’s in trouble in that job too for ethical violations.”

He held up his fist to April and she tapped with her own and they smiled at each other.

Henry said, “April, I’d like you to meet my son Hank.”

Hank said, “Dad, we already kind of know each other. Her brother, Keller and I are on the football team although I’ve only seen April around school. We have never met. Hey April.”

Slight smile, “Hey Hank, I’ve seen you around school too.”

Henry said, “Would you all mind eating lunch at another table so Howie and I can talk.”

Hank and April in unison, “Sure.”

I could see April was a little uncomfortable, but she didn’t hesitate to leave us.

Henry said, “I can see what you mean. She is a hoot.”

“Tess loves to tease so that’s where she learned it.”

We looked over at them and they were looking at the menu and it was quiet.

Henry turned back to me, “How you doin’?”

“Not so good. I’ve heard nothing of course, but I can’t shake this overwhelming feeling that she’s in danger.”

We talked for a half hour or so and Henry was always able to help me with getting more Centered and dealing with the reality of a situation. It was in the same way I had talked with April. There is only so much to be said: We can’t know the future and we’ll deal with whatever happens with acceptance and taking one moment at a time. And he reiterated of course that he would support and help me along the way.

We glanced over at their table, and they were laughing about something.

Henry said, “Well that looks like it’s going well.”

“Yes, it is. April’s best friend is leaving town on vacation, and I don’t get the impression she has another close friend. It’s good to see her laughing.”

Henry and I spent the rest of lunch talking about family news and work news. Big news being that Jill is still sober and going to AA.

He said, “I need to go. Got a meeting in about 30 minutes.” We could see they were finished eating. He waved at Hank, and we met them at the door.

We said our goodbyes and left.

Walking to the truck, April asked, “Do I have to go to Dad’s yet?”

“No, I told him I would drop you off around five. Would you like to go by your house? I told your mama I’d check on it every day.”

“Yes, I was going to ask you if we could do that. I need clothes and a shower.”

April went to her room while I checked on the plants made sure everything was okay. I went out on the deck and put my feet up. The next thing I knew, April was calling me. “Howie, it’s time to go.”

“What time is it?”

“4:30.”

“I must have dosed off.”

“How about passed out. I checked on you a couple of times and you were ‘out of it’ and snoring. Not a pretty sight.”

“Got it. We better head on.”

I decided it was a good idea to go in and meet Holly and Keller. Arthur wasn’t home yet. We exchanged some pleasantries and I left. They both seemed nice.

Si had invited me to dinner, so I went straight there. Si and I had a nice chat and I played with Chase and Dottie. We ate when Roger got home and sat on their deck for a while and as always enjoyed being together. Roger said he would put the kids to bed so Si and I could talk.

“How are you really doing Daddy?”

“Trying to stay Centered and of course not sleeping well.”

“How is it going with April?”

“So far, it’s going fine. We haven’t spent much time together with Leslie being there last night. I think I told you her dad will bring her over on Monday morning. We’ll be together all next week until Friday.”

“Do you think Tess will be back before then?”

“I wish I knew. She initially said it would be two weeks but also said it could be longer. She didn’t at that time have a clue.”

“Roger is going to take the kids in the morning to see his mom and dad and won’t be back till midafternoon. I’d like to come out and spend time with you.”

“Honey, that would be great.”

“I’ll plan to get there around ten.”

“Thank you!”

We hugged and I left.

Hanging on to Hope

I went home and went for a run and stopped on the way back at the sanctuary and did my meditation. I continued to work on integrating my Centered thinking asking the Universe to put a protective bubble around her and keep her safe and then I imagined that in my mind.

I had decided a long time ago to stop asking God for favors, but at times I just couldn't resist. I believe things happen and the circumstances are dictated by mysteries that are way beyond my comprehension. I won't make God small by pretending to comprehend I know how it all works. I do believe that if something happens to Tess, God, the Universe will sustain me through the experience, and I will eventually be able to accept it. I do believe, "All things shall be well, all manner of things shall be well."

Si came out in the morning, and we had some good talks. I left around two to visit Tess's mom and dad. I really like them. I told them everything I knew, and they were of course very worried about her safe return. I promised to visit them next weekend if Tess was not back and if she was back, we would visit a few days after she returned.

Henry was spending the weekend with Jill's family. I went to Larry's and sat at the bar chatting with Pete and eventually, Larry came out to say hello. He couldn't stay but a minute as the restaurant was packed. I left about 9:30. I watched a little TV and fell asleep and woke up around seven.

I followed my usual routine and stayed busy all day with projects around the house. Had a restless night and woke up around three. I couldn't get back to sleep so I went for a walk on the beach. The breeze made it a little chilly, but the moon was beautiful. I sat in the sanctuary, meditated, and then went back to the house. I dosed on the sofa and woke up around 6:30. Arthur arrived with April around eight.

She hugged her dad and he said, "Be sure to call me every day."

We both waved as he left.

She asked, "Are you off today?"

"Yes, what would you like to do?"

We walked over to the deck. She asked, "Could I have a water?"

"Sure and help yourself to anything in the kitchen to eat or drink. You don't have to ask."

"How about the wine?"

Smiling, "When it comes to alcohol, pretend you're asking your dad."

When she sat down, she said, "I've had a lot of nightmares about Mama all three nights I was home. I feel alone most of the time I am there and it's no one's fault. Holly tries to be nice, and Keller and I talked some about Mama. And dad was attentive. I don't know. I think it's just me."

"In what way?"

"Are you gonna be my 'shrink'?"

"Not unless you want me to, but just so you know, I'm also a good listener."

Smiling, "Good, 'cause I don't want it on my record that I had a shrink who also worked in a hardware store selling grass seed."

I laughed. "I got it. Now, that would be embarrassing!"

"I think I just need to let go of this whole 'Holly/Dad thing while Mama was in Afghanistan fighting a war.'"

"Okay so some hurt and anger are still hanging around. Sometimes imprints like that are really challenging."

"That sounds like a shrink response." Pause, "You know I'm just kidding."

Smiling, "I do, and I think it's your nature to kid around and in some ways, I think it works for you."

"Whatta ya mean?"

"I think you know what I mean."

Pause. "Right now, it helps me not think about Mama." Pause. "It's been a week today and we haven't heard anything. You were in the Army; do you think that's a bad sign?"

"Your mama said she was told it was a two-week assignment so that's a good sign."

"Do you have any idea what this is about?"

"Not a clue. It could be any number of things."

"Could any of those things be dangerous?"

"April, all I know is that your mama had no clue when she left."

"Why hasn't she at least called me?"

"There are any number of reasons and I think for both of us, it's best to believe that she has a good reason and not to jump to any unnecessary conclusions."

"Okay, I need to change the subject. Hank came over to visit Keller yesterday afternoon. Whatta you think about that Howie?"

"Has he ever visited Keller before?"

"No, but they are friends and play football together."

"What's your 'take' on it?"

Smiling, "I think he came to see me."

"How come?"

“The three of us were together all afternoon on Saturday. And that’s never happened. Keller and I aren’t very close. I guess it’s our age difference. I think that’s suspicious.”

Smiling, “Me too.”

“I like Hank. He’s nice.”

“I’ve been around him all his life. He’s a good kid.”

“I think I’ll go get PJ and GJ and cuddle up with them on the bed and try to get some sleep. I’m tired. I wanted to tell you ‘Thanks’ for letting me stay with you this week.”

“You’re welcome. It’s nice having you here. We can miss your mama together. Remember to make yourself at home. I’m going to go for a run and then have some work to do in the office. Come and get me when you’re ready for lunch. Let me know if you decide to walk on the beach.”

We both stood up and she came over and gave me a hug and started crying.

“I’m so worried about Mama.”

“I know Honey, me too.”

The days passed slowly. Si had invited us to eat with them that night. April seemed to have a good time playing with Chase and Dottie. She was really good with them. She and Si spent some girl time in the kitchen, and it was obvious they bonded. When we were getting ready to leave, Si and April hugged, and the tears were flowing. I knew Si could feel her fear and pain.

Over the next three days, Si and April were on the phone numerous times. On Tuesday, Si had a break from work and took April to lunch. She had a surprise visit from Keller and Hank on Wednesday afternoon. Between clients, I looked out the window and they were sunbathing and talking and seemed to be having a good time. At one point during a short break, I didn’t hear them or see them, and I got a little worried, but the next break I could see them again.

After my last client, they were still there, and I invited them to stay for a cook out. They stayed and had fun joking around. When they left, April was tired and kissed me on the cheek and went to bed with PJ and GJ. As she was walking toward the bedroom, I asked, “Have you talked with your dad today?”

She answered, “No I forgot. Thanks for reminding me, I’ll call him now.”

The next morning before I started work, I got a call from Hank, and he asked me if he could come over and see April. I asked him if he had talked with April and he said he had. I told him that April would have to ask her dad and that I would have her call him and let him know what her dad said.

As I was hanging up, April walked in the kitchen. “You were talking to Hank, right?”

“Yes, you’ll need to check with your dad about him coming over.”

“Okay.”

“If I were your dad, I would not agree unless I was at the house and not at my office. I had two cancellations today and they were my eleven and one o’clock so I will be at the house from eleven to two. We could have lunch together.”

She smiled, “Thanks Howie.”

She came back about five minutes later smiling and said he agreed he could come from 11:30 to 1:30.

“Sounds like a plan. I’ll fix lunch and you all can eat out on the deck.”

Smiling, “Thanks Howie” and she gave me a quick hug.

The afternoon went well as April had a distraction with Hank. I could see them from the office window talking and laughing. I saw them once swimming and splashing each other. After my last client, I was glad to have the work week behind me.

We walked over to Larry’s for supper. On the way back, I asked her about Hank.

“I like him. He has been very supportive about mama and allowed me to talk about it and then helped me to talk about some other things like my friends, my hobbies and stuff like that. He didn’t talk much about himself and seemed to be more interested in getting to know me. He has not kissed me or made any moves. I admit I wouldn’t have minded if he kissed me even though I have never kissed a boy.”

“As I said earlier, he’s a good kid. Very polite and respectful. How would you feel about talking to Si about the kissing thing?”

“I already have, and I wasn’t asking you for advice, I was just telling you I’ve been thinking about it and I already know what you would tell me.”

“What would I say?”

“You would tell me to please put that on hold till your mama gets back.”

“Bingo. But I’m glad you like him.”

We walked on in silence and when we got to the house, she said, “It’s been 10 days. I sure hope we hear from Mama soon.”

“Me too.”

We watched some TV and then she went to bed. I could hear her talking to someone and guessed it was Hank. An hour or so later, I went to bed and PJ and GJ must be with April. I missed them sleeping with me. It took me an hour or so to get to sleep and even after getting to sleep, I was restless.

At some point later in the night, the phone rang. Every night I had been fearful the phone would ring. I knew it would only ring if something was wrong. Tess would never call in the middle of the night because she knew how much it

would scare me. I grabbed it fearful that it would wake April. I checked to make sure my door was shut all the way. I was shaking so bad it was hard to stand up.

I whispered a weak, "Hello."

"Howard?" the voice asked. "Howard Kingston?"

"Yes."

"This is Mark Harris?"

"Who?"

"I'm sorry, everyone calls me 'Hotdog'."

"Yes, got it."

Before I could get out another word, he said, "I've got some bad news. Tess's helicopter went down. She is alive and will live but she has a bad concussion, but otherwise no other life-threatening injuries."

"No other life-threatening injuries?"

"No, but the doctors are concerned that she has not regained consciousness. However, she is in a coma, and they say that most people in her state do regain consciousness. I do not have any more information about her condition. We are in a wait and see mode. I can't imagine what you're going through. All during our training for this mission when we had a break, Tess could not stop talking about you and how she had found quote, 'the love of her life'."

He continued, "I'm going to give you my personal cell number. I want you to take some time to contact her ex-husband and children and when you have done that, call me and I will answer all your questions the best I can."

In a voice I could barely hear myself, I said, "Thank you Mark!"

I rushed over to the bed and buried my head in the pillow and sobbed. As soon as I could pull myself together, I tiptoed out the back door and called Arthur and gave him every detail of the conversation I could remember.

He said, "I'll wake up Keller and give us about a half hour."

"We can wake up April when you get here and be sure you cut your headlights off up the road."

"Thank you. I want to be the one to tell her."

"Of course."

I walked out toward the office and looked at my phone for the time: 4:43.

I called Mark and he answered right away.

"Howard, I know you have questions. Go ahead."

"Where is she now?"

"She is on the trauma ward at Brooke Army Medical Center in Fort Sam Houston, Texas. She has been there for two days. The doctors are amazed given the crash that she doesn't have more injuries. She is physically stable in good condition. They have done numerous scans of her brain and can see the physical trauma. With what they can see, they believe she should regain consciousness

soon. How soon they don't know. They have done everything they can here and have cleared her for a medevac at noon today to the Brain Research and Surgery Center attached to the VA Medical Center in Charleston. The Brain Center is doing extensive research on brain trauma, and they are well known on the east coast. The doctors here call that a 'win win' because they think it's also very important for her to be near her family."

He continued, "The mission she was involved in is still classified as 'Top Secret' and I can't divulge any information about it at this time. We suspect that some aspects of it will be declassified in a few days."

He went on: "I can tell you and her family this: there are soldiers on this mission who would have died if it weren't for her heroic efforts and incredible skills. The commander of this mission has already put in the paperwork for her to be awarded the 'Silver Star'."

I couldn't hold my tears and choked out, "Thank you Mark!"

"Thank you, Howard, for bringing such happiness to one of the finest soldiers and human beings I have ever known. Our thoughts and prayers are with you and her family. Call me mid-morning and I will have her arrival time at the hospital."

"Will do."

I walked out to edge of the water and couldn't stop sobbing.

"Howie, what's wrong?"

She took one look at me and screamed. "OH MY GOD!! IT'S MAMA!! WHATS HAPPENED TO HER? IS SHE DEAD? IS MAMA DEAD?"

No April, she's not dead!!

From behind us, "APRIL!!" Arthur yelled and took her in his arms. Your mama's not dead! But she is hurt.

Still screaming, HOW BAD IS SHE HURT?

"We don't know yet. Let's go up to the house so Howard can tell us what he knows." He picked her up and carried her to the house with Keller and me following behind.

She was sobbing and repeating over and over, "I can't do this!!"

I told Keller to get her a glass of water.

She took a couple of sips and Keller sat on the other side of her on the sofa and I pulled my chair up close and told them everything I knew. I started with the news that she has a concussion and that other than some scratches and bruises, the rest of her body is fine. Sometimes concussions can cause a blackout and as of an hour ago, she has not regained consciousness "DOES THAT MEAN SHE'S GONNA DIE???" Sobbing..."TELL ME SHE'S NOT GONNA DIE!!!!!"

I reached over and took her hands in mine and said sternly, "April, look at me, look at me!! The doctors said this is not unusual and they expect her to wake

up in a few days. They are transferring her to the Brain Research and Surgery Center attached to the VA Medical Center in Charleston and she should be there by three o'clock this afternoon. They have one of the top brain research centers on the East coast. We can all be there when she gets to the hospital."

Arthur had some questions, and I gave him all the information I had received. He asked how long she had been at the hospital in Texas.

"Two days. They assured me she was cleared to be transferred. They had done everything possible, and they wanted her to be close to her family."

I continued, "Arthur, I've had a little time to plan, and I wanted to run it by you, Keller and April. I went to visit her mom and dad last Saturday. On my way to the hospital, I can stop by and tell them what happened if that would help."

"Yes, that would help."

"I found a Hampton Inn around a half mile from the hospital. I can book two rooms with queen-size beds for the next few nights. Mark Harris, her mission commander, will be calling me mid-morning to let me know a more accurate time of arrival at the hospital. After I tell her parents, I'll check in the motel and then go over to the hospital to check out the ward where she will be admitted. Then I'll go back to the motel and wait for you all to get here so you can drop off your bags. Mark will call me when the plane touches down and again when she is settled in her room. Then we can go to the hospital.

April said, "I wanna go to the airport."

Arthur said, "No Honey, they will be going to another part of the airport and we won't even know where that is."

She started crying again and Arthur pulled her to him and let her cry.

It was of course still dark, and Arthur said, "April, go get your things. We'll head back home and wait for your call Howard."

"Dad, I want to go with Howie. I need to keep busy, and I can help him with whatever. I just can't sit around and wait to go to Charleston. Also, I want to be there when Howie tells Grandma and Grandpa. Please!"

By the look on his face, it looked like he would say no.

Instead, he looked at me and said, "Is that all right with you?"

"That's fine. I'll call you as soon as I hear from Colonel Harris. I'll take April by the house to get her bag packed and have her get a bag packed for her mama."

"Give me a call when you all are on the road to Charleston."

"Will do."

Keller said, "Sis, are you sure you don't want to come with us?"

"I'm sure Keller, but thanks for asking."

We watched their headlights disappear in the distance.

As we headed to the house, April said, “I feel like I’m in a state of shock right now. It’s like I feel numb.”

“It’s your mind and body’s mechanism to deal with the trauma. We will all have a lot of mood shifts ahead of us. Do the best you can to accept whatever you’re thinking and feeling. And let’s keep talking to each other about what we’re going through.”

“You seem so ‘calm and collected’.”

“I think that comes from my Army training. When you have a mission, you set everything else aside to focus on your role in the operation.”

“Is that what mama did?”

“It sure is!”

I continued, “Again, my moods will shift particularly when like you, I don’t have something to do. Let’s keep talking to each other. That will help me and may help you too.”

“Okay, so what do we do right now to keep busy?”

“It’s 6:26. Let’s clean the house. You take your bedroom and I’ll do mine and then we’ll work on the rest of the house. You can do kitchen or bathroom and we’ll tag team the rest.”

Slight smile “I’ll take the kitchen.”

We stayed busy for about 45 minutes and then I said, “Let’s fix a light breakfast. I have bagels and we can fry some bacon.”

“I’m not hungry.”

“Me neither, but we need to eat. You’re on the bagels and I’ll fix the bacon.”

She started crying and said through her tears, “Howie, I’m so scared that Mama’s not gonna make it.”

I went over and put my arms around her shoulders and said, “All we have to go on is the doctors said they expected her to regain consciousness in a few days.”

Starting to sob, “What if they’re wrong?”

“April, let’s do the best we can not to go down that road.”

“Okay, I’ll try.” Tears still flowing she asked, “Do you want your bagel toasted?”

“That’s the spirit Honey. Yes, please?”

I asked, “Do you like your bacon medium or well done?”

She responded, “That’s the spirit Honey.” Laughing a little through her tears, she said, “Well done please.”

We decided to eat in the great room and put on one of the morning TV shows to help distract us. We were about half through eating when the morning news came on, “Good morning, this just came in: The Pentagon released a statement that a special operations unit three days ago conducted a covert raid on one the largest cartels in South America. The raid’s mission was to destroy a large

supply of drugs stored in a warehouse on the premises of the large compound and take into custody any personnel found at the site. The raid was successful, but there is no word on possible casualties on both sides. Tune in for updates on the 'News at Noon.' In other news...."

I turned the TV off.

"Oh God, that's where Mama was." She started crying again.

I scooted over and put my arm around her. "Yes, I'm sure that was it. There was so much secrecy before she left, and she knew nothing." I told her some of the details when her mama was getting ready.

"Why did Mama have to go?"

"Because she is considered one of the top combat helicopter pilots in the Army. I know you have a lot of questions and I have no answer for you. When she wakes up, we can ask her all about it even though she will have to leave out some details which will be classified."

"What do you mean, classified?"

"That information will be either 'secret' or 'top secret'."

She was quiet and the tears slowed down.

"Let's clean up the dishes and then I'll pack a bag and you can get your things together. We'll go over to your house so you can pack a bag for you and for your mama. As you know, she will be in the hospital for at least a week. Think about what she will need during that time and clothes she will need after being discharged."

I went to the office and got my contact list of clients and phone numbers and we left for her house. While she was packing, I called Si, Mom and Dad and Henry and gave them the news. I told them I would give them updates in the morning and evening. Si and Henry both offered to come if we needed anything and to check on us. I thanked them and we hung up.

I checked the house and watered the plants. The phone rang and Si wanted to speak to April. "She's packing clothes for herself and her mama. I'll have her call you when we get on the road. Thanks for calling her Honey."

We left shortly after that. April called Si and she told her if she wanted/needed to talk to please call her at any time.

April said, "Si sure is nice. I really like her."

It was 8:15 and about an hour drive to the hospital. I asked April to call Arthur and give him an update. About halfway, I got a call from Mark. I said, "There's a rest area a mile from here, can I call you in a few minutes."

I called, "It's Howard....okay....do you know where they will land?....got it....oh you will? That's great! Thank you! We'll be in the waiting room of the brain surgery center. Thanks again!"

"What did he say?"

“Let me get back on the highway.” Pause. “He said they were making preparations and projected ‘wheels up’ at 9 AM which will be ten our time. There estimated flight time is about three hours. They will be on a Medevac hospital jet with a Neurologist and nurse and all the latest equipment for this kind of flight. They will be here around 1 or 1:30 our time. Colonel Harris will be accompanying her. That’s all he said.”

“Call your dad and give him the update,”

He said he and Keller would plan to arrive at the motel around one. After she called, we drove on in silence for a few minutes and she asked, “Do you mind if I put my headphones on and lean back?”

“Perfectly fine.”

“Why do you say, ‘perfectly fine’?”

“It’s my substitution for, ‘no problem’. Most people don’t know the brain does not record the ‘no’ and records only the ‘problem’. So from that deeper perspective, when you say, ‘no problem’ the brain records it as a problem.”

“That sounds like bullshit.”

“I don’t have the time or crayons to explain it to you!”

She laughed and hit me on the shoulder. “Oh, I’m sorry I didn’t mean to hit you that hard!”

“No problem.”

She hit me again and put on her headphones and leaned back.

We pulled into the driveway where her mom and dad lived. I gave them the news and they were of course scared like the rest of us. I told them our plan and said I would keep them informed and when Tess was allowed to have visitors, I would come and get them and bring them to see her. I told them April was in the truck and very upset and said to tell them she loved them.

We reached the motel about 9:30. I explained to the lady about the early check-in, and she said that was fine given the circumstances. After we got settled, I told April I had to make some calls, and some were confidential to my clients and that I was closing the adjoining room door. “If you need something, just knock. Also, please don’t leave the room without telling me.”

I cancelled most of my clients for the next week. I would try the others tomorrow. I searched on my phone for the name of Tess’s commanding officer at the Reserve Center. It was LTC Jason Woodward. After several tries, I reached him. He had received a call from Mark soon after I received the initial call. Tess had let him know about me when she went to the base to get her final instructions for departing from Charleston.

I explained to him the plans for her family. I asked him if he knew of any way, I could meet her plane when she landed. I let him know that I understood that she would be transferred from the plane to the hospital by medical personnel and

that all I wanted to do was watch from a distance. He was hesitant to answer, but said, "Let me make a call and I'll get back to you as soon as possible. I explained her ETA was between 1 and 1:30.

It was 12:05. He called back in about fifteen minutes and said he knew the operations officer at the military hangar at the airport where the transfer would be made. He said, "When you come into the main entrance to the hospital, make an immediate left and stay on that road until you get to gate five. He will meet you there at 12:45. You can park your vehicle and he will take you to the hangar. He only agreed if you understood that you would have to watch from a distance. I told him you would do that. It helped you had been an Army Ranger. He spent ten years in the Army and had also graduated from Ranger School. His name is Gary Mitchell."

I said, "I hope you know how much I appreciate you doing this for me."

He said, "That's what Tess would want."

I dialed Mark's number and didn't know if I could get through to him on the plane. He picked up immediately. "Hey Mark, how is she?"

"She's doing fine. Smooth sailing."

"Tess's CO has worked it out so I can be in the hangar when she gets here. I'm not sure how close I can get to the plane, but I'll be in khaki pants with a navy-blue shirt accompanied by the officer in charge of the hangar."

"I'll be looking for you. We're not far out."

"Thanks for everything!"

"Least I could do."

I knocked on April's door, "I'm going over to check out the hospital and find the Surgery Center and find out the location of the waiting room. I will talk to the staff and find out the protocol for visitation. It may take a while to get that information. I will call you all for updates and let you know when the plane has landed. It will take them a while to get her transferred to her room."

"I wanna go with you."

"I need you to stay here and wait for your dad and Keller. Please call him now and give him an update. Be sure to let him know that we stopped to tell your grandparents. They should be here in fifteen or twenty minutes. I'll call you soon and let you know when and where to come."

"I wanna go with you."

"There are going to be places I'm allowed to go because I'm former military. You would not be able to go with me. It will help with knowing information which will get us more smoothly into the surgery center."

"Okay I guess."

I gave her a quick hug and left.

I made it to the gate with about two minutes to spare.

He pulled up in a jeep and unlocked the gate. He held out his hand, “Gary Mitchell.”

“Gary, Howard Kingston.”

“Nice to meet you.”

“I appreciate so much you doing this for me.”

“Glad to help a Ranger buddy. We’re gonna have to play this by ear and I’m going to get you as close to the plane as I can. That might be a little tricky. As you know, the special ops mission was top secret and the security around her transport plane is tight. I do have a friend on that security detail and he’s going to get us as close as possible without causing any concern to the detail accompanying Major Angelina. As I suspect you already know, she was the hero of the mission by saving the lives of four Special Forces cadre.”

Tears welled up in my eyes.

“Take your time.”

“Thanks Gary. Just being able to see the plane land and know she is on board is very important to me. Just know that I wouldn’t want you to do anything the least bit uncomfortable for you; even for a Ranger buddy.”

“I’m glad to help in any way I can.”

We pulled up to his office in the hangar. “Wait here, I’ll go check with the tower to see about the “touch down” time.”

He came back and said, “They are early and will land in about five minutes. We had a briefing this morning about how the transfer will take place. As soon as the plane reaches the end of the runway, there will be an MP escort with the plane until it reaches the hangar. Once the hangar doors close, the security will be turned over to my friend. Once the plane is parked and engines are turned off, the medical transport staff will approach the plane and begin the transfer procedures. I am going to park as close as I can so you will get as good a view as possible.

He heard over his radio that the plane had landed. It seemed like forever before the hangar door opened and then there it was.

I couldn’t hold back my tears. I have no words beyond that. What was it? Overwhelmed that some thirty yards away was my Tess, my love, my dream, my life.... I became caught up in the activity inside the hangar. The doors to the hospital opened and the hospital staff appeared with all their gear. The door to the plane opened and a woman in a doctor’s attire came down the steps and met and conferred with the doctor from the hospital. After about two or three minutes, the bay door of the plane opened.

About that time, Gary told me that his friend had motioned us to get out of the jeep and walk over toward him. His friend had chosen a spot where we could clearly see what was going on and close to the path where the hospital staff would wheel her toward the hospital doors. Gary’s friend shook hands and left.”

“Thank you.”

I don’t know what I expected, but I was shocked when I saw her. She looked so frail and had what looked like two IV lines and several monitors. I said to myself that I need to focus on the activity of getting her off the plane into the hospital. Otherwise, I’m going to cause a scene.

I kept my composure and focused on sending love and healing energy telling her that I’m here my love and we will get through this together.

As they were transferring her from the plane, an officer in field fatigues came toward us. I knew it was Mark. He gave me a bear hug. Gary had walked away.

“Howard, so sorry we’re meeting under these circumstances. I’ll need to accompany Tess up to the ward, spend a few minutes talking to the doc and then hustle back to the plane. They have a pickup at Walter Reed and then we’re headed back to Texas. Please keep me posted on her status. When she’s better, my wife and I want to come and visit you all.” He glanced over his shoulder. “I’ve got to accompany her to the ward. We’re praying for her!” He gave me another hug and left.

I called after him, “Thanks for everything Mark!”

She came within about fifteen feet, and she didn’t look as frail. I focused on what Mark had told me on the phone that her body had only bumps and bruises and all vital signs were good, and that the prognosis was good. However, I knew enough about being in a coma to be terrified that she would never wake up even though the doctors were very optimistic based on the scans of her brain.

The hospital doors closed, and Gary introduced me to his friend Doug. I thanked them for allowing me to be here. We chatted for a few minutes and then Gary drove me to the gate.

Gary had given me directions on the closest entrance to the Brain Surgery part of the hospital. I found the desk and let them know that I was the “next of kin” of Major Angelina. The nurse smiled, “We have heard she was the hero of some military operation and saved the lives of four soldiers. We will take good care of her. It will take about an hour to get her settled so you and the family can have a seat in our waiting room. I’ll have to find out from the doctors about her having visitors. I thanked her and left.

I went back to the motel. Arthur and the children were waiting for me. I told them she had landed and been taken to the ICU unit on the brain surgery floor. I told them I found the waiting room and had talked to the nurse, and she had said come back in an hour to find out about visitation.

Nobody had eaten so we went to a fast-food sit-down place. All four of us picked at our food. We were quiet with our own thoughts. We drove separately and

Arthur followed me. When we got to the waiting room, I said, "I'll go and ask the nurse if she can come out and talk to us."

The nurse was Cheryl Matthews. She said, "The doctor and staff are finishing up their initial visit and will be out to talk with you all soon. I can tell you the transfer went very well. The doctor from Brooke briefed them on everything that took place during her stay at their hospital."

About twenty minutes later, Cheryl came out and took us all back to a consultation room. Dr Wade introduced himself and asked us to sit down.

"I don't have a lot to add to what was passed on to you all by Colonel Harris before Tess left Brooke, but I'll summarize and be glad to answer the best I can any questions you might have. First, physically other than the head trauma, she is doing fine. There are some minor lacerations on her body, but they are already starting to heal."

He went on, "The brain scans show trauma to the area of the brain that is consistent with what she's going through. I know coma is a scary word for many reasons, but all of us believe she will come out of the coma; we just don't know when. I also want to prepare you for the possibility that she may have some memory issues. That's something else we can't predict."

Arthur asked, "If she has memory issues, is there anyway, any sign that will indicate if she has a chance of recovering her memory?"

"There are no signs to indicate how long she will have the memory loss. If she starts to recover certain parts of her memory, that is a possible sign that she may recover more, but there are always a lot of uncertainties. I wish I had more definitive answers for you all."

I asked, "How about visitation?"

"The only treatment is to check her vitals every hour. We ask that only two people be in the room at a time. There are two recliners and if anyone wants to spend the night, that's fine. It's also fine to talk to her and hold her hand and kiss her on the cheek. You can also read to her. We are in a waiting mode, waiting for her to wake up. There is nothing else we can do."

Cheryl will be her main nurse and she will introduce you all to the other nurses who will be checking on her. I will be here at different times and there will always be a neurologist on duty here at the Brain Center. Any more questions for now?"

We didn't have any. He said, "Let me know."

We went back to the waiting room. Shortly after Cheryl came and told us that they were ready for visitors. Arthur said, "Howard, why don't you and April go back first."

"Thanks Arthur. April are you ready?"

“No and yes,” She got up and hugged her dad and Keller and took my hand and said, “I’m ready,”

We walked down the hallway and April paused. She put her arms around my waist and her head on my chest and whimpering said, “Tell me I can do this.”

“We’ll do it together.”

Pause, “Okay,”

We walked in and just stood there for a minute or two. Since I had seen her, I wasn’t surprised. April stood close to me while we stood at the end of the bed.

She whispered, “She just looks like she’s asleep.”

“She does.”

She went over by the bed and said, “Hi Mama. It’s me.”

I got one of the chairs and moved it by the bed. April sat in it and reached over and slipped her hand under her mama’s hand.

“Your hand is nice and warm Mama. I was so scared when I found out you were hurt.” Tears started rolling down her cheeks. I put some Kleenex in her left hand. “Howie, Dad and Keller are here and we’re going to help you get well.”

She eased her hand from underneath her mama’s and stood up and went out into the hallway. I followed her and she said, “I can’t stay in there any longer for now.”

“I understand Hon.”

She said, “I saw a sitting area outside with some trees. I’m going to go out there for a while.”

“Tell your dad I’ll be out in about 10 minutes.”

I went back in the room and kissed her on the cheek and took her hand and told her how much I loved her and talked about getting well and all the things we were going to do when she got home. Then the thought, ‘what if you don’t make it’ popped into my mind. I don’t think since that first call from Mark I had entertained that thought. It was unthinkable. And yet, there she was lying in the bed unconscious with no certainty that she would ever come out of the coma. No. I’m not going there! She is coming out of the coma. Even the neurologists were optimistic. I had to hold it together for April. Hold it together for myself. I kissed her lightly on the lips and went to the waiting room.

After Arthur and Keller came back, we joined April in the garden and made our plans. Arthur and Keller were going home, and Keller would use Holly’s car and drive up in the morning with Hank who wanted to come. Turns out that April had called him and asked him to come. Henry had called to see if it was okay for Hank to visit. Keller and Hank would pick up his grandparents and bring them to the hospital and then take them back on their way home.

Si and Roger came the third day and Henry came on the fourth day. Keller came every day for a few hours and then would head back home. April and I

stayed at the hospital during the day until about ten at night and the nurses said they would call us if there were any changes.

On the fifth day in mid-morning, April and I had been at the hospital for about an hour. She was on her headphones, and I was reading the newspaper. Tess made some groaning sounds. I touched April and pointed to her mama. Slowly blinking her eyes, she opened them and a little above a whisper said, “Where am I?”

She's Awake

April went over saying, "Mama, you're awake. Mama, you're awake."

I ran down to the nurse's station and Cheryl was doing some paperwork. "Cheryl, she's awake."

She got up and followed me and over her shoulder said to the clerk, "Page Dr. Wade!"

April was still standing over her mama smiling tears running down her cheeks. Tess had this faraway look in her eyes. Cheryl took one look at her and asked us to go to the waiting room. We reluctantly left.

No more than two minutes later, Cheryl came out to the waiting room and said, "Dr Wade and a colleague are with Tess. I'll check in with you every five minutes or so and let you know what's happening."

She checked in several times and said everything was going well. The last time she said there was a neuropsychologist conducting her portion of the assessment. She said it will probably take another half hour.

That time seemed like forever, but it was about thirty minutes when Cheryl told us to come on back to the consult room. Dr. Wade introduced Sally Jacobs, the neuropsychologist.

"Dr. Jacobs and I have finished our assessment. Physically Tess is doing fine. Her wounds are healing. Her vitals have continued to be good. And of course, she is awake. I'll let Dr. Jacobs continue."

"Sorry to meet you all under these circumstances. As you all know, Tess came out of the coma and didn't know who she was or who you all were. You all of course, want to know if or when she will get her memory back. Unfortunately, in my experience, there have been a wide range of answers to that question often depending on factors too complex for us to understand. So, I just don't know."

She continued, "However, there are things I can tell you which will facilitate the process that gives her the best chance of a full recovery. Patience is at the top of the list. It's so important to take it slow and at her pace. She will need lots of bedrest but also important that she slowly gets up and soon after takes little walks. Then you let her dictate the progression of activity. Mr. Kingston, we know you are a psychotherapist so we can leave that up to your best judgment. Let me reiterate that it's important that you be patient and take one day at a time.

She went on. "What we are hoping is that as time passes, she will recognize certain things/people/situations. What you can expect is that she has selected types

of recall. For instance, she knows things like she has to eat, how to use the bathroom, most hygienic rituals and so on. Smiling, probably won't remember right away using make-up. If she were to get separated from you, she would know things like how to seek help, but she would not know where to go or who you were so in essence would feel lost. Take her back to the environment where she would feel most safe. Initially, limit visitors to close family. That's an overall picture of going forward. Do you have any questions?"

I asked, "If she asks us who we are, do we tell her?"

She looked at Dr. Wade.

"I think that would be fine. Do you agree Sally?"

"Yes, but I think it's best that you just answer her questions and not elaborate unless of course, she has further questions."

Dr. Wade said, "Sally and I have decided that if her vitals remain stable and she is able to eat solid foods and regain some strength, we will release her to you in three days. Why don't you get a list of question you might have, and we can answer them the best we can between now and when you leave."

I asked about visiting her.

He answered, "For today and tomorrow, you all can visit her about once an hour and only stay for ten minutes. We want her to get a lot of rest in the next few days.

April asked, "Can we see her now for ten minutes?"

"I'm pretty sure she will be asleep. She got very tired while we were doing our assessment, but you can try."

We left and went to her room. She was asleep. We decided to go downstairs and get something to eat. After, we went upstairs, and she was awake but very drowsy.

April went over, "Hey Mama, how you are feeling?"

Very slowly and only a little above a whisper, "You are my daughter?"

"Yes."

"What's your name?"

"April."

A faint smile, again a little above a whisper, "I have a daughter."

Then she closed her eyes.

We stayed for a few more minutes and left.

When we got down to the garden, I asked April, "How do you think I should answer when she asks who I am?"

"You could say, 'I work at the hardware store and sell grass seed.' That might jog her memory."

"It's good to see you're feeling little better. I was worried about you."

“Howie, she’s awake and I’m gonna get my mama back one way or the other.”

“Good for you. I want your determination to rub off on me. All I can say to her is that ‘I’m your boyfriend’ and you know it goes so much deeper than that. She might not see me as an important person in her life.”

“I’ll be glad to help you with that if I can get a discount on our next grass seed order.”

Smiling and high five, “Thanks, you are going to be very important part of her recovery.”

“I know that. Mama and I have always been very close. I think you know that too. I’m determined to do everything I can to help her find her old self.”

“She needs to feel safe and identifying you as her daughter will give her that security.”

We went back up to her room and she was awake, I motioned for April to go over to her bed.

“Hey Mama, how you are feeling?”

“I think a little better. And you’re my daughter, right?”

“What is your name again?”

“April”

“I’m sorry. Everything seems like a blank.”

“The doctors told us that you had a head injury, and they are not surprised you’ve lost your memory, but they say you will eventually get it back,” She lied.

“So, you will help me?”

“Of course, Mama. You won’t remember, but you and I are very close.”

She motioned for April to come closer and whispered something.

April leaned in and whispered a response. As Tess glanced in my direction, she whispered something else, and April responded. It looked like Tess blushed a little.

She was about to doze off and mumbled, “Okay.” And her eyes closed.

We left and I asked, “What was the whispering about?”

“She asked me why she only had one ear. I told her she was a soldier in the Army and lost it in an explosion. She didn’t seem too surprised, but I don’t think she had the energy to have much of a response. Then she asked me who you were.”

“What did you tell her?”

“In essence, I told her you were the love of her life and you were going to help me help her get her memory back. Do you think it was okay to tell her about how she lost her ear?”

“Yes, I do. I don’t think it’s helpful to give her information that’s not true.”

“But I lied to her about the doctors saying she would recover her memory.”

“What to say and what not to say is not an exact science. Use your best judgment at the time. In both cases, I thought you used good judgment. An idea that might help is when you get a question, you’re not sure about answering, you could say, ‘Mama could we talk about this later?’ If she pushes you, give it your best shot. Most important is that you’re not going to hurt her chances of recovery by whatever response you give.”

We came back every hour that day until 10PM.

That night April and I decided that I should not visit her anymore. I would take April there in the morning each day and wait in the garden. I called Mark Harris and Jason Woodward and let them know she had regained consciousness. They were both relieved and said they would check in with me later to get updates. Fortunately, I had brought plenty to read. Keller came each day for a couple of hours and took reports back to his grandparents and his dad.

Tess was adjusting pretty well to the fact that she had a son. Each visit, Tess felt more comfortable with him. They would have to be a team to help Tess make progress. Keller and April decided it was best for him to move in with them when Tess was released to go home.

Henry came up twice in the evenings to spend time with me. On both trips, he brought Hank to visit April during her breaks. A day after Dr. Wade and Sally had given us their assessment, Dr. Wade told April she could come and go as she pleased and was welcome to spend the night in the recliner. April told him that we had decided I would not visit anymore after that first day. He thought that was a good idea.

The third day after the assessment, Dr. Wade told us there was nothing else they could do for Tess. She was getting her strength back and he said she could go home tomorrow. We were thrilled and hugged each other and exchanged high fives. We decided it was best if Keller would drive them home.

The next day, they wheeled Tess down to the car. She was still pretty weak, and Keller got her safely buckled in the front seat. I stayed in the background so Tess wouldn’t see me.

I followed them to Tess’s house and watched them get her inside. The hospital had provided a walker and she had been practicing some at the hospital. When they were inside, I left and went to the house. Even though it was Thursday, Henry had agreed to meet me for lunch. I needed some time to sort out all that had been happening. Si had been taking care of PJ and GJ, but they seemed glad to see me.

I looked over next week’s schedule and I was slammed. Knowing that I would not be seeing Tess for a while, I had decided to work a full week and catch

up on all the cancellations from last week. I did some chores and left for lunch with Henry. I called April on the way.

“We got Mama settled in her bed and she went right to sleep. Keller left to get his clothes and stuff. We are so lucky to have that small sunroom where he can sleep.”

“Yes, that’s working out great. I’m going to lunch with Henry.”

She interrupted, “Howie, I’m so glad. You need someone to talk to. I can’t imagine how hard it is not to be with Mama.”

“I’m glad too. He has always been my major support person. After lunch, I will head to Winn Dixie. If you will make me a list of groceries and toilet articles, I will pick them up for you.”

“Thanks Howie, but Holly called earlier, and she is going to do some shopping. I think it’s important to let her help. She will leave the groceries and other items on the front porch.”

“Yes, I think so too, but you know you can always call me if you need anything.”

“I’m so glad we talked about the plan going forward. I want you to know that Keller and I are on board. Keller and I will be the only people Mama will come in contact with until you and I have decided differently. We both agree the next person to see Mama when she is feeling better is you. The three of us are the most important people in her life and we will decide when Mama is ready to see other people.”

“Sounds good. I’ll call you when I get home.”

“One other thing. I’m going to keep a notebook of my interaction with Mama for three reasons. One, is I want you to know what we are talking about and two, I want your suggestions about how and what we can do to jog her memory and three, I think when she regains her memory, she would be interested in reading about it.”

“I think that’s a great idea. It’s a huge help to me to keep posted on her progress for obvious reasons and it helps to feel a part of her healing.”

“Howie, I haven’t said this yet, but if it hadn’t been for you, I don’t know how I would have survived.”

“We made a good team both supporting each other.”

“We did. Love you Howie.”

“Love you too Hon.”

Susie’s was packed. I spotted Henry at our favorite table. He stood up and gave me a bearhug, “How you holdin’ up bro?”

“Glad to have her settled and glad to be home myself.”

“You must be exhausted.”

I spent the lunch going over the last week and what that was like for me.

As usual, he was a good listener and empathetic.

“What are the plans going forward?”

I laid out the plan for him and then said, “I need a favor.”

“Sure, how can I help?”

I wondered if you could ride to Charleston with me at some point to pick up Tess’s vehicle?”

“Sure. I was going to ask you about going to Larry’s for a beer and supper tonight. I can get off around 3:30 today. If you’re free, we could go and pick up her vehicle and still go to Larry’s. Will that work?”

“Perfect. Why don’t I pick you up at Larry’s and we can leave from there?”

“Sounds good.”

“Four o’clock?”

“Great. See you at four.”

I knew Si had a full schedule, but I took a chance and called her.

“Hey Daddy, how you doin’?”

“Just tired. You must have had a cancellation.”

“I did.”

“Could you possibly come out for a visit tomorrow morning?”

“Should be fine. Let me check with Roger. I’ll call you if I can’t come. What time?”

“Around nine if that works.”

“Should be fine.”

I stopped by Mom and Dad’s and gave them updates. Made a quick trip to Winn Dixie for groceries. I called April and told her about picking up the vehicle and that we would park it in the driveway. When I got home, I fell into bed and passed out for about an hour. I felt better. Henry and I picked up her vehicle, parked it in her driveway and left. We had a good time at Larry’s. After he left, I went straight to bed and “slept like a rock.”

While drinking my coffee, I checked my email hoping April had time to tell me about yesterday. She did and gave me the following account:

Mama was exhausted after we got her in the house. She wanted to sit down on the sofa. “Mama, don’t you want to lie down?”

“No, I want to sit on the sofa for a little while.” Looking around, “So this is where we live?”

Keller said, “Mom, I don’t live here most of the time. I live with Dad.”

“Am I divorced?”

“Yes, you have been for about a year and a half.”

“It’s a pretty house, I love the view of the ocean.”

I asked, "Are you hungry?"

"A little bit. That hospital food was terrible."

I was so glad that she was at least remembering her past so far.

Keller said, "Mom, I've got to go out for a while, but I'll be back soon."

"Okay Keller."

"Mama, all we have until the groceries come is soup and crackers. Does that sound good?"

"Yes, thank you April. You are such a sweet girl. You have taken such good care of me."

"You've taken such good care of me since I was born."

"Well, I'm glad to hear it."

She ate a good size bowl of soup with some crackers and then wanted to lay down. She commented on how pretty her bedroom was and how nice it was that she could see the ocean. She slept for about three hours and then wanted to go sit on the deck. She asked me about her life, so I gave her a few basic details and while I was talking she was looking out at the ocean and it didn't seem like she was listening. Keller came in and we had a light supper, and she went to bed.

Keller and I were also exhausted.

Si came around nine and we went for a jog and stopped off at the sanctuary for a short meditation. I was eager for all the news from last week. She invited me over for dinner tonight and went home.

Shortly after that, April called, "Mama is sitting out on the deck, and I wondered if you wanted to see her from a distance. You could walk down the beach. Would you like to do that?"

"Yes, I would. How did she sleep last night?"

"She slept good and ate a light breakfast and seems to be getting her strength back."

"The docs have told us all along that physically she is fine. I'm expecting that her energy level is going to be much better in a few days."

"I hope you're right. I need to go back outside. I can see her from here, but I can tell you my worst fear is that she will wander away when I'm not looking."

"Yes, that would be a nightmare!"

I walked down the beach and stayed along the edge of the water. I could see them talking. I went down about another half mile and April got up and waved me over. This was a surprise.

As I approached, they were both laughing.

"What's so funny?"

“Mama has good eyes. She saw you walking and said, ‘There’s that man again.’ And I broke out laughing and April started laughing.

“And while you were walking toward us, she said, ‘So he is my boyfriend; he looks a little old for me.’” And April laughed again and then Tess joined in.

“I’m so glad you two are having a good laugh at my expense.”

Tess said to April, “He’s a little sensitive too.”

And they both laughed again.

I looked at Tess and asked, “What’s your name again?”

She looked at April, “I thought I was the one with memory problems.”

“Mama, be gentle. Before you got hurt, we agreed his elevator was stuck on the second floor?”

“Did we?” And they laughed again.

I said, “Well Tess you are doing a lot better. At least you have not forgotten how you and April ganged up on me numerous times.”

She said, “From where I sit you must have deserved it.”

She continued, “April, I’m really tired.”

“Come on Mama, let’s get you back in bed for a nap.”

Tess turned and looked at me, “Thank you for being a good sport. What’s your name again?”

“I’ve forgotten.”

“I’ll just call you ‘numb nuts.’”

April raised her voice, “Mama, that wasn’t very nice.”

She replied, “I didn’t know that. It just popped into my mind.”

I sat there for a few minutes. I didn’t wanna leave but as I was getting up, April came out and said, “Keller just came in. He said he would keep watch to make sure Mama didn’t leave.” She smiled, “What did you think of that exchange?”

“Memory loss like your mom’s is out of my expertise, but the same character trait of liking to tease is certainly still in place. I think that’s a good sign.”

“My idea is over the next few days is to help Mama get her strength back. Like Dr Jacobs said, ‘Short walks, short naps, hydrate and eat healthy’.”

“I think that’s a good plan. She always loved the idea, ‘listen to your body; pay attention to your body.’ I think she will let you know her limitations just like a few minutes ago, she wanted a nap. I think at the same time, be careful she doesn’t try to do too much too soon.”

“What part do you want to play?”

“My suggestion is that you follow your plan for the next two days. If she wants to see me, let’s let that be her idea. Each day I think she will get stronger. A good question to ask her is, ‘what would you like to do now’? As you know, I’ll be

working next Monday through Friday and I'm booked since I had to cancel clients this past week, however, if you need me at any point, call! I will have my cell phone with me and of course I'm free the next two days."

"Sounds like a plan."

"You know how much I want to be with her and how hard it is to stay away. It would really help me if you would call me every day and let me know how she's doing."

"You don't have to ask me to do that. I will call you every day. We are a team." Tears welling up, "You and me are gonna get my mama back!" We hugged and I left.

When I got back to the house, I called Tess's mom and dad and gave them an update. I spent the afternoon working around the house and took a nap midafternoon. That felt good. April called around 5:30.

"Howie, the notebook seemed like a good idea at the time, but I would rather talk to you than read my notes."

"Whatever works best for you is fine with me."

"Mama did well this afternoon. She ate a light lunch and then wanted to walk out to the edge of the water. Then we walked along the edge for about 10 minutes and then she wanted to go back to the house and went straight to her bedroom and slept for a couple of hours."

"Keller came back, and she wanted to go for a drive. I asked where she wanted to go and she said, 'Just take me around town and point out the places that should be familiar to me.' When we got outside, she noticed the SUV and asked where it came from, I told her it was hers and she asked how it got here and I told her that you and a friend of yours picked it up. She asked where it had been and I told her that when she felt better, you and I would fill her in on the details of what happened."

"Perfect answer April. This is too soon to go into any talk at all about what happened to her."

"I got it. On the ride, she didn't recognize anything, but asked a lot of questions. She did well from an energy standpoint. She is sitting on the couch right now watching TV with Keller. They are watching some comedy show and I could hear her laughing some. That's a little different for Mama. She has never been a fan of comedy shows. I'm fixing supper and she said a little while ago she was hungry.

How was your afternoon?"

I gave her the details and I told her I was leaving shortly to have dinner with Si and family.

"Good, I'm glad you can spend time with them. How are Chase and Dottie doing?"

“Thanks, they’re fine. When are you going to take a break?”

“I was just getting ready to tell you that Hank called this afternoon and wondered if I could do something with him tonight. Keller said he would stay with Mama. Do you think that’s okay?”

“I’m also glad you’re getting a chance to leave for a while. Sometimes with you, I get a little fatherly remembering you’re only 14 even though you seem like you’re at least 17 or 18 and I should say even then very mature for your age.”

“Does it help that I’ll be 15 soon?”

Laughing, “Not much.”

“Anyway, be sure to check in with your dad about the date with Hank.”

“I already did, and he told me to be back at the house by ten.”

“I’m so proud of you April.”

“Oh, I forgot to tell you I asked Mama and she said, ‘Based on our history, would I let you do something like this?’ I told her that she was already letting me sleep with boys. Keller broke out laughing.”

Mama smiling asked, “How many?”

“I said I lost count.”

“Mama asked Keller, ‘Would I have let her go?’”

“Probably. Howie knows him and he and I are on the football team and Dad met him while you were in the hospital. And Dad already agreed.”

“Mama said I guess you can go but be home by eight.”

Smiling, “But Mama, we’re not leaving till seven.”

“Okay, what did your dad tell you?”

“Ten.”

“Okay, have fun. I’m not waiting up on you.”

I said, “She is really doing better. Would you call me in the morning and give me an update?”

“Sure.”

“Have fun with Hank!”

“I will.”

April called around nine and said, “Mama slept through the night and was drinking a cup of coffee when I got up. I told her that I was impressed that she remembered how to make coffee. She said when she got up, she didn’t think about it.; she just made the coffee. That would seem like a good sign.”

“I think so too.”

“Keller and I talked after I got home last night.”

I interrupted, “How did your date go with Hank?”

“I really like him. It went great. We kissed when we got to the door.”

“Sounds like you both had fun. I’m glad.”

“Don’t mention the kiss to Dad. Sometimes, he’s a little overprotective.”

“I won’t, but I hope you’ll tell him at some point. I think that’ll help him build trust in you.”

“Hey Howie, don’t put your ‘shrink hat’ on.”

“Got it. I deserved that. You mentioned you and Keller talked.”

“He wanted to know if I was okay with him going home to sleep.”

“I told him I was fine with that.”

“He promised to come over every morning and help me plan the day and see what he could do to help. He did tell me that football practice starts in two weeks and he is hoping Mama will be back to normal.”

“I told him the big thing was driving. He called earlier and he’s coming over at 10:30. We’ll figure out what to do in two weeks.”

“Yes, we will.”

“Have you all talked about what to do today?”

“Not yet. Should I just ask her what she wants to do?”

“Yes. Let’s see what she says.”

“Will do. I’ll call you back.”

About an hour later, she called.

“Hey! After I came back in, she was sitting on the sofa drinking her coffee and asked me where you live and what you did for a living. When I told her you were a ‘shrink’, she smiled. She asked. ‘Was I that screwed up that I needed to date a shrink?’”

“I told her some of her family and friends thought it was a good fit. And when I laughed, she motioned me to come over and sit by her and she gave me a hug and said, ‘I’m so glad you’re my daughter. I already love being around you. Were we like this before?’ I told her again how close we were, and she told me that she feels safe with me.”

I responded, “That’s good. It’s very positive. I just had a strange thought. What if your mom never gets her memory back? During our therapy sessions, I suggested to her that the past has only three benefits: 1. Lesson’s learned, 2. Objective data like where you live and how to drive a car etc., 3. Fond memories. That’s it. After I explained it, she liked the idea.”

I continued, “So, the question is, to what degree does she need her past? Could she have a good life without ever getting her memory back? I don’t think it would be her first choice because she has many wonderful memories. But on the other hand, there are probably lots of memories she would like to forget. I’m not sure where I’m going with that.”

She said, “I get it. We might even be closer because I’m older and we can also become great friends. That could also be true with Keller and even Dad where

all the old history doesn't exist. We are bonded to her whether she remembers us or not."

"Yes, you are and I'm not. I'm on the outside. Not a real pleasant thought but you know I'm not giving up."

"Let me be clear about this Howie. I'm on your team and I'm not going to let you get away. I've never seen Mama so happy in all her life as she was after you all got together. I know who you are and my Mama will not be able to keep from loving you the same way she did before all this happened. She's calling me. Will talk later."

A Start

April called at eleven.

“Mama wants to go for another drive with Keller and me. She is getting ready, and we should leave here in about 30 minutes.”

“I’m taking that as a good sign she is starting to get her strength back.”

“After you and I talked, we went for a walk on the beach. I tried to subtly steer her up toward your house, but she headed down the beach. After about a quarter of a mile, she turned around. I was happy she felt like walking that far. When we got back to the house, we sat out on the deck and that seemed to be enough rest. Keller is sitting with her now and I can hear them talking.”

“Did she say much on the walk?”

“No just some small talk about how pretty it was and how the breeze felt good. She didn’t indicate that any of what she saw was familiar. They are getting up and coming in. Talk later.”

I went for a run and reminded myself to avoid the heat and get back into my early morning run and meditation. After my meditation where I went over gratitude and thankfulness to the Universe for Tess’s return, I cleaned up and went over to see Si, Roger and the grandkids and then went to see Mom and Dad. When I got home, I called Tess’s mom and dad. Her mom said that April was calling every day to let them know about her progress.

I spent the rest of the afternoon working outside. I cleaned up and called Henry to see if by any chance he could join me at Larry’s for a beer and dinner. I had forgotten that some of Jill’s family were there, and he couldn’t make it. I sat at the bar and talked on and off to Bert. My phone rang and I excused myself and went outside.

It was April. “Hey Howie. How you doin’?”

“I’m fine or as good as could be expected. How did she do today?”

“We went for a ride again and she seemed to enjoy it, but this afternoon there was some frustration about not being able to recognize things. We did go over and visit Dad and Holly for a few minutes. Mama did fine and probably a good thing she didn’t remember the situation. It was all very cordial. Then we came home. We had lunch and then she napped for a couple of hours and when she woke up, she wanted to walk on the beach again and we went further, and she did fine. She still seemed to consciously avoid going toward your house. I don’t know

if she remembers you live in that direction. It's hard to say. Right now, she's reading a book, Jonathan Livingston Seagull."

"I love that one. It's full of inspiration to do something you didn't believe you could do."

"I think she read it to me when I was younger, but I don't remember much about it. I'm feeling pretty good about today. Mama is getting stronger, and her attitude is good. I'm going to continue to keep her as active as possible."

"Good plan. Thanks for keeping me posted?"

"You're welcome, Howie. I'll check in with you tomorrow."

I went back in the bar and soon after, things slowed down and Larry came out for a chat. I filled him in on what was going on. He has always been a great listener and I felt better after talking to him."

On my walk home, I got a call from Mark. He was eager to know how Tess was doing. He had been in touch with Dr. Wade at the hospital. I gave him all the details and he was happy about her progress so far and of course was hopeful she would regain her memory soon. He said he would like to check in every two or three days if that was okay and of course I said I would be glad to keep him in the loop. I thanked him for all he had done for Tess, and he said something like that's the least I could do.

He said, "As I told you, she was a hero out there. I'll never forget the courage and sacrifice she showed out in that hell hole. Take care Howard. I'm praying things will work out for the two of you. I've never seen her face light up the way it did when she talked about you. Take care and I'll be back in touch."

"Thanks for calling Mark."

I was tired when I got back to the house. I watched a little TV and decided to turn in. PJ and GJ decided to join me. Even though I felt exhausted, I was restless at times but, I slept until eight which was late for me. I drank some water and went for my run and stopped at the sanctuary for my meditation.

I called Jason Woodward and gave him the update. I did some chores outside and worked some in the office. The next five days were going to be challenging. I had no slots open except for a lunch break.

April called at twelve and said they had been for another ride and stopped at the library to pick up a couple of books on the history of this area. Still no progress on memory recall. She told me that Hank had called a little while ago.

She continued, "I really like him. Tell me what you know about him."

"I think I told you he's a great kid. I have always liked him. He and Henry have their moments, but as you know, that's normal. He gets along really well with his mom. They are close."

"Mama likes him too even though she has only seen him a few times. We talked about this before, but even though Mama has no memory about her past, she

retains things she's learning now. She remembers everything that has happened since she woke up. Do you think that's a good sign?"

"I do even though I'm not sure how that impacts her capacity to get her old memory back."

"In so many ways, she seems like the same Mama before the injury. Before, we were so close and had such a great relationship and now we are already doing so well together. We are getting closer every day. She is so much like she was before."

"That's wonderful. It's like you almost have her back even though she doesn't remember before. In the span of things, how important is it that she remembers her past?"

"I remember we talked about that yesterday or the day before. I thought about what it would be like to be in her shoes. It's hard to imagine and kind of frightening. I mean it feels like I would be lost and so dependent on other people to help guide me."

"From what you've said, she doesn't seem to feel scared. You might ask her about that sometime when you all are talking. She seems to be curious more than anything. Doing what she can to figure out what's going on. That gives me hope since that is so much like her. It's like we in that sense have her back. She's the same incredible, wonderful, kind person without a history."

"Isn't that a little too early to tell?"

"Yes, I'm sure it is. It's me wanting that to be true. Sometimes, I do wonder if she will be the same person I fell in love with. I just don't want to allow myself to even think about it. The 'what ifs' on that subject can be unsettling. But as I'm sure you can imagine, by far the most fearful thought is that she won't get her memory back and won't fall in love with me again."

"I know. Yes, I think I can imagine. And it's hard for me to think about you not being in my life."

"That will never happen if you want me in your life. You're already like a daughter to me and that will never change."

"That means a lot to me Howie."

"To me too. Love you honey."

"Love you too Howie."

I spent the afternoon on more chores inside and out. Spend an hour in my sanctuary meditating and rereading parts of one of my favorite books, 'The Power of Now' by Eckhart Tolle. His book is filled with so many reminders about the importance of living in the moment. I never would have made it through those two years without his guidance and encouragement. And that's what will get me

through these next days and weeks with predicted slip-ups from time to time. I need to let the moments unfold.

After supper, I went over to the office to get my charts ready for tomorrow and I did some tidying up of the waiting room and bathroom. I took another walk, came back, and watched some mindless TV.

April called about nine. "Hey Howie, how was your afternoon?"

I gave her a sketch and asked, "How did your mama do this afternoon?"

"She did really well. She continues to have great memory from the time she woke up in the hospital and how to do things that she did before like driving and using the washing machine and even recipes, but no sign of memory of people, places, being a helicopter pilot etc."

"No recollection of what happened?"

"None at all. She did ask me this afternoon if I would be comfortable with her driving to The Market by herself. I forgot to tell you this morning that we got her a new phone. She reminded me that I was the number one on her speed dial and that if she got confused, she would call me. Keller was here and we wanted her to build some confidence about getting out and we thought it was worth the risk."

"I think you made a good choice and I'm glad she wanted to do it. Again, it's such a good sign that this is the person we know. Independent and determined to be her own person."

"I think so too. This afternoon, she went for a walk by herself. She wanted to start getting back in shape, so she told me she was going to jog and walk in short spurts. I kept an eye on her from the patio. She did well."

"Another good sign. Has she mentioned me at all?"

"Yes, she asked me about you this afternoon. I'll give you a little of the conversation the best I can remember."

"Okay."

"She said. 'Tell me about this guy who is supposed to be my boyfriend.'

I said he was more to you than just your boyfriend. He was more like the love of your life.

'That serious?'

'Yes.'

'I know he's a shrink, but what else can you tell me?'

'Mama, this is not gonna work for me.'

'Why?'

'Because when you're feeling better, I hope you will ask him these questions yourself.'

'You're right. Sorry I was just curious.'

‘All I’m going to say about him is, please give him a chance. Believe me, you won’t regret it regardless of how it turns out.’

‘Did I call him Howie?’

‘Yes, not only that, but you called him numb nuts.’

‘Oh, I had forgotten that. Well, I think when I decide to check him out, I’ll call him Howard. Howie is too familiar.’

‘Well, I’m impressed when I gave you his name the other day that you remembered it.’

She thought for a moment and then said, ‘Now that you mention it, I am too.’

That’s it.”

“Thanks April. That’s a start. I like your idea that she’s going to have to decide if she wants to see me.”

“How long are you willing to wait until she reaches out to you?”

“My knee jerk answer is as long as it takes. But my more thought-out answer is for a while and I don’t know how long a while is, but at that point, I will contact her and ask her if we can spend some time together and perhaps at least be friends.”

“I like your plan Howie, but if in a week or so, she hasn’t contacted you, I’d go ahead and ‘pull the trigger.’ Mama needs someone other than Keller or me to spend time with her.”

“I understand. Just keep calling me every evening and we’ll take it a day at a time. I hope it goes without saying you can call me anytime day or night. You know I’ll be working the next five days, but I will check my messages between clients and call you right back. If it’s an emergency, call me, hang up and call again.”

“Sounds good. I better go check on Mama.”

“Talk to you tomorrow. April, I am still so proud of you!”

“Thanks. Bye Howie.”

I got up around six, went for my run and meditation in the sanctuary. It was a little breezy and the sunrise was beautiful as usual. As I walked back to the house, I thought back to the first time we met after the two-year period.

I remember so well seeing her as she walked up the beach toward me. Such a thrill, such excitement just to be able to talk with her. I couldn’t hold back the tears and the ache in my chest. Now she didn’t even know who I was. To have glimpsed the dream come true and now facing the possibility that I could lose her was almost unbearable.

I wasn't sure how I was going to get through these next five days, but I had to pull it together. I owed this to my clients. As I got closer to the house, I took more deep breaths and kept repeating over and over, 'I can do this! I can do this! I can do this!'

The five days were long, but manageable. I stayed with my rituals and was in bed every night by ten and slept good until six. I think I needed the rest more than anything. I felt a lifting of my spirits partly due to the rest and partly because of what happened this morning.

I had a client standing in front of the picture window looking out at the water focusing on the soft eyes exercise and listening to the waves. I saw a woman walking north on the beach and even though she wasn't that close to the office, I realized it was Tess. For the two or three minutes or so I could see her, she didn't look toward the house or the office, but just that she walked in this direction I took to be a good sign.

April called me shortly after she knew my last client had left. "Did you see Mama when she walked up by the office and house?"

"I sure did. Did she say anything about it?"

"She did. She told me she was going to do it. I think she felt safe because I had told her you were working and there was very little chance that she would run into you."

"Did she say anything when she got back?"

"Not much. She said she liked your house. I asked her if there was any recall at all and she said there was none. How was your day? Last night you said you had several challenging clients. After we hung up, I wondered what kind of challenges you were talking about."

"Sometimes people are so focused on their problems and/or symptoms that they put up a lot of resistance to exploring ways to work on the healing. Sometimes it's challenging to get them to shift gears. It gets complicated at times, and I feel bad for them. And on a lighter note, it also means I have to work harder, and I like that."

"Was Mama one of those challenging clients?"

"Yes, but for other reasons. My biggest challenge with her was trying to convince her I wasn't crazy."

Lightly, "That sounds like Mama."

"How did she do today?"

"She is feeling better with more energy; she was jogging more and walking less. We drove around the island and over into town. Then we went to see her mom and dad and drove by the hospital. She also did a little shopping in Winn Dixie and was friendly with the store clerks. I think she is doing better in all areas."

“I’m happy she walked up to the house. I think that is a good sign for me. Perhaps she’s curious.”

“I think she is. As I said earlier, when she asks about you, I tell her she is going to have to find out the answers from you. She takes it very well and seems to understand.”

“What do you all have planned for tomorrow?”

“We haven’t talked about it yet. I’ll let you know as soon as I find out. Howie, you sound a little better today. I know you’ve had a busy five days. I thought you would sound more tired.”

“I am a little tired but have been sleeping well and that’s helped a lot.”

“I’m glad. Well, let me go check on Mama and talk to you as soon as I find out our plans for tomorrow.”

“Sounds good. Sorry I didn’t ask how you’re doing.”

“I’m fine. Hank and I have been talking on the phone and I really like him. Keller is coming to stay with Mama while Hank and I go out.”

“Is it true that you have cleared it with your dad?”

“Sure is.”

“Have a good time Hon!”

“Thanks Howie.”

I went for a walk down toward Tess’s house and turned around when I got to where I could see the house, but if she were on the deck, I was too far away for her to recognize me. I stopped and on the one hand I was so glad to know that she was there and not in some special ops situation, but on the other hand it was so frustrating to know that she was there and still out of reach. My whole body ached for her.

I turned around and walked to the sanctuary and did some deep breathing and thanking the Universe again that she was safe. I did some imagery on staying Centered and being grateful for the moment and all the blessings surrounding me in each moment. I had a couple of beers and a nice supper out on the deck. Went to the office and finished up my client notes, checked in with Si and went straight to bed. PJ and GJ cuddled up beside me and I went right to sleep.

I woke up at seven and felt rested and optimistic about the day. I drank some water, did a few chores, ate part of a granola bar, went outside to a beautiful morning and after a few stretching exercises started my morning routine of running and meditation at the sanctuary.

As usual, I walked from the sanctuary back toward the house. The preserve beach was for the most part deserted, but in the distance, there was someone coming my way. As I got closer, I could tell it was Tess. There was something about the way she walked. I was both nervous and excited. As we got closer, I had

a faint smile and she slowed down and stopped about five feet in front of me and I stopped at the same time.

“Hello Howard.”

“Hello Tess.”

It was obvious we were both nervous.

“I told April when I got up that I thought it was time to see you again. And she told me that every morning you go for a run and meditate and that I might catch you around this time.”

I hesitated, not sure how to respond but finally said, “I’m glad.”

We just looked at each other for a few awkward moments and I finally kind of blurted out, “Would you like a cup of coffee?”

“Yes, that would be nice.”

We walked up to the house in silence. When we got to the deck, I asked, “Would you like to come in while I fix it or would you like to wait out here.?”

Slight smile, “I’ll just wait out here.”

“What would you like in your coffee?”

“Black, and a little milk and a little Splenda.”

“Have a seat and I’ll be right back.”

I was surprised that she remembered exactly how she took her coffee, but April had told me she remembered things like that. I’m still looking for any positive signs and that still seems like a good one.

When I came out with the coffee, she was gone. I looked around and she came around the edge of the house.

“For a moment, I thought you had left.”

Slight smile, “I was tempted, but just walked around your house to see what it was like in the back.”

“I’m glad you didn’t leave.”

We sat down and we sipped our coffee.

“This is good. Thank you.”

“You’re welcome.”

We sat in what to me and I assume to her was an awkward silence.

Then we both started to talk at the same time, and I quickly said, “You go ahead.”

A moment of hesitation and then, “April told me about our relationship before the accident and what all you did for me at the hospital. I’m very grateful.”

Again, not sure how to respond but, “I’m just glad you’re back home.”

More silence as we sipped our coffee.

She continued, “The last couple of days, I’ve tried to imagine what it must be like for you.” She teared up but went on, “For you, it must seem like I died.

April told me how close we were and how that because of you, I was the happiest I had ever been in my life.”

More tears. “But I look at you now and I don’t know you. You’re a stranger to me. And for you, you look at me and see me sitting in front of you and as April described your feelings for me as ‘the love of your life’ and I’m right here and I know you want to hold on to me and kiss me and love me and make love to me and spend your life with me.”

And she starts sobbing. “And I can’t feel anything for you and I’m so so sorry!! More sobbing. “I have to go back home. I don’t feel well.”

She stood up and her knees buckled, and she lost her balance. I caught her and picked her up and took her in the house and laid her on the guest bed. She was still whimpering and kept saying, “I’m sorry, I’m so sorry.”

I said, “I’ll be right back Tess.”

Still crying, “I wanna go home.”

I stepped in the great room and called April. “Is Keller there?”

“Yes.”

“I need you to come up here right now. Your Mom’s okay, but very upset.”

“We’re leaving now.”

I went back to the bedroom with a damp washcloth, and she was almost asleep. She was sweating and I patted her forehead with the washcloth and she muttered, “I wanna go home.”

A couple of minutes later, April came in the kitchen door, “Howie where are you?”

“We’re in the guest bedroom.”

I met her in the great room and gave her a quick summary of what happened.”

She went into the bedroom, and I closed the door. Keller came in the great room, and I briefed him on what happened. About ten minutes later, April and Tess came out of the bedroom.

“Mama wants to go home.”

They put her in the car and left.

About a half hour later, April called, “Hey Howie, I know you’ve been worried sick, but Mama is fine and is sleeping. I just think the stress was too much. But I don’t see this as a setback. Mama and I talked last night, and she wanted to walk up to see you this morning and didn’t tell me what she was going to say. But I know she had a restless night and didn’t sleep well. I expect a good nap and lunch will revive her. As I’ve said, she is getting stronger every day. She is determined to face what’s happened and get on with the life she has right now.”

“That’s all good to hear. If she wants to see me again, what do you think?”

“I think she needs to go ahead. This week she has been progressively getting bored and tired of riding around town.”

“When she wakes up, let me know how she’s doing?”

“Sure will. Talk to you later.”

I made a few calls, worked on my book, and ate lunch. Around one, the phone rang, I didn’t recognize the number.”

“Hello, this is Howard Kingston,”

“Hello Howard, this is Tess. Sorry about this morning.”

“Perfectly fine Tess. I can’t imagine what you’re going through. How are you feeling right now?”

“I took a nap and feel fine. I didn’t sleep well last night, and the nap really helped. I wondered if you could come down this afternoon?”

“Sure. What time?”

“How about two?”

“I’ll be there.”

“Okay, see you then.”

She was sitting on the deck when I got there.

“Hello Howard. Thanks for coming.”

“Hello Tess. Thanks for inviting me. How are you feeling?”

“Much better, thanks.”

Another awkward silence.

Finally, I gently asked, ‘Was there anything specific you wanted to talk about?’

“Other than a thousand questions, no not right now. But you didn’t get a chance to say anything much this morning and I wanted to give you a chance to tell me what you’re going through although I think I have an idea.”

“I think you do too. You expressed my exact thoughts and feelings this morning.”

“Which part?”

“I stood up and went to the edge of the deck and looked out over the water. In a little above a whisper, “I do want to hold you, kiss you, make love to you, hold on to you forever and never let you go.”

I turned around and faced her and continued. “I’ve tried to imagine what it would be like to go through what you’re going through right now. I don’t think it’s possible for me to even begin to know what that’s like. And there’s a part of me that is hesitant to even ask you.”

“Why is that?”

“Because I have lost my Tess, and she may never come back.”

“And I don’t know who I am or who I was and as I said this morning, you are a stranger, and I can’t know what I had with you, so I don’t know what I have lost. It’s like I’m a blank sheet and if it weren’t for April and Keller, I would be terrified.”

“I’m so happy you have them.”

“I’ve had a couple of people come by that April said were my good friends, but I didn’t recognize them. She told them she would contact them when there was a change and when I was feeling better.”

She continued, “April is encouraging me to spend time with you, and I have to admit I’m reluctant to do that right now. But April keeps reminding me how I felt about you; that I chose you to love and to spend the rest of my life with. Trust your judgment. You picked him. You can trust him.”

“What are you thinking?”

“I’m thinking it makes perfect sense, but I’m still hesitant. On the one hand I feel so vulnerable and on the other, I’m determined to get better and willing to do whatever it takes.”

“Could I make a suggestion?”

“Yes, please do.”

“Let’s spend time together and see if you want to be friends.”

“I was the love of your life and now you want to check out a possible friendship?”

I started laughing and April came out on the porch and asked what was so funny.”

When I told her what just happened, she smiled really big and asked her mama, “You want to know what was so funny?”

“Yes.”

“It’s because that question to Howie was so much like the old you.”

“What do you mean?”

“The old you would never let an opportunity to confront anything you thought was ridiculous.”

“I didn’t?”

Both of us in unison, “No!”

She smiled.

April said, “I’ll go back in and leave you two.”

We sat in silence for a while. For me, I was content to look out at the water and sit with her and love her feeling the energy without words or touching or even seeing. For a few moments, I was able to relive being with my Tess as I knew her and loved her knowing that I might not ever get her back, that this might be as good as it gets. And yet content in this moment for that to be enough today, right here, right now.

She asked, "Is it hard to look at me?"

I turned and looked at her with tears running down my cheeks.

She said, "I would give anything to be able to look in your eyes and cry and let the tears run down my cheeks. Somewhere in my heart I must long to love you, but I can't right now. Will you be my friend? Will you wait to see if you again over these few next days and weeks or maybe longer come into my heart and once again become the love of my life?"

"Only if you promise Tess not to try and fall in love with me. Promise me you will let whatever stirs inside and honor that for the sake of who you are right now. And I will promise in as much as I have the strength that I will not try to make you fall in love with me. I will be true to who I am and be open to what unfolds for us both."

She responded, "Howard, I promise I will do the best I can. Right now, I'm tired and need to go lay down. Would it be okay if I walk up to see you in the morning about the same time as today?"

"Yes, I would like that."

She turned around and went inside. I sat down and waited for April. I knew she would want to talk. Several minutes later she appeared.

"I got Mama settled in bed. Howie. What happened? I can tell you've been crying."

I gave her the best I could remember the whole picture.

"So you all will start as friends. I'm relieved. I wasn't sure if she was quite ready."

"She wants to walk up to see me in the morning about the same time she came today."

"I take that as a good sign."

"I'm trying to do that too, but there are so many unknowns."

"I know. But you all were meant to be together and yes, the situation has changed, but I believe with all my heart that your destiny is to be together and nothing can stop that from happening."

Come here honey and give me a hug. She rested her head on my chest and I said. "I don't know what I would have done without you."

"And I feel the same way. You have been my rock through all this. Thank you. I love you."

"I love you too, April."

Stepping Up

The next morning, on my way back from my run and meditation, April called me and said, “She’s on the way,”

“How did she sleep?”

“She slept well and there seems to be a new bounce in her step. I’m not sure what’s happened. I’m hoping the reason is because she’s looking forward to seeing you. She said she was going to do a slow jog up to your house. How did you sleep Howie and how are you feeling?”

“I slept fine Hon and like your mama, I’m feeling a little more energetic. How about you?”

“Mama went to bed early and Hank came over and we had fun talking and walking on the beach. I really like him Howie.”

“I’m glad. I see your mom in the distance. I’ll check in with you later.”

“Howie, you have to make this work.”

“Got it.”

I was doing a cool down walk, and we met almost directly in front of the house. “Hello Tess.”

A little out of breath, “Hello Howard.”

“I just talked to April, and she said you were going to do a slow jog all the way up here. That’s impressive given everything you’ve been through.”

“I think I may have overdone it a bit. Can we go sit on your deck?”

“Sure, can I give you my arm?”

“No that won’t be necessary.”

“Would you like some water and/or a cup of coffee?”

“I’ll take both thank you.”

“I’ll be right back.”

I noticed it was getting hot with the morning sun even in the shade so I turned around and asked, “Would you like to come inside? It’s warming up pretty fast.”

“Yes, I would.”

I opened the door for her and motioned for her to follow me. “Have a seat in the nook and I’ll get your drinks.”

“I like your nook.”

“Thanks. It’s one of my favorite places in the house.”

“Have you lived here long?”

I gave her the short version of the history of the house and how I came to live here and the story about adding the office.

“Can you give me a brief tour of the house? I keep hoping I will recognize something on the island or in the town. Of course, I don’t even recognize my own house, but something in yours might jog my memory,”

“Sure.” I showed her around and introduced her to PJ and GJ. PJ rubbed up against her leg and GJ took off for the guest room.

“Did PJ like me before?”

“Yes, sorry, but he likes everybody. GJ only likes me and two other people, my daughter Si and April.”

“How did April get to know GJ?”

“She spent some time with me while you were gone.”

“Why didn’t she stay with her dad?”

“She did stay with them on the weekend.”

“Why not the rest of the time?”

“That’s something you need to talk to April about. I do want to say that Arthur and I met and talked about the arrangement, and we were both in agreement.”

“Okay, I can talk to her later.”

I continued, “The first time April came here with you, we were here talking right where we are now, and I told her about GJ and she went to the guest room where GJ hangs out and they bonded right away. By the way, that was the same time and day when Mark called and told you about your orders to report for a special operations assignment. You went to the guest room and told April and she was very upset remembering your deployment to Afghanistan. She was scared you would be gone for a longer time and would get injured again and maybe die.”

“I feel terrible about putting her through that again. She is so young to have to go through that twice.”

“Before you left, you designated me as ‘your next of kin’. You left on a Monday night, and I got the call from Mark around 2AM about ten days later to tell me what happened. April was spending the night here so as not to wake her I went outside down near the water to deal with my own pain and fear and panic and a few minutes later called Arthur and he came right over. We were down near the office and somehow April heard us talking and came out already almost hysterical when she saw us and guessed something had happened to you.”

Tess couldn’t hold back the tears.”

As a reflex, I reached over and put my hand on top of hers and she immediately withdrew her hand and I said, “I’m sorry.”

She said, “No, I’m sorry. I know you’re just trying to help.”

“It took me until later that morning to pull myself together. In the meantime, I had been back on the phone with Mark, and he was giving me updates on your condition and what they were planning. Right now, I can’t even remember how long it took for the Army doctors to let us know through Mark that they had done everything they could and that they were going to transfer you to the VA hospital in Charleston. All I can say was it seemed like an eternity.”

“Someday, I’ll tell you how April and I took over from this end and arranged everything from the moment you landed in Charleston until the time you were released. During this period, your daughter and I were a team. She made calls, made arrangements, coordinated updates for the family, conferred with the physicians and very seldom left your side.”

“What did you do?”

“There you are again Tess. When you say/ask something like that, I think you’re back. That is so like you, teasing and joking.”

“What if I wasn’t teasing and joking?”

“There you go again. Then I would say that’s not like you.”

“But I was teasing and joking. April told me about all the things you did to make sure everything went smoothly and that you even arranged to be in the hangar when they transferred me into the hospital,”

“That would not have been possible without help from Jason Woodward. Do you know who he is?”

“Yes, he called me a day or two after I got home and introduced himself as my CO at the Reserve Center. He seemed very worried about me.

“Yes, he was.”

“He told me about my time at the Reserve Center and that I was a major and second in command.”

We were silent for a few minutes, not as awkward as past silences.

“Would you like to hear more about your daughter?”

“Yes, I would.”

“I watched her go from a sweet and funny 14 year old girl to a competent and mature 14 year-old young woman. You don’t remember what she was like, but you all had a wonderful relationship. I’m so proud of her. In that short period of time, I came to love her like a daughter.”

I continued, “I don’t know the future for us, but I can tell you that she and I will be like family for the rest of our lives. We will let nothing change how we feel. There was a bond between us that came about as we joined together to care for, to protect, to tag team a plan that would eventually lead to the healing of the most important person in our lives. And we are still committed to that plan!”

And tears rolled down both our cheeks. We sipped our coffee as we both looked out the window finding it hard to meet the eyes of the other. Both afraid.

that Tess would never get back her memory and me that she and I would never be the same again.

After a little more silence, I asked her what she knew about her past. She said April had filled her in on as much as she could remember about her background and history both in and out of the military.

She said “When I asked her about our relationship, she told me again that I would have to ask you about that. I also got a call from Mark Harris the same day I got the call from Jason Woodward. He explained who he was and expressed how sorry he was about everything that happened. When I asked him for more details, he promised to keep in touch with me and you. He said it was your call about when I was ready to hear the details. I asked him why you? He said you all had been coordinating every step of the way since my injury and he trusted you and your opinion as a psychotherapist to make that call.”

She hesitated and then in a lower voice continued, “He also told me that while he and I were training for the mission that I couldn’t stop talking about how wonderful you were and how much I loved you.”

I said, “Words could never describe those four days we had together.”

“I wasn’t there and yet I can see in your expressions how much I meant to you. When you look at me, it’s like your eyes sparkle and it’s embarrassing. I feel uncomfortable and want to escape.”

More silence that went on for a while.

She asked, “Does it ever cross your mind that I am almost as much a stranger to you as you are to me? I am not the woman you fell in love with.”

I must have looked stunned because I was.

“I don’t think I’ve allowed myself to even consider that scenario.”

More silence.

“But Tess, you are the woman I fell in love with. April and I have seen little bits of you coming back. And yes, you are in some ways like a stranger, but in other ways you are the same Tess with amnesia. In situations like this, there is not enough data to take a stand on any outcome. But I think the Tess I love is in there waiting to unfold as time passes even if you don’t regain your memory.”

She said, “I have no idea if that’s possible, but I feel so sad for you. I can’t imagine what it must be like to have found me and now I’m gone. I want to say to you that I’ll try to love you, but I know that’s not what you want.”

“No, that’s not what I want, and I can’t have what I really want right now. So, I’m asking you to please give being friends a chance. If you can just do that, I’ll do the best I can to let you go if you decide that friendship is all you want from me.”

“That is the least I can do Howard,”

“Would you like more coffee?”

“No thanks.”

“Are you hungry?”

“Do you have any bagels or maybe a piece of toast?”

“Yes, I have bagels.”

“Will you toast me a half?”

“Sure. Cream cheese?”

“That would be nice.”

Smiling, “That’s exactly how you always wanted your bagels.”

Smiling back, “I think that as a sign is a stretch.”

“I’ll take anything I can get.”

She was looking out the window while I was getting it ready and said, “I think I’m ready to ask you about us.”

I brought the bagels to the table, and she turned around and asked, “When and how did we meet?”

“About three years ago you called me and scheduled a therapy appointment,”

“Why did I need therapy?”

“You had had a traumatic experience related to the loss of your ear while in Afghanistan and were suffering with Post Traumatic Stress which we now call PTS. You were having nightmares, flashbacks, panic attacks, depression, alcohol problems and trying to adjust to having one ear.

“How long was I in therapy?”

“About five months.”

“Did the therapy work?”

“You were skeptical at first, but you worked hard and when we terminated, you were pleased with your progress, and I was pleased that I had been able to help.”

I continued, “But there was a situation that occurred during the therapy.”

“What kind of situation?”

“We fell in love with each other.”

“What?”

“We fell in love with each other.”

A slight smile, “How did you all fall in love?”

A slight smile back, “That’s right. You weren’t there.”

I continued, “I don’t know. We just did. We never talked about it. When you get your memory back, it would be a fun conversation.”

“Why didn’t you talk about it?”

“We only got together about three weeks ago.”

“Why only three weeks ago.”

“First, neither one of us knew we were in love with the other. And I was required by ethical regulations to wait two years before any kind of contact with a client after the last session. During our last session, you suggested that we might have coffee together at some point. That’s when I let you know about the two-year rule.”

“So, you had no contact for the two years?”

“We bumped into each other a couple of times at the grocery store, but only spoke and there was no conversation. Those were the hardest two years of my life. Fortunately, I have a wonderful family and friends, so I had a lot of support and encouragement.”

“What happened after the two years were up? If I’m doing the math right, you didn’t get together for another five or six months.”

“That’s true.”

“Why not?”

“As you know, you and April were really close. I’m not sure what the two years were like for you. In our four days together, we didn’t get around to talking very much about those years, we were too engaged in loving each other.”

I continued, “I don’t know what you shared with April during that time. When the two years were up, I do know you and Arthur had been divorced for a while and that you and April were living together.”

I continued, “Tell April if it’s alright with her and you agree, I would like for her to tell you what you were going through during that period. If you don’t get your memory back but things work out for us, I’ll tell you my side of the story during that same period.”

We sat in silence for a while, both looking out at the water.

I asked, “Would you like some lunch?”

“No thank you Howard. Would you take me home? I’m feeling tired and need to lay down.”

I took her home. She hugged April and went straight to her bedroom. April and I sat on the deck for a few minutes.

“How did you all do?”

I gave her a brief summary of the visit and what we talked about and mentioned my idea that she talks to her mama about what she remembers about those two and a half years before we got together. She agreed to do that telling me that she didn’t have much to tell her before she and her dad were divorced. But, from the time when they moved in together, she would tell her as best she could everything she remembered during that period. We hugged and I left.

I had called Henry to check in and stopped by to see Si. We had a good talk and then I went with her to pick up the kids. I stayed around and played with them a while and then headed home. On the way, I got a call from April. Her Mom had

asked her to invite me to dinner. I accepted. I got some chores done, got cleaned up and headed out.

I walked down toward the house, and I was surprised that Tess met me halfway. We headed back to her house. “Are you feeling better?”

“Yes, I must have slept at least two hours. I guess I needed that.”

“Do you think you might be trying to do too much?”

“Maybe. Do you think I am?”

“Slow jogging to my house this morning might be an example. That’s over two miles. We talked in therapy about the importance of paying attention to your body. It took me a long time to learn that myself. The body has a lot of wisdom.”

“Do you think I need therapy?”

“No, right now I think you just need more time to build up your physical strength. Do you think you need therapy?”

“I don’t know. Sometimes I feel lost and alone and I get really scared. I feel like April and Keller, and you are all I have.”

“Maybe it would be helpful to spend some time with your friends. April could help make the arrangements.”

“I don’t know if I’m ready for that yet.”

“I’ve got an idea. I have tomorrow off. Why don’t we take a day trip. We could visit your mom and dad and maybe have lunch with them. We could look at the map and see if there is any other place you would like to go. Would you like to talk with April about it and see what she thinks?”

“Yes, I think so.”

“You seem a little hesitant.”

“I am. I’m just not sure what to do.”

I stopped and held out my hands and she put hers in mine and I said, “I want you to look in my eyes and see if you can go deeper and look into my heart. I want you to understand that I will take care of you and keep you safe and I will introduce you to this world you find yourself in right now until you feel safe in your own mind and body.”

With some hesitation, “Okay. Thank you.”

When we got to the house, April and Hank were sitting on the deck. She got up and hugged her mama and then me. She said, “Hank and I were wondering if you all mind us going out to eat and a movie?”

“No Honey, that’s fine. Just be back by ten.”

“Mama, there is a lot of food in the fridge, but I haven’t cooked anything for you all to eat.”

I said, “That’s fine, we’ll find something to fix. You all go ahead if it’s alright with your mama.”

“Go ahead April. You all have fun. Be careful.”

We cooked some hamburgers and ate mostly in silence. It seemed a little more comfortable to me. I wondered if it was to her too but decided not to ask her.

She asked, "Can we go for a walk?"

"Sure."

We walked a little while in silence and then she said, "For the last few days, I've been trying to figure out what to do next. There's something stirring in me, some form of energy that is speaking to me and saying something like, 'You need to get off your ass and get your shit together and find a path forward and stop waiting around for something to happen.'"

That sounded a lot like Tess. We kept walking and I was not about to open my mouth. This was not a lost and scared Tess. This was the Tess, the combat helicopter pilot, the combat veteran who risked her lifetime and time again in the war and the Tess who saved the life of three of her comrades and was a hero during this special ops mission. She was beginning to emerge. This was hope!

She stopped, took my arm and turned to me. "Howard, you and April have saved my life. Like you said, you all have been a team and have made it possible for me to reach this point. It's now time for me to step up and as they say, 'Get this show on the road!' I've been doing some thinking and have a tentative strategy."

I asked, "How can I help?"

She hesitated, "I'm not sure yet. It may be a day-to-day thing."

I asked, "Have you told her yet?"

"No, I plan to talk with her when she gets home."

I said, "I think you know I'll be available to help in any way I can."

"I don't know how long this is going to take. But every day I'll have my plan for the day. Some days I may be gone most of the day. But I'll leave no earlier than nine and be home by six. I would like for us to run together each morning and if you're okay with it, I would like for April, you, and me to have supper together either at my house or your house. Of course, others could eat with us too like Keller, Hank, or anyone else you all would like to invite. It would help if you and April could plan those meals. I will be keeping a journal of everything. I want to stay focused on the journey and the implications and so on."

"So, it sounds like you're going to be taking some day trips to as you said, 'get this show on the road'."

She looked in my eyes and said, "You know I can't promise you anything, but this is for all of us. But especially, I want more than anything to get my memory back. I want me back to experience being madly in love with you, to celebrate what we experienced in those four days and a life of loving each other for as long as we live. I am determined and at the same time scared I will never have those memories back and the love I felt for you."

I had nothing but tears as we held hands and walked back toward the house.

The Plan

We walked awhile in silence and then I asked, “What do you think about April spending so much time with Hank?”

“He seems like a nice young man. I just think April is a little young to get too serious. But he has been a great support for her and I’m grateful for that. We’ll just take a day at a time.”

“Sounds good.”

When we reached the house, April was walking in the door.

Tess said, “You’re home a little early.”

Smiling, “After we ate, Hank caught me yawning and asked if I was tired and I told him I was ‘kinda of tired’. He offered to bring me home and I accepted.”

“I like that boy. Honey, if you’re not too tired. I wanna talk to you.”

“Sure Mama. I’m not that tired.”

Howard, would you mind cleaning up the dishes?”

“Mama, I can get them later.”

I butted in, “I don’t mind. It will give me something to do while you all talk.”

“Thanks Howard.”

April followed her out to the patio.

After finishing the dishes, I went out front and checked in with Si and then Mom and Dad. Just as I hung up, Tess said, “Howard, can you come in?”

She led me back onto the patio.

Tess said, “I have talked with April about everything you and I talked about. Do you all have any questions?”

“But what if you get lost?”

“Keller has worked with me on how to use the GPS and I have gotten good at it.”

April asked, “Does Keller know about your plan?”

“Yes, I talked to him yesterday because he and your dad had made special plans several weeks ago to go to a ballgame today in Charleston for a father and son outing. He’s on board.”

She looked at April. “When I talked to Howard a little while ago while we were on the beach. I told him that I was doing this to do everything in my power to get ‘me’ back, the ‘me’ that was madly in love with him and to you I say the ‘me’ that can cherish our history and remember all the wonderful times we had together and give me an opportunity to ask you to forgive me for the times I failed you in one

way or another. And the ‘me’ that remembers all the other important people in my life.”

April asked, “Will you let us know how you’re doin’?”

“There may be some things I’m working on that I want to keep to myself for a while but ask me any questions you want, and I’ll let you know. I won’t be trying to keep anything from you two, but I will need to concentrate and focus on what I’m doing. I’ll be journaling every step of the way and when this is all over, I will share everything I have written down. I’m just asking both of you to be patient.”

I asked, “Is there anything else we can do?”

“Every day, I will probably have some things you can do to help.”

“Howard, can you and I can go for a run in the mornings? Can we meet at your house at 7:30? I think I’ll just drive. The three of us, plus Keller, Hank or anyone else we invite will eat supper either here or Howard, at your house. April, you and Hank are not to be here by yourselves.” Smiling, “Sorry, but Keller is not an approved chaperone. When I’m not here you can meet with Hank at Howard’s or at your dad and Holly’s house.”

She continued, “Howard, while I was talking to April a few minutes ago, I decided that I will drive myself tomorrow, but thanks for the offer to help. Thanks to both of you for taking care of dinner. Howard, can you take April on errands and grocery shopping when you’re available? April, I’ve told Keller to help you with transportation when Howard is not available. At supper each night, I will let you all know my plans for the next day.”

Pause. “I can’t think of anything else. Do you all have any questions?”

Both of us nodded no.

Tess said, “I’m feeling tired. I think I’ll go to bed.”

I said, “Rest well and I’ll see you in the morning for our run.”

“Thanks Howard.”

We sat there for a few minutes.

I asked, “Whatta you think?”

“I’m so glad she has this attitude. I’m feeling a little relieved that she’s doing something.”

“Me too. I think it’s a good sign. And the fact that she wants minimal help from us means she’s letting go of some of her fears and gaining some confidence.”

“What am I gonna do all day? I’ve gotten used to having Mama around and doing things with her.”

“Have you talked to Leslie since she’s been back from vacation? I forgot to tell you that Harriet called me when they got back from vacation asking about your mama. I gave her the update and I’m sure she told Leslie. Maybe you all could spend some time together.”

“Maybe I’ll call her. I could spend the days at your house and maybe Hank and Keller could come over some and Leslie could come over too.”

“That’s fine with me. You’ll need to run that by your mama. She’ll be coming back here after our run to get ready. She could drop you off at my house when she leaves. Since I’m free tomorrow, we could plan our menus and go to the store to pick up groceries.”

I continued, “Since it looks like you’ll be staying at my house during the day, it will be easier for us to eat there. You and I can tag team preparing supper and if they are available, we can invite Hank, Keller, and Leslie to eat with us. They can also come over during the day. On the days I’m working, I’ll keep an eye on you all from the office.”

“Is there anything else you want to talk about?”

“I can’t think of anything.”

I got up, “Okay, so call me later and let me know what your mama thinks about our plan. I’ll see you tomorrow morning.”

“Do you have to leave now?”

“Come here.” I took her in my arms. “What’s going on with you Hon?”

She started softly crying. “I don’t know. Suddenly, I just feel sad and alone. What if Mama never comes back?” More tears. “What if she doesn’t love me like she used to? What if we can’t laugh at all the funny things we used to do? What if we can’t do all the fun stuff we used to do? I want my mama back so bad!”

In that moment, I felt an arm go around my waist Tess maneuvered her head between us and she was crying, and the tears were flowing. We stood there together with only the sound of sniffing and the feel of lightly shaking bodies as we poured out in tears our grieving and longing and loneliness. After a few more moments, I said very softly, “We can do this. We can do this. We can do this.” And then Tess and April joined in softly and then it got a little louder and then a little louder and it got louder until we were screaming, We can do this!!!.... each of us trying to scream louder than the others and then we all started laughing and fell exhausted onto the sofa.

As the laughter died down, I got up and said, “I’ve got to get away from you two nut cases.”

And then Tess, shouted, “Go ahead and desert us numb nuts!!” and then April joined in, and they were both yelling, “Go ahead and desert us numb nuts!!” over and over as I took off up the beach and they came out in the sand and kept yelling/screaming and people were staring, and I looked back and they were in hysterics.

I thought to myself, we’re getting there.

The next morning, Tess came at 7:30 and we went for a run.

She said, “Howard, if it’s alright, I’ll set the pace. Of course, I don’t remember what my normal pace was, but somewhere in my mind is ‘let your body dictate your pace’. This seems pretty slow.”

“I like your idea.”

She was quiet during the run and when we got back to the house, she said, “April told me about the plan for the week and it’s fine with me. I’ll drop her off here on my way out and I will call you all when I get home and see you for supper a little after that.”

She drove away and I felt depressed. She was all business this morning and there was no mention of yesterday and the fun the three of us had screaming and laughing. On the other hand, I felt encouraged that she was determined to do this on her own.

She dropped off April about an hour later and drove away before I could get outside to wish her well.

April hugged me and said, “Mama’s on a mission. She didn’t say much of anything to me this morning.”

“She didn’t say much to me either. I trying to take that as a good sign.”

“Me too.”

“I thought we could plan our menu for the week and then go to Winn Dixie and The Market to pick up the groceries.”

“Sounds good. I asked Leslie if she could come over today for lunch and spend the afternoon. I don’t think I thanked you for letting me stay with you this week and I should have asked you if it was okay to invite her.”

“Hon, I told you yesterday it was fine to have any of them come this week.”

“Thanks Howie!”

“You’re welcome. Let’s go plan our menus and go pick up our groceries.”

Harriet dropped off Leslie around noon and we chatted for a few minutes and she left saying she would pick up Leslie around 4:30 or 5. The girls seemed to have a good time sunbathing on the beach listening to music and spending time with PJ and GJ inside when they needed a break from the sun. I worked some in the office and a few projects outside.

Keller came over and ate with us. We were all eager to hear what Tess had been up to.

After some small talk around the table and finishing our meal, we all went out on the deck.

Tess said, “I’ll give you all a short version of my day. I had a nice visit with Mom and Dad. I talked with Dr Wade at the VA Center last week and told him I was on a mission to get my memory back. Keller, you may not remember him. He was my Neurologist. He told me one of his best friends specialized in treating amnesia and he set me up with an appointment at one o’clock today. I have never had such a

thorough battery of tests and consults with different clinicians. It took about four hours.”

She continued, “The whole experience today made me feel good about myself. You all have taken such good care of me, and I realized I was too dependent on all of you and because of that, I was feeling stuck and somewhat desperate. I now have the courage to pursue my healing and do whatever is necessary to explore my life as it is in this moment and to do everything I can to recover the life that has been lost for now.”

April responded, “I think I’m still feeling like I want to protect you and take care of you.”

“I understand Honey, but I’m telling you to trust me and know that I am determined to move on and find my way. Even if I don’t get my memory back, I’m ready to be the best mother I can be to you and to you too Keller.” Slight smile, “On the other hand, I’m not sure what to do about the man sitting here with us. What was your name again?”

“Numb nuts.”

“That is not a promising sign.”

“Got it.”

We all laughed.

“I will tell you that I have an appointment at eight in the morning with the Brain Center that did all the testing. The doctor will give me the results of the testing. After that I am going to the Reserve Center and spend the day with Jason.”

Keller asked, “Who is he again?”

“He is my boss at the Reserve Center.”

“Jason is going to give me a tour of the center and then go over the history of all the things we have done together since being assigned there ten or so years ago. Howard, of course I won’t be here in the morning.”

“Right, April you can spend the night here if you want to.”

“That would be great so I can sleep in. Is that okay Mama?”

“Yes, that would help me out too.”

“Howie, I talked to Leslie, and she can come over and spend the day with me again tomorrow if that’s okay.”

“That’ fine.”

Tess asked, “Keller, can you join us for supper tomorrow night.”

“Sure, can I bring Hank?”

“Howard, is that alright with you?”

“Yes, that’s fine.”

“Sounds like we’re all set for tomorrow. Can we eat around six?”

“Sure.”

“If you all don’t mind, I’m tired. I wanna write in my journal, take a walk, and then go to bed.”

We all walked her out to her vehicle; hugs all around and she was gone. Keller said he would see us tomorrow afternoon and he also left.

“What do you think Howie?”

“I like what I’m hearing and at the same time feel a little shut out.”

“Me too, but I’m like you, I feel more hopeful.”

“I’m glad you got hold of Leslie. I’ve got a full day tomorrow. There’s plenty of food in the fridge. I finish at five. You and I can tag team supper. Leslie can stay for supper if you like.”

“She can’t. Her mom is picking her up at four.”

“How are things with you and Hank?”

“Pretty good. When Keller is around, all they do is talk about football which is very boring.”

“Got it.”

“Other than that, I still really like him.”

“I’ve got some work to do over at the office. What do you wanna do?”

“I’ll watch some TV and then go to bed early. I’m really tired.”

“I hope you sleep well. I predict PJ and GJ will sleep with you.”

“I hope so. I hope you sleep well too Howie. I love you.”

“I love you too Sweetie.”

I headed out for my run in the morning and April walked north to meet me on the way back. We walked to the house and had a light breakfast. I showered and got ready for work and April was curled up on the couch with PJ and GJ. I kissed her on the cheek and asked as I headed form the door, “What time does Leslie come?”

“Ten.”

I’ll see you all for lunch around one.”

“Okay.”

After my last client of the day, I headed back to the house. Keller and Hank were throwing a football. April was in the kitchen setting the table. I changed and we fixed spaghetti with a tossed salad and garlic bread.

Tess pulled in around 5:45. She looked tired. She waved at the boys, came in the kitchen, kissed April, and said, “Hey Howard.”

“Mama, you look exhausted. Why don’t you go and lay down for a while?”

I said, “A great idea. April can wake you up around seven or later if you want.”

Tess responded, “Thank you all. Wake me at seven.”

She remembered where the guest bedroom was from her visit last week.

We had our supper with some light conversation.

When we were finished, April said, “Mama, how was your day?”

“All the physical testing at the Brain Center showed no brain damage that would rule out a complete recovery of my memory. And all the psychological testing produced the same conclusion. I was however expecting them to tell me they could not predict if I would regain my memory or if I did when that might happen.”

Keller said, “Mom, that sounds like a waste of time.”

“Not really Keller. Actually, it gave me hope.”

“In what way?”

“Up until this morning, Dr Wade had said the same thing, but he was only giving an educated guess. He had told me I needed to get a full workup to check for the nature of any brain injury. It gives me hope because they had scientific data to back it up Dr. Wade’s prediction.”

“Mama, what about the Reserve Center?”

“As I told you all, I spent the rest of the day with Jason. We talked for hours touring all parts of the Reserve Center as he recalled the different experiences we had been through together and the numerous personnel we commanded over the ten years. I had no memory of any of what he talked about. I was however amazed what all we had accomplished together over those years.”

“He took me out to the hangar and asked me if I recognized either of the two models of choppers. I didn’t recognize either model. He said the smaller chopper was a Loach and the larger was a Huey. He said I had flown the Loach in some exercises with our Reserve unit, but my expertise was with the Huey, and I had flown many combat missions in that model.”

“At that point, I was getting discouraged hoping there would be some recall. I asked him if he could take me up in the Huey. He said ordinarily, we are not cleared to fly because of budget restrictions, but he had called his CO in Columbia and when he told him it was me and the circumstances, he agreed to clear us for 30 minutes in the air.”

“Jason had called one of the pilots to come in for the flight. I had to sit in the bay of the chopper for obvious reasons.”

Keller again, “What’s a bay and how come?”

“A bay is short for ‘cargo’ bay behind the pilots. No one is allowed to fly a Huey in the military without a copilot. Anyway, we flew around for the 30 minutes with our headphones, and they talked the whole time about the chopper and the controls and different skills in flying. I was very disappointed that nothing about flying came back to me.”

“When we got back to the hangar, the copilot came up to me and said, ‘Major Angelina, I was so sorry to hear about what happened. You have taught me so much over the last few years about flying and to hear what you did on that mission, I’m speechless and all I can say is that I am so proud and honored to serve with you’.”

“To hear that was just so unreal. Everyone tells me I’m a hero and I have no idea what they’re talking about. I thanked Jason for all he did for me today. We both had some tears in our eyes. He walked me to the car and here I am.”

Tess asked all of us about our day. I think we all felt a little flat with our descriptions after hearing about her day. No one wanted dessert.

Tess said, “I’m sorry you all that I’m so tired a lot of the time, but I’ve got a long day tomorrow. I need to get some rest.

“Mama, can I spend the night here again?”

“Did you ask Howard?”

“Howie, can I spend the night here?”

“It’s fine with me.”

Keller asked, “If it’s alright with Howie, Hank and I would like to ‘hang’ here for a while and I’ll plan to sleep at Dad’s.”

“Alright.” She looked at me. “Howard, I won’t be able to make the run again tomorrow morning.”

“Understand. Hope you have a good day tomorrow.”

“Thanks. Hope you all have a good day too.”

I watched her through the window drive away and felt a pang of emptiness. There had been no time this week for any time to work on our friendship. It was like she was slipping away.

April and Hank were finishing up the dishes and she came over and gave me a hug. “I feel it too. She’s seemed kind of distant this week.”

“I know. I think she is totally focused on her plan to do everything she can to awaken her memory.”

She said, “And so far, it seems like there has been no progress.”

“It sure does.”

21

Tess

I woke up a little after 6:30, checked on April who was sleeping soundly with PJ and GJ cuddled next to her and wrote her a note to let her know I had gone for a run and would be spending some time in my sanctuary.

I needed some time to get Centered. Buddy was awake after being quiet for some days and he was preaching gloom and doom, “She is never going to get her memory back and the chances of her falling back in love with you are slim to none.”

“Shut up Buddy.”

I went for my run and pushed myself more than usual. I was feeling angry. Angry at Buddy, angry at myself for not being Centered and generally angry at the situation. I was gasping for air when I got to my sanctuary around seven.

I started my Centering meditation with some breathing and began one of my favorite chants, “The Spirit is around us like a rainbow ‘round the sun.” I got louder and louder and was beginning to feel the vibrations and stood up and opened my hands and arms and welcomed into my body the sunbeams shining through the trees.

I don’t know how long that lasted but at some point, I realized someone was coming up the path from the beach. I blinked my eyes and lowered my voice until like a whisper and even though the sun was blurring my vision, I recognized April.

“I could hear you from way down the beach.”

“Was I that loud?”

“Yes. Is that your meditation?”

“Yes, one of them.”

“I thought meditations were supposed to be quiet.”

“No one gets to define a meditation. A meditation is created by the meditator and can take any form or no form.”

“So, what’s the purpose?”

Smiling, “That’s also personal.”

“What was your purpose?”

“To get Centered.”

“What does that mean? Oh, that’s personal too.”

“Come here and give me a hug.”

“I’ll pass. You’re all sweaty and wet.”

Smiling, "Oh, I forgot. Let's walk back to house and I'll tell you my short version of how I define getting Centered today."

We walked down to the edge of the water and headed south.

"I found myself feeling angry this morning at the whole situation. I was angry at God, myself, the Army, the doctors, your mama, you and so on."

Turning to face me, "Why are you angry with me?"

"Because PJ and GJ want to sleep with you and not with me anymore."

Sternly, "That's not my fault Howie. You need to sing more verses about the Spirit being in like some kind of rainbow."

"Perhaps."

"No, not perhaps. You need to sing it."

I yelled it at the top of my lungs.

She quickly looked around, "Stop stop, I take it back. Now I know why Mama calls you 'numb nuts'. Why were you angry with Mama?"

"Because she made me fall in love with her, then left me and now won't get her memory back."

You're joking, right?"

"No, I'm not joking, I'm insane!"

She shoved me and I almost lost my balance.

"You are so much like your mama."

"How so?"

"She would have shoved me too or done worse."

"So, getting Centered means stop being angry and insane and calm down."

"That's it in a nutshell."

"Someday, teach me that chant. I could use it myself."

"I will."

We walked in the house, and I said, "Would you rustle up some grub and make some coffee? I have to shower and get ready for work."

"Have you gotten Centered?"

"Yes, for the most part."

"Okay."

"She had fired some bacon and made French toast."

"Where did you learn to cook like that?"

"Where do you think?"

"Your mama."

"Bingo pinhead!"

"And that phrase?"

"My mama."

I said, "Figures! On a more serious note, I have a full day with a short lunch break at 12:45."

"I'll make you a sandwich and have it ready when you come over."

"That would be great."

"I called Leslie earlier and is it okay if she comes over?"

"As long as it's okay with her mom."

"Keller and Hank still want to come over too."

"I guess since you're making me a sandwich."

"Can I show them your sanctuary?"

"How about another day? I'd feel more comfortable if you all stayed around the house where I can see you from my office."

"We can do that."

I ate my breakfast, gave her a hug and left.

They were in the nook eating lunch when I came in. They moved over and made a place for me. While I ate my sandwich, April and I talked about what we were going to fix for supper.

When I went out in the waiting room at four to get my client, April was there and said, "Can't I speak to you for a minute?"

I motioned to my client, "You can go on back and I'll be with you in a minute."

"What's up?"

"Mama called me about twenty minutes ago and said it had been a long day and she was going home to rest and wanted to know if I could bring the supper we had planned for here to our house and eat there instead of here?"

"Sure, that would be fine."

"She said to tell you to come about 6:30."

"Sounds good. Can you get all the food together?"

"Yes, Leslie is going to help me and of course the boys will drive us."

"Sounds like a plan."

She hugged me and left.

After my last client left, I went for a quick swim, took a shower, and finished getting dressed and the phone rang. It was April.

"Hey Howie, how was the rest of your afternoon?"

"It was fine. How is your mama?"

"She was still asleep when we got here. She woke up about fifteen minutes ago and said she felt a little better,"

"Did you get any indication about how her day went?"

"When I asked her, I could tell she was still discouraged, but trying not to show it. Anyway, she said she wanted to get some exercise and I suggested she

could walk up to your house, and you could meet her and come on back here for supper.”

“Sounds like a plan. Has she left yet?”

“Yes, about ten minutes ago and told me to call her if you had already left and were driving.”

“Got it. Okay, I’m going to wait some time before I start walking so when we meet, we won’t be very far from here. I’m going to ask her to come back here for a glass of wine. We haven’t had much time alone and I want to talk to her about ways we can explore our friendship.”

“But Mama has two more days by herself where she wants to explore getting her memory back.”

“I know and I’m going to respect that, but since there has not been much progress yet, I want to talk to her about trying not to get her hopes up and remembering that if this week doesn’t make it happen, there is still plenty of time to keep working on her goal and time to make new memories and explore our friendship. What do you think?”

“Honestly, I’m feeling a little discouraged myself. She told me a little about today and if what she did today doesn’t bring back her memory, I don’t know what will.”

“I’ll let her tell me about it. Why don’t you kids go ahead and eat. I’m eager to spend as much time alone with her as I can, and I have plenty here to eat if I can convince her to stay for a while.”

“Okay Howie. Keep me posted!”

“Will do Hon. Love you,”

“Love you too.”

I started walking south. I could see her in the distance. She was about a half mile away. When we got closer, she gave me a little wave and I gave her a little wave back. And then she was right in front of me.

Slight smile, “Hello Howard.”

“Hey Tess. How you doin’?”

“Pretty good. The kids were busy working on supper, and I needed some exercise after my nap so I thought I would walk up and meet you.”

“Sorry, I didn’t get further down the beach.”

“That’s okay. The walk did me good.”

“Would you come up the house and have a glass of wine with me?”

“I guess. But April is expecting us for supper.”

We walked into the kitchen.

“When she called to let me know you were on the way, I told her I was going to ask you to have a glass of wine with me.”

“What did she say?”

“She said,” ‘okay.’

“I hope it was alright, but I told them to go ahead and eat and that I had plenty of food here if we got hungry.”

She looked away and seemed disappointed.

“Was that okay?”

“I just wish we could all have eaten together.”

“I’ll call her and tell her we’re on the way.”

“No, no, that’s okay. To be honest, sometimes I feel a little self-conscious around you when we’re alone. I assume you can guess why.”

“Yes, I can.”

“I’ll take that glass of wine.”

I poured our wine and said, “There’s a nice breeze, let’s sit out on the deck.”

We sat down and she said, “Howard, this deck is such a nice space. Do you spend a lot of time out here?”

“Yes, I love it out here.”

We both were looking out at the ocean and seemed to be lost in our own thoughts.

“I guess you suspect I’m eager to hear about your day.”

“Yes, I know you are.” Short silence. “Howard, I wish I had better news. I thought several times today I was catching a glimpse of something, but then it faded.”

I noticed her glass was empty. “Would you like more wine?”

“Yes, thank you.”

I went in the kitchen and while opening another bottle at the counter, I felt her arms go around me and she whispered in my ear, “My love, I’m home.”

I broke into uncontrollable sobs. I had no words, no breath. I just turned in her arms and held on to her just like that first night when I was so afraid it was a dream; afraid I would wake up and she would be gone.

She kissed my lips, cheeks, tears and clung on to me. “Cry and cry and cry my darling, my love, my life. I can’t imagine what you’ve been through. For me it’s like I left, did my job, and went to sleep and just woke up this afternoon and I’m home. I was only gone less than 2 weeks. And for you it was four weeks and you thought you might have lost me forever. Oh my precious Howie! I’m so sorry!!”

She reached over and got a towel and wiped my tears and I asked, “Is it really you Tess? Am I dreaming?”

“No Sweetheart, you’re not dreaming! Pour my wine and let’s go out on the deck. Do you want more wine?”

“I need a shot of something.”

“Don’t move, I’ll get it for you.”

“I’m right behind you. I’m not letting you get any further than within reach.”

She poured a shot for each of us, and we went out on the deck. I toasted, “To the return of my soul mate, the love of my life, my Princess!”

She said, “Let’s walk on the beach. I left the dress I wore that first night we walked. It’s in the drawer in our room. I’ll get it.”

“I’m right behind you.”

She got it and we walked back to the deck. She took off her shorts, top and sandals and put on the dress and I looked up to the sky, spread my arms and open hands and yelled at the top of my lungs, “Tess is home, my love is home!!!!”

She yelled, “I’ll race you to the water” and she took off. As usual she beat me.

As soon as she reached the water line, she took a knee.

“Tess, what’s wrong?”

“I just feel weak.”

She tried to stand up and I scooped her up in my arms.

“Howie, I’m alright. On the other hand, this feels pretty good,” as she laid her head on my shoulder and kissed my neck.

“Feels wonderful to have you in my arms.”

When we reached the deck, I sat on the lounge, and she sat up on my lap and kissed me. How I missed her sensuous soft kisses that now slowly turned more passionate. I couldn’t get enough of her. We came up for air and I held her as tight as I could without hurting her. My phone rang. We came up for air.

Tess said, “It’s probably April. Put it on speaker.”

“Hey Howie, would you tell Mama that Kent is here and wants to see her right away.”

“Shut up you little shit!”

Laughing, “Got it. I know you all are playing smackie mouth, but I need to know when you two want to come up for air and eat supper.”

I asked, “Why would we want to do that?”

“Because my mama has been through a lot and needs to eat numb nuts.”

Tess, “April, I won’t allow you to talk to Howie like that.”

“Mama, you gave him the name.”

Hesitating, “Now that you mention it, I do recall the name.”

April said, “Enough! Howie, I wish I could have seen your face. I’m so thrilled for you and for me and everyone else who knows and loves Mama.”

“Me too, Honey! I’m speechless.”

“Okay, I’ve got 6:40. What time do you all want to eat?”

I looked at Tess and she said, “We’ll be there at 7:30. Why don’t you all go ahead and eat.”

“No, that’s okay Mama, we’ll wait on you all. Go back to kissing and we’ll see you soon. Stay out of the bedroom! We’re hungry!” She hung up.

We both laughed. I asked, “How much do you remember since you woke up in the hospital until this afternoon?”

“It seems like a dream, but I think I remember right much of it. Can we talk about that later? I want to get back to what we were doing before April called.”

“Me too. Just one more thing. Remember you’ve been through a lot of physical and mental trauma. In the past few days, you have been doing better but physically, you still have a way to go.”

She cuddled up even closer, “So you are worried about my physical stamina?”

“Well in some respects, to some extent.”

Smirking, “What does that mean?”

“The bedroom could be or is an exception.”

“Which is it?”

“Is.”

Smiling, “Let’s disobey April and go lay on the bed.”

“I’m all in.”

Smirking, “Not yet.”

I laid on my back and as usual, she draped one leg over me and cuddled her head in my neck. She said, “I want to tell you about today. You’ll have to help me with some of the details from the time I woke up until the moment I got my memory back this afternoon. We can talk about this in more detail later, but I want to give you the short version. I remember telling you all about my time spent with Jason yesterday. On Monday, I had called Mark and told him I needed help and that I was making no progress getting my memory back.”

“He called me back later that morning and told me had talked to several doctors who work at the Army’s Brain Research and Trauma Center. They had given him several ideas to explore to help me with memory recall. He said he had made arrangements to meet me at the Reserve Center today at 1100.”

“I got there, and Jason had made plans for Mark and me to have lunch at a restaurant close to the Center. Mark talked again about our tour in Afghanistan, how I lost my ear and his admiration for my reputation as the best helicopter pilot in the unit excluding himself of course.”

“He then went through all the details of our preparation for the special operation and then the details of what happened during the operation. He said, ‘There were four Hueys and our mission was to extract the Special Forces soldiers whose mission was to attack and blow up the buildings of a major drug storage warehouse and shipping operation. The intel said the buildings were about a mile into the jungle bordering a small airfield and were not heavily guarded.’

‘The mission went off like clockwork. Our LZ was only big enough for one chopper at a time and about 500 meters from the buildings in the jungle. I was in the first Huey, and you were in the third. I dropped in and picked up my troops and lifted off. Don dropped in and picked up his troops and lifted off. Then you picked up yours and lifted off. Ted dropped in to pick up his and out of nowhere there was an explosion and Ted’s chopper was blown up.’

‘We all saw and heard the explosion. You were probably 100 meters off the ground and radioed there were casualties on the ground still moving and you were going back in. You went dark at that point. I ordered Don to return to base and by the time I circled back you had dropped in and picked up the wounded soldiers and were lifting off the ground while your chopper was taking heavy small arms fire.’

‘I was following you back to base and was wondering how the hell your chopper was still in the air as smoke was coming out of the tail section and you were struggling with keeping the chopper on course. Your radio was also out. Then about twenty meters before you set down, there was a small explosion on the tail and your rotor went dead and you lost control and the chopper then crashed into a tree and you took the brunt of the force. Miraculously, you were the only one seriously hurt. The force knocked your helmet off your head and the trauma to the head followed.’

‘Five died in the explosion at the site, but no one was seriously hurt on your chopper except you. You saved the life of three soldiers and the CO of the operation has recommended to the Secretary of the Army that you be awarded the Silver Star. You’re a hero. I am so proud of you.’”

“I was speechless and of course at that time I had no memory about what happened.”

“I’m so proud of you too my darling!!”

A little embarrassed, she smiled and continued. “Mark went on, ‘Tess, I’ve talked to a number of neurologists and as a team, we’ve put together a plan to hopefully unlock your memory. I’m going to give you the short version.’

‘In about 30 minutes, we’re going back to the airfield. Four of us are going to take a Huey up. I will be the pilot, you the copilot and in the bay will be a neurologist, David from the Brain Center and another pilot, Joseph.’”

“I said, Jason took me up yesterday and I sat in the bay. I watched them and had no clue what they were doing.”

“He responded, ‘This experimental approach to healing brain trauma and amnesia has been approved by the Pentagon. We have taken every safety precaution and have rehearsed a number of trial runs. Even though you don’t remember how to pilot a Huey, we are hopeful this will change during our flight. We have modified this Huey so if needed, Joseph can take over quickly for you. It’s a little complicated, but it works.’

‘For training purposes, we recorded all the radio commo between choppers during the entire mission. We have edited the tape to highlight the period when I first went in until you crashed into the tree. When we lift off, I’m going to ask you to close your eyes and David will control the tape. Any questions?’”

“I asked how is this supposed to work? He said, ‘that’s above your pay grade Major.’”

She continued, “I’m going to make this short. They took me up and I closed my eyes and was instructed not to open my eyes for any reason. I don’t know how long we were in the air, but they played that tape very loud over and over as the chopper made all kinds of abrupt maneuvers to simulate conditions similar to the ones we made during the mission. This of course included all the shouting and explosions and small arms fire.”

“I have no idea how long this went on. It was like I was reliving it over and over and at some point, everything switched from something I was observing to something I was experiencing. It was like I woke from the dream. I opened my eyes and screamed, ‘I’m back!!’”

“Mark said, ‘Take us home Major Angelina!’”

“When we got back to the airfield where Jason and many members of our Reserve Unit were there to greet us. When I got off the chopper, there was a big roar and applause. I greeted everyone and then Mark, Jason, David, Joseph and I went into Jason’s office. Mark handled the debriefing and Jason provided wine and beer.”

“We talked about the experience, and I had questions some of which were answered, and others were not. David explained that this experiment was part of a thrust at the Brain Center to explore experimental treatment for brain trauma and amnesia. For now, they were compiling data and wanted to keep it ‘in house’ for now.”

“David and Joseph left. I looked at these two men who were my mentors and friends. I told them there were no words to adequately express how grateful I was for all they had done for me. To express my gratitude, I gave them both a blow job and left.”

I howled with laughter. “If there’s any doubt about you being back, that comment sealed it!!”

With a straight face, she said, “That was the least I could do.”

Now we were both laughing. She rolled over on top of me and whispered in my ear, “I love you my precious.”

Her phone rang, “What’s up April?”

“Okay Honey, we’ll leave here in five minutes.”

When we got there, Tess said, “Alright everyone, before we eat, let’s go down the list of people who have the good news. I’ll start. I went by to see mom and dad on the way back from Charleston and I came straight here.”

Keller said, “I called dad.”

April said, “I called Si. I hope that was okay Howie. Si has been so good to me through all of this.”

“Perfectly fine April.”

April continued, “I told Leslie.”

Hank said, “I told Dad.”

I said, “I think that only leaves Mom and Dad who will spread the word in our family.”

Tess asked, “Why don’t you call them now while we get supper on the table?”

“Will do.”

We had a delightful time talking, laughing and there were some tears relating to different experiences during these past two weeks. Keller and Hank left around nine as they started football practice tomorrow with “two-a days”. Tess, April, and I cleaned up.

Tess said, “Howie, why don’t you go on. April and I have a lot of catching up to do and I’ll check back in with you after the weekend.”

“But I have to work next week.”

“Oh, well you could meet us at church on Sunday.”

“But, Mama, Kent promised to take us sailing on Sunday.”

I said, “Look you two, it’s been tough enough to put up with just one of you for the two last weeks. I’m not doing this tag team shit again. If you don’t stop, I’m gonna go home.”

In unison, “Go!!”

I smiled, “I have a better idea. Why don’t we all go spend the night at my house.”

About the Author

Banks Hudson is a graduate of the US Military Academy at West Point. He completed Airborne and Ranger training, spent twenty years in the Army and served in Vietnam. He has forty years' experience as a psychotherapist specializing in the treatment of the generalized anxiety disorders to include post-traumatic stress, panic attacks, acute stress, phobias, obsessive-compulsive and teaching clients how to access "the power of the mind and the power of now" to maximize their potential in life and in sports.

Books by the Author

Return to Harvest

A novel about two combat veterans, Jett and Ace, who grew up together, trained as Army Rangers and spent two combat tours in Iraq. They returned home from the war suffering from post-traumatic stress (PTS). You follow their experience of coming home to Harvest, NC and the daily challenges they face to unsuccessfully maintain a sense of sanity.

They, along with eight other combat veterans suffering from PTS are desperate to find some relief from the flashbacks, nightmares, panic attacks and other PTS symptoms. They reluctantly agree to participate in an experimental PTS treatment program led by a psychologist they call, "Doc." In the midst of their hopelessness, rage, despair and tears, they discover healing comes from a source they never expected.

Neural Training for Highly Skilled Athletes

The challenge for highly skilled athletes is consistent mechanical execution. This video training system offers a new and unique way to help these athletes access more consistently and strengthen the neural imprints that hold the neuromuscular memory of their highest mechanical skill level. This short and simple approach can be a powerful and effective compliment to their existing training program.

A Journey to Now

Tess, a helicopter pilot, returns from Afghanistan suffering from post-traumatic stress (PTS). An explosion killed and wounded friends and severed her ear. She suffers from flashbacks, panic attacks, anger, nightmares, a drinking problem, exaggerated startle response and adjusting to having one ear.

Her therapist has some strange ideas. They can be summed up in this glimpse of his approach with her: “You don’t have any problems. Nothing bad has ever happened to you. Waking up is an important key to healing. You have a mistaken identity. Self-esteem is not important, You can slow your racing and/or runaway mind. You are not your body.”

Leadership Training for Mental Toughness in Football

Football coaches live with an ongoing concern for the following: letdowns in and between games, lack of consistency, mental mistakes, sluggish practices, self-defeating behavior, outside distractions, lapse in motivation and a passion for winning.

Coaches do everything they can to prevent these distractions by continuous motivational talks and the use of motivational techniques. These help some, but the key to addressing these issues must come from the within the players.

This manual contains a step-by-step leadership training program for the players designed to address preventing all the situations listed above and with the goal of heightened mental toughness in all phases of practice and competition.

Self-Modeling Video Training

The focus of this system is not video instruction, but video training. The training is designed to help the athlete access and execute more consistently their highest skill level and at the same time build a higher level of confidence.

The core phase of the training consists of watching the athlete execute picture perfect skills over and over during training and/or competition with personal audio suggestions to enhance and build confidence.

The research shows the core training stimulates, sharpens, and strengthens the mechanical skill in some of the same ways this happens with repetitive practice. The same neural pathways stimulated by perfect practice would be similarly activated and reinforced with the training video. In other words, the nervous system would react as if it were physically performing the skill.

Sports Video Modeling for Children and Adults

Steven DeVore, the founder of SyberVision along with Dr. Karl H. Pribram, a renowned brain scientist at Stanford University researched in the 1980’s the theory that an athlete could improve mechanical skills by watching a video of a model athlete repeatedly performing mechanically picture-perfect skills.

They found by watching the video that through the sensory imaging, the nervous system would respond to the observed modeled skills almost as if the muscles and body were physically performing the desired action over and over.

This handbook uses that research and develops the structure of a sports video training system designed to maximize accelerated learning in children and adult athletes. It provides an effective and exciting supplement to normal athletic training and can provide a mechanical and mental edge over opponents.

A Peak Performance Handbook

This handbook serves as a compilation of the author's handbooks on sports performance and addresses all athletes, teams, coaches and parents in all sports to include high school, college and professional.

Section I explores the nature of peak performance.

Section II section contains a leadership training program to address the goal of athletes/players taking ownership of the responsibility for everything related to the mental challenges in practice and competition. One benefit of this training is it teaches mental toughness. The training uses a football team as an example.

Section III focuses on the training designed to strengthen mental alertness, concentration and attention to each moment in practice, execution and competition.

Section IV explains the use of anchoring designed to help improve consistency at peak performance and to serve as a shifting device from poor performance to peak performance for individuals and for teams.

Section V is training designed to help athletes access and execute more consistently their highest skill level by watching their execution of picture perfect skills over and over during training and/or competition with personal audio suggestions to enhance and build confidence.